Jude, Unfolded

An Exploration of Every Verse, Word, Image, and Meaning

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Comparison texts (public domain). World English Bible (WEB); American Standard Version (1901, ASV); Berean Standard Bible (BSB); King James Version (1769 text, KJV); Robinson–Pierpont, *The New Testament in the Original Greek: Byzantine Textform 2018*; the Greek Textus Receptus; and Brenton's Greek and English Septuagint. All were obtained from eBible.org. "World English Bible" is a trademark of eBible.org, and WEB quotations are unaltered.

Other ancient texts. R. H. Charles's translation of 1 Enoch (1917); J. W. Etheridge's translation of the Targums (1862); William Whiston's translation of Josephus; and early Christian writers in the *Ante-Nicene Fathers* and *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers* translations. All are in the public domain. Translations from Pliny's Latin are the author's own.

Full details of every source, including what was verified and how, appear in the Bibliography and in the Translation and Licensing Acknowledgments at the end of the book.

A Reader’s Introduction

Jude is easy to miss. It sits just before Revelation, a single chapter of twenty-five verses, and in the Greek text that underlies this book it runs to about 460 words. Most people could read it aloud in under three minutes. Many Christians know only its closing benediction, “to Him who is able to guard you without stumbling,” and perhaps its call to “fight for the faith once delivered to the holy ones.” The middle of the letter (fallen angels, an archangel quarrelling with the Devil over a corpse, a prophecy from Enoch, reefs, clouds, uprooted trees, and stars that have wandered from their paths) can seem so strange that readers hurry past it.

This book is written for readers who would rather slow down.

Jude rewards slowness because it is so compressed. Almost every phrase calls up a story, a scripture, or a tradition that its first readers knew well and we mostly do not. “The way of Cain” assumes a whole history of how Jewish interpreters understood Cain. “Clouds without water” assumes a farmer’s dread of a rainless sky. “Love feasts” assumes a practice of shared meals in early Christian communities that most churches no longer keep in that form. When Jude names Michael and Moses’ body, or quotes “Enoch, the seventh from Adam,” he speaks the language of a world of Jewish scriptural interpretation that has its own texts, conventions, and arguments. Unfold those references and the letter changes from a cryptic rant into a carefully built piece of pastoral persuasion. It is written with real literary skill, steeped in Israel’s scriptures, and aimed at keeping a community together in the love of God.

What this book is

Jude, Unfolded is an expository commentary: a guided walk through the text, verse by verse and phrase by phrase. It sets out to explain:

- **what the text says**, in the words of a very literal English translation and in the Greek behind it;
- **what it likely meant** to its first readers, given their scriptures, customs, and situation;
- **why it may have been said that way**, which means attending to Jude’s images, his rhetorical patterns, and his choices among traditions;
- **how it may be responsibly applied today**, kept clearly separate from the explanation of what the text meant.

Along the way the book stops for **deep dives**, longer explorations of subjects that modern readers rarely meet elsewhere. A reader who wonders “What exactly was a love feast?” will find a full answer in Chapter 6, drawn from the New Testament and from the earliest Christian and Roman writers who describe such meals. The same care goes to the Book of Enoch, the dispute over Moses’ body, the wandering stars, the “faith once delivered,” and more than a dozen other subjects.

How the chapters work

After the introductory chapters, each of the thirteen main chapters follows the same pattern, so you can always find your way:

- **A. The Text**: the passage in the Literal Standard Version.
- **B. Plain-English Orientation**: the big picture before the details.
- **C. Phrase-by-Phrase Exploration**: the heart of each chapter.
- **D. Original-Language Investigation**: the Greek words that matter, explained for readers who know no Greek.
- **E. The Historical and Cultural World**: the customs, beliefs, and institutions the text assumes.
- **F. Connections Across Scripture**: quotations, allusions, and shared themes, each explained.
- **G. Scholarly and Theological Questions**: where interpreters disagree, and why.
- **H. The Passage Within Jude**: how this section advances the letter’s argument.
- **I. Contemporary Understanding**: possible implications for faith and life today.
- **J. Reflection and Discussion**: questions for personal study or groups.
- **K. Sources**: the notes behind the chapter’s claims.

You do not need to read every section in order. A small group might read A, B, C, and I together, use J for discussion, and leave D and G to members who want more detail. A preacher or teacher will probably want everything.

Why the Literal Standard Version?

The **Literal Standard Version (LSV)**, published by Covenant Press in 2020, is a very literal modern translation. Its publisher presents it as an improvement on earlier literal versions, including Robert Young’s *Literal Translation* of the nineteenth century. It keeps closely to the form of the original languages. It preserves verb tenses where it can, marks supplied words in square brackets, renders ἄγγελος consistently as “messenger” and αἰώνιος as “continuous,” and prints “LORD” in capitals in the New Testament

where the reference is to the God of Israel. Some of its phrasing is unusual (“those dreaming indeed defile the flesh”; “stars going astray”), and that is part of its value here. A literal translation keeps the seams of the original visible, so we can see what the Greek is doing before we smooth it into natural English. Where the LSV’s literalness hides the sense, this book explains it and compares other translations.

The LSV is also openly licensed (Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike), which allows it to be quoted fully and freely. Its publisher asks that its English text not be altered, and this book honors that request: every LSV quotation appears exactly as the LSV has it.

What you will not need

You will not need to know Greek. Every Greek word appears with a transliteration and a plain explanation. You will not need a theological education; technical terms are explained when they first appear and collected in the Glossary. You will not need to agree with every conclusion. Where good interpreters disagree, this book tries to set out the options fairly and to show the evidence on each side, so you can weigh them for yourself.

A word about the tone of Jude

Jude can sound harsh. It speaks of judgment, fire, and darkness, and it describes certain people in vivid and unflattering images. Some readers find this off-putting, and others find it attractive for the wrong reasons. This book takes the severity of Jude seriously without making it the whole story. The letter begins with readers who are “called, … loved, … and … kept,” and it ends with praise to the God who is able to keep them from stumbling. Its last practical words are about mercy, rescue, and compassion for those who are wavering. The darkness of the middle section stands inside a frame of love, and the letter cannot be read rightly without both.

Jude wanted, by his own account, to write about “our common salvation” (v. 3). Circumstances forced him to write a warning instead. Even so, the salvation he wanted to celebrate shines through the warning, and helping you see it is the purpose of this book.

Research Method and Interpretive Principles

A commentary is only as trustworthy as the way it was made. This chapter sets out how this book was researched, what kinds of sources stand behind its claims, and the principles that guided interpretation. Readers who want to get straight to the text can skip ahead and come back later. Readers who want to know how far to trust what follows should read on.

Sources and how they were used

The biblical text. The English text is the Literal Standard Version (LSV), taken from the eBible.org edition and checked word for word against a second rendering of the same edition. The Greek text is the SBL Greek New Testament (SBLGNT), edited by Michael W. Holmes, with its apparatus of variant readings. An updated form of that apparatus records where the Nestle–Aland 28th edition (NA28), the most widely used critical edition today, differs. For comparison the book uses the Robinson–Pierpont edition of the Byzantine text (the form of the Greek found in the majority of later manuscripts), the Textus Receptus (the printed Greek text behind the King James Version), and four public-domain English translations: the WEB, ASV, BSB, and KJV.

Ancient sources. When Jude alludes to a Jewish or early Christian tradition, the book goes back to the ancient text itself wherever an openly available edition exists: 1 Enoch in R. H. Charles's translation, the Targums in J. W. Etheridge's translation, Josephus in William Whiston's, the Septuagint in Brenton's edition, and the church fathers in the standard nineteenth-century translations. Each passage relied on was read directly. The notes give book, chapter, and section so that readers can check them.

Lexical sources. Greek word meanings are drawn mainly from G. Abbott-Smith's *Manual Greek Lexicon of the New Testament* (1922). It is a public-domain lexicon that still repays use, and it summarizes the classical, Septuagint, and papyrus evidence for each New Testament word. Word counts and grammatical data were computed directly from the MorphGNT edition of the SBLGNT, so a statement such as "this word occurs nowhere else in the New Testament" rests on a count of the actual text.

Modern scholarship. The book draws on the main modern commentaries on Jude, above all Richard Bauckham's, which shaped the modern study of the

letter, together with studies of its text, rhetoric, and background. These works could not all be re-consulted page by page during the research for this edition. The book therefore attributes to them only positions they are well known for, cites them by the verse under discussion rather than by page, and identifies them in the Bibliography as works to check before any claim is built on them. This is a deliberate choice: it is better to say less, and say it accurately, than to decorate a sentence with a citation that cannot be traced.

The full **source ledger**, which records what was verified, how, and what remains uncertain, is part of the project files that accompany the manuscript.

Principles of interpretation

1. The text has the first word. Fidelity to Scripture comes before defending any preferred interpretation. Where a popular reading does not fit Jude's words, the book says so, even when that reading is cherished.

2. Meaning before application. Each chapter separates what the text meant in its first setting from how it may be applied now. The two are related, but they are not the same thing, and confusing them is the source of much misuse of Jude.

3. Kinds of claims are labeled. The book tries to make clear whether a statement is a textual fact ("the Greek word occurs only here"), historical evidence ("Pliny reports…"), scholarly consensus, a contested interpretation, a theological tradition, a plausible inference, or a suggested application. Historical reconstructions, however likely, are presented as reconstructions.

4. Words mean what they mean in use. A Greek word's meaning is determined by how it was actually used in its period, not by its etymology or by adding up its parts. The book points out etymologies when they are interesting and warns when they have been overworked. For example, ἐκκλησία does not mean "the called-out ones" just because it contains the parts "out" and "call." Jude's word σπιλάδες, discussed in Chapter 6, is a good example of a word whose sense must be settled by usage.

5. Traditions outside the Bible are taken seriously and handled carefully. Jude quotes 1 Enoch and alludes to a tradition about Michael and Moses that appears nowhere in the Old Testament. The book does not explain these away. It shows where they come from, how Jude uses them, and how the church has argued about what that use implies. Quoting a text is not the same as endorsing everything in it, and the book is careful not to claim more than Jude does.

6. Disagreements are presented fairly. When responsible scholars disagree, the book sets out the main options, the evidence for each, and their

strengths and weaknesses. It sometimes states a preference and gives reasons, but it tries to give readers what they need to decide differently.

7. No denominational polemics. Christians read Jude within many traditions. Where those traditions differ in ways that affect the meaning, for example on the "brothers" of Jesus or on how believers are "kept," the book describes the differences without taking sides in old quarrels.

8. The letter stays whole. Word studies serve the reading of the letter and do not replace it. Each chapter ends by placing its passage in the flow of Jude's argument, and the overview chapter maps the whole.

About the Greek

Greek words appear in Greek script with a transliteration in italics, for example ἀγάπη (*agapē*). The transliteration follows a simple scholarly system: η = *ē*, ω = *ō*, υ = *y* (*u* in diphthongs), χ = *ch*, θ = *th*, φ = *ph*, ψ = *ps*, and rough breathing = *h*. Readers who do not read Greek can ignore the Greek script and follow the transliteration and explanation. Grammatical terms are explained when they first appear and collected in the Glossary.

A few grammatical ideas recur often enough to introduce here:

- **Tense and aspect.** Greek verb forms say less about *when* an action happens than English tenses do and more about *how* the action is viewed. The **perfect** presents a completed action with continuing results ("having been loved," and still loved). The **aorist** presents an action as a whole, without comment on its duration. The **present** presents an action as ongoing or in progress.
- **Participles** are verbal adjectives ("having been called," "praying"). Jude uses them heavily, and much of his meaning rides on them.
- **The optative** is a verb form used to express wishes ("may mercy … be multiplied"). It is rare in the New Testament, and Jude uses it twice.
- **Cases** (nominative, genitive, dative, accusative) mark a noun's role in the sentence. The **dative** in particular can mean "to," "for," "by," or "in," and Jude's first verse depends on which is chosen.

About the variant readings

The New Testament survives in thousands of handwritten manuscripts, and they differ in small and sometimes significant ways. Jude has more than its share of interesting variants. One of them changes who is said to have led Israel out of Egypt, and another changes the shape of the letter's final instructions. The book explains the significant variants where they arise and gathers them in Appendix A. Readers should know that none of these variants

touches the substance of the Christian faith. Some do, however, affect how particular verses are read, and they deserve honest explanation.

About application

The “Contemporary Understanding” sections suggest ways Jude’s message may inform belief, worship, fellowship, ethics, and spiritual practice today. They are offered as possibilities to weigh, not as divine instructions. Jude was written against particular people doing particular things, and it is easy to aim its sharpest words at whoever we happen to dislike. The book tries to resist that temptation and to let Jude question its readers, this author included, before it is turned on anyone else.

Historical and Literary Introduction to Jude

Before walking through Jude verse by verse, it helps to ask the questions any careful reader asks of an ancient letter. Who wrote it? When, and to whom? What was happening that made it necessary? What kind of writing is it, and what world of ideas does it assume? How did the early church receive it? For a letter as short as Jude, the answers are often less certain than we would like. The evidence is still worth laying out, both for what it shows and for what it leaves open.

1. "Judas … brother of James": who wrote the letter?

The letter opens:

> Judas, a servant of Jesus Christ, and brother of James, …
>
> — Jude 1, LSV

The Greek name Ἰούδας (*Ioudas*) is the Greek form of the Hebrew *Yehudah*, Judah, the name of Jacob's fourth son and of the tribe and land descended from him. English Bibles usually write "Jude" for the author of this letter. The convention distinguishes him from Judas Iscariot, but the Greek name is the same, and the LSV keeps "Judas." The name was very common among Jews of the period, so the author's identity depends on the clue he gives: he is the "brother of James."

The candidates

Several men named Judas appear in the New Testament:

1. **Judas the brother of Jesus.** Mark lists him among Jesus' brothers: "Is this not the carpenter, the Son of Mary, and brother of James, and Joses, and Judas, and Simon?" (Mark 6:3, LSV; cf. Matt 13:55).
2. **Judas "of James,"** one of the Twelve, listed by Luke: "Judas of James, and Judas Iscariot, who also became betrayer" (Luke 6:16, LSV; cf. Acts 1:13). John calls him "Judas … (not the Iscariot)" (John 14:22, LSV). The Greek Ἰούδας Ἰακώβου most naturally means "Judas son of James," which is the usual way of using a genitive with a personal name. It does not mean "brother of James."
3. **Judas called Barsabbas**, a prophet and leader in the Jerusalem church who carried the apostolic letter to Antioch (Acts 15:22, 32).

4. **Judas Thomas**, a figure of later Syriac Christian tradition in which the apostle Thomas ("twin") is named Judas.

Among these, the first is the only one for whom "brother of James" is a natural self-description. Only one James in early Christianity was famous enough to identify someone simply by naming him: James of Jerusalem, "the brother of the LORD" (Gal 1:19, LSV). Paul names him as one of the "pillars" of the Jerusalem church (Gal 2:9). He leads the council in Acts 15 and receives Paul in Acts 21:18, and tradition takes him to be the author of the Letter of James, who also calls himself simply "a servant of God and of the Lord Jesus Christ" (Jas 1:1, LSV). A Judas who introduces himself as "brother of James" is almost certainly claiming to be the brother of *that* James, and so a brother of Jesus.

Why "brother of James" and not "brother of the Lord"?

If Jude was the brother of Jesus, why did he not say so? Ancient readers asked the same question. Clement of Alexandria, writing around AD 200, answered with a comment that later readers have found persuasive:

> Jude, who wrote the Catholic Epistle, the brother of the sons of Joseph, and very religious, while knowing the near relationship of the Lord, yet did not say that he himself was His brother. But what said he? Jude, a servant of Jesus Christ,—of Him as Lord; but the brother of James.[1]

Several factors probably worked together. The family relationship was no longer the defining fact; after the resurrection, Jesus' brothers came to know him as Lord. The Gospels remember that during Jesus' ministry "not even His brothers were believing in Him" (John 7:5, LSV). Yet after Easter they appear among the praying disciples (Acts 1:14), and Paul knows that the risen Christ "appeared to James" (1 Cor 15:7, LSV). A brother by birth who had become a servant by faith might well prefer to call himself the second. Naming James also placed Jude within a recognized line of authority without claiming the title of apostle, which he appears to reserve for others (v. 17).

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1. Clement of Alexandria, *Adumbrationes* (Comments) on the Epistle of Jude, in *Ante-Nicene Fathers* 2, "Fragments of Clemens Alexandrinus," II; online at https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/0211.htm. The comment also identifies Jude as "His brother, (the son) of Joseph."↩

The family of Jesus in early tradition

Two pieces of evidence outside the Gospels fill out the picture.

First, Paul mentions in passing that "the brothers of the LORD" traveled on missionary work with their wives (1 Cor 9:5, LSV). That remark, written in the

mid-50s, shows that at least some of Jesus' brothers besides James were known as traveling preachers among the churches. Jude, who writes to readers he knows and who are at some distance from him, fits that profile.

Second, the second-century Jewish-Christian writer Hegesippus, quoted by Eusebius, tells a story about Jude's grandsons. When the emperor Domitian (reigned AD 81–96) feared the descendants of David, "the grandchildren of Jude, who is said to have been the Lord's brother according to the flesh," were brought before him. They owned a small farm worth nine thousand denarii, showed him the calluses on their hands from working it, and explained that Christ's kingdom was "not a temporal nor an earthly kingdom, but a heavenly and angelic one." Domitian let them go as harmless. Afterward, Hegesippus says, they "ruled the churches because they were witnesses and were also relatives of the Lord," and they lived until the time of Trajan.[2] The story probably includes some legendary color, but it preserves a memory of Jude's family as Galilean farmers, rooted in Jewish Christianity and respected in the churches.

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2. Eusebius, *Ecclesiastical History* 3.19–20, quoting Hegesippus (NPNF² 1; https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/250103.htm).↩

Deep dive: who were Jesus' "brothers"?

The New Testament names four brothers of Jesus (James, Joses or Joseph, Judas, and Simon) and mentions sisters (Mark 6:3). Christians have understood these relationships in three main ways, and the differences matter for how readers picture Jude.

- **Full brothers (the "Helvidian" view, after Helvidius, a fourth-century writer).** On this view they were children of Mary and Joseph born after Jesus. Most Protestant interpreters hold it, pointing to the plain sense of the word ἀδελφός (*adelphos*) and to texts such as Matt 1:25.
- **Older half-brothers, sons of Joseph by an earlier marriage (the "Epiphanian" view, after Epiphanius of Salamis).** This view is attested in second-century writings. It has been common in Eastern Orthodox tradition and fits Clement's description of Jude as "the brother of the sons of Joseph."
- **Cousins (the "Hieronymian" view, after Jerome).** This view takes *adelphos* in the broader sense of "kinsman," a sense it can carry in Jewish usage. It became standard in the Latin West and is common in Roman Catholic interpretation.

All three views agree on what matters most for this book: Jude belonged to Jesus' own family circle, grew up near him, and came to call him "Master and

Lord" (v. 4). Readers who hold different views of Mary can read Jude in the same way.

Did Jude himself write it?

Many scholars accept that the letter was written by Jude, the brother of Jesus. Many others think it was written later by someone using his name, a practice called pseudonymity that was known in the ancient world. The main arguments for a later writer are these:

- **The Greek is good.** Jude's vocabulary is rich, with sixteen words found nowhere else in the New Testament, and his style is vivid and carefully patterned. Could a Galilean villager write like this?
- **"The faith once delivered" (v. 3)** is said to treat Christianity as a fixed body of doctrine, which some regard as typical of a later, more institutional stage.
- **The apostles seem to belong to the past** (v. 17).

Defenders of authenticity reply:

- **Greek was widely used in Galilee**, and a family whose members traveled as missionaries in the Greek-speaking world (1 Cor 9:5) had every opportunity to learn it well. Ancient authors also commonly used secretaries, who could polish style. The quality of the Greek is a real question, but it does not settle authorship.
- **"The faith" as the content of the Christian message** already appears in Paul's earliest letters: "he who is persecuting us then, now proclaims good news—the faith that he was then destroying" (Gal 1:23, LSV). Language about "delivering" teaching is also early (1 Cor 11:2; 15:3).
- **Verse 17 asks readers to remember what the apostles told *them***. That requires only that the apostles had preached to these readers earlier, not that they were all long dead.
- **The choice of name is the strongest argument.** A later writer who wanted authority would hardly choose an obscure figure like Jude, and having chosen him, would likely have added the impressive title "brother of the Lord." A modest self-description fits the real Jude better than an imitator.

This book treats authorship by Jude the brother of Jesus as a responsible conclusion that fits the evidence well. It does not regard the question as closed, and very little of the letter's interpretation depends on the answer.[3]

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3. For a sustained case for authenticity, see Richard Bauckham, *Jude, 2 Peter* (WBC 50; Waco: Word, 1983), introduction, and his *Jude and the Relatives of Jesus in the Early Church* (Edinburgh: T&T Clark, 1990). For views favoring a later date and pseudonymous authorship, see the introductions in J. N. D. Kelly, *A Commentary on the*

Epistles of Peter and of Jude (London: A&C Black, 1969), and Jerome H. Neyrey, *2 Peter, Jude* (AB 37C; New York: Doubleday, 1993). (These works are cited from prior knowledge; see the Bibliography.)↩

2. Language and style

Jude writes a compact, energetic, and artful Greek. Several features stand out, and they will recur throughout this book:

- **Rare words.** Of about 226 distinct words in Jude, sixteen occur nowhere else in the New Testament, among them the words meaning ‘contend for’ (v. 3), ‘slip in’ (v. 4), ‘reefs’ (v. 12), ‘late-autumn’ (v. 12), ‘foam up’ (v. 13), ‘wanderers’ (v. 13), ‘grumblers’ and ‘fault-finders’ (v. 16), ‘make divisions’ (v. 19), and ‘without stumbling’ (v. 24).[4]
- **Triads.** Jude thinks in threes: called, loved, kept (v. 1); mercy, peace, love (v. 2); three examples of judgment (vv. 5–7); three sins of the ‘dreamers’ (v. 8); Cain, Balaam, Korah (v. 11); three groups to whom mercy is shown (vv. 22–23).
- **Catchwords.** Key words return in new settings and bind the letter together. The clearest is “keep” (τηρέω, *tēreō*): the readers are “kept” (v. 1), the angels did not “keep” their position and are “kept” for judgment (v. 6), darkness is “kept” for the wandering stars (v. 13), and the readers are to “keep” themselves in God’s love (v. 21) as they trust the God who is able to “guard” them (v. 24).
- **The “these” pattern.** After each example or prophecy, Jude turns to the troublemakers with “these” (οὗτοι, *houtoi*): “those dreaming” (v. 8, where the LSV renders the word “those”), “these, indeed, whatever [things] they have not known” (v. 10), “These are stains” (v. 12), “These are … grumblers” (v. 16), “these are those causing divisions” (v. 19).
- **Vivid images drawn from nature and from Israel’s story.**

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4. Counts computed from the SBLGNT with MorphGNT lemmatization: 459 words, 226 distinct lemmas, 16 lemmas unique to Jude within the New Testament. See the project file `research/data-notes.md`. A different edition or lemmatization would change the figures slightly.↩

3. Date and setting

The letter gives no explicit date. If Jude the brother of Jesus wrote it, it was written within his lifetime, probably before the 90s and possibly much earlier, since Hegesippus’s story about Domitian concerns his grandsons. Some scholars date it to the 50s or early 60s, which would make it one of the earliest New Testament writings. Others place it between 70 and 100. The letter’s horizon is strikingly Jewish and apocalyptic. It never mentions the destruction

of Jerusalem's temple (AD 70), but arguments from silence are weak in so short a letter.

This uncertainty affects the interpretation less than one might expect. Jude's concerns are about holding to the received faith, moral integrity, authority, divisive teachers, and mercy toward the wavering. Those concerns fit the first Christian century at almost any point.

4. The recipients

Jude addresses "those called, having been loved … and having been kept" (v. 1), a description of all believers rather than of a particular place. Yet the letter is clearly written to particular people: he calls them "beloved" three times (vv. 3, 17, 20). He knows that intruders have slipped into their community (v. 4) and sit at their love feasts (v. 12), and he can remind them of what the apostles had told them (vv. 17–18).

He also assumes that they will understand compressed references to the exodus, to fallen angels, to Michael and Moses, to Cain, Balaam, and Korah, and to the prophecy of Enoch. Such readers were most likely Jewish Christians, or a mixed community deeply formed by Jewish scriptural interpretation. Suggested locations include Palestine, Syria, Egypt, and Asia Minor. None can be proven, and this book does not build on any of them.

5. The troublemakers

Jude does not name the people he opposes. He calls them "certain men" (v. 4), and everything we know about them comes from his description. Gathering his charges gives this profile:

- They are **inside** the community. They "came in … stealthily" (v. 4) and share its meals (v. 12).
- They turn **grace into license**, especially sexual license (vv. 4, 7–8, 16, 18).
- They **deny** Jesus Christ as Master and Lord, probably by the way they live rather than by explicit doctrinal denial (v. 4).
- They appeal to **dreams**, apparently claimed revelations (v. 8).
- They **reject authority** and **slander glorious beings** (vv. 8–10).
- They are **self-serving**, "shepherding themselves" (v. 12), "for the sake of profit" (v. 16), like Balaam "for reward" (v. 11).
- They are **divisive** and, in Jude's judgment, **"not having the Spirit"** (v. 19).

Older commentators often identified them as Gnostics, members of the second-century movements that taught salvation through secret knowledge

and despised the material world. The resemblance is partial at best. Jude says nothing about a lower creator-god, a cosmic myth, or a doctrine of secret knowledge. The developed Gnostic systems also belong to a later period than most scholars assign to Jude. A more cautious description, widely held since Richard Bauckham's commentary, sees them as traveling teachers who claimed prophetic or charismatic authority and taught that grace freed believers from moral law.[5] That is itself a reconstruction, and the book treats it as one.

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5. Bauckham, *Jude, 2 Peter*, introduction ("The Opponents"). The "Gnostic" identification was common in nineteenth- and early twentieth-century scholarship.↩

6. What kind of writing is Jude?

Jude is a **letter**. It has the standard opening (sender, recipients, greeting) and an elaborate closing doxology in place of the usual farewell. In substance it is a **sermon or word of exhortation in letter form**, with a clear rhetorical aim: to move its hearers to "fight for the faith" (v. 3).

Two analyses of its structure have been especially influential:

- **A Jewish interpretive pattern.** Scholars such as E. Earle Ellis and Richard Bauckham observed that the central section (vv. 5–19) alternates between *texts*, meaning scriptural examples, a tradition, a prophecy, and an apostolic prediction, and *interpretations* introduced by "these." The pattern resembles the commentary method known from the Dead Sea Scrolls, in which a biblical text is quoted and then applied to the present ("its interpretation concerns…"). It suggests a writer trained in Jewish ways of reading Scripture as prophecy fulfilled in his own time.[6]
- **Greco-Roman rhetoric.** Duane F. Watson read Jude according to the conventions of ancient persuasive speech: an introduction stating the purpose (v. 3), a statement of the situation (v. 4), the main proofs (vv. 5–16), and a concluding appeal (vv. 17–23), framed by the letter opening and doxology.[7]

The two analyses do not compete. A Jewish author writing in Greek could use both inherited Jewish methods and the persuasive patterns any educated speaker of Greek would know.

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6. E. Earle Ellis, "Prophecy and Hermeneutic in Jude," in *Prophecy and Hermeneutic in Early Christianity* (Tübingen: Mohr Siebeck, 1978); Bauckham, *Jude, 2 Peter*, on vv. 5–19.↩

7. Duane F. Watson, *Invention, Arrangement, and Style: Rhetorical Criticism of Jude and 2 Peter* (SBLDS 104; Atlanta: Scholars Press, 1988).↩

7. Jude’s scriptural world

Jude is saturated with Israel’s scriptures, yet he never introduces an Old Testament quotation with “it is written.” His one formal quotation comes from 1 Enoch (vv. 14–15). His references to the Hebrew Bible are compressed allusions that assume the reader knows the story:

Jude	Allusion
5	The exodus and the wilderness unbelief (Exod 12–14; Num 14)
6	The “sons of God” (Gen 6:1–4) as read in 1 Enoch 6–16
7	Sodom and Gomorrah (Gen 19)
9	Michael and Moses’ burial (Deut 34:5–6) via later tradition; Michael’s words echo Zech 3:2 (“YHWH pushes against you, O Satan”)
11	Cain (Gen 4), Balaam (Num 22–24; 31:16), Korah (Num 16)
12	Shepherds feeding themselves (Ezek 34:2); clouds and wind without rain (Prov 25:14)
13	The restless sea casting up mire (Isa 57:20)
14–15	Enoch (Gen 5:21–24); 1 Enoch 1:9
16	The wilderness grumbling (Exod 16; Num 14)
23	A brand snatched from the fire; filthy garments (Zech 3:2–4; Amos 4:11)

One detail suggests that Jude knew his scriptures in Hebrew or Aramaic rather than only in the Greek Septuagint. In Isa 57:20 and Prov 25:14, the passages behind his images of the foaming sea and the rainless clouds, the Hebrew text contains the very details Jude uses: the sea “casts out filth and mire,” and there are “clouds and wind without rain” (LSV, translating the Hebrew). The Septuagint versions of both verses lack those details.[8] This is not proof, but it fits a Palestinian Jewish author.

Jude also draws on **Jewish traditions outside the Hebrew Bible**: 1 Enoch, the fullest surviving source for the Watcher story and for the prophecy he quotes, and a tradition about Michael’s dispute with the Devil over Moses’ body, which early Christian writers associated with a work called the *Assumption* (or *Ascension*) *of Moses*. These references were the main reason some early Christians hesitated over Jude. They are discussed fully in Chapters 3, 4, and 8.

8. Compare the Septuagint of Isa 57:20 (Οἱ δὲ ἄδικοι κλυδωνισθήσονται, καὶ ἀναπαύσασθαι οὐ δυνήσονται, “the unrighteous will be tossed like waves and will not be able to rest”), which lacks the mire, and LXX Prov 25:14, which differs substantially from the Hebrew. Greek text from Brenton’s Septuagint, eBible.org edition. Bauckham makes the broader argument that Jude’s allusions reflect the Hebrew text (*Jude, 2 Peter*, introduction and on vv. 12–13).↩

8. Jude and 2 Peter

Anyone who reads Jude and then 2 Peter 2 notices the resemblance. The same sequence of themes and images appears in both: intruders who deny the Master (Jude 4; 2 Pet 2:1), sinning angels kept in gloom for judgment (Jude 6; 2 Pet 2:4), Sodom and Gomorrah (Jude 7; 2 Pet 2:6), defiling the flesh and despising authority (Jude 8; 2 Pet 2:10), angels who do not bring a slanderous judgment (Jude 9; 2 Pet 2:11), creatures without reason (Jude 10; 2 Pet 2:12), Balaam’s love of reward (Jude 11; 2 Pet 2:15), feasting together (Jude 12; 2 Pet 2:13), waterless clouds and gloom of darkness (Jude 12–13; 2 Pet 2:17), “swollen” words (Jude 16; 2 Pet 2:18), and scoffers foretold by the apostles (Jude 17–18; 2 Pet 3:2–3). Three Greek words occur in the New Testament only in these two letters.

There are three main explanations:

1. **2 Peter used Jude.** This is the majority view. Jude’s version is usually the more compact and more Jewish, and it is easier to explain why 2 Peter would omit Jude’s quotation from Enoch and his named Michael story than why Jude would add them. 2 Peter also arranges the examples in biblical order (angels, flood, Sodom), while Jude’s order follows his own thematic logic.
2. **Jude used 2 Peter.** A minority view, defended by older scholars such as Charles Bigg. It points to 2 Peter’s future tense (“there will be false teachers,” 2 Pet 2:1) and Jude’s past tense (“there came in,” Jude 4), as if Jude were reporting the fulfillment of 2 Peter’s prediction.
3. **Both used a common source**, perhaps a body of early Christian teaching about false teachers.

The question matters for the study of 2 Peter more than for Jude. This book reads Jude on its own terms and uses 2 Peter as an early interpreter of Jude’s language. Appendix C gives the parallel texts side by side.

9. How the church received Jude

Jude’s place in the New Testament was secure early in some regions and debated in others, and the debate centered on his use of Enoch.

- **Late second century:** the Muratorian Fragment, a Latin list of accepted books whose date is debated, includes "the Epistle of Jude."[9] Clement of Alexandria commented on Jude in his *Hypotyposes*, and part of that commentary survives in Latin.[10] Tertullian, around AD 200, used Jude to defend Enoch's authority: "Enoch possesses a testimony in the Apostle Jude."[11]
- **Third century:** Origen praised Jude as "a letter of few lines, it is true, but filled with the healthful words of heavenly grace."[12]
- **Early fourth century:** Eusebius placed Jude among the "disputed writings, which are nevertheless recognized by many," noting that "not many of the ancients have mentioned it" but that it had been "read publicly in very many churches."[13]
- **AD 367:** Athanasius's Easter letter listing the books of the New Testament includes "one of Jude" among the seven catholic epistles.[14]
- **Late fourth century:** Jerome explained the hesitation directly: "because in it he quotes from the apocryphal Book of Enoch it is rejected by many. Nevertheless by age and use it has gained authority and is reckoned among the Holy Scriptures."[15]

At the Reformation, Martin Luther valued the letter but placed it among the books "that need not be counted among the chief books," calling it "an extract or copy of St. Peter's second epistle."[16] John Calvin defended its authority and suggested that Jude drew on ancient tradition, not necessarily on an apocryphal book.[17]

One further fact helps modern readers understand the issue. **The Book of Enoch, which Jude quotes, is itself part of the Old Testament canon of the Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church and the Eritrean Orthodox Tewahedo Church**, though not of other churches or of Judaism.[18] The question "What does it mean that Jude quotes Enoch?" therefore receives different answers in different Christian traditions. Chapter 8 explores it.

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9. Muratorian Fragment, in *Ante-Nicene Fathers* 5, "Fragments of Caius," §4 (https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/0510.htm).↩

10. Eusebius, *Ecclesiastical History* 6.14.1 (https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/250106.htm); Clement, *Adumbrationes* (see n. 1).↩

11. Tertullian, *On the Apparel of Women* (*De cultu feminarum*) 1.3 (ANF 4; https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/0402.htm).↩

12. Origen, *Commentary on Matthew* 10.17 (ANF 9; https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/101610.htm).↩

13. Eusebius, *Ecclesiastical History* 3.25.3 and 2.23.25 (https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/250103.htm,

https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/250102.htm).↩

14. Athanasius, *Festal Letter* 39.5 (NPNF² 4; https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/2806039.htm).↩

15. Jerome, *On Illustrious Men* (*De viris illustribus*) 4 (NPNF² 3; https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/2708.htm).↩

16. Martin Luther, "Preface to the Epistles of St. James and St. Jude" (1522), English translation as reproduced at https://www.bible-researcher.com/antilegomena.html (from *Luther's Works*, vol. 35).↩

17. John Calvin, *Commentaries on the Catholic Epistles*, trans. John Owen (Edinburgh: Calvin Translation Society, 1855), on Jude 9 and 14 (CCEL edition).↩

18. On the canonical status and textual history of 1 Enoch, see the summary in "Book of Enoch," *Wikipedia* (accessed 7 November 2026), and George W. E. Nickelsburg, *1 Enoch 1* (Hermeneia; Minneapolis: Fortress, 2001), introduction (cited from prior knowledge).↩

10. Why Jude matters

Jude has been called the most neglected book of the New Testament. Its neglect is understandable but costly. In twenty-five verses it offers:

- a picture of **Christian identity** as gift before task: called, loved, kept;
- a clear statement that the **gospel has content**, entrusted once for all and worth contending for;
- an unflinching moral seriousness about **grace twisted into license**;
- a demonstration of how the first Christians read **Israel's scriptures and traditions** as speaking to their present;
- a remarkably early and high **Christology**: Jesus is "our only Master and Lord," possibly the one who saved Israel from Egypt, and the coming Lord of Enoch's prophecy;
- a model of **contending without contempt**, defending the faith while showing mercy to the wavering and rescuing those in danger;
- one of the most beautiful **doxologies** in Scripture, which turns the whole letter toward the God who keeps his people.

The chapters that follow try to show how these pieces fit together.

The Whole Letter at a Glance

Jude is short enough to read in one sitting, and it should be read that way before it is taken apart. Its first hearers would have heard it read aloud as a whole, probably at a gathering of the church. Read it now, slowly, ideally aloud.

The Epistle of Jude in the Literal Standard Version

> **1** Judas, a servant of Jesus Christ, and brother of James, to those called, having been loved in God [the] Father, and having been kept in Jesus Christ, **2** mercy and peace and love be multiplied to you!
>
> **3** Beloved, using all diligence to write to you concerning our common salvation, I had necessity to write to you, exhorting [you] to fight for the faith once delivered to the holy ones, **4** for there came in certain men stealthily, having been written beforehand to this judgment long ago, impious, perverting the grace of our God to licentiousness, and denying our only Master and Lord—Jesus Christ.
>
> **5** Now I intend to remind you, you once having known all this, that Jesus, having saved a people out of the land of Egypt, He secondly destroyed those not having believed; **6** messengers also, those who did not keep their own principality, but left their proper dwelling, He has kept in eternal bonds under darkness until [the] judgment of [the] great day, **7** as Sodom and Gomorrah, and the cities around them, in like manner to these [messengers], having given themselves to whoredom, and having gone after other flesh, have been set before [as] an example, undergoing the justice of continuous fire.
>
> **8** In like manner, nevertheless, those dreaming indeed defile the flesh, and they disregard lordship, and they speak evil of glorious [ones], **9** yet Michael, the chief messenger, when disputing with the Devil, reasoning about the body of Moses, did not dare to bring against [him] a judgment of slander, but said, “The LORD rebuke you!” **10** But these, indeed, whatever [things] they have not known, they speak evil of; and whatever [they know], like the irrational beasts, they understand naturally—in these they are corrupted; **11** woe to them! Because they went on in the way of Cain, and they rushed to the deceit of Balaam for reward, and in the controversy of Korah they perished.

> **12** These are stains at your love-feasts, feasting together with you without fear, shepherding themselves; waterless clouds, being carried away by winds; autumnal trees without fruit, having died twice, having been uprooted; **13** wild waves of a sea, foaming up their own shameful [deeds]; stars going astray, for whom the gloom of the darkness throughout the age has been kept.
>
> **14** And Enoch, the seventh from Adam, also prophesied to these, saying, “Behold, the LORD has come with myriads of His holy ones, **15** to do judgment against all, and to convict all their impious ones, concerning all their works of impiety that they did impiously, and concerning all the harsh [words] that impious sinners spoke against Him.” **16** These are discontented grumblers, walking according to their own lusts; and their mouth speaks swollen words, giving admiration to persons for the sake of profit;
>
> **17** but you, beloved, remember the sayings spoken before by the apostles of our Lord Jesus Christ, **18** that they said to you, that in the last time there will be scoffers, following after their own lusts of impieties, **19** these are those causing divisions, natural men, not having the Spirit.
>
> **20** But you, beloved, building yourselves up on your most holy faith, praying in the Holy Spirit, **21** keep yourselves in the love of God, waiting for the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ [resulting] in continuous life; **22** and, indeed, show mercy to those who are doubting, **23** and rescue others by snatching [them] out of fire; but show mercy to others in fear, hating even the coat having been stained from the flesh.
>
> **24** And to Him who is able to guard you without stumbling, and to set [you] in the presence of His glory unblemished, in gladness, **25** to the only wise God our Savior, [is] glory and greatness, power and authority, both now and forever! Amen.
>
> — Jude 1–25, LSV

The shape of the letter

Read as a whole, Jude has a clear architecture: a bright frame around a dark center.

Section	Verses	Content	Key words
Greeting	1–2	Sender; recipients called, loved, kept;	*kept, love, mercy*

Section	Verses	Content	Key words
		wish for mercy, peace, love	
Occasion and appeal	3–4	Jude meant to write about salvation, but must urge readers to contend for the faith, because intruders have slipped in	*beloved, faith, impious*
The case against the intruders	5–19	Five “texts,” each followed by “these” applying it to the intruders	*these, impious, judgment, kept*
— first text	5–7	Three examples of judgment: wilderness generation, angels, Sodom	
— application	8	“those dreaming…”	
— second text	9	Michael’s restraint in the dispute over Moses’ body	
— application	10–13	“these … speak evil”; woe (Cain, Balaam, Korah); images from nature	
— third text	14–15	Enoch’s prophecy of the Lord’s coming with holy myriads	
— application	16	“These are … grumblers”	
— fourth text	17–18	The apostles’ prediction of scoffers	
— application	19	“these are those causing divisions”	
Exhortation	20–23	Build, pray, keep yourselves, wait; show mercy, rescue, show mercy with fear	*beloved, keep, love, mercy*
Doxology	24–25	Praise to the God who is able to guard and present his people	*guard, glory*

(Some outlines count the woe of v. 11 as a separate "text" and vv. 12–13 as its application, giving five texts in all. The structure is the same either way.)

Three features of this design are worth carrying into every chapter.

1. The frame interprets the center

The darkest material in the letter, judgment, darkness, and fire, sits between a greeting that calls the readers loved and kept and a doxology that praises God for keeping them from stumbling. The structure itself makes a theological claim: the readers' security does not depend on the absence of danger. The danger is real, but the one who keeps them is greater. A reading of Jude that remembers only the middle has misread the letter.

2. "Keep" runs through the whole

The Greek verb τηρέω (*tēreō*, "keep, guard, preserve") appears five times, and its near relative φυλάσσω (*phylassō*, "guard") once more at the climax:

Verse	LSV	Who keeps what
1	"having been kept in Jesus Christ"	God keeps the believers
6	"those who did not keep their own principality"	Angels failed to keep their position
6	"He has kept in eternal bonds"	God keeps the rebel angels for judgment
13	"the gloom of the darkness … has been kept"	Darkness is kept for the wanderers
21	"keep yourselves in the love of God"	Believers are to keep themselves
24	"Him who is able to guard you"	God guards the believers

Two kinds of keeping run through the letter: protective keeping for those who belong to God, and custodial keeping for those who rebel. The angels "did not keep" what was theirs, and so they are "kept" for judgment. The readers are "kept" by God, and so they are to "keep" themselves in his love. The whole letter turns on this wordplay.

3. "Beloved" vs. "these"

Jude addresses his readers as "beloved" (ἀγαπητοί, *agapētoi*) three times (vv. 3, 17, 20). Each time the address marks a turning point toward them. He refers to the intruders as "these" (οὗτοι, *houtoi*) five times (vv. 8, 10, 12, 16, 19), each time applying an ancient example to them. The letter moves between

the two groups, and its rhetoric depends on the contrast. In vv. 22–23, however, the line between them becomes porous. Some who have been influenced by the intruders can still be shown mercy and snatched from the fire. Jude's contrast exists to protect people, not to write them off.

Reading strategy for the chapters ahead

As you work through the commentary, it may help to keep three questions in mind for each passage:

1. **What is Jude asking his readers to *see*?** Much of the letter is an argument from examples: "remember," "behold," "these are."
2. **What is Jude asking his readers to *do*?** The commands are few but weighty: contend (v. 3), remember (v. 17), build, pray, keep, wait (vv. 20–21), show mercy, rescue (vv. 22–23).
3. **What is Jude asking his readers to *trust*?** The letter begins and ends with God's keeping. Everything between is written by someone who believes God is able.

Part One: The Commentary

Chapter 1. Called, Loved, and Kept: Identity and Greeting (Jude 1–2)

A. The Text

> **1** Judas, a servant of Jesus Christ, and brother of James, to those called, having been loved in God [the] Father, and having been kept in Jesus Christ, **2** mercy and peace and love be multiplied to you!
>
> — Jude 1–2, LSV

B. Plain-English Orientation

Ancient letters opened with a standard formula: *From A, to B, greetings.* Jude follows the pattern, but he fills each part with meaning. He introduces himself by two relationships, servant of Jesus Christ and brother of James. He describes his readers by three things God has done for them: God has called them, loved them, and kept them. Then he wishes them three gifts in abundance: mercy, peace, and love.

These two verses are easy to skim on the way to the "real" content of the letter. They are, however, the foundation on which everything else stands. Before Jude says a word about danger, he tells his readers who they are and whose they are. The letter will speak of people who "did not keep" their place and are "kept" for judgment, and it will urge the readers to "keep" themselves in the love of God. All of that is anchored here, in a description of believers as people who have *already* been loved and kept.

C. Phrase-by-Phrase Exploration

"Judas"

The author's name is the Greek form of *Judah*, the patriarch whose name became the name of a tribe, a kingdom, and finally the Jewish people as a whole. For a Jewish family in Galilee, naming a son Judah was a patriotic and pious act. The name also recalled Judas Maccabeus, the hero of the revolt against Antiochus IV in the second century BC. Among Jews of the first century it was one of the most common names.

English Bibles traditionally write “Jude” for the author of this letter and “Judas” for others, partly so that readers do not confuse him with Judas Iscariot. The LSV, true to its literal approach, keeps “Judas.” The Greek makes no distinction. As the Historical Introduction explains, the author is almost certainly the Judas named among the brothers of Jesus in Mark 6:3.

“a servant of Jesus Christ”

The Greek word is δοῦλος (*doulos*), the ordinary word for a slave. The LSV’s “servant” is a long-standing English convention, but it softens the word. In the Roman world a *doulos* was not an employee who could resign. A *doulos* was a person owned by another, whose time, labor, and body belonged to a master.

Two backgrounds give the phrase its force.

The first is the Old Testament phrase “servant of the LORD” (in Hebrew *ʿebed YHWH*). It was a title of honor, given to Moses (“My servant Moses is dead,” Josh 1:2, LSV), to David (“Go, and you have said to My servant, to David,” 2 Sam 7:5, LSV), and to the prophets. To be someone’s servant was to be identified with that person’s authority and to act on his behalf. The Septuagint uses δοῦλος almost always to translate the Hebrew *ʿebed*.[19]

The second is Christian usage. Paul begins Romans with “Paul, a servant of Jesus Christ” (Rom 1:1, LSV), and James begins his letter “James, a servant of God and of the Lord Jesus Christ” (Jas 1:1, LSV). Paul could also describe Christ himself as one who “emptied Himself, having taken the form of a servant” (Phil 2:7, LSV), using the same word, *doulos*.

For Jude the title says something personal. He grew up in the same household as Jesus. He might have presented himself as an equal, or at least as a relative with special standing. Instead he calls himself Jesus’ slave. The family tie remains, but it has been taken up into a new relationship of total belonging, the same belonging that will mark all his readers. A few lines later he will call Jesus “our only Master” (v. 4), and the Greek word there, δεσπότης (*despotēs*), is the normal word for a slave’s owner. Jude is consistent: if Jesus is the *despotēs*, Jude is his *doulos*.

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19. Abbott-Smith, *Manual Greek Lexicon*, s.v. δοῦλος: “in LXX, ὁ δ. nearly always for עֶבֶד.” ↩

“and brother of James”

The second relationship identifies Jude for his readers by naming his famous brother, James, the leader of the Jerusalem church (Gal 1:19; 2:9; Acts 15:13). As the Historical Introduction explains, early readers like Clement of Alexandria saw humility in Jude’s choice to name James rather than Jesus.[20]

The phrase also establishes credentials. Jude speaks as a member of a family whose authority the churches recognized, without claiming to be an apostle.

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20. Clement of Alexandria, *Adumbrationes* on Jude, ANF 2 (https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/0211.htm): Jude, "while knowing the near relationship of the Lord, yet did not say that he himself was His brother."↩

"to those called"

In Greek the description of the readers is built so that the key word comes last: *to-the-in-God-the-Father-loved-and-for-Jesus-Christ-kept called-ones*. The final word, κλητοῖς (*klētois*), "called," is the noun the other phrases describe. It is the readers' basic identity: they are people God has called.

"Calling" in the Bible is not a general invitation that people may take or leave. It is God's effective summons that brings a people into being. God called Abraham out of Ur, and he called Israel out of Egypt. In Isaiah, God says to his servant, "I, YHWH, called you in righteousness, / And I lay hold on your hand, and keep you" (Isa 42:6, LSV). There *calling* and *keeping* stand side by side, as they do in Jude.

The New Testament applies this language to the church. Paul writes to "the called of Jesus Christ … called holy ones" (Rom 1:6–7, LSV), and to "those called—both Jews and Greeks" (1 Cor 1:24, LSV). Revelation pictures the Lamb's companions as those who "are called, and chosen, and steadfast" (Rev 17:14, LSV). By placing "called" in the climactic position, Jude says that his readers' existence as a community begins with God's initiative, not their own.

"having been loved in God [the] Father"

The Greek participle ἠγαπημένοις (*ēgapēmenois*) is in the **perfect** tense, which presents a past action with continuing results. Its sense is "having been loved and remaining loved." The love Jude has in mind is not a passing feeling but a settled state.

The phrase "in God [the] Father" is unusual. Most often the New Testament speaks of being loved *by* God. Some interpreters take the Greek preposition ἐν (*en*) here in an instrumental sense, "loved *by* God the Father." Others keep the local sense, "loved *in* God," meaning that believers are held within the sphere of God's own love. The LSV keeps the literal "in" and lets the reader feel its strangeness. Either way, the source of the love is God the Father, and it is the same love in which the readers are later told to "keep" themselves (v. 21).

The Old Testament roots of this idea are deep. Moses told Israel that God did not choose them for their size or merit, "but because of YHWH's loving you,

and because of His keeping the oath" (Deut 7:8, LSV). Love and keeping stand together there too.

A variant reading. Many later Greek manuscripts read ἡγιασμένοις (*hēgiasmenois*), "sanctified," in place of ἠγαπημένοις, "loved." The King James Version follows this reading ("to them that are sanctified by God the Father"), as does the WEB, which translates the Majority Text. The critical editions (Westcott–Hort, Tregelles, NA28, and SBLGNT) all read "loved," and the LSV, though it generally follows the Majority Text, does so here too. The likely explanation is that a scribe found "loved in God" awkward and replaced it with the more familiar "sanctified in," which echoes 1 Cor 1:2 ("sanctified in Christ Jesus"). This variant also illustrates a basic principle of textual criticism. According to the manuscript tallies in one modern edition, "sanctified" appears in about 90 percent of surviving manuscripts and "loved" in about 9 percent.[21] Most of those manuscripts, however, are late copies of a single textual tradition. The editors of the critical texts judged that the reading of the earliest witnesses, and the harder reading that best explains its rival, is more likely original. Counting manuscripts is not the same as weighing them.

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21. The Text-Critical Greek New Testament notes (Robert Adam Boyd; eBible.org `grctcgnt`) give ἡγιασμένοις 90.2% and ἠγαπημένοις 8.9% of manuscripts. These figures count manuscripts and do not weigh them; they are cited only to illustrate the distribution. The critical editions' choice of ἠγαπημένοις is recorded in the SBLGNT apparatus (WH, Treg, NIV, NA28 against RP).↩

"and having been kept in Jesus Christ"

Again the participle is perfect: τετηρημένοις (*tetērēmenois*), "having been kept and remaining kept." The verb τηρέω (*tēreō*) means "to watch over, guard, keep, preserve."[22] It will become the central word of the letter.

The Greek has no preposition here. It reads simply "to-Jesus-Christ kept," with "Jesus Christ" in the dative case. Because the Greek dative can express several relationships, three readings are possible:

1. **"kept *for* Jesus Christ"** (WEB, ASV, and most modern translations). Believers are kept safe *for* Christ, held in trust until his return. This fits Paul's prayer that believers' "whole spirit and soul and body be preserved, unblameably at the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ" (1 Thess 5:23, LSV), and the letter's own climax, where God sets believers before his glory (v. 24).
2. **"kept *by* Jesus Christ."** Christ himself is the keeper. Compare Jesus' prayer, "when I was with them in the world, I was keeping them in Your Name" (John 17:12, LSV).
3. **"kept *in* Jesus Christ"** (LSV). The preposition "in" from the previous phrase is understood again, so that believers are kept within their union

with Christ.

The first reading is the most natural sense of a dative of this kind, and it fits the forward-looking shape of the letter, which ends with believers presented before God's glory. The other readings are possible, and all three are true to the New Testament's wider teaching. Jude's emphasis is clear in any case: the readers' safety is something God has done and is doing.

The word will return with sharp irony. In v. 6, angels who "did not keep" (μὴ τηρήσαντας, *mē tērēsantas*) their position are "kept" (τετήρηκεν, *tetērēken*) in bonds for judgment. In v. 13, the gloom of darkness "has been kept" (τετήρηται, *tetērētai*) for the wandering stars. In v. 21, the readers are told, "keep yourselves" (τηρήσατε, *tērēsate*). From the opening line, Jude is preparing a contrast between two kinds of keeping: keeping for glory and keeping for judgment.

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22. Abbott-Smith, s.v. τηρέω: "to watch over, guard, keep, preserve."↩

"mercy and peace and love"

Most New Testament letters greet their readers with "grace and peace." The pastoral letters to Timothy and 2 John have "grace, mercy, peace." Only Jude has **mercy, peace, and love**.

- **Mercy** (ἔλεος, *eleos*) is God's compassion toward the needy and undeserving. In the Septuagint it most often translates the Hebrew *ḥesed*, God's steadfast covenant love and loyalty.[23] Jude will mention mercy three more times: the readers are to wait for "the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ" (v. 21), and they are to "show mercy" to others (vv. 22–23). The letter begins with mercy given and ends with mercy passed on.
- **Peace** (εἰρήνη, *eirēnē*) carries the full sense of the Hebrew *shalom*: wholeness, safety, right relationship with God and others. In the Septuagint, *eirēnē* chiefly translates *shalom*.[24]
- **Love** (ἀγάπη, *agapē*) picks up "having been loved" from v. 1. It will appear again in a surprising place, the community's "love-feasts" (v. 12), and once more in the command "keep yourselves in the love of God" (v. 21).

The three gifts are not three separate packages. Together they describe the life of the called community: God's mercy received, God's peace enjoyed, God's love shared.

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23. Abbott-Smith, s.v. ἔλεος: "[in LXX chiefly for חֶסֶד] mercy, pity, compassion"; the entry lists Jude 2 among the benedictions and Jude 21 as mercy "of Christ."↩

24. Abbott-Smith, s.v. εἰρήνη: "[in LXX chiefly for שָׁלוֹם] peace."↩

“be multiplied to you!”

The verb πληθυνθείη (*plēthyntheiē*) is an **optative**, the Greek mood used for wishes and prayers. It is rare in the New Testament, which has only about sixty-eight optative forms in all.[25] Jude uses it twice: here and in Michael’s “The LORD rebuke you!” (v. 9).

The wish formula has a history. In the Greek translation of Daniel attributed to Theodotion, the royal letters of Nebuchadnezzar and Darius both open with εἰρήνη ὑμῖν πληθυνθείη, ‘peace be multiplied to you’ (Dan 4:1; 6:26).[26] First and Second Peter use the same formula: “Grace and peace be multiplied to you!” (1 Pet 1:2, LSV; cf. 2 Pet 1:2). Jude uses a familiar form of greeting, apparently at home in Jewish letters, and fills it with his own triad.

The point of “multiplied” is abundance. Jude does not wish his readers a modest share of mercy, peace, and love; he prays that these will grow and overflow. Given the troubles the letter describes, that prayer is not decoration but provision. A community facing division needs more love, not less, and mercy that grows enough to reach those who are wavering (vv. 22–23).

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25. Computed from the MorphGNT/SBLGNT data: 68 verb forms in the optative mood in the whole New Testament.↩

26. Greek Daniel (Theodotion) 4:1 and 6:26, in Brenton’s Greek Septuagint (eBible.org). Abbott-Smith, s.v. πληθύνω, also notes the construction with the dative of person in Daniel.↩

D. Original-Language Investigation

Greek	Transliteration	Basic meaning	In Jude 1–2	Notes and cautions
Ἰούδας	*Ioudas*	Judah/Judas (personal name)	The author	Same name as Judas Iscariot; “Jude” is an English convention.
δοῦλος	*doulos*	slave, bondservant	“servant of Jesus Christ”	Implies belonging and obedience; also an OT honorific (“servant of the LORD”). “Servant” can obscure the ownership language; “slave” can

Greek	Transliteration	Basic meaning	In Jude 1–2	Notes and cautions
				obscure the honor. Both senses are present.
ἀδελφός	*adelphos*	brother; kinsman	“brother of James”	Can mean full brother, half-brother, or relative; see the Historical Introduction’s deep dive.
κλητός	*klētos*	called, invited	“those called”	Placed last for emphasis. In the NT “always of the Divine call” (Abbott-Smith).
ἠγαπημένοις (from ἀγαπάω)	*ēgapēmenois*	having been loved	“having been loved in God [the] Father”	Perfect passive participle: a settled state. Variant ἡγιασμένοις, “sanctified.”
τετηρημένοις (from τηρέω)	*tetērēmenois*	having been kept	“having been kept in Jesus Christ”	Perfect passive participle. Dative “Jesus Christ” may mean *for*, *by*, or *in*.
ἔλεος	*eleos*	mercy, compassion	“mercy”	In LXX chiefly for Hebrew *ḥesed*.
εἰρήνη	*eirēnē*	peace	“peace”	In LXX chiefly for *shalom*: wholeness, security.
ἀγάπη	*agapē*	love	“love”	See caution below.
πληθυνθείη (from πληθύνω)	*plēthyntheiē*	may it be multiplied	“be multiplied”	Aorist passive optative: a wish or prayer.

A caution about *agapē*. Popular teaching often claims that *agapē* and the verb *agapaō* name a uniquely divine, self-giving love, distinct from human affection. The New Testament’s own usage does not support so sharp a distinction. The same verb describes Demas, who deserted Paul, “having loved the present age” (2 Tim 4:10, LSV), and those of whom John says “men loved

the darkness rather than the light" (John 3:19, LSV). Abbott-Smith's lexicon notes that the traditional contrast between *agapaō* and *phileō* rests partly on a disputed etymology.[27] What gives Christian *agapē* its distinctive character is not the word itself but its object and source: the love of God shown in Christ. Jude's usage fits this. The readers are loved *by God*, and they are to keep themselves in *God's* love.

A grammatical note on word order. Greek allows an author to wrap a noun in its descriptions. Jude's "to the … called" encloses "in God the Father loved and for Jesus Christ kept." The arrangement places God the Father and Jesus Christ in parallel as the sources of the readers' security, and it saves the noun of identity for last.

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27. Abbott-Smith, s.v. ἀγαπάω, notes that the distinction from φιλέω is drawn "from its supposed etymology" and is qualified ("If this distinction holds…").↩

E. The Historical and Cultural World

Letter-writing conventions. Thousands of letters survive from the Greco-Roman world, many of them on papyrus from Egypt. The typical opening was brief: "A to B, greetings (χαίρειν, *chairein*)." Jewish letters often used "peace" instead. Christian letter-writers took over the basic form and transformed it, replacing *chairein* with *charis* ("grace") or with theological triads like Jude's, and expanding the descriptions of sender and recipients to make theological claims. Jude's opening is shorter than Paul's, but it is just as deliberate.

Slavery in the Roman world. Slavery was pervasive in the first-century Mediterranean world. Slaves worked in households, farms, mines, workshops, and government offices. Some held positions of considerable responsibility as stewards and agents of their masters, and a slave of a powerful master could share some of that master's status. Calling oneself "a slave of Jesus Christ" therefore said two things at once: complete submission, and representation of a master whose authority exceeded every other. Modern readers should hold both senses without romanticizing an institution that was, for most of those caught in it, brutal.

The family of Jesus. The household of Joseph and Mary in Nazareth was a family of craftsmen (Mark 6:3 calls Jesus "the carpenter"). Hegesippus's account of Jude's grandsons farming a small plot of land suggests a family of modest means in the following generations.[28] By the time Jude wrote, members of this family were known throughout the churches. James led the church in Jerusalem, and "the brothers of the LORD" traveled as missionaries (1 Cor 9:5, LSV). Jude writes from inside this network of relationships, but he presents himself first of all as Christ's servant.

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28. Eusebius, *Ecclesiastical History* 3.20.1–5, quoting Hegesippus.↩

F. Connections Across Scripture

Called and kept (Isa 41–42; Rom 8). The pairing of God's call with God's keeping goes back to Isaiah's portrait of the servant Israel: "I have called you, / And I say to you, You [are] My servant, / I have chosen you, and not rejected you" (Isa 41:9, LSV); "I, YHWH, called you in righteousness, / And I lay hold on your hand, and keep you" (Isa 42:6, LSV). Paul's chain of God's actions in Rom 8:30, "whom He called, these also He declared righteous; and whom He declared righteous, these also He glorified" (LSV), expresses the same confidence that God finishes what he begins. Jude belongs to this stream: those God calls, he holds. This is a shared theme rather than a direct allusion.

Loved by God (Deut 7:7–8; Rom 1:7; 2 Thess 2:13). Israel's election rested on God's love, not on its merit (Deut 7:7–8). Paul addresses Roman believers as "beloved of God, called holy ones" (Rom 1:7, LSV), joining "loved" and "called" as Jude does. Second Thessalonians gives thanks for "brothers, beloved by the LORD, that God chose you from the beginning to salvation" (2 Thess 2:13, LSV).

Kept (John 17; 1 Pet 1:4–5; Rev 3:10). Jesus' prayer, "Holy Father, keep them in Your Name" (John 17:11, LSV), uses the same verb as Jude, τηρέω. So does Jesus' further petition that the Father "keep them out of the evil" (John 17:15, LSV), and his promise in Revelation: "I also will keep you from the hour of the trial" (Rev 3:10, LSV). Peter describes believers as people "who, in the power of God are being guarded, through faith, to salvation" (1 Pet 1:5, LSV). The Aaronic blessing, "YHWH bless you and keep you" (Num 6:24, LSV), stands behind all of this language. These passages share Jude's conviction, though Jude's wording is not drawn directly from any of them.

The greeting formula (Dan 4:1; 6:26; 1 Pet 1:2; 2 Pet 1:2). As noted above, "be multiplied" appears in royal letters in Greek Daniel and in the openings of 1 and 2 Peter. This is a shared epistolary convention rather than a literary dependence.

Mercy in benedictions (Gal 6:16; 1 Tim 1:2; 2 Tim 1:2; 2 John 3). "Mercy" appears in several New Testament blessings, but only Jude combines it with peace *and love*.

G. Scholarly and Theological Questions

1. Who is Jude? This question is treated in the Historical Introduction. For the opening verses, it is enough to note that the self-description "servant of Jesus Christ, and brother of James" is most naturally read as coming from the

brother of Jesus and of James of Jerusalem. Scholars who regard the letter as pseudonymous read it as a later writer's appeal to that family's authority.

2. "Loved" or "sanctified"? The critical editions and the LSV read "loved." The Byzantine tradition reads "sanctified." The meaning differs only slightly, since both describe God's action on behalf of believers. The choice affects how strongly the opening anticipates the letter's theme of love (vv. 2, 12, 21).

3. "Kept for," "by," or "in" Jesus Christ? All three are grammatically possible. The choice affects the emphasis: Christ's return, Christ's agency, or union with Christ.

4. How does God's keeping relate to human responsibility? Jude says that believers *have been kept* (v. 1). He urges them to *keep themselves* (v. 21). He closes by praising the God who *is able to guard* them (v. 24). Christian traditions have related these statements in different ways:

- The **Reformed** tradition reads v. 1 and v. 24 as teaching the perseverance of the saints: those truly called and loved by God will be preserved to the end. On this view the command of v. 21 is the means by which God's keeping is worked out.
- **Wesleyan and Arminian** traditions emphasize that v. 21 is a real command whose neglect has real consequences, and they read the warnings of the letter (especially v. 5) as showing that those once delivered can fall away.
- **Catholic and Orthodox** traditions speak of grace and human cooperation working together, with God's keeping as the ground and enabling power of the believer's perseverance.

Jude himself does not resolve the theological puzzle. He states both sides with equal force and lets them stand together. This book follows his lead. The keeping of God comes first and frames everything, and the call to keep oneself is meant seriously. Readers will weigh the systematic question according to their traditions, but they should notice that Jude saw no contradiction in saying both.

H. The Passage Within Jude

The greeting is the letter's foundation stone. It introduces three threads the rest of the letter will pull tight:

- **Keeping.** The readers are "kept" (v. 1). The rebels are "kept" for judgment (vv. 6, 13). The readers must "keep" themselves (v. 21). God is able to "guard" them (v. 24).
- **Love.** The readers are "loved" (v. 1). Love is wished upon them (v. 2). Their meals are "love-feasts" that intruders spoil (v. 12). They must stay

in “the love of God” (v. 21).
- **Mercy.** Mercy is wished upon them (v. 2). They wait for Christ’s mercy (v. 21). They are to show mercy to others (vv. 22–23).

These threads form a frame. The opening greeting (vv. 1–2) and the closing exhortation and doxology (vv. 20–25) share most of their key words: love, keep, mercy, Jesus Christ, God. Whatever darkness comes between, the readers are meant to read it from inside this frame.

I. Contemporary Understanding

The following reflections suggest ways the passage may inform Christian life today. They are applications, not claims about what Jude’s first readers were thinking.

Identity before instruction. Jude tells his readers who they are before he tells them what to do. Modern Christian teaching often reverses the order and leads with demands. Jude’s order suggests that believers may face hard truths and difficult tasks better when they begin from the security of being called, loved, and kept. For churches facing conflict, this ordering may itself be part of faithful leadership.

Authority without self-promotion. Jude had a family connection to Jesus that few could claim, yet he introduced himself as a servant and named his brother James instead of the Lord. Leaders in churches and Christian organizations today might ask how they present their credentials, and whether their self-descriptions point to themselves or to the one they serve.

Being kept in a world of loss. Many people experience faith as fragile, something they might lose through doubt, failure, or suffering. Jude’s perfect participles (“having been loved,” “having been kept”) describe a settled state grounded in God’s action. They do not deny the reality of struggle; the rest of the letter shows that Jude took struggle seriously. They do offer a place to stand.

Blessing as a practice. Jude’s greeting is a prayer: “mercy and peace and love be multiplied to you!” Christians often greet one another casually. Jude’s opening might encourage the practice of speaking blessing deliberately, in letters, messages, and gatherings, wishing others an abundance of God’s gifts rather than mere pleasantries.

J. Reflection and Discussion

1. Jude describes his readers by what God has done for them (called, loved, kept) before he describes anything they must do. How might this order

change the way you approach the challenges described later in the letter?
2. Why do you think Jude called himself a “servant of Jesus Christ” rather than “brother of the Lord”? What would each description have communicated to his readers?
3. The phrase “kept in [or for, or by] Jesus Christ” can be read three ways. Which reading seems most natural to you, and what difference does the choice make?
4. Jude says believers *have been kept* (v. 1) and must *keep themselves* (v. 21). How do you hold these two statements together? Where have you seen people emphasize one at the expense of the other?
5. Of the three gifts Jude wishes his readers (mercy, peace, love), which do you think your own community most needs “multiplied” right now, and why?

K. Sources

- LSV text of Jude 1–2 and all LSV cross-references: eBible.org LSV edition (see the Copyright page).
- Greek text: SBLGNT, Jude 1–2. Variant data: SBLGNT apparatus and the eBible.org SBLGNT edition with NA28 notes; Robinson–Pierpont 2018; manuscript tallies from the Text-Critical Greek New Testament notes (eBible.org).
- Lexical data: G. Abbott-Smith, *A Manual Greek Lexicon of the New Testament* (Edinburgh: T&T Clark, 1922), s.vv. δοῦλος, κλητός, ἀγαπάω, τηρέω, ἔλεος, εἰρήνη, πληθύνω.
- Greek Daniel (Theodotion) 4:1 and 6:26: Brenton’s Greek Septuagint (eBible.org).
- Clement of Alexandria, *Adumbrationes* on Jude, ANF 2.
- Eusebius, *Ecclesiastical History* 3.19–20 (Hegesippus).
- Optative count: computed from MorphGNT (SBLGNT) data.

Chapter 2. The Faith Entrusted Once for All (Jude 3–4)

A. The Text

> **3** Beloved, using all diligence to write to you concerning our common salvation, I had necessity to write to you, exhorting [you] to fight for the faith once delivered to the holy ones, **4** for there came in certain men stealthily, having been written beforehand to this judgment long ago, impious, perverting the grace of our God to licentiousness, and denying our only Master and Lord—Jesus Christ.
>
> — Jude 3–4, LSV

B. Plain-English Orientation

These two verses give the reason for the letter. Jude had been eager to write to his friends about the salvation they shared. Something forced a change of plan. People had slipped into the community unnoticed, people whose judgment was already on record. They were taking God's grace as permission for immoral living, and in doing so they were denying Jesus Christ, the only Master and Lord. So Jude writes urgently instead, appealing to his readers to contend for the faith that had been handed over to God's people once for all.

Verse 3 states the **purpose** of the letter: an appeal to contend for the faith. Verse 4 states the **occasion**, the intruders. Everything that follows explains and supports these two verses. Verses 5–19 show why the intruders deserve the judgment already "written beforehand," and verses 20–23 show what contending for the faith actually looks like.

C. Phrase-by-Phrase Exploration

"Beloved"

The address ἀγαπητοί (*agapētoi*) echoes "having been loved" in v. 1 and the wish for "love" in v. 2. It is affectionate, and it is also strategic: Jude uses it three times (vv. 3, 17, 20), each at a point where he turns directly to the readers. Before he tells them about the intruders, he reminds them where they stand. They are beloved by God and by him.

“using all diligence to write to you concerning our common salvation”

The Greek phrase πᾶσαν σπουδὴν ποιούμενος (*pasan spoudēn poioumenos*) means “making every effort” or “being very eager.” The word σπουδή (*spoudē*) means haste, diligence, or earnestness. Jude had been fully intent on writing a letter of a different kind, and perhaps had already begun one.

Its subject was to be “our common salvation” (περὶ τῆς κοινῆς ἡμῶν σωτηρίας). The adjective κοινός (*koinos*) means “shared, held in common.” It is the word Luke uses of the first believers who “had all things common” (Acts 2:44, LSV), and Paul calls Titus his “true child according to a common faith” (Titus 1:4, LSV). It does not mean “ordinary.” The salvation Jude wanted to celebrate belongs equally to him and his readers, and perhaps to Jewish and Gentile believers alike. It is the common possession of the whole people of God.

We do not know what that other letter would have contained, or whether Jude ever wrote it. Some readers wish he had. Yet the letter we have is not a departure from the subject of “our common salvation.” It is a defense of it. The salvation he wanted to celebrate is the very thing the intruders threaten.

“I had necessity to write to you”

The change of plan is expressed with strong language: ἀνάγκην ἔσχον (*anankēn eschon*), “I had necessity,” or “I found it necessary,” “I felt compelled.” Paul uses the same noun when he says that “necessity is laid on me” to proclaim the good news (1 Cor 9:16, LSV). Something had happened that left Jude no choice.

There is also a quiet shift in the verb. The first “to write” (γράφειν, *graphein*) is in the present tense, describing the ongoing project he had in mind. The second (γράψαι, *grapsai*) is aorist, describing this particular letter as a single urgent act. The grammar fits the story: a long-planned general letter, interrupted by an immediate and specific one.

“exhorting [you]”

The participle παρακαλῶν (*parakalōn*) means “urging, appealing, exhorting.” It is a warm and pastoral word, from the same family as παράκλητος (*paraklētos*), the title of the Holy Spirit that the LSV renders “Comforter” (John 14:16), and that other versions render ‘Helper’ or ‘Advocate’. Jude does not command his readers like a superior issuing orders. He appeals to them as a brother. The LSV supplies “[you]” because the Greek leaves the object to be understood.

“to fight for the faith”

Here is the heart of the appeal. The verb ἐπαγωνίζεσθαι (*epagōnizesthai*) occurs nowhere else in the New Testament. It belongs to the family of ἀγών (*agōn*), the word for an athletic contest or struggle, from which English gets “agony.” Paul uses related words for the Christian life: “I have striven the good strife” (2 Tim 4:7, LSV); “Be striving the good strife of the faith” (1 Tim 6:12, LSV). The prefix ἐπ- (*ep-*) may add a sense of “for” or “on behalf of,” and the dative case of “the faith” means “contend *for* the faith.” The faith is what the contest defends, not the weapon used in it.

The LSV’s “fight” is vigorous and literal. Other translations have “contend earnestly” (WEB, ASV, KJV) or “contend” (BSB). The image is of exertion, of a struggle that costs effort. It is not an image of violence. The rest of the letter will show what this struggle involves. The intruders are not to be attacked; they are to be recognized for what they are and resisted. The readers’ main task, spelled out in vv. 20–23, is to build themselves up in the faith, to pray, to keep themselves in God’s love, and to show mercy to those who waver. Jude’s contending is defined by his closing instructions, not by the heat of his warnings.

“once delivered to the holy ones”

Three words in this phrase carry great weight.

“Once” translates ἅπαξ (*hapax*), “once, once for all.” The same word describes Christ’s sacrifice: “now He has been revealed once, at the full end of the ages, for [the] annulling of sin through His sacrifice” (Heb 9:26, LSV); “Christ suffered once for sin—righteous for unrighteous—that He might lead us to God” (1 Pet 3:18, LSV). The faith was handed over on a particular occasion, completely. It does not need supplementing by later revelations, and that is exactly the claim the intruders, with their ‘dreams’ (v. 8), appear to have made.

“Delivered” translates παραδοθείσῃ (*paradotheisē*), from παραδίδωμι (*paradidōmi*), “to hand over, pass on.” This is the technical language of tradition. Paul uses it for the most important things he taught: “For I delivered to you as most important what I also received: that Christ died for our sins according to the Writings” (1 Cor 15:3, LSV), and “For I received from the LORD that which I also delivered to you, that the Lord Jesus in the night in which He was delivered up, took bread” (1 Cor 11:23, LSV). Jewish teachers used the same pair of ideas, receiving and handing on, for the transmission of sacred teaching. The Mishnah, compiled around AD 200, opens its tractate *Avot* with a chain of tradition from Moses through Joshua and the elders. Christianity understood itself from the beginning as a message received and passed on through faithful witnesses.

The aorist passive participle presents the delivering as a completed act, with God as the implied giver. The faith did not originate with the church; it was given to the church.

“The holy ones” translates τοῖς ἁγίοις (*tois hagiois*), “the saints.” The LSV’s “holy ones” helps modern readers avoid thinking of a special class of exceptionally virtuous Christians. In the Bible “the holy ones” are God’s people as a whole, set apart for him. Daniel foresees that “the saints of the Most High receive the kingdom” (Dan 7:18, LSV), where the Aramaic word behind “saints” means “holy ones.” The faith was entrusted to the whole community, not to a spiritual elite. That matters, because the intruders, as v. 19 will suggest, seem to have divided the community into ranks.

“for there came in certain men stealthily”

Verse 4 explains why the appeal was necessary. The verb παρεισέδυσαν (*pareisedysan*) is another word found only here in the New Testament. It means “to slip in secretly, steal in.”[29] It pictures someone entering through a side door, unnoticed. Paul uses related language of the “false brothers brought in unaware, who came in secretly to spy out our liberty” (Gal 2:4, LSV), and 2 Peter of false teachers “who will stealthily bring in destructive sects” (2 Pet 2:1, LSV).

The point is not necessarily that the intruders hid their identity. It is that their arrival was not recognized for what it was. They came as fellow believers, perhaps as traveling teachers welcomed according to the customs of Christian hospitality, and only later did their influence become clear. The phrase “certain men” (τινες ἄνθρωποι, *tines anthrōpoi*) is deliberately vague and somewhat dismissive. Jude never names them.

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29. Abbott-Smith, s.v. παρεισδύω: “to slip in secretly, steal in,” noting the form παρεισεδύησαν read by some editions.↩

“having been written beforehand to this judgment long ago”

This is one of the most debated phrases in the letter. The Greek οἱ πάλαι προγεγραμμένοι εἰς τοῦτο τὸ κρίμα (*hoi palai progegrammenoi eis touto to krima*) means literally “those long ago written-beforehand for this judgment.”

- **προγράφω** (*prographō*) means “to write before” or “to write publicly.”[30] Paul uses it for the scriptures: “as many things as were written before, for our instruction were written before” (Rom 15:4, LSV).
- **πάλαι** (*palai*) means “long ago, of old.”[31]
- **κρίμα** (*krima*) means “judgment” or “condemnation,” the verdict and its sentence.

What does it mean that these people were “written beforehand” for judgment? Three main interpretations have been offered.

1. **Written about in earlier prophecies.** The intruders’ judgment was described in advance in the scriptures and prophecies Jude is about to cite: the wilderness generation, the angels, Sodom, Cain, Balaam, Korah, and especially Enoch’s prophecy against the “impious.” “This judgment” points forward to the judgments Jude will describe. On this reading, Jude is saying: *people like these were written about long ago, and what was written about them is about to be read out.* The word “long ago” (πάλαι) fits a prophecy as ancient as Enoch’s. This is the interpretation most modern commentators favor, and the structure of the letter supports it.
2. **Written in heavenly books.** Jewish writings of the period speak of heavenly records in which deeds and destinies are inscribed (for example, the “heavenly tablets” of 1 Enoch 81 and 93:2). Jude might mean that the intruders’ condemnation was already recorded in heaven.
3. **Predestined to condemnation.** Some theological traditions have read the phrase as a statement of individual reprobation, a divine decree that these persons would be condemned. Clement of Alexandria already addressed this, insisting that the intruders were ordained to judgment “not that they might become impious, but that, being now impious, they were ordained to judgment.”[32]

The first interpretation best fits the flow of the letter, which immediately sets out “written” examples of judgment. This book adopts it while acknowledging the others. The phrase is a statement about the certainty of judgment on a certain kind of behavior, not a statement that particular persons were created for damnation. It is also, in context, a word of reassurance. The intruders’ arrival had not taken God by surprise.

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30. Abbott-Smith, s.v. προγράφω: “to write before: Ro 15:4, Eph 3:3, Ju 4. to write in public, placard, proclaim … Ga 3:1.”↩

31. Abbott-Smith, s.v. πάλαι: “long ago, of old, in time past.”↩

32. Clement of Alexandria, *Adumbrationes* on Jude 4, ANF 2 (https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/0211.htm).↩

“impious”

The single word ἀσεβεῖς (*asebeis*), “ungodly, impious,” stands alone in the Greek like a verdict. It is Jude’s key term for the intruders. The noun, verb, and adjective of this word family occur six times in the letter, four of them in the quotation from Enoch: “to convict all their impious ones, concerning all their works of impiety that they did impiously, and concerning all the harsh [words] that impious sinners spoke” (v. 15). By calling the intruders “impious” here, Jude labels them with the very word of the prophecy he will quote. The

asebeia family describes a failure of reverence toward God, a life lived as though God were not to be feared.

“perverting the grace of our God to licentiousness”

This phrase names the intruders’ central error. The participle μετατιθέντες (*metatithentes*), from μετατίθημι (*metatithēmi*), means “to transfer, change,” and here “to make one thing a pretext for another.”[33] The intruders take “the grace of our God” and turn it into **licentiousness**, ἀσέλγεια (*aselgeia*), a word for unrestrained, shameless behavior, often sexual.[34] It appears in the New Testament’s vice lists: “adultery, whoredom, uncleanness, licentiousness” (Gal 5:19, LSV).

The error is ancient and recurring. Paul had to answer it: “Will we continue in sin that grace may abound? … Let it not be!” (Rom 6:1–2, LSV); “you were called to freedom, brothers, only the freedom [is] not for an occasion to the flesh” (Gal 5:13, LSV). Peter warns believers not to have “freedom as the cloak of evil” (1 Pet 2:16, LSV). Titus offers the positive counterpart: “the saving grace of God has appeared to all men, teaching us, that denying the impiety and the worldly desires, we may live soberly, and righteously, and piously in the present age” (Titus 2:11–12, LSV). In Titus, grace teaches the denial of impiety. In Jude, the impious deny the Master and use grace as license.

The intruders probably did not see themselves as opponents of grace. They likely saw themselves as its most consistent champions: if God forgives freely, why should conduct matter? Jude’s verdict is that such a view does not exalt grace; it perverts it.

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33. Abbott-Smith, s.v. μετατίθημι: “to change … fig., i.e. to make one thing a pretext for another, χάριν εἰς ἀσέλγειαν, Ju 4.”↩

34. Abbott-Smith, s.v. ἀσέλγεια: “licentiousness, wantonness, excess.”↩

“and denying our only Master and Lord—Jesus Christ”

The participle ἀρνούμενοι (*arnoumenoi*), “denying,” does not necessarily mean the intruders publicly renounced Christ in words. The New Testament often speaks of denial by conduct: “They profess to know God, but they deny [Him] by their works” (Titus 1:16, LSV). Since the intruders were inside the church, it is likely that they confessed Jesus with their lips while denying his lordship with their lives. To use grace as license is to refuse the authority of the one who gave it.

The titles are striking. **“Master”** translates δεσπότην (*despotēn*), the accusative of δεσπότης (*despotēs*), the word for an owner of slaves and a ruler with absolute authority.[35] In the Septuagint and elsewhere in the New

Testament it is used of God (“LORD, You [are] God, who made the heaven, and the earth,” Acts 4:24, LSV; cf. Luke 2:29). Second Peter uses it of Christ, “denying the Master who bought them” (2 Pet 2:1, LSV). **“Only”** (μόνος, *monos*) is the language of Jewish monotheism. In v. 25, Jude will praise “the only … God our Savior.” To call Jesus “our *only* Master and Lord” is to apply to him language that belongs to the God of Israel. Jude, who calls himself Jesus’ *doulos* in v. 1, now calls him the *despotēs* of all believers.

The LSV’s dash (“our only Master and Lord—Jesus Christ”) makes clear that both titles refer to Jesus. In Greek this is signaled by a single article (τόν, *ton*) governing both nouns, a construction in which two singular personal nouns joined by “and” under one article normally refer to the same person.

A textual note. The Byzantine tradition and the Textus Receptus add θεόν (*theon*), “God”: “the only Master God and our Lord Jesus Christ.” The King James Version translated this as two persons: “denying the only Lord God, and our Lord Jesus Christ.” The WEB, translating the same Majority Text, renders it as one person: “denying our only Master, God, and Lord, Jesus Christ.” The critical editions omit θεόν, and the LSV follows them. On either reading, Jude’s Christology is high.

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35. Abbott-Smith, s.v. δεσπότης: “a master, lord, correlative of δοῦλος”; used “as title of God” and “of Christ, II Pe 2:1, Ju 4.” Abbott-Smith quotes Thayer that δεσπότης “denoted absolute ownership and uncontrolled power.”↩

D. Original-Language Investigation

Greek	Transliteration	Basic meaning	In context	Notes
σπουδή	*spoudē*	haste, diligence, eagerness	“using all diligence”	Eager intent, not anxiety.
κοινός	*koinos*	common, shared	“our common salvation”	“Shared,” not “ordinary”; cf. Titus 1:4.
ἀνάγκη	*anankē*	necessity, compulsion	“I had necessity”	Strong external pressure; cf. 1 Cor 9:16.
παρακαλέω	*parakaleō*	urge, appeal, encourage	“exhorting”	Warm pastoral appeal.
ἐπαγωνίζομαι	*epagōnizomai*	contend for	“to fight for”	NT hapax; athletic/agonistic imagery; dative = “for” the faith. Do not overread the prefix.

Greek	Transliteration	Basic meaning	In context	Notes
πίστις	*pistis*	faith, trust; the faith	“the faith”	Here the *content* believed (as in Gal 1:23), not the act of believing.
ἅπαξ	*hapax*	once, once for all	“once”	Finality and completeness (Heb 9:26; 1 Pet 3:18).
παραδίδωμι	*paradidōmi*	hand over, deliver	“delivered”	Technical term for transmitting tradition (1 Cor 11:2, 23; 15:3).
ἅγιοι	*hagioi*	holy ones, saints	“the holy ones”	All God’s people.
παρεισδύω	*pareisdyō*	slip in secretly	“came in … stealthily”	NT hapax. Some manuscripts (followed by WH) have the variant aorist form παρεισεδύησαν.
προγράφω	*prographō*	write beforehand; placard	“written beforehand”	Rom 15:4 (“written before”); Gal 3:1 (“publicly portrayed”).
πάλαι	*palai*	long ago	“long ago”	Absolute past.
κρίμα	*krima*	judgment, sentence	“this judgment”	Points forward to vv. 5–15.
ἀσεβής	*asebēs*	impious, ungodly	“impious”	Jude’s key word (×6 in the word family).
χάρις	*charis*	grace, favor	“the grace of our God”	SBLGNT reads the rarer accusative form χάριτα.
μετατίθημι	*metatithēmi*	transfer, change	“perverting”	To turn one thing into a pretext for another.
ἀσέλγεια	*aselgeia*	licentiousness, debauchery	“licentiousness”	Shameless excess, often sexual.

Greek	Transliteration	Basic meaning	In context	Notes
δεσπότης	*despotēs*	master, owner, sovereign	“Master”	Of God in LXX/NT; here of Christ.
ἀρνέομαι	*arneomai*	deny, disown, renounce	“denying”	Can be denial by conduct (Titus 1:16).

Two cautions.

1. *Etymology and ἐπαγωνίζομαι.* Because the word is related to *agōn*, sermons sometimes describe Jude’s readers as athletes “agonizing” in the arena. The word does belong to the language of contest, and the image is fair as far as it goes. But the meaning of a rare compound is best derived from its context, not from a picture assembled from its parts. Here the context says only that the readers should exert themselves on behalf of the faith. Jude defines how in vv. 20–23.
2. *“The faith” vs. “faith.”* With the article and with “once delivered,” *pistis* here means the body of belief, not personal trust. That is not a sign of a “later” Christianity: Paul already speaks this way in Gal 1:23. Equally, Jude does not imagine faith as a mere list of propositions. The faith is “most holy” (v. 20), something believers build themselves up on.

E. The Historical and Cultural World

Traveling teachers and Christian hospitality. The early churches depended on traveling apostles, prophets, and teachers, and they extended them hospitality. That openness made communities vulnerable. The *Didache*, an early Christian manual of church practice usually dated between the late first and early second century, gives practical tests for visitors. “Whosoever … comes and teaches you all these things that have been said before, receive him. But if the teacher himself turn and teach another doctrine to the destruction of this, hear him not.” An apostle should stay no more than a day or two, and “if he ask money, he is a false prophet.” “Not every one that speaks in the Spirit is a prophet; but only if he hold the ways of the Lord. Therefore from their ways shall the false prophet and the prophet be known.”[36] These instructions match Jude’s concerns closely: teaching measured against what was handed down, character as the test of a claimed spiritual gift, and suspicion of teachers who seek profit (vv. 11, 16). The *Didache* was not written to Jude’s readers, and the two documents are independent. It does show that the problem Jude faced was a recognized one in the early churches.

Contests and the *agōn*. Athletic games were a major feature of Greco-Roman civic life, and the language of contest (*agōn*, “struggle, competition”) was

widely used metaphorically by philosophers and moralists for the moral life. Hellenistic Jewish writers also used it of faithfulness under persecution. Jude's word draws on this widely understood world of strenuous, disciplined effort.

Tradition in Judaism and early Christianity. Jewish teachers carefully transmitted the interpretation of the Law from teacher to student. Early Christians, many of them Jews, used the same vocabulary of "receiving" and "handing on" for the gospel and for the teachings of Jesus. When Jude speaks of "the faith once delivered," he speaks the language of a community conscious of being entrusted with something it did not invent.

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36. *Didache* 11.1–2, 4–6, 8; 12.1–5, trans. M. B. Riddle, ANF 7 (https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/0714.htm).↩

F. Connections Across Scripture

Contending for the faith (Phil 1:27; 1 Tim 6:12; 2 Tim 4:7). Paul urges the Philippians to stand "with one soul, striving together for the faith of the good news" (Phil 1:27, LSV), using a related compound (συναθλέω, "strive together"). Timothy is told, "Be striving the good strife of the faith" (1 Tim 6:12, LSV), and Paul says of himself, "I have striven the good strife, I have finished the course, I have kept the faith" (2 Tim 4:7, LSV). These are shared themes and vocabulary rather than quotations. Together they show that "contending for the faith" was part of the common moral language of early Christianity.

Guarding a deposit (1 Tim 6:20; 2 Tim 1:14). Paul tells Timothy, "guard the thing entrusted" (1 Tim 6:20, LSV) and "guard the good thing committed through the Holy Spirit that is dwelling in us" (2 Tim 1:14, LSV). The image of a deposit held in trust parallels Jude's faith "once delivered."

Received and delivered (1 Cor 11:23; 15:1–3). The closest verbal parallels are Paul's statements of tradition. Note especially 1 Cor 15:1–2: "the good news that I proclaimed to you, which you also received, in which you also have stood, through which you are also being saved" (LSV). The gospel is received, stood in, and saving, like Jude's "common salvation."

Infiltrators (Gal 2:4; 2 Pet 2:1). Paul's "false brothers brought in unaware, who came in secretly" (Gal 2:4, LSV) offers the nearest Pauline parallel to Jude's "came in … stealthily." The parallel with 2 Pet 2:1 ("stealthily bring in destructive sects, even denying the Master who bought them") is one of the strongest verbal links between Jude and 2 Peter (see Appendix C).

Grace and license (Rom 6:1–2, 15; Gal 5:13; 1 Pet 2:16; Titus 2:11–12). Discussed above. These passages show that the abuse of grace was a danger the apostles recognized and resisted in several places.

Denial by conduct (Titus 1:16; Matt 10:33; 2 Tim 2:12). Jesus warned, “whoever will deny Me before men, I also will deny him before My Father who is in the heavens” (Matt 10:33, LSV). Jude’s charge stands in this line.

G. Scholarly and Theological Questions

1. Did Jude write the other letter? Some have suggested that the planned letter about “our common salvation” might survive elsewhere, for example as 2 Peter. There is no evidence for this, and most scholars regard the question as unanswerable.

2. Is “the faith once delivered” a sign of late authorship? As noted in the Historical Introduction, some scholars see in “the faith” a fixed body of doctrine typical of later “early catholic” Christianity. Others point out that Paul spoke of “the faith” as content (Gal 1:23) and of delivering traditions (1 Cor 11:2, 23; 15:3) in the 50s. The phrase is compatible with an early date.

3. What exactly is “the faith”? Jude does not define it. From the letter itself we can infer that it includes the lordship of Jesus Christ (v. 4), the reality of judgment (vv. 5–15), the grace of God that does not license immorality (v. 4), the apostles’ teaching (v. 17), the work of the Holy Spirit (vv. 19–20), the love of God and the mercy of Christ (v. 21), and the hope of eternal life (v. 21). That is, it includes both belief and the shape of life that belief requires. Christian traditions differ on where this “faith once delivered” is now authoritatively found. Many Protestants locate it in Scripture alone. Catholic and Orthodox Christians locate it in Scripture together with the church’s living tradition. All agree that it was given, not invented.

4. What does “written beforehand” imply about predestination? See the discussion in section C above. The phrase has been read in support of divine reprobation, but the context points most naturally to *recorded prophecies of judgment*, which Jude proceeds to cite.

5. Does “only Master” imply that Jesus is God? Jude does not use the word “God” of Jesus (unless the Byzantine θεόν is original). He does apply to Jesus titles and monotheistic language (“only Master,” “Lord”) that Jewish usage reserved for God. If the reading “Jesus” in v. 5 is original (see Chapter 3), Jude also attributes to Jesus the exodus deliverance, the defining saving act of Israel’s God. Many scholars see Jude as evidence of a very early and very high Christology emerging within Jewish Christianity.

H. The Passage Within Jude

Verses 3 and 4 are the hinge on which the letter turns. Verse 3 states the **appeal**: contend for the faith. Verse 4 states the **reason**: intruders have come

in. The rest of the letter unfolds both:

- Verses 5–19 expand v. 4. They show from scripture, tradition, and prophecy that the intruders' judgment was indeed "written beforehand," and they describe the intruders' "impious" character in detail.
- Verses 20–23 expand v. 3. They show what "contending for the faith" means in practice: building up, praying, keeping, waiting, and showing mercy.

Jude's frequent use of "impious" (vv. 4, 15, 18) and the word "faith" at both ends of this structure (vv. 3, 20) mark these connections.

I. Contemporary Understanding

These are suggested applications, distinct from the text's original meaning.

Contending without contention. Jude's call to "fight for the faith" has often been used to justify combativeness, sometimes over matters far removed from the core of the gospel. Jude's own letter shows a different picture. His concern was the lordship of Christ and the moral meaning of grace, not secondary disputes. His instructions for contending (vv. 20–23) are about spiritual formation and mercy, not argument and exclusion. Christians today might ask whether their "contending" looks like Jude's: urgent about what matters most, and practiced through prayer, love, and rescue.

The faith as gift and trust. "Once delivered to the holy ones" means the faith belongs to the whole people of God and was entrusted, not invented. For modern believers this may be both humbling and freeing. They do not need to create a faith that fits their moment, and they are responsible for passing on what they received.

Grace that teaches. Every generation meets the temptation to treat grace as permission. Jude may help believers see that grace and holiness are not rivals. The grace of God that forgives is the same grace that "teaches" a transformed life (Titus 2:11–12).

Recognizing infiltration without paranoia. Jude's intruders "came in … stealthily," and their influence was recognized only over time. Churches today might learn from the early Christian practice of testing teaching by its fidelity to the received faith and testing teachers by their conduct, as the *Didache* advised. They should do this without turning community life into suspicion of every newcomer. Jude's own ending (vv. 22–23) shows that vigilance and mercy belong together.

J. Reflection and Discussion

1. Jude intended to write about “our common salvation” but felt compelled to write a warning instead. Have you experienced a situation in which encouragement had to give way to correction? How did you decide?
2. What do you think belongs to “the faith once delivered to the holy ones,” and what is secondary? How might different Christian traditions answer this question?
3. The intruders likely saw themselves as champions of grace. How can a community distinguish between a genuine emphasis on grace and the “perverting” of grace that Jude describes?
4. Jude says the intruders denied Jesus as Master and Lord, probably by their conduct rather than their words. In what ways can people confess Jesus with their lips while denying him with their lives?
5. If contending for the faith is defined by vv. 20–23, what would it look like for you or your community to “fight for the faith” this week?

K. Sources

- LSV texts: eBible.org LSV edition. Greek: SBLGNT; variant θεόν from the SBLGNT apparatus (RP) and the Textus Receptus; WEB and KJV renderings from the eBible.org editions.
- Lexical data: Abbott-Smith, *Manual Greek Lexicon*, s.vv. παρεισδύω, προγράφω, πάλαι, μετατίθημι, ἀσέλγεια, δεσπότης, ἐπαγωνίζομαι, ἅπαξ.
- *Didache* 11–12, trans. M. B. Riddle, ANF 7.
- Clement of Alexandria, *Adumbrationes* on Jude, ANF 2.
- Interpretation of “written beforehand” as recorded prophecy: Bauckham, *Jude, 2 Peter*, on v. 4 (cited from prior knowledge).

Chapter 3. Three Ancient Warnings: The Exodus, the Angels, and Sodom (Jude 5–7)

A. The Text

> **5** Now I intend to remind you, you once having known all this, that Jesus, having saved a people out of the land of Egypt, He secondly destroyed those not having believed; **6** messengers also, those who did not keep their own principality, but left their proper dwelling, He has kept in eternal bonds under darkness until [the] judgment of [the] great day, **7** as Sodom and Gomorrah, and the cities around them, in like manner to these [messengers], having given themselves to whoredom, and having gone after other flesh, have been set before [as] an example, undergoing the justice of continuous fire.
>
> — Jude 5–7, LSV

B. Plain-English Orientation

Jude now begins to show why the intruders' judgment was "written beforehand" (v. 4). He reminds his readers of three well-known examples of God's judgment:

1. **The wilderness generation.** The people whom the Lord saved from Egypt were later destroyed when they refused to trust him (v. 5).
2. **The rebellious angels.** Heavenly beings who abandoned their assigned place are now held in darkness until the final judgment (v. 6).
3. **Sodom and Gomorrah.** The cities that pursued sexual immorality and "other flesh" now stand as a warning example of fiery judgment (v. 7).

Each example concerns people or beings who had a privileged position. Israel had been redeemed, the angels had a heavenly station, and Sodom and its neighbors lived in a fertile, well-watered land (Gen 13:10). Each abandoned that position through unbelief, rebellion, or immorality, and each came under judgment. The implication for the intruders, and for anyone tempted to follow them, is plain. Belonging to God's people does not guarantee safety for those who turn grace into license.

Jude's opening, "I intend to remind you," matters too. He is not telling his readers anything new. He is calling to mind what they already know, in a way that makes its present relevance unmistakable.

C. Phrase-by-Phrase Exploration

“Now I intend to remind you, you once having known all this”

The verb ὑπομνῆσαι (*hypomnēsai*), “to remind,” places Jude in the role of a teacher who refreshes memory rather than introducing novelty. That role fits his claim that the faith was delivered “once” (v. 3). The readers already “know all this,” literally “having known all things once” (εἰδότας ὑμᾶς ἅπαξ πάντα, *eidotas hymas hapax panta*). The participle εἰδότας (*eidotas*), “knowing,” is concessive: *although* you know. Second Peter uses the same courtesy, “I will always be ready to remind you about these things, although you have known [them]” (2 Pet 1:12, LSV).

The word ἅπαξ (*hapax*), “once” or “once for all,” has wandered in the manuscripts. In some it stands with “knowing” (“you who once for all knew all things”). In others it moves into the next clause (“the Lord, having *once* saved a people”). The SBLGNT and NA28 place it with “knowing,” and the LSV follows them: “you once having known all this.” The echo of v. 3 is deliberate: the faith was delivered *once for all*, and the readers *once for all* came to know it. What remains is to remember.

“that Jesus, having saved a people out of the land of Egypt”

This is one of the most remarkable phrases in the New Testament, and one of the most debated. The LSV reads **“Jesus.”** Many other translations read **“the Lord”** (WEB, ASV, KJV), and the BSB reads “Jesus” with a note. The difference is not a translation choice. It reflects a difference in the Greek manuscripts, explored in the deep dive below.

If “Jesus” is original, Jude says that Jesus himself, before his human birth, was the one who delivered Israel from Egypt. That is a striking claim, but not an isolated one. Paul says that the Israelites in the wilderness “were drinking of a spiritual rock following them, and the rock was the Christ” (1 Cor 10:4, LSV), and he warns, “neither may we tempt the Christ, as also certain of them tempted” (1 Cor 10:9, LSV). John says that Isaiah “saw His glory, and spoke of Him” (John 12:41, LSV), referring to Jesus and to Isaiah’s vision of the LORD in the temple. Jude’s reading belongs to the same early Christian conviction that the one revealed in Jesus was already active in Israel’s history.

The verb σώσας (*sōsas*), “having saved,” is the ordinary New Testament word for salvation. Its use here recalls the language of the exodus itself: “YHWH saves Israel out of the hand of the Egyptians in that day” (Exod 14:30, LSV). The exodus was Israel’s defining experience of salvation. Jude’s point depends on this. The people who were later destroyed were not outsiders; they had been *saved*.

“He secondly destroyed those not having believed”

The phrase τὸ δεύτερον (*to deuteron*) literally means “the second time” or “secondly.” It can simply mean “afterward” (WEB: “afterward destroyed”), but its natural sense sets two acts side by side: first salvation, then destruction. The LSV keeps the literal “secondly.”

The reference is to the wilderness generation, which refused to enter the promised land after the report of the spies. God says to Moses, “Until when do they not believe in Me, for all the signs which I have done in its midst?” (Num 14:11, LSV). The sentence follows: “Your carcasses fall in this wilderness … who have murmured against Me” (Num 14:29, LSV). The aorist participle “those not having believed” (τοὺς μὴ πιστεύσαντας, *tous mē pisteusantas*) sums up the whole episode.

The warning in Jude’s first example is the most pointed of the three, because it concerns *God’s own redeemed people*. The intruders are inside the church. They share its meals and claim its grace. Jude’s readers might suppose that being among the saved is protection enough. The wilderness generation shows otherwise. The early church used this example often: Paul in 1 Corinthians 10 and the author of Hebrews (“we see that they were not able to enter in because of unbelief,” Heb 3:19, LSV). Jude uses it first in his series, perhaps for that reason.

“messengers also, those who did not keep their own principality”

The LSV’s “messengers” translates ἀγγέλους (*angelous*), the ordinary word for “messengers” that, in a heavenly context, means “angels.” The LSV renders it consistently as “messengers,” but the context makes clear that heavenly beings are meant.

These angels “did not keep” (μὴ τηρήσαντας, *mē tērēsantas*) “their own principality” (τὴν ἑαυτῶν ἀρχήν, *tēn heautōn archēn*). The word ἀρχή (*archē*) means “beginning,” “rule,” or “domain.” Here it most likely means the position of authority and the sphere of responsibility God had assigned them. The New Testament can call angelic powers “principalities” (ἀρχαί, *archai*; e.g., Rom 8:38; Eph 6:12). The LSV’s “principality” preserves that link. The WEB has “their first domain,” the ASV “their own principality,” and the BSB “their positions of authority.”

Note the first play on “keep.” The readers have been “kept” (v. 1). These angels did not “keep” what God had given them.

“but left their proper dwelling”

The angels also “left” or “abandoned” (ἀπολιπόντας, *apolipontas*) “their proper dwelling” (τὸ ἴδιον οἰκητήριον, *to idion oikētērion*). An οἰκητήριον is a habitation, a dwelling place.[37] Paul uses the same rare word for the resurrection body: “our dwelling that is from Heaven” (2 Cor 5:2, LSV). The angels’ proper home was heaven. They left it.

Which angels, and what did they do? Jude assumes his readers know the story. As the deep dive below shows, they almost certainly did: it is the story of the “sons of God” who took human wives in Genesis 6:1–4, as expanded in the Jewish tradition preserved in 1 Enoch.

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37. Abbott-Smith, s.v. οἰκητήριον: “a habitation: Ju 6; trop., II Co 5:2.”↩

“He has kept in eternal bonds under darkness until [the] judgment of [the] great day”

Now comes the second, ironic “keep.” The angels who did not *keep* their position, God “has kept” (τετήρηκεν, *tetērēken*, perfect tense: has kept and still keeps) under guard. Jude’s wordplay states a principle: those who refuse to keep their God-given place are themselves kept, for judgment.

- **“Eternal bonds”** (δεσμοῖς ἀϊδίοις, *desmois aidiois*). The adjective ἀΐδιος (*aidios*), “everlasting,” appears elsewhere in the New Testament only in Rom 1:20, of God’s “eternal power.” The “bonds” are chains of imprisonment.
- **“Under darkness”** (ὑπὸ ζόφον, *hypo zophon*). The word ζόφος (*zophos*) means deep gloom. In Homer it was used of the gloom of the underworld.[38] It appears again in v. 13 (“the gloom of the darkness”) and in the parallel passages of 2 Peter (2:4, 17).
- **“Until [the] judgment of [the] great day”** (εἰς κρίσιν μεγάλης ἡμέρας, *eis krisin megalēs hēmeras*). The imprisonment is not the final penalty. It is custody awaiting trial. The “great day” is the final judgment, the “day of the LORD” of the prophets.

These phrases match the language of 1 Enoch closely, as the deep dive shows.

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38. Abbott-Smith, s.v. ζόφος: “in Hom. the gloom of the under-world; hence, darkness, deep gloom … He 12:18, II Pe 2:4, 17, Ju 6, 13.”↩

“as Sodom and Gomorrah, and the cities around them”

The third example, Σόδομα καὶ Γόμορρα (*Sodoma kai Gomorra*), is the most famous. Genesis 19 tells how God “rained on Sodom and on Gomorrah brimstone and fire from YHWH, from the heavens; and He overthrows these cities, and all the circuit” (Gen 19:24–25, LSV). The “cities around them” (αἱ

περὶ αὐτὰς πόλεις, *hai peri autas poleis*) are Admah and Zeboim, named in Deut 29:23 and Hos 11:8 as destroyed with Sodom and Gomorrah. (Zoar, the fifth city of the plain, was spared at Lot's request.)

"in like manner to these [messengers]"

The Greek τὸν ὅμοιον τρόπον τούτοις (*ton homoion tropon toutois*) means "in the same way as these." Grammatically, "these" (τούτοις, *toutois*) is masculine, so it cannot refer to the cities (πόλεις, *poleis*), which is feminine. It most naturally refers to the nearest masculine plural, the angels of v. 6. The LSV makes this explicit by supplying "[messengers]" in brackets. (Some interpreters have suggested that "these" looks ahead to the intruders of v. 8, but the immediate sense is a comparison between Sodom and the angels.)

So the comparison is this: *the cities sinned in the same way as the angels*. In what way? The next phrases answer.

"having given themselves to whoredom"

The participle ἐκπορνεύσασαι (*ekporneusasai*) is a strengthened form of the common verb for sexual immorality, πορνεύω (*porneuō*). Its prefix ἐκ- (*ek-*) suggests going to excess, "giving oneself up to fornication."[39] The word occurs nowhere else in the New Testament. In the Septuagint it often describes Israel's spiritual unfaithfulness, pictured as prostitution, but here, as the following phrase shows, the sense is literal.

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39. Abbott-Smith, s.v. ἐκπορνεύω: "strengthened form of πορνεύω, implying excessive indulgence; mid., to give oneself up to fornication: Ju 7."↩

"and having gone after other flesh"

The phrase ἀπελθοῦσαι ὀπίσω σαρκὸς ἑτέρας (*apelthousai opisō sarkos heteras*) means literally "having gone away after other (or different) flesh." The KJV's famous "strange flesh" and the WEB's "strange flesh" translate it. The BSB has "perversion." The LSV keeps the literal "other flesh."

What is "other flesh"? This phrase has become a flashpoint in modern debates about sexuality, and it needs careful handling. The deep dive below sets out the evidence. In brief, the parallel Jude has just drawn with the angels ("in like manner to these") strongly suggests the following: as the angels crossed the boundary between heaven and earth to unite with human women, so the men of Sodom sought sexual relations with beings of a different order, namely the angels who visited Lot (Gen 19:1–5). On this reading, "other flesh" refers above all to the attempted violation of the angelic visitors. Jude's emphasis falls on the transgression of the created order.

“have been set before [as] an example”

The verb πρόκεινται (*prokeintai*), “they are set forth, displayed,” is in the present tense: the cities *are* still set forth. The noun δεῖγμα (*deigma*), another New Testament hapax, means “a thing shown,” a specimen or example, and here a warning example.[40] Second Peter uses the related ὑπόδειγμα (*hypodeigma*): “having set [them as] an example to those about to be impious” (2 Pet 2:6, LSV).

Ancient readers believed they could still see the evidence. The region around the southern end of the Dead Sea, desolate, salty, and sulfurous, was identified with the ruined cities. The Wisdom of Solomon says of them: “even to this day the waste land that smoketh is a testimony, and plants bearing fruit that never come to ripeness: and a standing pillar of salt is a monument of an unbelieving soul” (Wis 10:7, Brenton).[41] Third Maccabees says that God made the Sodomites “an example to after generations” (3 Macc 2:5, Brenton).

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40. Abbott-Smith, s.v. δεῖγμα: “(cl.) a thing shown, a specimen. = cl. παράδ- (cf. ὑπόδ-, II Pe 2:6), an example (a warning): Ju 7.”↩

41. Wisdom 10:7 and 3 Maccabees 2:5, in Brenton’s English Septuagint (eBible.org). The Greek of 3 Macc 2:5 reads παράδειγμα τοῖς ἐπιγινομένοις καταστήσας (“having established [them as] an example to those coming after”).↩

“undergoing the justice of continuous fire”

The present participle ὑπέχουσαι (*hypechousai*), “undergoing,” also unique in the New Testament, means “to undergo, suffer” a penalty.[42] The noun δίκη (*dikē*), “justice,” here means the execution of a sentence, punishment. The phrase πυρὸς αἰωνίου (*pyros aiōniou*) is “eternal fire,” which the LSV renders “continuous fire,” in keeping with its consistent treatment of αἰώνιος (*aiōnios*).

Two senses may be combined. The visible, smoking desolation of the region was understood as an ongoing display of the fire that destroyed the cities. That fire also pointed beyond itself to the “continuous fire that has been prepared for the Devil and his messengers” (Matt 25:41, LSV). The cities are an example *because* their temporal destruction prefigures final judgment. Jesus made the same connection: “it will be more tolerable for the land of Sodom and Gomorrah in the day of judgment than for that city” (Matt 10:15, LSV).

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42. Abbott-Smith, s.v. ὑπέχω: “to undergo, suffer: δίκην, Ju 7 (Soph., Eur., al.).”↩

D. Original-Language Investigation

Greek	Transliteration	Basic meaning	In context	Notes
ὑπομιμνῄσκω	*hypomimnēskō*	remind	“I intend to remind you”	Calling to mind the known, not teaching the new.
εἰδότας	*eidotas*	knowing (perf. ptc. of οἶδα)	“you once having known”	Concessive: “although you know.”
ἅπαξ	*hapax*	once, once for all	“once”	Position varies in manuscripts (see deep dive).
Ἰησοῦς / κύριος	*Iēsous* / *kyrios*	Jesus / Lord	“Jesus”	Major variant (deep dive).
σῴζω	*sōzō*	save, deliver	“having saved”	Exodus salvation.
τὸ δεύτερον	*to deuteron*	the second time, afterward	“secondly”	Contrasts salvation and destruction.
ἀρχή	*archē*	beginning; rule, domain	“principality”	Assigned position and authority.
οἰκητήριον	*oikētērion*	dwelling, habitation	“proper dwelling”	Elsewhere only 2 Cor 5:2.
ἀΐδιος	*aidios*	everlasting	“eternal bonds”	Elsewhere only Rom 1:20. In later Greek not sharply distinct from αἰώνιος.[43]
ζόφος	*zophos*	gloom, deep darkness	“under darkness”	Homeric “gloom of the underworld”; also v. 13; 2 Pet 2:4, 17; Heb 12:18.
τηρέω	*tēreō*	keep, guard	“did not keep … has kept”	Wordplay.
ἐκπορνεύω	*ekporneuō*	give oneself to fornication	“given themselves to whoredom”	NT hapax; intensive.
σὰρξ ἑτέρα	*sarx hetera*	other/different flesh	“other flesh”	See deep dive on Sodom.
πρόκειμαι	*prokeimai*	be set forth, displayed	“set before”	Present tense: still displayed.
δεῖγμα	*deigma*	specimen, example	“an example”	NT hapax; 2 Pet 2:6 has

Greek	Transliteration	Basic meaning	In context	Notes
				ὑπόδειγμα.
δίκη	*dikē*	justice; penalty	“the justice”	Execution of a sentence.
ὑπέχω	*hypechō*	undergo, suffer	“undergoing”	NT hapax; with δίκην = “suffer punishment.”
αἰώνιος	*aiōnios*	eternal, age-long	“continuous”	LSV’s consistent rendering.

On “eternal” and “continuous.” The LSV’s “continuous” for αἰώνιος reflects a decision to translate the word by its root, αἰών (*aiōn*, “age”), rather than by the traditional “eternal.” Whether αἰώνιος in the New Testament means “unending” or “belonging to the age to come” has long been discussed, and the word can carry both ideas: the life and judgment of the coming age, which does not end. Readers should not build a doctrine of the duration of judgment on the LSV’s English choice alone, any more than on “eternal.” The theology must be built from the whole biblical witness.

Deep dive: “Jesus … saved a people out of Egypt” — the text of Jude 5

The Greek manuscripts of Jude 5 are a tangle. The two main points of variation are (a) the name of the one who saved the people and (b) the position of “once.”

The readings. According to the SBLGNT apparatus and its updated form citing NA28:[44]

Edition	Reading of the key words
SBLGNT (2010), NA28 (2012)	εἰδότας ὑμᾶς ἅπαξ πάντα ὅτι **Ἰησοῦς** λαὸν… (“knowing all things once, that **Jesus**…”)
NA27 (1993)	…πάντα ὅτι **ὁ κύριος ἅπαξ** λαὸν… (“that **the Lord**, having *once* saved…”)
Westcott–Hort (1881), Tregelles	…ἅπαξ πάντα ὅτι **κύριος**… (“that **[the] Lord**…”)
Robinson–Pierpont (Byzantine), TR	εἰδότας ὑμᾶς ἅπαξ **τοῦτο** ὅτι **ὁ κύριος**… (“once knowing **this**, that **the Lord**…”)

The great majority of later Byzantine manuscripts read “the Lord.” According to the tallies in one modern edition, the Byzantine wording appears in about 69 percent of manuscripts and the wording with “Jesus” in a fraction of one percent.[45] The earliest manuscripts, however, divide differently. “Jesus” is the reading of two of the most important early codices, Alexandrinus (A, fifth

century) and Vaticanus (B, fourth century), together with other early witnesses. The earliest surviving papyrus of Jude, P72 (third or fourth century), has the remarkable reading θεὸς Χριστός, "God Christ." Other manuscripts read "God."[46]

How did the committee decide? When the United Bible Societies committee prepared the text that became NA27, the majority chose "the Lord." Bruce Metzger's *Textual Commentary* reports that two members of the committee, Metzger himself and Allen Wikgren, dissented, arguing that critical principles favored "Jesus" as the best-attested reading.[47] By the time of NA28 (2012), which followed the *Editio Critica Maior* for the Catholic Letters, the editors had adopted "Jesus," as the SBLGNT (2010) had already done independently.

The arguments.

For "Jesus":

1. **Strong early attestation** in important manuscripts and early translations.
2. **It is the harder reading.** Scribes were more likely to change a surprising "Jesus" into an unproblematic "the Lord" than the reverse. A scribe copying "Jesus saved a people out of Egypt" might suppose that the historical Jesus was meant, find the statement impossible, and "correct" it.
3. **It explains the other readings.** "Lord," "God," and "God Christ" can all be understood as attempts to resolve the difficulty of "Jesus."
4. **A possible scribal mechanism.** In manuscripts, sacred names were abbreviated: ΙΣ for "Jesus" and ΚΣ for "Lord." These differ by one letter, so confusion in either direction was possible. This cuts both ways, though, and does not decide the question.

For "the Lord":

1. **"Lord" is Jude's usual word for God and Christ** (vv. 4, 9, 14, 17, 21, 25). A reading that uses "Jesus" for the pre-existent Christ would be unusual.
2. Some scholars judge that "Jesus" acting in the exodus is so unexpected that it is more likely a scribal slip (ΚΣ to ΙΣ) than an original reading.

Scholarly discussion continues. In 2007 Timo Flink argued that the reading "Jesus" has no parallel that a scribe could have imitated and is therefore hard to explain as an invention.[48] Others have defended "the Lord." What can be said with confidence is that "Jesus" is now the reading of the most widely used critical editions, of the SBLGNT on which this book is based, and of the LSV, and that it is very well attested.

What does it mean? If Jude wrote “Jesus,” he identifies the one who saved Israel from Egypt with Jesus Christ. He does not imply that the man from Nazareth lived in the second millennium BC. Rather, the one who became incarnate as Jesus already existed and acted as Israel’s deliverer. Christian theology calls this the **pre-existence** of Christ. It is affirmed elsewhere in the New Testament (John 1:1–3; 8:58; Phil 2:6–7; Col 1:15–17; Heb 1:2), and 1 Cor 10:4, 9 apply it specifically to the wilderness. Some interpreters connect it further with the mysterious “Messenger” of Exodus who leads Israel and of whom God says, “My Name [is] in His heart” (Exod 23:21, LSV). Jude does not develop the idea. He simply states it, as if it were already familiar to his readers.

If Jude wrote “the Lord,” he almost certainly still meant to evoke the same God whose lordship is now exercised by Jesus. Note that Jude calls Jesus “our only Master and Lord” in the previous verse (v. 4). On either reading, the warning is the same: the Lord who saves can also judge those who, having been saved, refuse to believe.

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43. Abbott-Smith, s.v. ἀΐδιος: “The etymological distinction between the meanings of the two words seems not to be retained in late Greek.”↩

44. SBLGNT apparatus for Jude 5 (https://www.sblgnt.com/download/86-Jud-APP.txt) and the eBible.org SBLGNT edition’s updated notes: “Ἰησοῦς NA28] κύριος WH Treg; ὁ κύριος NIV RP; ὁ κύριος ἅπαξ NA27.”↩

45. Text-Critical Greek NT notes (eBible.org `grctcgnt`): “υμας απαξ τουτο οτι ο κυριος 69.4% … υμας απαξ παντα οτι ιησους NA SBL 0.2%.” These percentages count manuscripts without weighing them.↩

46. The witness information for A, B, and P72 is drawn from the standard critical apparatuses and the discussions cited in nn. 11–12. It was not re-verified against a printed apparatus in this edition’s research (see the Bibliography’s verification notes).↩

47. Bruce M. Metzger, *A Textual Commentary on the Greek New Testament*, 2nd ed. (Stuttgart: Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft, 1994), on Jude 5.↩

48. Timo Flink, “Reconsidering the Text of Jude 5, 13, 15 and 18,” *Filologia Neotestamentaria* 20 (2007): 95–125. See also Philipp F. Bartholomä, “Did Jesus Save the People out of Egypt? A Re-examination of a Textual Problem in Jude 5,” *Novum Testamentum* 50 (2008): 143–58.↩

Deep dive: angels and the judgment traditions

Who were the angels “who did not keep their own principality, but left their proper dwelling”? The Old Testament offers only one story that fits: Genesis 6:1–4.

> **1** And it comes to pass that mankind has begun to multiply on the face of the ground, and daughters have been born to them, **2** and the sons

> of God see that they, the daughters of men, [are] beautiful, and they take women for themselves of all whom they have chosen. … **4** The giants were in the earth in those days, and even afterward, when sons of God come in to the daughters of men, and they have borne to them those who [were] the mighty from of old, the men of renown.
>
> — Gen 6:1–4, LSV

Genesis does not say that the “sons of God” were punished, or even that they were angels. By the time of Jude, however, an elaborate Jewish tradition had grown up around these verses. Its fullest surviving form is the “Book of the Watchers,” 1 Enoch 1–36, usually dated to the third century BC or earlier. In it, two hundred angels called “Watchers” descend to earth, take human wives, father the giants, and teach humanity forbidden arts. God then sends his archangels to bind them:

> And again the Lord said to Raphael: ‘Bind Azâzêl hand and foot, and cast him into the darkness: and make an opening in the desert … and cast him therein. And place upon him rough and jagged rocks, and cover him with darkness, and let him abide there for ever, and cover his face that he may not see light. And on the day of the great judgement he shall be cast into the fire.’
>
> — 1 Enoch 10:4–6 (trans. R. H. Charles)[49]

And to Michael:

> ‘Go, bind Semjâzâ and his associates who have united themselves with women so as to have defiled themselves with them in all their uncleanness. And when their sons have slain one another … bind them fast for seventy generations in the valleys of the earth, till the day of their judgement and of their consummation …’
>
> — 1 Enoch 10:11–12 (trans. R. H. Charles)

The correspondences with Jude 6 are close:

Jude 6	1 Enoch
“did not keep their own principality, but left their proper dwelling”	The Watchers abandon heaven for earth (1 Enoch 6–7; 12:4; 15:3, 7)
“in eternal bonds”	“Bind … hand and foot”; “bind them fast” (10:4, 12)
“under darkness”	“cast him into the darkness … cover him with darkness” (10:4–5)
“until [the] judgment of [the] great day”	“on the day of the great judgement” (10:6); “till the day of their judgement” (10:12)

Jude quotes 1 Enoch explicitly in vv. 14–15, so there is little doubt that he knew this tradition and expected his readers to know it. Second Peter's parallel adds the term "Tartarus," the Greek name for the deepest prison of the underworld: "God did not spare messengers having sinned, but having cast [them] down to Tartarus with chains of deepest gloom, delivered [them], having been reserved to judgment" (2 Pet 2:4, LSV). First Peter's mysterious reference to "the spirits in prison, who sometime [ago] disobeyed … in [the] days of Noah" (1 Pet 3:19–20, LSV) probably belongs to the same circle of ideas.

The tradition also appears in other Jewish writings of the period. The *Testament of Naphtali*, discussed below, pairs the Watchers with Sodom exactly as Jude does. Sirach says that God "was not pacified toward the old giants" (Sir 16:7, Brenton). Third Maccabees recalls that God destroyed "the giants, who trusted in their strength and hardihood" (3 Macc 2:4, Brenton). The fall of the Watchers was a standard example of judgment in Second Temple Judaism, and Jude uses it the way his contemporaries did.

Other interpretations. Later Christian interpreters moved away from the angelic reading of Genesis 6. Augustine argued that the "sons of God" were "according to the flesh the sons of Seth" who intermarried with the ungodly line of Cain, and he insisted that angels, being spiritual, could not father children.[50] Many readers have followed him, and others have read Jude 6 as a reference to an original fall of Satan and his angels before creation (cf. Rev 12:7–9), unconnected with Genesis 6. Both views are defensible as readings of Genesis in its own right. They fit Jude less well, because Jude's vocabulary tracks 1 Enoch's account of the Watchers, his next verse compares the angels' sin to Sodom's sexual sin, and he quotes 1 Enoch a few lines later. Clement of Alexandria, an early commentator, read Jude 6 of angels who "left their own habitation, meaning, that is, the heaven and the stars," and took the "chains" as "the loss of the honour in which they had stood."[51]

What Jude affirms, and what he does not. Jude affirms that some heavenly beings rebelled, that they are under restraint, and that they await final judgment. He does not provide a full angelology, a description of their prison, or a timetable. He uses a story his readers knew to make a single point: *even angels who abandoned their God-given place did not escape judgment.* How much of the surrounding Enochic narrative Jude believed to be historical is a separate question, taken up in Chapter 8.

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49. R. H. Charles, *The Book of Enoch* (London: SPCK, 1917), 1 Enoch 10:4–6, 11–12; Wikisource transcription. Charles's typographical marks are omitted.↩

50. Augustine, *City of God* 15.23 (NPNF¹ 2; https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/120115.htm).↩

51. Clement of Alexandria, *Adumbrationes* on Jude 6, ANF 2.↩

Deep dive: Sodom and Gomorrah

Sodom and Gomorrah became the Bible's standard example of total destruction. Moses warns Israel that disobedience would leave the land "like the overthrow of Sodom and Gomorrah, Admah and Zeboim" (Deut 29:23, LSV). Isaiah calls Jerusalem's rulers "you rulers of Sodom" (Isa 1:10, LSV). Jesus says the coming of the Son of Man will be like the days of Lot, when "He rained fire and brimstone from the sky, and destroyed all" (Luke 17:29, LSV). Paul and Peter both cite the cities. But what, according to the Bible and early Jewish tradition, was Sodom's sin?

The biblical evidence.

- **Genesis 18–19.** The outcry against Sodom was already great before the angels arrived: "The cry of Sodom and Gomorrah—because great; and their sin—because exceedingly grievous" (Gen 18:20, LSV). The episode in Gen 19:4–5 shows the city's character in action. The men of the city, "from young even to aged," surround Lot's house and demand that the visitors be brought out "and we know them" (LSV), that is, for sexual assault. The scene combines violent sexual aggression, the violation of guests whom hospitality required Lot to protect, and the fact that the guests were angels.
- **Ezekiel 16:49–50.** Ezekiel names the sins of "your sister Sodom" as "Arrogancy, fullness of bread, and quiet ease," the failure to strengthen "the hand of the afflicted and needy," and adds, "they are haughty and do abomination before Me" (LSV). Ezekiel's emphasis is on pride, complacent wealth, and neglect of the poor, with "abomination" as a further charge.
- **Isaiah 1:10** and **Jeremiah 23:14** use Sodom as a byword for injustice and moral corruption in Jerusalem.

The Second Temple evidence. Jewish writers of Jude's era gave the story different emphases:

- **Pride and insolence:** God "abhorred them for their pride" (Sir 16:8, Brenton). God destroyed "the Sodomites, those workers of exceeding iniquity" for their pride and insolence (3 Macc 2:5).
- **Hostility to strangers and sexual practices:** Josephus writes that "the Sodomites grew proud, on account of their riches and great wealth; they became unjust towards men, and impious towards God … they hated strangers, and abused themselves with Sodomitical practices."[52]
- **Gluttony, debauchery, and same-sex relations:** Philo of Alexandria describes Sodom as "full of innumerable iniquities, and especially of gluttony and debauchery," and says that its men "not only … went mad after women, and defile[d] the marriage bed of others, but also those who were men lusted after one another."[53]

- **Changing the order of nature, paired with the Watchers:** The *Testament of Naphtali* urges its readers to recognize the Lord in creation, "that you become not as Sodom, which changed the order of its nature, in like manner also the Watchers changed the order of their nature, whom also the Lord cursed at the flood."[54]

The last text is especially important for Jude, because it makes exactly Jude's pairing. **Sodom and the Watchers are linked as two instances of transgressing the order of nature God established.** The Watchers crossed from heaven to earth to unite with human women. Sodom's men sought to violate heavenly visitors. Jude's "in like manner to these … having gone after other flesh" fits this pattern precisely.

What "other flesh" means in Jude. Three readings are found among interpreters:

1. **Angelic flesh.** "Other" (ἑτέρα, *hetera*) means "of a different kind." The men of Sodom pursued sexual union with beings who were not human, the counterpart of the angels' pursuit of human women. This is the reading most modern critical commentators favor, because it makes the best sense of "in like manner to these" and of the Testament of Naphtali parallel.
2. **Same-sex relations.** "Other" means "contrary to nature," and Jude refers to homosexual acts, which Philo and Josephus associated with Sodom. This reading is traditional in much Christian interpretation.
3. **Sexual immorality in general**, with the angelic and same-sex dimensions both included in the description of the city's excess.

The first reading best explains Jude's comparison, and this book adopts it as the primary sense. Two cautions follow from it. First, Jude 7 should not be made to carry more than it says. The phrase's main reference is to the attempted violation of angels, and Jude does not address modern questions about committed same-sex relationships. Those questions are usually argued from other texts (for example Lev 18:22 and Rom 1:26–27), and readers should weigh those passages on their own terms. Second, the opposite overcorrection is equally mistaken: Jude clearly condemns *sexual immorality* ("having given themselves to whoredom"). Sodom in Jude is not merely a symbol of inhospitality, even though inhospitality and violence were part of its sin. Honest reading lets Jude say what he says and no more.

Why Sodom fits Jude's argument. Jude's three examples move from God's people (Israel), to heavenly beings (angels), to pagan cities (Sodom). The circle widens to show that judgment reaches every order of creation. All three share one feature: *they left the place God gave them*. Israel left trust for unbelief, the angels left heaven for earth, and Sodom left the order of creation for the pursuit of "other flesh." The intruders, Jude will say, do "in like manner" (v. 8).

52. Josephus, *Antiquities* 1.11.1 (Whiston), Project Gutenberg #2848.↩

53. Philo, *On Abraham* 133–135, trans. C. D. Yonge, https://www.earlyjewishwritings.com/text/philo/book22.html.↩

54. *Testament of Naphtali* 3:4–5, trans. R. Sinker, ANF 8 (https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/0801.htm).↩

E. The Historical and Cultural World

The exodus in Jewish memory. The exodus from Egypt was the central saving event of Israel's story, recited at Passover, celebrated in the Psalms, and used by the prophets as the pattern for future deliverance. The wilderness generation's failure was equally remembered, as a warning. Psalm 95, sung in synagogue and church, ends with God's oath: "Forty years I am weary of the generation, … Where I swore in My anger" that they would not enter his rest (Ps 95:10–11, LSV). Jude's readers would have known both sides of the story.

Angels in Second Temple Judaism. Jewish thought between the Testaments developed a rich angelology: named archangels (Michael, Gabriel, Raphael, Uriel), angelic hierarchies, guardian angels of nations, and fallen angels. The Dead Sea Scrolls, 1 Enoch, Jubilees, and other writings show how widely these ideas were held. Jude's casual reference to rebellious angels and, in v. 9, to Michael the archangel shows that he and his readers shared this world of thought.

The Dead Sea region. The southern end of the Dead Sea, with its salt formations, bitumen, and barren landscape, was identified in antiquity with the destroyed cities of the plain. Wisdom 10:7, quoted above, speaks of its "waste land that smoketh" and its pillar of salt. Josephus also describes the region.[55] For Jude's readers, the "example" was not only a story but a place.

55. Josephus, *Antiquities* 1.11.4 and *Jewish War* 4.8.4, describe the region of the Dead Sea and Lot's wife (cited from prior knowledge; not re-verified in this edition).↩

F. Connections Across Scripture

1 Corinthians 10:1–11 (close thematic parallel). Paul's use of the wilderness generation is the closest parallel to Jude 5. All Israel "passed through the sea … and all ate the same spiritual food," yet "in the most of them God was not well pleased, for they were strewn in the wilderness" (1 Cor 10:1, 3, 5, LSV). Paul identifies the rock as "the Christ" (10:4) and warns against tempting "the Christ" (10:9). His conclusion, "these things happened to those persons as types, and they were written for our admonition" (10:11,

LSV), is exactly Jude's use of the story. The texts share a tradition of interpretation, but neither is likely quoting the other.

Hebrews 3:16–19 (close thematic parallel). "Was it not with those who sinned, whose carcasses fell in the wilderness? … they were not able to enter in because of unbelief" (Heb 3:17, 19, LSV). Hebrews stresses unbelief just as Jude does ("those not having believed").

2 Peter 2:4–9 (literary parallel). Peter's version lists angels, the flood, and Sodom, in biblical order. It adds Noah and Lot as examples of the righteous rescued and concludes: "the LORD has known to rescue [the] pious out of temptation, and to keep [the] unrighteous being punished to [the] day of judgment" (2 Pet 2:9, LSV). The relationship to Jude is discussed in the Introduction and Appendix C.

Matthew 25:41; Revelation 20:10 (shared theme). The "continuous fire that has been prepared for the Devil and his messengers" (Matt 25:41, LSV) connects the fate of rebellious angels and the fire of judgment, the same two ideas that Jude 6–7 places side by side.

Exodus 23:20–21 (possible background). The Messenger in whom God's Name dwells and who leads Israel through the wilderness has been connected by some interpreters with Jude's "Jesus" in v. 5. This is a suggestive connection, not a demonstrated allusion.

G. Scholarly and Theological Questions

1. "Jesus" or "the Lord" in v. 5? Discussed in the deep dive. The reading "Jesus" is strongly attested and is now printed in the main critical editions, but a minority of scholars still prefers "the Lord."

2. Can the redeemed be destroyed? Jude's first example concerns people who were genuinely saved from Egypt and later destroyed for unbelief. Christian traditions read this differently. Some see in it a warning that those who were once part of the redeemed community can fall away. Others see it as a type: physical deliverance from Egypt was real, but not every member of the delivered people had saving faith, and so the warning targets those whose membership in the church is not matched by faith. Jude's purpose is practical rather than systematic. He warns the readers not to trust in privilege, and he assures them that God is able to keep them (v. 24).

3. Does Jude endorse the Watcher story as history? Jude certainly uses the tradition, and his argument assumes its point. Whether he regarded every detail of 1 Enoch's narrative as historical cannot be determined from his brief allusion. The question is discussed further in Chapter 8.

4. What was Sodom's sin? Discussed in the deep dive. Jude's own emphasis is on sexual immorality and the pursuit of "other flesh," understood in light of the angel parallel. Other biblical texts emphasize pride, wealth, injustice, and inhospitality. A full biblical portrait includes all of these.

5. "Eternal" or "continuous" fire? The question of what αἰώνιος means, and of the nature and duration of final judgment, is a larger theological discussion that Jude's verse alone cannot settle. Jude's own point is that Sodom's destruction is a visible, lasting example of judgment that should give the reader pause.

H. The Passage Within Jude

Verses 5–7 are the first of Jude's "texts," the evidence that the intruders' condemnation was "written beforehand" (v. 4). The next verse begins "In like manner" (ὁμοίως, *homoiōs*) and applies the examples: "those dreaming indeed defile the flesh, and they disregard lordship, and they speak evil of glorious [ones]" (v. 8). The three sins of v. 8 correspond loosely to the three examples. Defiling the flesh corresponds to Sodom. Disregarding lordship corresponds to the angels who left their place and to Israel's rebellion. Slandering glorious ones prepares for the contrast with Michael in v. 9.

The passage also develops the letter's key word: "keep." The angels "did not keep" and are "kept" (v. 6). The readers, "kept" by God (v. 1), will be urged to "keep" themselves (v. 21). The examples of vv. 5–7 are not only threats against the intruders. They are also mirrors for the readers, showing what it would mean to leave the place God has given.

I. Contemporary Understanding

These reflections are suggested applications, distinct from the original meaning.

Privilege is not protection. Jude's first example is directed at people who belong to the community of the saved. Church membership, a dramatic conversion story, or a heritage of faith do not by themselves guarantee faithfulness. Jude's warning may be most needed in communities that feel most secure.

The goodness of boundaries. All three examples involve leaving a God-given place. Modern culture often treats limits as obstacles to self-realization. Jude's examples suggest that boundaries such as the place of trust, of creaturely station, and of the created order can be gifts that protect and do not merely restrict. This idea can be misused to justify unjust social hierarchies, which Jude does not address. Applied to the believer's relationship with God, though,

it invites reflection on the freedom found in remaining where God has placed us: in his love (v. 21).

Reading hard texts honestly. Jude 7 is often quoted in modern debates. Responsible readers will resist both the temptation to make it say more than it does and the temptation to make it say less. That discipline is itself a form of "contending for the faith."

Christ in the whole story. If Jude 5 identifies Jesus as Israel's deliverer, Christians may read the Old Testament as the story of the same Lord they know in the Gospels. That conviction has shaped Christian worship and interpretation from the beginning.

J. Reflection and Discussion

1. Why do you think Jude began his examples with God's own people rather than with pagan Sodom? What effect might that order have had on his readers?
2. What difference does it make to your understanding of Jesus if Jude 5 says that *Jesus* saved Israel from Egypt?
3. The angels "did not keep their own principality" and are now "kept" for judgment. How does this wordplay illuminate the relationship between faithfulness and security?
4. Jude, Ezekiel, Josephus, and Philo describe Sodom's sin differently. Why might different writers emphasize different aspects of the same story? What are the risks of focusing on only one?
5. Jude says his readers already know these things but need reminding. What truths do you know well but most need to be reminded of?

K. Sources

- LSV texts: eBible.org edition. Greek and variants: SBLGNT and apparatus (with NA28 data); Robinson–Pierpont 2018; TR; manuscript tallies from the Text-Critical Greek NT notes.
- 1 Enoch 10:4–6, 11–12: R. H. Charles, *The Book of Enoch* (1917), via Wikisource.
- Testament of Naphtali 3:3–5: trans. R. Sinker, ANF 8.
- Sirach 16:7–8; Wisdom 10:6–7; 3 Maccabees 2:4–5: Brenton's English Septuagint.
- Josephus, *Antiquities* 1.11.1 (Whiston numbering): Project Gutenberg #2848.
- Philo, *On Abraham* 133–136, trans. C. D. Yonge (1854–55), via earlyjewishwritings.com.
- Augustine, *City of God* 15.23 (NPNF¹ 2).

- Clement of Alexandria, *Adumbrationes* on Jude 6.
- Abbott-Smith, *Manual Greek Lexicon*, s.vv. οἰκητήριον, ζόφος, ἀΐδιος, ἐκπορνεύω, δεῖγμα, ὑπέχω, δίκη.
- Metzger, *Textual Commentary* (2nd ed.), on Jude 5 (cited from prior knowledge); Flink, "Reconsidering the Text of Jude 5, 13, 15 and 18" (2007); Bauckham, *Jude, 2 Peter*, on vv. 6–7.

Chapter 4. Dreamers, Authority, and the Archangel’s Restraint (Jude 8–10)

A. The Text

> **8** In like manner, nevertheless, those dreaming indeed defile the flesh, and they disregard lordship, and they speak evil of glorious [ones], **9** yet Michael, the chief messenger, when disputing with the Devil, reasoning about the body of Moses, did not dare to bring against [him] a judgment of slander, but said, “The LORD rebuke you!” **10** But these, indeed, whatever [things] they have not known, they speak evil of; and whatever [they know], like the irrational beasts, they understand naturally—in these they are corrupted;
>
> — Jude 8–10, LSV

B. Plain-English Orientation

Having set out three examples of judgment, Jude now applies them. The intruders behave “in like manner.” Relying on their dreams, they do three things: they defile the flesh, they reject authority, and they slander heavenly beings.

To expose the arrogance of the third charge, Jude tells a story his readers evidently knew. When Michael, the greatest of the archangels, disputed with the Devil over Moses’ body, he did not presume to pronounce judgment on his adversary on his own authority. He left that to God: “The LORD rebuke you!”

The intruders show no such restraint. They mock what they do not understand. Meanwhile, the things they do understand, their instincts and appetites, are understood the way animals understand them, and those very things are destroying them.

The passage turns on a contrast between **presumption** and **reverence**. The intruders claim special insight through dreams, yet they are ignorant of spiritual realities and governed by animal instinct. Michael, who stands in the presence of God, knows the limits of his authority.

C. Phrase-by-Phrase Exploration

“In like manner, nevertheless”

The opening Ὁμοίως μέντοι καὶ οὗτοι (*Homoiōs mentoi kai houtoi*), literally “In the same way, however, these also,” ties the intruders to the examples of vv. 5–7. The particle μέντοι (*mentoi*), “nevertheless, yet,” adds a note of surprise or protest. *In spite of* these well-known examples of judgment, the intruders do the same things. This is the first of the letter’s “these” applications.

“those dreaming”

The participle ἐνυπνιαζόμενοι (*enypniazomenoi*), “dreaming,” stands as the description of the intruders that governs all three of the following verbs. The LSV’s “those dreaming indeed defile the flesh” preserves this: the dreaming is the source of the behavior.

What does Jude mean? Some interpreters take it figuratively, as if the intruders lived in a dream world of self-delusion or fantasized about immorality. The background of the word points elsewhere. In the Greek Old Testament, the same verb describes the false prophet of Deuteronomy 13: “When a prophet or a dreamer of a dream arises in your midst … saying, Let us go after other gods … you do not listen to the words of that prophet or to that dreamer of the dream” (Deut 13:1–3, LSV). The Septuagint uses ἐνυπνιαζόμενος, Jude’s word, for that “dreamer of a dream.”[56] Jeremiah denounces prophets “who prophesy falsehood in My Name, saying, I have dreamed, I have dreamed” (Jer 23:25, LSV), and God says, “I [am] against the prophets of false dreams” (Jer 23:32, LSV).

Dreams were not suspect in themselves. Joel promised that in the last days “Your old men dream dreams” (Joel 2:28, LSV), and Peter announced the fulfillment of that promise at Pentecost (Acts 2:17). The problem was dreams claimed as divine revelation that led people away from God’s revealed will. Jude’s intruders seem to have claimed visions or revelations that authorized their conduct. That would explain why Jude stresses that the faith was delivered “once” (v. 3). No new revelation can overturn it.

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56. LXX Deut 13:2 (Eng. 13:1): Ἐὰν δὲ ἀναστῇ ἐν σοὶ προφήτης ἢ ἐνυπνιαζόμενος τὸ ἐνύπνιον; also 13:4, 6 (Brenton’s Greek Septuagint, eBible.org). The same participle appears in LXX Jer 34:9 (Eng. 27:9) of those who mislead the people.↩

“indeed defile the flesh”

The first of three charges, σάρκα μὲν μιαίνουσιν (*sarka men miainousin*), uses the verb μιαίνω (*miainō*), “to stain, defile, soil,” in a moral sense.[57] “The flesh” here means the body. The charge corresponds to Sodom’s sexual immorality (v. 7) and to the intruders’ turning grace into “licentiousness” (v. 4).

The three charges are linked by the Greek particles μέν … δέ … δέ (*men … de … de*), “on the one hand … on the other … and.” The LSV’s “indeed … and … and” reflects this. The construction holds the three together as aspects of a single pattern of life.

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57. Abbott-Smith, s.v. μιαίνω: “to stain, defile, soil; in physical sense; in moral sense: Tit 1:15, He 12:15, Ju 8.”↩

“and they disregard lordship”

The second charge, κυριότητα δὲ ἀθετοῦσιν (*kyriotēta de athetousin*), uses ἀθετέω (*atheteō*), “to set aside, reject, nullify,”[58] with the object κυριότης (*kyriotēs*), “lordship, dominion.” What lordship do they reject?

1. **The lordship of the Lord.** The word is derived from κύριος (*kyrios*, “lord”), and Jude has just said that the intruders deny “our only Master and Lord—Jesus Christ” (v. 4). Rejecting “lordship” would then mean rejecting the authority of Christ. Clement of Alexandria read it this way: “despise dominion … that is, the only Lord, who is truly our Lord, Jesus Christ.”[59]
2. **Angelic powers.** In Eph 1:21 and Col 1:16, “lordship” (κυριότης) is one of a list of angelic ranks: “principality, and authority, and might, and lordship” (Eph 1:21, LSV). Since the next charge concerns “glorious [ones],” Jude might mean angelic authorities here too.
3. **Human church leaders.** Some have suggested that the intruders despised the leadership of the community.

The first interpretation fits the immediate context best, since it echoes v. 4. It also fits the contrast with the angels of v. 6, who left their place under God’s authority. The singular “lordship,” without an article, may also suggest an abstract principle: the intruders reject the very idea of being under authority.

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58. Abbott-Smith, s.v. ἀθετέω: “properly, to make ἄθετον, or do away with what has been laid down … to reject: … Ju 8.”↩

59. Clement of Alexandria, *Adumbrationes* on Jude 8, ANF 2. Clement adds: “They speak evil of majesty, that is, of the angels.”↩

“and they speak evil of glorious [ones]”

The third charge is the most puzzling. The verb βλασφημέω (*blasphēmeō*) means “to slander, revile, speak abusively of.” The object δόξας (*doxas*), literally “glories,” refers to glorious beings, almost certainly angels. The LSV’s bracketed “[ones]” signals that the Greek has only the plural noun. Second Peter’s parallel confirms the angelic reference: “they are not afraid to speak evil of glorious ones, whereas messengers, being greater in strength and

power, do not bear a slanderous judgment against them before the LORD" (2 Pet 2:10–11, LSV).

Why would anyone slander angels? Jude does not say, and scholars have proposed several explanations:

- **Disparaging the angels as guardians of the moral law.** Jewish and early Christian tradition held that the Law of Moses was given "through messengers" (Gal 3:19; Acts 7:53; Heb 2:2). If the intruders taught that grace freed them from the moral law, they might have belittled the angels associated with that law. This explanation has been influential in modern scholarship.[60]
- **Mocking evil powers.** If the "glorious ones" include fallen angels (some argue this from the Michael example, where the slander concerns the Devil), the intruders may have treated spiritual evil with contempt, claiming that their spiritual status put them beyond its reach.
- **General irreverence** toward the whole unseen order of God's creation.

The example that follows, Michael's restraint toward the Devil, suggests that Jude's main point is the intruders' presumption. Whatever beings they slandered, they spoke with an authority they did not possess.

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60. Bauckham, *Jude, 2 Peter*, on v. 8 (cited from prior knowledge).↩

"yet Michael, the chief messenger"

Michael is one of only two angels named in the Protestant canon of Scripture; the other is Gabriel. In Daniel he is "Michael, first of the chief heads" and "the great head, who is standing up for the sons of your people" (Dan 10:13; 12:1, LSV), the guardian of Israel. In Revelation, "Michael and his messengers warred against the dragon" (Rev 12:7, LSV). Jude calls him ὁ ἀρχάγγελος (*ho archangelos*), "the archangel," literally "the chief messenger," as the LSV renders it. The only other New Testament use of the word is in 1 Thess 4:16, "with the voice of a chief-messenger" (LSV).

The choice of Michael heightens the contrast. If anyone had the standing to condemn the Devil, it was the commander of heaven's armies.

"when disputing with the Devil, reasoning about the body of Moses"

Two legal or debating verbs describe the encounter. διακρινόμενος (*diakrinomenos*) means "contending, disputing," often in a judicial sense. διελέγετο (*dielegeto*) means "was arguing, debating." The scene is a dispute, perhaps a kind of court case, "about the body of Moses" (περὶ τοῦ Μωϋσέως σώματος, *peri tou Mōyseōs sōmatos*), over who had rights to it.

The Old Testament says only this about Moses' death: "Moses, servant of the Lord, dies there in the land of Moab, according to the command of YHWH; and He buries him in a valley in the land of Moab, opposite Beth-Peor, and no man has known his burying place to this day" (Deut 34:5–6, LSV). The mysterious burial, done by God himself in an unknown place, invited speculation, and a tradition grew up that angels were involved. Jude's version, the only surviving ancient form of the story that names a dispute between Michael and the Devil, is explored in the deep dive below.

"did not dare to bring against [him] a judgment of slander"

The key phrase οὐκ ἐτόλμησεν κρίσιν ἐπενεγκεῖν βλασφημίας (*ouk etolmēsen krisin epenenkein blasphēmias*) can be read in two ways.

1. **"He did not dare to pronounce a slanderous (or abusive) judgment against him."** The genitive βλασφημίας (*blasphēmias*) describes the kind of judgment: an insulting, reviling condemnation. Michael did not abuse the Devil, even though the Devil deserved condemnation. He left judgment to God. This is the traditional reading (KJV: "durst not bring against him a railing accusation") and the one most translations follow.
2. **"He did not presume to condemn him for slander."** The genitive names the charge: Michael did not pronounce a verdict of "slander" against the Devil. On this reading, which draws on a reconstruction of the lost ending of the *Testament of Moses* (see the deep dive), the Devil had slandered Moses, perhaps by accusing him of murder. Michael, though in the right, did not presume to judge the Devil for this slander and appealed to God instead.[61]

Both readings reach the same point. Michael, though an archangel and in the right, recognized that judgment over a fellow spiritual being belonged to God alone. The intruders, mere humans, pass judgment freely on beings far above them.

The verb ἐτόλμησεν (*etolmēsen*), "he dared," is important. Jude does not say Michael was unable to condemn the Devil, or that the Devil deserved no condemnation. He says Michael *did not dare*. The restraint was reverence, not weakness.

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61. For the second interpretation, see Bauckham, *Jude, 2 Peter*, on v. 9 and his excursus on the Moses tradition (cited from prior knowledge).↩

"but said, 'The LORD rebuke you!'"

Michael's words, Ἐπιτιμήσαι σοι κύριος (*Epitimēsai soi kyrios*), use the **optative** of wish: "May the Lord rebuke you!" This is the second optative in

Jude, after “be multiplied” in v. 2. The LSV prints “LORD” in capitals, indicating that the reference is to the God of Israel.

The words echo Zechariah’s vision of Joshua the high priest, accused by Satan before the angel of the LORD: “And YHWH says to Satan: ‘YHWH pushes against you, O Satan, / Indeed, YHWH pushes against you’” (Zech 3:2, LSV). The Greek Septuagint renders the same words as Ἐπιτιμήσαι Κύριος ἐν σοί, διάβολε, “May the Lord rebuke you, O Devil,” nearly identical to Jude.[62] In both scenes, a heavenly figure facing the accuser leaves the rebuke to God.

Zechariah 3 will return in Jude 23: the high priest Joshua is “a brand delivered from fire” and is “clothed with filthy garments” (Zech 3:2–3, LSV), images that reappear in Jude’s call to snatch others “out of fire” and to hate the “coat having been stained from the flesh.”

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62. LXX Zech 3:2: Καὶ εἶπε Κύριος πρὸς τὸν διάβολον, Ἐπιτιμήσαι Κύριος ἐν σοὶ διάβολε (Brenton’s Greek Septuagint).↩

“But these, indeed, whatever [things] they have not known, they speak evil of”

Verse 10 returns to the intruders, “these” (οὗτοι, *houtoi*), with a pointed contrast built on two verbs of knowing:

- ὅσα μὲν οὐκ οἴδασιν βλασφημοῦσιν (*hosa men ouk oidasin blasphēmousin*), “whatever they do not know, they slander.” The verb οἶδα (*oida*) here refers to knowledge of spiritual realities, the unseen world of angels and authority. Those who claimed revelatory dreams are, in Jude’s judgment, ignorant of the very realm they speak about.

“and whatever [they know], like the irrational beasts, they understand naturally—in these they are corrupted”

- ὅσα δὲ φυσικῶς ὡς τὰ ἄλογα ζῷα ἐπίστανται (*hosa de physikōs hōs ta aloga zōa epistantai*), “whatever they understand by instinct, like unreasoning animals.” The second verb, ἐπίσταμαι (*epistamai*), means “to understand, know how.” The adverb φυσικῶς (*physikōs*), “naturally, by nature,”[63] found only here in the New Testament, describes knowledge that comes from instinct, not reason or revelation. The phrase τὰ ἄλογα ζῷα (*ta aloga zōa*), “the irrational animals,” literally “the creatures without *logos*,” without reason or speech, was a stock expression for brute beasts.

Then the verdict: ἐν τούτοις φθείρονται (*en toutois phtheirontai*), “by these things they are destroyed” or “in these they are corrupted.” The verb φθείρω (*phtheirō*) means both “to corrupt” and “to destroy, ruin,” and Jude may intend

both: the appetites they follow corrupt them morally and are leading them to destruction.

The irony is sharp. The intruders claim higher knowledge through dreams. In reality they are ignorant of spiritual things, and the only knowledge they truly possess is the instinctive knowledge of appetite, which they share with animals and which is ruining them. Clement of Alexandria paraphrased: “He means that they eat, and drink, and indulge in uncleanness, and says that they do other things that are common to them with animals, devoid of reason.”[64] Paul’s description of those whose “god [is] the belly, and whose glory [is] in their shame” (Phil 3:19, LSV) is similar.

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63. Abbott-Smith, s.v. φυσικῶς: “naturally, by nature: Ju 10.”↩

64. Clement of Alexandria, *Adumbrationes* on Jude 10, ANF 2.↩

D. Original-Language Investigation

Greek	Transliteration	Basic meaning	In context	Notes
ὁμοίως	*homoiōs*	likewise, in the same way	“In like manner”	Links to vv. 5–7.
μέντοι	*mentoi*	nevertheless, yet	“nevertheless”	Adversative: despite the examples.
ἐνυπνιάζομαι	*enypniazomai*	to dream	“those dreaming”	LXX Deut 13:2–6 (Eng. 13:1–5): the false prophet as “dreamer.”
μιαίνω	*miainō*	stain, defile	“defile”	Moral defilement.
ἀθετέω	*atheteō*	set aside, reject	“disregard”	To nullify what is established.
κυριότης	*kyriotēs*	lordship, dominion	“lordship”	Christ’s lordship, or angelic powers (Eph 1:21; Col 1:16).
δόξαι	*doxai*	glories; glorious beings	“glorious [ones]”	Angels (cf. 2 Pet 2:10–11).
βλασφημέω / βλασφημία	*blasphēmeō* / *blasphēmia*	slander, revile / slander	“speak evil of” / “slander”	Not only against God; any abusive speech.
ἀρχάγγελος	*archangelos*	archangel, chief messenger	“the chief messenger”	NT: only here and 1 Thess

Greek	Transliteration	Basic meaning	In context	Notes
				4:16.
διάβολος	*diabolos*	slanderer, accuser; the Devil	“the Devil”	The word itself means “slanderer,” fitting the theme of slander.
διακρίνομαι	*diakrinomai*	dispute, contend; doubt, waver	“disputing”	Same verb as v. 22 (“doubting”).
διαλέγομαι	*dialegomai*	argue, discuss	“reasoning”	
τολμάω	*tolmaō*	dare, presume	“did not dare”	Restraint as reverence.
κρίσις	*krisis*	judgment, verdict	“a judgment”	
ἐπιτιμάω	*epitimaō*	rebuke, censure	“rebuke”	Optative of wish; = LXX Zech 3:2.
οἶδα / ἐπίσταμαι	*oida* / *epistamai*	know / understand	“known” / “understand”	Two kinds of knowing.
φυσικῶς	*physikōs*	naturally, by instinct	“naturally”	NT hapax.
ἄλογος	*alogos*	without reason	“irrational”	“Creatures without reason.”
φθείρω	*phtheirō*	corrupt; destroy	“corrupted”	Both senses likely.

A note on διάβολος. The Greek word for “Devil” means “slanderer” or “accuser.” There is a quiet irony in the scene. Michael refuses to slander the Slanderer, while the intruders slander even “glorious ones.” The term *diabolos* is used in the Septuagint of Zech 3:1–2 for the accuser (Hebrew *haśśāṭān*, “the adversary”), which strengthens the connection between Jude 9 and Zechariah 3.

A note on διακρίνομαι. The verb describing Michael’s dispute will reappear in v. 22 for those who are “doubting” or “wavering.” It is a good example of a word whose sense depends entirely on context: “dispute” in v. 9, “doubt” or “waver” (or perhaps “dispute” again) in v. 22. Chapter 12 explores the possibility that Jude intends a link.

Deep dive: Michael the archangel and the body of Moses

Jude’s reference to a dispute over Moses’ body is one of the most intriguing puzzles in the New Testament. The Old Testament contains no such story.

Where did it come from?

What the Bible says. Deuteronomy 34:5–6 records that Moses died "according to the command of YHWH" (literally "at the mouth of YHWH") and that "He buries him … and no man has known his burying place to this day" (LSV). God himself buried Moses, and the grave was unknown. That combination of divine burial and hidden grave naturally invited questions. Who carried out the burial? Why was the grave hidden? Was there opposition?

What early Christians said about Jude's source. Several early Christian writers connected Jude 9 to a specific Jewish book:

- **Clement of Alexandria** (c. 200), commenting on Jude 9, writes: "Here he confirms the assumption of Moses."[65] The Latin translation preserves the phrase *assumptionem Moysi*, which may refer either to a book (the *Assumption of Moses*) or to the event of Moses' being "taken up."
- **Origen** (c. 230), in *On First Principles*, refers to "the work entitled The Ascension of Moses (a little treatise, of which the Apostle Jude makes mention in his Epistle)," in which "the archangel Michael, when disputing with the devil regarding the body of Moses, says that the serpent, being inspired by the devil, was the cause of Adam and Eve's transgression."[66]
- Later writers, including Didymus the Blind and Gelasius of Cyzicus, also refer to this work. Gelasius quotes from it in a way that later enabled scholars to identify a surviving manuscript.[67]

What survives. In the mid-nineteenth century Antonio Ceriani discovered in the Ambrosian Library in Milan a single, incomplete sixth-century Latin manuscript of a Jewish work in which Moses, before his death, prophesies Israel's history to Joshua. Ceriani published it in 1861 and identified it, through its agreement with a quotation in Gelasius, as the *Assumption of Moses*. R. H. Charles later argued that the surviving text is better called the *Testament of Moses*, since it contains Moses' farewell speech but no account of his being taken up, and that the testament and the assumption may originally have been distinct works or parts of a combined one. The manuscript breaks off before Moses' death. The dispute between Michael and the Devil does not appear in what survives, and it may have stood in the lost ending.[68]

Reconstructing the story. Combining the patristic references, scholars have proposed outlines of the lost scene. In one widely discussed reconstruction, associated especially with Richard Bauckham, Michael is sent to bury Moses. The Devil opposes him and claims the body, either as lord of the material world or by accusing Moses of murder, since Moses had killed an Egyptian (Exod 2:11–12). Michael refuses to pronounce judgment on the Devil's slander and says, "The Lord rebuke you."[69] Some versions add that the Devil then fled and

Michael buried Moses. Because the ending is lost, every reconstruction is provisional. The details above are scholarly proposals, not recovered text.

How did Jude use the story? Jude uses it as he uses the examples of vv. 5–7: as a known story with a clear moral point. He assumes his readers know it, mentions only what he needs, and draws a single lesson. He does not quote a book by name or introduce the story as Scripture.

Did Jude believe the event happened? Interpreters answer this differently.

- Some hold that Jude, writing under the guidance of the Spirit, affirmed a true event preserved in Jewish tradition. Calvin, for example, judged that since "the Jews at that time had many things from the traditions of the fathers," it was not unreasonable to say "that Jude referred to what had already been handed down for many ages."[70]
- Others hold that Jude used a familiar story as an illustration, much as a modern preacher might cite a well-known parable or a classic novel, without endorsing its historicity. On this view the authority lies in the moral point, not in the narrative details.
- Still others think the question cannot be settled and is not essential to understanding Jude's argument.

All agree on the point Jude draws: *if the archangel Michael did not presume to pronounce judgment on the Devil, how much less should mere humans slander heavenly beings?* Readers may hold different views about the story's origin and still receive its lesson.

Why did the story matter in Jude's world? A story about angels disputing over Moses' body would have resonated with Jewish readers for whom Moses was the supreme prophet and lawgiver, and for whom the hidden grave was a sign of his unique relationship with God. In a community debating authority, revelation, and the moral law, a story in which even the great archangel deferred to God's authority over the body of the lawgiver was a pointed choice.

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65. Clement of Alexandria, *Adumbrationes* on Jude 9, ANF 2 (https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/0211.htm).↩

66. Origen, *De principiis* 3.2.1, ANF 4 (https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/04123.htm).↩

67. On Didymus and Gelasius (*Ecclesiastical History* 2.21.7), see the summary in "Testament of Moses," *Wikipedia*, and Bauckham's excursus. These texts were not directly consulted for this edition.↩

68. "Testament of Moses," *Wikipedia* (accessed 7 November 2026), summarizing Ceriani's discovery and Charles's analysis.↩

69. Bauckham, *Jude, 2 Peter*, excursus on the background of v. 9 (cited from prior knowledge). The reconstruction is a scholarly hypothesis.↩

70. John Calvin, *Commentaries on the Catholic Epistles*, trans. John Owen (1855), on Jude 9.↩

E. The Historical and Cultural World

Angels and the law. Jewish tradition held that angels were present at Sinai and mediated the giving of the Law (Deut 33:2 LXX; Jubilees 1:27–29; Acts 7:53; Gal 3:19; Heb 2:2). Stephen speaks of Israel as those "who received the Law by arrangement of messengers" (Acts 7:53, LSV). If the intruders rejected the moral authority of the law of God, it would be natural for them to speak disparagingly of the angels associated with it.

Dreams and revelation in the ancient world. Throughout the ancient Mediterranean, dreams were widely regarded as a channel of divine communication. Jewish tradition accepted that God could speak through dreams, as with Joseph and Daniel, but also warned against dreamers who led people astray (Deut 13; Jer 23). Early Christianity valued prophecy and visions while insisting on testing them (1 Cor 14:29; 1 Thess 5:19–21; 1 John 4:1). The *Didache* warned that a prophet's claims were to be judged by his "ways," his conduct.[71] Jude's "dreamers" fall under this kind of judgment.

Testaments and "assumptions." Jewish literature of the period included many "testaments," farewell discourses of patriarchs before death (the *Testaments of the Twelve Patriarchs*, the *Testament of Moses*), and stories of figures "taken up" to heaven (Enoch, Elijah, and in some traditions Moses). Jude's references to Moses' body and to Enoch (vv. 14–15) show that he and his readers were at home in this literature.

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71. *Didache* 11.8, ANF 7: "from their ways shall the false prophet and the prophet be known."↩

F. Connections Across Scripture

Deuteronomy 13:1–5; Jeremiah 23:25–32 (background for "dreaming"). The "dreamer of a dream" who leads people to "go after other gods" (Deut 13:1–2, LSV) is the clearest Old Testament background for Jude's term. The verbal link is strongest in the Greek Old Testament, where Jude's word appears. This is probably a deliberate echo, though Jude does not quote the passage.

Zechariah 3:1–4 (direct allusion). Michael's words in Jude 9 match the Septuagint of Zech 3:2 almost exactly. Since Zechariah 3 also supplies the imagery of Jude 23, Jude, or his source, seems to have known the whole scene well.

2 Peter 2:10–12 (literary parallel). Second Peter generalizes Jude's example: "messengers, being greater in strength and power, do not bear a slanderous judgment against them before the LORD" (2 Pet 2:11, LSV). It omits the names of Michael and Moses and the specific story, perhaps because the story came from a non-canonical source. It also expands Jude's comparison to animals: "as irrational natural beasts, made to be caught and destroyed" (2 Pet 2:12, LSV).

Daniel 10:13, 21; 12:1; Revelation 12:7–9 (Michael). These passages establish Michael as Israel's guardian and the leader of the heavenly forces against the dragon. Jude's portrait of a Michael who refuses to presume is all the more striking against that background.

Matthew 4:10 (shared theme). When Jesus dismisses Satan in the wilderness, he does so by appealing to Scripture: "it has been written" (Matt 4:10, LSV). Like Michael, he grounds his response in God's authority rather than his own.

Romans 1:22–24; Philippians 3:19 (shared theme). Paul's description of those who, "professing to be wise, … were made fools" (Rom 1:22, LSV) and were given up to their desires parallels Jude's portrait of people who claim higher knowledge yet live by animal appetite.

G. Scholarly and Theological Questions

1. What is the source of the Michael story, and what does its use imply? Discussed in the deep dive. The source is most likely a lost ending of the *Testament* or *Assumption of Moses*. Christians have drawn different conclusions about what Jude's use of the story implies about its historical truth.

2. What is "lordship," and who are the "glorious ones"? Discussed above. The most likely readings are the Lord's authority and angels, respectively. Alternatives are noted.

3. What does "a judgment of slander" mean? "A slanderous judgment" (traditional) or "a condemnation for slander" (reconstructed setting). Both lead to the same point.

4. Should Christians "rebuke the Devil"? Some modern Christian practices encourage believers to address and rebuke Satan directly in prayer. Jude 9 has been cited on both sides of this question. Some read it as a model, since Michael's words are a form of rebuke spoken in God's name. Others read it as a caution, since Michael refused to pronounce judgment himself and appealed to God. Jude's own point concerns *slander and presumption*, not techniques of spiritual warfare. The verse most clearly teaches humility: whatever believers

say about spiritual evil should be said in dependence on God's authority, not their own.

H. The Passage Within Jude

Verse 8 is the first application in the letter's alternating pattern of text and application. Verses 5–7 supplied the text, and v. 8 says "In like manner … those dreaming." Verse 9 then introduces a second "text," the Michael story, and v. 10 applies it: "But these…"

The passage also prepares for what follows. The animal comparison of v. 10 anticipates the woe on those who follow Cain, Balaam, and Korah (v. 11). The theme of slanderous speech anticipates the "harsh [words]" of v. 15 and the "swollen words" of v. 16. The phrase "they understand naturally" anticipates the description of the intruders in v. 19 as ψυχικοί (*psychikoi*), "natural" people "not having the Spirit." In Jude's view, the intruders' claimed spirituality is in fact the opposite of spirituality.

I. Contemporary Understanding

Suggested applications, distinct from the original meaning.

Testing claimed revelations. Movements in every generation claim new revelations, special dreams, or private words from God that set aside the received faith or its moral teaching. Jude, like Deuteronomy and the *Didache*, suggests a test. Does the claimed revelation lead toward the faith "once delivered" and toward holiness, or away from them? Christian traditions differ on the place of ongoing prophecy in the church. They can agree that no experience authorizes a believer to "defile the flesh" or reject the lordship of Christ.

Reverence in speech about spiritual realities. Michael's restraint may challenge both careless mockery of spiritual realities and presumptuous bravado toward them. Christians may speak about evil truthfully and confidently, yet without contempt or self-reliance, leaving final judgment to God.

The danger of contempt. Jude's charge is that the intruders "speak evil of" what they do not understand. Contempt for what one has not understood is a common failing in religious and political disputes today. Jude's example invites believers to examine their own speech, including their speech about the people Jude warns against.

Appetite and identity. Jude's picture of people who know their appetites "like the irrational beasts" may prompt reflection on how far modern life is

shaped by instinctive desire, often deliberately cultivated by commerce and media, and on how Christian discipleship offers a different kind of knowledge and freedom.

J. Reflection and Discussion

1. Jude describes the intruders as “dreaming,” probably meaning that they claimed revelations that justified their behavior. How can individuals and communities test claims to spiritual experience today?
2. Why do you think Jude chose a story about Michael and the Devil to make his point about slander? What would be lost if he had simply said, “Do not slander angels”?
3. Michael “did not dare” to pronounce judgment, even on the Devil. What does this suggest about the attitude believers should have toward those they consider enemies of God?
4. Jude contrasts two kinds of knowledge: ignorance of spiritual realities and instinctive knowledge of appetite. Where do you see these two kinds of “knowing” in your own life or culture?
5. How do you respond to the fact that Jude draws on a story not found in the Old Testament? Does it affect how you read the letter? Why or why not?

K. Sources

- LSV texts: eBible.org edition. Greek: SBLGNT. LXX Deut 13:2–6 and Zech 3:2: Brenton’s Greek Septuagint.
- Clement of Alexandria, *Adumbrationes* on Jude 8–10 (ANF 2); Origen, *De principiis* 3.2.1 (ANF 4); Calvin, *Commentaries on the Catholic Epistles*, on Jude 9.
- On the *Testament/Assumption of Moses*: summary in “Testament of Moses,” *Wikipedia* (accessed 7 November 2026); R. H. Charles, *The Assumption of Moses* (London: A&C Black, 1897) (cited from prior knowledge).
- Bauckham, *Jude, 2 Peter*, on vv. 8–10 and excursus on the background of v. 9 (cited from prior knowledge).
- Abbott-Smith, s.vv. μιαίνω, ἀθετέω, κυριότης, φυσικῶς.
- *Didache* 11, ANF 7.

Chapter 5. The Way of Cain, the Error of Balaam, the Rebellion of Korah (Jude 11)

A. The Text

> **11** woe to them! Because they went on in the way of Cain, and they rushed to the deceit of Balaam for reward, and in the controversy of Korah they perished.
>
> — Jude 11, LSV

B. Plain-English Orientation

Jude now speaks as a prophet. He pronounces a "woe" over the intruders, an announcement of coming judgment mixed with lament. He gives the reason by comparing them to three notorious figures from Israel's scriptures:

- **Cain**, the first murderer, who killed his brother out of envy;
- **Balaam**, the prophet-for-hire, who led Israel into immorality and idolatry for profit;
- **Korah**, the Levite who rebelled against the leadership God had appointed and was swallowed by the earth.

Each figure stands for a kind of sin that Jude sees in the intruders. The three verbs also trace a progression: they *went* in Cain's way, they *abandoned themselves* to Balaam's error, and they *perished* in Korah's rebellion. Jude speaks of their destruction as if it had already happened, because in his view it is as certain as Korah's was.

C. Phrase-by-Phrase Exploration

"woe to them!"

The interjection οὐαί (*ouai*), "woe!" or "alas!", is the classic opening of a prophetic oracle of judgment. Isaiah pronounces a series of them: "Woe [to] those saying to evil 'good,' and to good 'evil'" (Isa 5:20, LSV). Habakkuk, Amos, and other prophets use the same form. Jesus pronounced woes on the rich and on the scribes and Pharisees (Luke 6:24–26; Matt 23:13–36). The Epistle of Enoch, part of 1 Enoch that Jude knew, contains long series of woes against sinners: "Woe to those who build unrighteousness and oppression /

And lay deceit as a foundation; / For they shall be suddenly overthrown” (1 Enoch 94:6, trans. Charles).[72]

Outside the Gospels and Revelation, the word “woe” appears in the New Testament only twice: in Paul’s “woe is to me if I may not proclaim good news” (1 Cor 9:16, LSV) and here.[73] Jude’s is the only woe pronounced against others in the New Testament letters. It marks this verse as the emotional and prophetic climax of the first half of his argument.

A woe is not a curse that the speaker wishes on someone. It is a solemn announcement that judgment is coming. It often carries a note of grief. The English “alas” catches some of that tone.

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72. 1 Enoch 94:6, trans. R. H. Charles, *The Book of Enoch* (1917), Wikisource. Woes continue through chs. 94–100.↩

73. Computed from MorphGNT/SBLGNT: οὐαί occurs in Matthew (13), Mark (2), Luke (15), 1 Corinthians (1, at 9:16), Jude (1), and Revelation (14).↩

“Because they went on in the way of Cain”

The first verb, ἐπορεύθησαν (*eporeuthēsan*), “they went, walked,” pictures a course of life, a “way” (ὁδός, *hodos*) followed by choice. To walk in someone’s way is to follow that person’s example. The phrase τῇ ὁδῷ τοῦ Κάϊν (*tē hodō tou Kain*), “the way of Cain,” does not refer only to one act of murder. It refers to the kind of life Cain represents.

What did Cain represent? Genesis tells the bare story: Cain’s offering was not accepted, he became angry, and he killed his brother Abel. When God asked where Abel was, Cain replied, “I have not known; am I my brother’s keeper?” (Gen 4:9, LSV). The deep dive below shows how Jewish and Christian interpreters filled out the picture. For Jude’s purpose, three features are most likely in view:

- **Envy and hatred of a brother.** First John draws exactly this lesson: “not as Cain—he was of the evil one, and he slew his brother. And for [what] reason did he slay him? Because his works were evil, and those of his brother [were] righteous” (1 John 3:12, LSV). Jude’s intruders are divisive (v. 19), and they sit at the love feasts while betraying their meaning (v. 12).
- **Cynicism about judgment.** Jewish tradition remembered Cain as the first person to deny that God judges. In the Targum’s retelling, Cain says to Abel, “There is neither judgment nor Judge, nor another world; nor will good reward be given to the righteous, nor vengeance be taken of the wicked.”[74] Jude’s intruders, the “scoffers” of v. 18, live as if judgment were not real.

- **Corrupting others.** Josephus describes Cain after his exile as one who "excited his acquaintance to procure pleasures and spoils by robbery, and became a great leader of men into wicked courses."[75] Jude's intruders lead others astray.

Jude does not say which aspect he means. He may intend the whole tradition. Cain is the first person in Scripture to turn against God's order and against his brother, the father of a "way" that others follow.

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74. Targum Pseudo-Jonathan on Gen 4:8, trans. J. W. Etheridge, *The Targums of Onkelos and Jonathan ben Uzziel on the Pentateuch* (1862), https://www.targum.info/pj/pjgen1-6.htm. The Jerusalem (Fragment) Targum has a similar exchange.↩

75. Josephus, *Antiquities* 1.2.2 (Whiston), Project Gutenberg #2848.↩

"and they rushed to the deceit of Balaam for reward"

The second verb is vivid. ἐξεχύθησαν (*exechythēsan*) is the passive of ἐκχέω (*ekcheō*), "to pour out." Used of people it means "they were poured out," that is, they gave themselves up wholly or abandoned themselves.[76] The LSV's "rushed" catches the headlong motion. The ASV has "ran riotously," the KJV "ran greedily," and the BSB "rushed headlong." The intruders did not drift into Balaam's error. They threw themselves into it.

"The deceit of Balaam" translates τῇ πλάνῃ τοῦ Βαλαάμ (*tē planē tou Balaam*). The noun πλάνη (*planē*) means "error, wandering, deception," the state of going astray and leading others astray. It belongs to the same word family as the "stars going astray" (ἀστέρες πλανῆται, *asteres planētai*) of v. 13.

The phrase μισθοῦ (*misthou*), "for reward" or "for pay," is a genitive of price: they abandoned themselves to error *for wages*. Balaam was famous for being hired. Moab's king Balak sent elders "with divinations in their hand," payment for the seer's services (Num 22:7, LSV), and promised to honor him greatly (Num 22:17). Deuteronomy remembers that Moab "hired against you Balaam son of Beor … to revile you" (Deut 23:4, LSV). Second Peter summarizes: Balaam "loved a reward of unrighteousness" (2 Pet 2:15, LSV).

Balaam's "error" was more than greed. According to Numbers, after he failed to curse Israel, it was "through the word of Balaam" that the Israelites were led "to cause a trespass against YHWH in the matter of Peor" (Num 31:16, LSV), the episode in which Israelite men engaged in sexual immorality with Moabite and Midianite women and joined in the worship of their gods (Num 25:1–3). Revelation puts the tradition plainly: Balaam "taught Balak to cast a stumbling-block before the sons of Israel, to eat idol-sacrifices, and to commit whoredom" (Rev 2:14, LSV). For Jude's readers, Balaam was the prophet who, for profit, taught God's people that immorality was permissible. The parallel

with the intruders, who turn grace into licentiousness (v. 4) and flatter people "for the sake of profit" (v. 16), is exact.

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76. Abbott-Smith, s.v. ἐκχέω: "pass., of persons (like Lat. *effundor*), to give oneself up to (RV, ran riotously in): Ju 11."↩

"and in the controversy of Korah they perished"

The third clause turns to rebellion. "Controversy" translates ἀντιλογίᾳ (*antilogia*), literally "speaking against," hence "contradiction, dispute, rebellion."[77] The LSV's "controversy" is literal. Most translations have "rebellion" (WEB, BSB) or "gainsaying" (ASV, KJV).

The word carries an echo that Jude's Greek-reading audience may have heard. In the Septuagint, ἀντιλογία is the word used for the "water of contention" at Meribah, where Israel quarreled with Moses and God: Τοῦτο τὸ ὕδωρ Ἀντιλογίας, 'This is the water of Contention' (Num 20:13 LXX; also Num 27:14; Deut 32:51; 33:8). It is also used for legal disputes brought before judges (Exod 18:16; Deut 17:8; 19:17).[78] The word suggests a challenge to God-given authority.

Korah's story is told in Numbers 16. A Levite, already privileged to serve at the tabernacle, he led two hundred and fifty leaders of the congregation against Moses and Aaron. His slogan sounded spiritual and egalitarian: "Enough of you! For all the congregation—all of them [are] holy, and YHWH [is] in their midst; and why do you lift yourselves up above the assembly of YHWH?" (Num 16:3, LSV). Moses saw through it: "is it little to you that the God of Israel has separated you … and you have also sought the priesthood! Therefore, you and all your congregation are meeting against YHWH" (Num 16:9–11, LSV). The judgment was spectacular: "the earth opens her mouth and swallows them … and they go down—they and all that they have—alive to Sheol … and they perish from the midst of the assembly" (Num 16:32–33, LSV), while fire consumed the two hundred and fifty who offered incense (16:35).

The verb ἀπώλοντο (*apōlonto*), "they perished," is in the aorist, a past tense. Jude speaks of the intruders as if they had *already* perished. Grammarians sometimes call this a "prophetic" use of the past tense: a future event is described as already accomplished because it is so certain. In a sense they perished when they joined Korah's rebellion, as Korah's company was doomed the moment it set itself against God. The word ἀπόλλυμι (*apollymi*) also links back to v. 5, where Jesus "destroyed" (ἀπώλεσεν, *apōlesen*) the unbelieving wilderness generation.

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77. Abbott-Smith, s.v. ἀντιλογία: "[in LXX chiefly for ריב] gain-saying, strife."↩

78. Brenton's Greek Septuagint: Num 20:13; 27:14; Deut 32:51; 33:8 (the "water of contention"); Exod 18:16; Deut 17:8; 19:17; 21:5; 25:1 (legal disputes).↩

The progression of the three verbs

Read in sequence, the three verbs describe a downward path:

Verb	Figure	Stage
ἐπορεύθησαν, "they went"	Cain	Setting out on a way of life
ἐξεχύθησαν, "they rushed / abandoned themselves"	Balaam	Throwing oneself into it wholeheartedly
ἀπώλοντο, "they perished"	Korah	Reaching its end

The sins also escalate. Cain's sin was personal: hatred, murder, and contempt for judgment. Balaam's sin led others into sin for profit. Korah's sin openly defied God's appointed order. The intruders, Jude suggests, embody all three.

D. Original-Language Investigation

Greek	Transliteration	Basic meaning	In context	Notes
οὐαί	*ouai*	woe, alas	"woe"	Prophetic oracle of judgment; only woe against others in the NT letters.
πορεύομαι	*poreuomai*	go, walk, proceed	"went on"	Way of life; also vv. 16, 18.
ὁδός	*hodos*	way, road	"the way of Cain"	Pattern of life.
Κάϊν	*Kain*	Cain	"Cain"	
ἐκχέω (pass.)	*ekcheō*	pour out; (of persons) abandon oneself	"rushed"	Passive used reflexively.
πλάνη	*planē*	error, deception, wandering	"deceit"	Related to πλανῆται (v. 13).
Βαλαάμ	*Balaam*	Balaam	"Balaam"	
μισθός	*misthos*	wages, reward	"for reward"	Genitive of price.
ἀντιλογία	*antilogia*	contradiction, dispute, rebellion	"controversy"	LXX: Meribah "water of contention"; legal disputes.

Greek	Transliteration	Basic meaning	In context	Notes
Κόρε	*Kore*	Korah	"Korah"	Only here in the NT.
ἀπόλλυμι	*apollymi*	destroy; (mid.) perish	"they perished"	Aorist describing certain doom; links to v. 5.

A caution about "prophetic aorist." Not every past tense in prophecy is a "prophetic aorist." Here, though, the context makes the category apt. Jude has just said the intruders' judgment is "written beforehand" (v. 4) and is about to quote Enoch's prophecy of judgment in the past tense: "Behold, the LORD has come" (v. 14). The past tense expresses certainty.

Deep dive: Cain, Balaam, and Korah in Scripture and tradition

The three figures had rich afterlives in Jewish and Christian interpretation, and Jude's readers would have heard his brief allusions against that background.

Cain.

- *In Genesis* (4:1–16), Cain is the firstborn of Adam and Eve and a tiller of the ground. His offering is not accepted. God warns him that sin is crouching at the door but that he must rule over it (4:7). He kills Abel, denies responsibility, and is sentenced to be "a wanderer, even a trembling one" (4:12, LSV), though God marks him for protection.
- *In the New Testament*, Cain is the archetype of hatred: "not as Cain—he was of the evil one" (1 John 3:12, LSV). Hebrews contrasts Abel's faith with Cain's lack of it: "By faith Abel offered a better sacrifice to God than Cain" (Heb 11:4, LSV). Jesus speaks of "all the righteous blood … from the blood of Abel the righteous" (Matt 23:35, LSV).
- *In Jewish tradition*, Cain became the prototype of several vices. Josephus portrays him as "wholly intent upon getting," the inventor of "measures and weights," who "changed the world into cunning craftiness" and "became a great leader of men into wicked courses."[79] The Palestinian Targums turn the brothers' conversation in the field into a theological argument, with Cain denying that there is "judgment" or a "Judge" or "another world," and Abel affirming them, before Cain kills him.[80] (The Targums as we have them were written down later than Jude, though they preserve older traditions. Their witness here is to a line of interpretation, not proof of what Jude had read.)

Any of these portraits could stand behind Jude's "way of Cain." Jealous hatred fits the divisions in v. 19. Leading others into sin and greed fit vv. 11–12 and 16. Denial of judgment fits the "scoffers" of v. 18. Jude's brevity leaves the

allusion open, and that openness allows it to cover the full range of the intruders' behavior.

Balaam.

- *In Numbers 22–24*, Balaam is a non-Israelite seer from Pethor on the Euphrates whom Balak, king of Moab, hires to curse Israel. Repeatedly, he insists, "If Balak gives to me the fullness of his house of silver and gold, I am not able to pass over the command of YHWH" (Num 24:13, LSV), and he ends up blessing Israel. His donkey sees the angel that he cannot see and speaks to him (22:21–35). Read by itself, the story is ambiguous. Balaam obeys God's word in the end, but his eagerness to go, and God's anger at his going (22:22), suggest mixed motives.
- *The rest of Scripture* resolves the ambiguity negatively. Numbers 31:16 blames Balaam's counsel for the apostasy at Peor. Deuteronomy, Nehemiah, and Joshua remember him as hired to curse Israel and as "the diviner" killed among Israel's enemies (Deut 23:4–5; Neh 13:2; Josh 13:22). Micah calls Israel to "remember … What Balaam son of Beor answered" Balak (Mic 6:5, LSV).
- *In Jewish tradition*, Josephus has Balaam advise the Midianites to send their most beautiful daughters to the Israelite camp to seduce the young men into abandoning their law and worshipping other gods, "for by this means God will be angry at them."[81]
- *In the New Testament*, Balaam becomes the type of the false teacher who is motivated by money and leads believers into immorality and idolatry (2 Pet 2:15–16; Rev 2:14).

Jude's two words, "error" and "reward," compress this whole tradition. The intruders are teachers who, for personal gain, mislead God's people into sexual immorality while claiming spiritual authority.

Korah.

- *In Numbers 16*, Korah, a Levite of the clan of Kohath, joined with the Reubenites Dathan, Abiram, and On to challenge Moses' leadership and Aaron's priesthood. God vindicated Moses: the earth swallowed the rebels, and fire consumed the two hundred and fifty incense-offerers. Afterward, God confirmed Aaron's priesthood by making his rod blossom, so that "the murmurings of the sons of Israel" would cease (Num 17:5, LSV).
- *Elsewhere in Scripture*, Korah's rebellion is remembered as "striving against YHWH" (Num 26:9, LSV) and as envy: "they are envious of Moses in the camp, / Of Aaron, YHWH's holy one" (Ps 106:16, LSV). Ben Sira recalls how "the congregation of Core" maligned Aaron "with fury and wrath" and were "consumed … with the fiery flame" (Sir 45:18–19, Brenton). Remarkably, "the sons of Korah did not die" (Num 26:11, LSV).

Their descendants became temple singers, and several psalms bear their name.
- *In Jewish tradition*, Korah became the archetype of the schismatic who challenges legitimate authority under the guise of spiritual equality.

Korah's slogan, "all the congregation—all of them [are] holy," sounds like something the New Testament itself might say, and in a sense it does (1 Pet 2:9). That is what makes him a fitting type for the intruders. Their rejection of authority (v. 8) may have been dressed in the language of spiritual freedom and equality. Korah shows that true statements can be used to justify rebellion against God's order.

Why these three? All three are figures who opposed God's purposes while associated in some way with God's people or God's word: a son of Adam, a prophet, and a Levite. All three led others, or tried to lead others, with them. All three met judgment. Together they show that the intruders' danger lies not only in their own sin but in their influence on others.

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79. Josephus, *Antiquities* 1.2.1–2 (Whiston).↩

80. Targum Pseudo-Jonathan and Jerusalem Targum on Gen 4:8 (Etheridge). On the dating of the Targums, see the standard introductions; the traditions they preserve are older than the written texts, but how much older is debated.↩

81. Josephus, *Antiquities* 4.6.6 (Whiston).↩

E. The Historical and Cultural World

Prophetic speech in the early church. Early Christian communities recognized prophets alongside apostles and teachers (Acts 13:1; 1 Cor 12:28; Eph 4:11). Jude's woe oracle shows him speaking with prophetic authority, in the tradition of Israel's prophets and of Jesus. His opponents, the "dreamers," may also have claimed prophetic gifts. Jude answers prophecy with prophecy, but his prophecy is anchored in Scripture.

Paid religious teachers. In the Greco-Roman world, philosophers and religious specialists often taught for fees, and critics of the time routinely mocked them for greed. Early Christians debated how traveling ministers should be supported. Paul defended the right to support but often declined it so as not to burden or mislead (1 Cor 9:3–18; 1 Thess 2:5–9). The *Didache* warns that a traveling apostle who "ask[s] money" is a false prophet.[82] Balaam was a fitting type for teachers whose message bent to their income.

Interpreting Israel's stories as types. Jewish and early Christian teachers commonly read figures from Israel's history as patterns (Greek τύποι, *typoi*, "types") for the present. Paul says of the wilderness stories, "these things happened to those persons as types, and they were written for our

admonition” (1 Cor 10:11, LSV). Jude’s three figures are used in exactly this way.

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82. *Didache* 11.6, ANF 7.↩

F. Connections Across Scripture

1 John 3:11–12 (shared tradition). John’s use of Cain as the antithesis of brotherly love is the closest New Testament parallel to Jude’s reference. Both writers assume that their readers know Cain as a type of the person who belongs to the evil one.

2 Peter 2:15–16 (literary parallel). Peter expands Jude’s Balaam reference, mentioning Balaam’s love of “a reward of unrighteousness” and the “mute donkey” that “forbid the madness of the prophet” (LSV). He omits Cain and Korah.

Revelation 2:14 (shared tradition). The letter to Pergamum names “those holding the teaching of Balaam,” which Revelation defines as eating idol-sacrifices and committing sexual immorality. The parallel shows that Balaam had become a standard type of the antinomian teacher in early Christianity.

Numbers 16; Psalm 106:16–18; Sirach 45:18–19 (Korah). The core narrative and its later echoes. The theme of envy in Ps 106:16 parallels the grumbling of Jude 16.

Isaiah 5; Luke 6:24–26; Matthew 23 (woes). The prophetic and dominical woes provide the form of Jude’s oracle.

1 Corinthians 10:1–11 (method). Paul’s typological reading of the wilderness narratives, including the warning “neither murmur, as also some of them murmured, and perished by the destroyer” (1 Cor 10:10, LSV), parallels Jude’s method and some of his material.

G. Scholarly and Theological Questions

1. Which aspect of Cain does Jude intend? Interpreters differ. Some emphasize hatred and murder (following 1 John), some the corruption of others (following Josephus), and some the denial of judgment (following the Targums). Bauckham and others have argued that Jude draws on the Jewish tradition of Cain as the archetypal sinner and corrupter of others, which fits the context of false teaching.[83] The allusion may be deliberately broad.

2. Is the aorist “they perished” prophetic? Most commentators take it so. An alternative view holds that Jude regards the intruders’ fate as already

sealed by their choice, in the way Korah's company was doomed as soon as it set itself against Moses.

3. How does Jude's use of Balaam relate to Numbers 22–24? Numbers 22–24 portrays Balaam ambiguously, and other passages (Num 31; Deut 23; Neh 13; Josh 13) portray him negatively. Jude relies on the latter. This shows that the New Testament writers read individual passages in light of the whole canon and of traditional interpretation.

4. Is authority itself sacred? Jude's use of Korah could be misused to defend any human authority against criticism. Moses and Aaron's authority in Numbers 16 was explicitly God-given and confirmed by God. Korah's sin was rebellion against *God's* appointment, not criticism of human leaders as such. The Bible elsewhere honors prophets who challenged corrupt leaders (Nathan, Elijah, Jeremiah). Applying Jude 11 requires discernment about whether authority is truly from God and exercised under God.

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83. Bauckham, *Jude, 2 Peter*, on v. 11 (cited from prior knowledge).↩

H. The Passage Within Jude

Verse 11 is the climax of the section that began in v. 8. The "dreamers" of v. 8, who slander what they do not understand and are ruled by instinct (v. 10), are now placed in a line of biblical rebels. The woe also prepares for the dense metaphors of vv. 12–13, which open "These are…" and describe the intruders' character and fate. The three verbs of v. 11, *went*, *rushed*, and *perished*, recall the movement of the earlier examples, from salvation to destruction (v. 5).

The three figures also connect with later verses. Balaam's "reward" anticipates the intruders' flattery "for the sake of profit" (v. 16). Korah's "murmuring" (Num 16:11; 17:5) anticipates the "discontented grumblers" of v. 16. Cain's "way" anticipates their "walking according to their own lusts" (vv. 16, 18).

I. Contemporary Understanding

Suggested applications, distinct from the original meaning.

Three enduring temptations. Cain, Balaam, and Korah represent temptations that recur in every religious community: resentment and hatred toward fellow believers; using spiritual influence for personal gain; and rejecting God's order while using spiritual language to justify it. Jude's woe may invite communities to examine themselves before they examine others.

Religion and money. Balaam's "reward" remains a live issue. Churches and ministries today face questions about how leaders are supported, how money shapes messages, and how marketing can bend teaching. Jude does not condemn all payment for ministry; other New Testament writers defend it. He does condemn error embraced for profit.

Equality as a cover for rebellion. Korah's slogan, "all the congregation—all of them [are] holy," was true and yet was used to justify defiance of God's appointment. Believers may need discernment to recognize when good principles are being used for self-promotion, while remaining open to legitimate challenges to leaders who abuse their position.

The weight of influence. All three figures harmed others. Teachers, parents, leaders, and anyone with influence may consider that their "way" becomes a path others walk.

J. Reflection and Discussion

1. Why do you think Jude chose a "woe" rather than a simple warning? How does the form of a prophetic oracle change the effect of his words?
2. Which of the three figures (Cain, Balaam, Korah) seems most relevant to the challenges facing Christians today? Why?
3. Korah's slogan was that "all the congregation" is holy. How can a community tell the difference between a legitimate challenge to leaders and a Korah-like rebellion?
4. Balaam's error was embraced "for reward." In what subtle ways can financial or social rewards shape what religious leaders say, or what congregations want to hear?
5. Jude's three verbs describe a downward progression: going, rushing, perishing. Where might a person or community notice the early stages of such a path, and turn back?

K. Sources

- LSV texts: eBible.org edition. Greek: SBLGNT. LXX uses of ἀντιλογία: Brenton's Greek Septuagint.
- 1 Enoch 94:6–8, trans. R. H. Charles (1917), Wikisource.
- Josephus, *Antiquities* 1.2.1–2 (Cain) and 4.6.6 (Balaam), trans. Whiston.
- Targum Pseudo-Jonathan and Jerusalem Targum on Gen 4:8, trans. J. W. Etheridge (1862).
- Sirach 45:18–19, Brenton's English Septuagint.
- *Didache* 11, ANF 7.
- Abbott-Smith, s.vv. ἐκχέω, ἀντιλογία.
- Word counts for οὐαί: MorphGNT/SBLGNT.

- Bauckham, *Jude, 2 Peter*, on v. 11 (cited from prior knowledge).

Chapter 6. Reefs at the Love Feast: Shepherds, Clouds, and Trees (Jude 12)

A. The Text

> **12** These are stains at your love-feasts, feasting together with you without fear, shepherding themselves; waterless clouds, being carried away by winds; autumnal trees without fruit, having died twice, having been uprooted;
>
> — Jude 12, LSV

B. Plain-English Orientation

After the woe of v. 11, Jude turns to the intruders again with “These are…” and describes them in a cascade of images. This verse holds the first three; v. 13 adds two more.

1. At the community’s **love feasts**, its shared meals, the intruders are hidden dangers, like reefs beneath the surface (or, on another reading, stains on a garment). They eat with the community without reverence, and they care only for themselves, like shepherds who feed themselves instead of the flock.
2. They are **clouds without water**, promising rain that never comes, blown along by the wind.
3. They are **trees in late autumn**, the season of harvest, yet without fruit. They are dead twice over, pulled up by the roots.

Each image describes a gap between appearance and reality. The meal looks like fellowship but hides danger. The cloud looks like rain but delivers nothing. The tree looks like a fruit tree but bears no fruit and has no life. The intruders look like members, leaders, and teachers of the community, but they are empty and dangerous.

This chapter spends extra time on the first phrase, because the “love feast” opens a window onto the inner life of the earliest Christian communities.

C. Phrase-by-Phrase Exploration

“These are”

Οὗτοί εἰσιν (*Houtoi eisin*), “These are,” introduces the second application in Jude’s pattern of text and interpretation. The woe of v. 11, with its three biblical types, is now applied to the intruders’ present behavior. The same formula opens vv. 16 and 19.

The Greek reads οὗτοί εἰσιν οἱ ἐν ταῖς ἀγάπαις ὑμῶν σπιλάδες συνευωχούμενοι (*houtoi eisin hoi en tais agapais hymōn spilades syneuōchoumenoi*). The article οἱ (*hoi*) is masculine, while σπιλάδες (*spilades*) is feminine. The article therefore goes with the masculine participle “feasting together,” giving the sense “These are the ones who feast with you, [like] reefs at your love feasts.” The Byzantine text omits the article.[84]

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84. SBLGNT apparatus: “οἱ WH Treg NIV] – RP.” The article οἱ is masculine and cannot agree with the feminine σπιλάδες, so it goes with the participle συνευωχούμενοι. Abbott-Smith (s.v. σπιλάς) notes the question of gender in Jude 12 and refers to Mayor.↩

“stains at your love-feasts”

The two key words here, “stains” and “love-feasts,” are each explored in a deep dive below.

σπιλάδες (*spilades*). The LSV’s “stains” follows one ancient understanding of the word. The more common meaning in Greek literature is “reefs” or “rocks in the sea,” and most modern translations adopt that sense (BSB: “hidden reefs”; WEB and ASV: “hidden rocks”). The KJV has “spots.” See the deep dive “Hidden reefs versus stains.”

ἀγάπαις (*agapais*). The plural of ἀγάπη (*agapē*), “love,” here means “love feasts,” the community’s shared meals. This is the earliest surviving use of the word in this sense.[85] See the deep dive “Agape and the ancient Christian love feast.”

The pronoun “your” (ὑμῶν, *hymōn*) matters. The love feasts belong to the readers. The intruders are guests at a table that is not theirs, though they behave as if it were.

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85. Abbott-Smith, s.v. ἀγάπη: “In pl., love feasts: Ju 12.”↩

“feasting together with you without fear”

The participle συνευωχούμενοι (*syneuōchoumenoi*), “feasting together,” comes from a verb meaning “to entertain sumptuously, to feast,” with a prefix meaning “with.” It occurs in the New Testament only here and in the parallel at 2 Pet 2:13.[86] The word does not in itself imply excess, but it suggests a festive, abundant meal.

The adverb ἀφόβως (*aphobōs*), “without fear,” can be read with what precedes (“feasting with you without fear”) or with what follows (“without fear shepherding themselves”). Either way, it describes an absence of reverence. Elsewhere in the New Testament the word can be positive, meaning “without fear” of human threats (Luke 1:74; Phil 1:14). Here it is negative. The intruders have no fear of God. They eat at the Lord’s table as if nothing sacred were happening and no judgment were possible. Paul had warned the Corinthians that eating the Lord’s meal in an unworthy manner brings judgment (1 Cor 11:27–34).

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86. Computed from MorphGNT/SBLGNT: συνευωχέομαι occurs only at Jude 12 and 2 Pet 2:13. Abbott-Smith has no separate entry under the deponent form; see s.v. συνευωχέω.↩

“shepherding themselves”

The phrase ἑαυτοὺς ποιμαίνοντες (*heautous poimainontes*), “shepherding themselves” or “feeding themselves,” alludes to Ezekiel’s indictment of Israel’s leaders: “Woe [to] the shepherds of Israel, / Who have been feeding themselves! Do the shepherds not feed the flock? You eat the fat, and you put on the wool, / You slaughter the fed one, / You do not feed the flock” (Ezek 34:2–3, LSV). The Septuagint’s wording is close to Jude’s: “the shepherds fed themselves” (ἐβόσκησαν οἱ ποιμένες ἑαυτούς, *eboskēsan hoi poimenes heautous*, Ezek 34:8).[87]

The image implies that the intruders held, or claimed, positions of leadership, as teachers or as hosts at the meals. Instead of using their position to nourish others, they used it to nourish themselves. At a meal where food is literally shared, the image is also concrete. See the deep dive “Shepherding as a biblical metaphor.”

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87. LXX Ezek 34:8, Brenton’s Greek Septuagint. LXX Ezek 34:2 reads μὴ βόσκουσι ποιμένες ἑαυτούς; (“Do shepherds feed themselves?”).↩

“waterless clouds, being carried away by winds”

The second image moves from the community’s table to the sky. νεφέλαι ἄνυδροι (*nephelai anydroi*), “clouds without water,” and ὑπὸ ἀνέμων παραφερόμεναι (*hypo anemōn parapheromenai*), “carried along by winds.” The verb παραφέρω (*parapherō*) means “to carry aside, carry away.” Hebrews uses it in a warning: “Do not be carried away with strange and manifold teachings” (Heb 13:9, LSV).[88]

The image recalls Proverbs: “Clouds and wind without rain, / [Is] a man boasting himself in a false gift” (Prov 25:14, LSV). It describes people who

promise much and deliver nothing. See the deep dive “Clouds without water.”

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88. Abbott-Smith, s.v. παραφέρω: “to take or carry away … pass., seq. ὑπό, Ju 12; metaph., pass., c. dat., He 13:9.”↩

“autumnal trees without fruit”

The third image is δένδρα φθινοπωρινὰ ἄκαρπα (*dendra phthinopōrina akarpa*), “late-autumn trees without fruit.” The adjective φθινοπωρινός (*phthinopōrinos*), unique to Jude in the New Testament, derives from φθινόπωρον (*phthinopōron*), “late autumn,” the end of the harvest season.[89] A tree that has no fruit at harvest time is a failure. Jesus’ cursing of the fig tree comes to mind: “He came to it, and found nothing in it except leaves only” (Matt 21:19, LSV). See the deep dive “Trees twice dead and uprooted.”

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89. Abbott-Smith, s.v. φθινοπωρινός: “(< φθινόπωρον, late autumn), autumnal.”↩

“having died twice, having been uprooted”

The trees are δὶς ἀποθανόντα (*dis apothanonta*), “twice dead,” and ἐκριζωθέντα (*ekrizōthenta*), “uprooted.” A fruitless tree might be thought merely dormant. These trees are dead, and dead beyond any hope of revival, because their roots have been torn out of the ground. “Twice dead” may mean (a) dead in two senses, fruitless and uprooted; (b) dead now and destined for the “second death” of final judgment (Rev 2:11; 20:14); or (c) as Clement of Alexandria suggested, “once … when they sinned by transgressing, and a second time when delivered up to punishment.”[90] Jesus’ saying lies close by: “Every plant that My heavenly Father did not plant will be rooted up” (Matt 15:13, LSV), using the same verb.

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90. Clement of Alexandria, *Adumbrationes* on Jude 12, ANF 2.↩

Deep dive: Agape and the ancient Christian love feast

What exactly was a love feast? This is one of the questions Jude raises most sharply for modern readers, and the evidence allows a fairly full answer, provided we distinguish carefully between what is documented, what is probable, and what belongs to later centuries.

1. Meals at the heart of early Christian life

From the beginning, Christian communities gathered around tables. Luke describes the Jerusalem believers “continuing steadfastly in the teaching of the apostles, and the fellowship, and the breaking of the bread, and the prayers” and “breaking bread at every house, they were partaking of food in

gladness and simplicity of heart" (Acts 2:42, 46, LSV). At Troas, "on the first [day] of the weeks, the disciples having been gathered together to break bread," Paul taught until midnight, and later, "having broken bread, and having tasted," he continued talking "until daylight" (Acts 20:7, 11, LSV).

Christians met in homes, and the main gathering included a real meal. That was natural in the ancient world. Jewish households marked Sabbaths and festivals with meals, Jesus' ministry was remembered as a ministry of meals (Mark 2:15–17; Luke 15:1–2), and his last supper with his disciples took place at a meal. Greek and Roman social life also revolved around the communal dinner (*deipnon* in Greek, *cena* in Latin), whether in a household, a trade guild, a religious society, or a funeral association.

2. The Lord's Supper within a meal (1 Corinthians 11)

Our earliest detailed evidence comes from Paul's first letter to Corinth, written in the mid-50s. The Corinthian Christians gathered for what Paul calls "the LORD's Dinner" (κυριακὸν δεῖπνον, *kyriakon deipnon*, 1 Cor 11:20, LSV). It was clearly a full meal, because Paul complains that "each takes his own dinner before in the eating, and one is hungry, and another is drunk" (11:21, LSV). Wealthier members, apparently arriving early or eating separately, consumed their own food while poorer members, perhaps slaves or laborers who arrived late, went hungry. Paul is indignant: "do you despise the Assembly of God, and shame those not having?" (11:22, LSV).

Within this meal, the bread and cup were shared in remembrance of Jesus, and Paul recalls the words of institution (11:23–26). His remedy is not to abolish the meal but to reform it: "so then, my brothers, coming together to eat, wait for one another; and if anyone is hungry, let him eat at home, that you may not come together to judgment" (11:33–34, LSV).

Paul does not call the Corinthian meal an "agape." The situation he describes is the kind of setting in which the word arose: a shared community meal, including the Lord's Supper, meant to express the unity of the body ("we all partake of the one bread," 1 Cor 10:17, LSV), and liable to be spoiled by selfishness and division.

The Corinthian problem has a well-documented cultural background. Roman dinners often reflected social hierarchy, with better food and seating for the honored and worse for the rest. Pliny the Younger describes with disgust a dinner at which the host served "choice dishes to himself and a few, cheap and scraps to the rest," and divided the wine into three grades, one for himself and his guests of rank, one for "lesser friends," and one for freedmen. Pliny himself says he serves everyone alike, "for I invite them to dinner, not to be graded."[91] The Corinthian church seems to have absorbed such customs, and Paul insisted that the Lord's table must not mirror the world's rankings.

91. Pliny the Younger, *Letters* 2.6.2–3 (Latin text from The Latin Library, https://www.thelatinlibrary.com/pliny.ep2.html): *sibi et paucis opima quaedam, ceteris vilia et minuta ponebat … ad cenam enim, non ad notam invito.* Translation mine.↩

3. “Your love-feasts” (Jude 12)

Jude is the first writer known to call these community meals ἀγάπαι (*agapai*), “loves,” meaning “love feasts.” He does so casually, as if the term were already familiar to his readers. The name expressed the meal’s meaning: it was a practical enactment of the love that bound believers together, rich and poor, Jew and Gentile, at one table.

The parallel in 2 Pet 2:13 shows how the term was understood and transmitted. The best-attested text of 2 Peter reads ἐν ταῖς ἀπάταις αὐτῶν (*en tais apatais autōn*), “in their deceits,” and the LSV translates “reveling in their deceits, feasting with you.” Some manuscripts read ἀγάπαις, “love feasts,” as in Jude.[92] The two Greek words differ by only one letter, and the variant shows that early scribes connected the passages.

What did a love feast include? Jude does not describe one, but from the New Testament evidence and the sources that follow we can infer that it probably included a shared meal, prayers of thanksgiving, the Lord’s Supper (at least in Jude’s period), teaching and exhortation, and perhaps singing. It was the occasion at which traveling teachers would be welcomed and heard. That explains why the presence of the intruders at the love feasts was so dangerous: the meal was the setting for teaching as well as fellowship.

92. SBLGNT apparatus for 2 Pet 2:13: “ἀπάταις WH NIV RP] ἀγάπαις Treg.”↩

4. Second-century evidence

Several sources from the generations after Jude fill out the picture. They come from different regions and should not be blended into a single description, but together they show the love feast as an established Christian institution.

- **Ignatius of Antioch** (c. 110), writing to the church at Smyrna, says: “It is not lawful without the bishop either to baptize or to celebrate a love-feast” (ἀγάπην ποιεῖν, *agapēn poiein*).[93] This is the earliest use of the term after Jude, and it shows the agape as a recognized church gathering under the oversight of leaders. In the same passage, Ignatius speaks of the Eucharist separately, so it is unclear whether he regarded the two as one event or as distinct.
- **The *Didache*** (late first or early second century) gives eucharistic prayers for the cup and the bread and then a thanksgiving to be said “after you are filled.”[94] That suggests a real meal surrounding the

prayers. It also warns that “every prophet who orders a meal in the Spirit eats not from it, except indeed he be a false prophet,”[95] a striking parallel to Jude’s intruders feasting at the community’s table.

- **Pliny the Younger** (c. 112), Roman governor of Bithynia, reported to the emperor Trajan what he had learned from former Christians under interrogation. They said they used to meet on a fixed day before dawn, sing a hymn “to Christ as to a god,” and bind themselves by oath not to commit crimes. “When this was done, it was their custom to depart and to assemble again to take food—ordinary, however, and harmless food.” They had stopped doing even this after Pliny’s edict banning associations (*hetaeriae*).[96] Pliny’s “ordinary and harmless” answers popular rumors that Christian meals involved cannibalism or immorality. His account is the earliest non-Christian description of a Christian meal, and it shows two separate gatherings: worship at dawn and a meal later in the day.
- **Tertullian** (c. 197), defending Christianity to Roman officials, describes the love feast in detail: “Our feast explains itself by its name. The Greeks call it agapè, i.e., affection.” Its cost is gain, “since with the good things of the feast we benefit the needy.” “The participants, before reclining, taste first of prayer to God. As much is eaten as satisfies the cravings of hunger; as much is drunk as befits the chaste.” After washing and lighting the lamps, “each is asked to stand forth and sing, as he can, a hymn to God.” “As the feast commenced with prayer, so with prayer it is closed.”[97] Tertullian presents the agape as a charitable, orderly meal in which the poor were fed.
- **Clement of Alexandria** (c. 200) complains about people who “dare to apply the name agape, to pitiful suppers, redolent of savour and sauces,” and insists that “the supper is made for love, but the supper is not love (agape); only a proof of mutual and reciprocal kindly feeling.”[98] The problem Jude addressed, the love feast corrupted by self-indulgence, was still alive more than a century later.

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93. Ignatius, *To the Smyrnaeans* 8.2, ANF 1 (https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/0109.htm).↩

94. *Didache* 10.1, ANF 7 (https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/0714.htm).↩

95. *Didache* 11.9, ANF 7.↩

96. Pliny the Younger, *Letters* 10.96.7 (Latin text from The Latin Library, https://www.thelatinlibrary.com/pliny.ep10.html): *quibus peractis morem sibi discedendi fuisse rursusque coeundi ad capiendum cibum, promiscuum tamen et innoxium; quod ipsum facere desisse post edictum meum, quo secundum mandata tua hetaerias esse vetueram.* Translation mine.↩

97. Tertullian, *Apology* 39, ANF 3 (https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/0301.htm).↩

98. Clement of Alexandria, *Paedagogus* 2.1, ANF 2 (https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/02092.htm).↩

5. What we can and cannot say

Documented: Early Christians gathered for shared meals. In Corinth in the 50s, the Lord's Supper was celebrated within such a meal. By the time of Jude, at least some communities called these meals "love feasts." In the second century, the love feast was an established practice, associated with prayer, charity to the poor, and the oversight of church leaders.

Probable: In Jude's time, the love feast and the Lord's Supper were not yet clearly separated, and the bread and cup were shared in the context of the meal. The love feast was an occasion for teaching and for receiving visitors.

Later development: Over the following centuries, the Eucharist and the agape gradually separated in most churches. The Eucharist became a liturgical rite, often celebrated in the morning, and the agape survived for a time as a charitable meal before largely disappearing or being restricted. Some modern Christian groups have revived love feasts in various forms, among them Moravians, Methodists, Church of the Brethren and related Brethren communities, and others. Those revivals are modern practices and should not be read back into Jude.

Speculative and to be avoided: Detailed reconstructions of a fixed "order of service" for first-century love feasts, or claims that every church observed them in the same way, go beyond the evidence.

6. Why the love feast mattered to Jude

The love feast was where the community's life was most visible: rich and poor eating together, believers giving thanks together, the body of Christ made concrete around a table. For intruders to "feast" there "without fear" while "shepherding themselves" was a profound violation. They turned the table of love into an occasion for self-indulgence. Because the meal was also the setting for teaching, they turned it into a platform for their influence. That is why Jude's image for them at the love feast is so stark. They are not merely blemishes but hidden reefs on which the community might founder.

Deep dive: Hidden reefs versus stains

The word σπιλάδες (*spilades*) has two possible senses, and the choice affects the image.

"Reefs" or "hidden rocks." In Greek literature, σπιλάς (*spilas*) normally means "a rock or reef over which the sea dashes." It is used in this sense by the poets, by the historian Polybius, and by Josephus.[99] Sailors dreaded such rocks because they lay just below the surface, invisible in calm water and fatal

to an unwary ship. Most modern translations adopt this sense (BSB: “hidden reefs”; WEB and ASV: “hidden rocks”).

“Stains” or “spots.” In later Greek, σπιλάς was sometimes used as an equivalent of σπίλος (*spilos*), “a spot, stain.”[100] The parallel in 2 Pet 2:13 has σπίλοι καὶ μῶμοι (*spiloi kai mōmoi*), “spots and blemishes” (LSV), and the same word family appears in Jude 23 (“the coat having been stained,” ἐσπιλωμένον, *espilōmenon*). The KJV (“spots”) and the LSV (“stains”) follow this sense.

Weighing the options.

- In favor of “reefs”: it is the established meaning of σπιλάς. It fits the danger Jude describes, a hidden hazard that can wreck the community. It also prepares for the sea imagery of v. 13 (“wild waves of a sea”). Paul uses a related image when he speaks of those who “made shipwreck concerning the faith” (1 Tim 1:19, LSV).
- In favor of “stains”: it matches 2 Peter’s interpretation, which may be the earliest commentary on Jude, and the stained garment of v. 23. Abbott-Smith’s lexicon notes that the stain sense is attested in late writers and cites J. B. Mayor’s discussion.
- A third possibility: Jude may intend a deliberate double meaning, playing on the sound of σπιλάς and σπίλος. In that case the intruders are both hidden reefs and stains.

On balance, “hidden reefs” is the more probable primary sense, and this book follows it. The LSV’s “stains” is a defensible rendering with ancient support, and readers of the LSV should be aware of the alternative. Either way, the point is that the intruders’ presence at the love feasts is not harmless. Whether as unseen hazards or as defiling blemishes, they endanger the community’s life.

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99. Abbott-Smith, s.v. σπιλάς: “poët. in cl., a rock or reef over which the sea dashes (Polyb., FlJ, al.).” (“FlJ” is Abbott-Smith’s abbreviation for Flavius Josephus.)↩

100. Abbott-Smith, s.v. σπιλάς: “In late writers = σπίλος (q.v.), a spot, stain; metaph., Ju, l.c., R, mg. (cf. Mayor, 41…).” See also s.v. σπίλος.↩

Deep dive: Shepherding as a biblical metaphor

In the ancient Near East, kings and gods were often called shepherds of their people. Israel’s scriptures take up the image. The LORD is the shepherd of Israel (Ps 23; 80:1), and its leaders are under-shepherds, accountable to him. Moses and David were shepherds before they were leaders.

Ezekiel 34 is the classic indictment of bad shepherds. They feed themselves rather than the flock, take the wool and the fat, fail to strengthen the weak,

heal the sick, or seek the lost, and have “ruled them with might and with rigor” (Ezek 34:4, LSV). The result is a scattered flock, prey to wild beasts. God’s response is to promise that he himself will shepherd his sheep, and that he will set over them “one shepherd,” “My servant David” (Ezek 34:23).

The New Testament sees that promise fulfilled in Jesus: “I AM the good shepherd; the good shepherd lays His life down for the sheep” (John 10:11, LSV). Jesus contrasts himself with “the hired worker,” who flees when the wolf comes “because he is a hired worker, and is not caring for the sheep” (John 10:12–13, LSV). The apostles applied the image to church leaders. Peter says, “feed the flock of God that [is] among you, overseeing not by compulsion, but willingly, neither for shameful gain, but eagerly, neither as exercising lordship over the heritages, but becoming patterns for the flock” (1 Pet 5:2–3, LSV). Paul tells the Ephesian elders to “feed the Assembly of God” and warns that “there will enter in, after my departing, grievous wolves to you, not sparing the flock” (Acts 20:28–29, LSV).

Jude’s phrase “shepherding themselves” places the intruders in the line of Ezekiel’s false shepherds and Jesus’ hired hands. They exercise leadership, but for their own benefit. At the love feast, where the shepherd’s role was literally to see that all were fed, their self-feeding was both a spiritual failure and a visible one.

Deep dive: Clouds without water

In the land of Israel, life depended on the rains. The rainy season ran from about October to April, with the “early rain” in autumn softening the ground for plowing and sowing and the “latter rain” in spring bringing the crops to maturity. Joel promised: “He … causes a shower to come down to you, / Early rain and spring rain [as] in the beginning” (Joel 2:23, LSV). Rain clouds came from the west, off the Mediterranean. Jesus remarked, “When you may see the cloud rising from the west, immediately you say, A shower comes, and it is so” (Luke 12:54, LSV). Elijah’s servant saw “a little thickness as the palm of a man … coming up out of the sea,” and soon “the heavens have become black—thick clouds and wind—and the shower is great” (1 Kgs 18:44–45, LSV).

A cloud that rolled in from the sea, darkened the sky, raised the farmer’s hopes, and then drifted past without dropping rain was a bitter disappointment. Proverbs uses exactly this image for the empty promiser: “Clouds and wind without rain, / [Is] a man boasting himself in a false gift” (Prov 25:14, LSV). Hosea uses a related image for Israel’s fleeting loyalty: “Your goodness [is] as a cloud of the morning, / And as dew rising early—going” (Hos 6:4, LSV).

Jude’s “waterless clouds, being carried away by winds” combines the two ideas of empty promise and instability. The intruders promise spiritual

refreshment, perhaps through their claimed revelations, but provide none. They are also driven by every wind. Ephesians speaks of believers who are “carried around by every wind of the teaching” (Eph 4:14, LSV). The intruders are not merely victims of such winds. They are clouds moved by them, with nothing of their own to give.

There may also be an echo of 1 Enoch, where the obedience of nature contrasts with the disobedience of sinners, and where in the days of sinners “the rain shall be kept back / And the heaven shall withhold (it)” (1 Enoch 80:2, trans. Charles).[101] That connection is explored in Chapter 7.

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101. 1 Enoch 80:2, trans. R. H. Charles (1917), Wikisource.↩

Deep dive: Trees twice dead and uprooted

The fruit tree is one of Scripture’s favorite images for a life before God. The righteous person “has been as a tree, / Planted by streams of water, / That gives its fruit in its season” (Ps 1:3, LSV). John the Baptist warned that “every tree not bearing good fruit is cut down, and is cast into fire” (Matt 3:10, LSV), and Jesus taught that “every good tree yields good fruits, but the bad tree yields evil fruits” (Matt 7:17, LSV). In his parable of the fig tree, the owner says, “three years I come seeking fruit in this fig tree, and do not find [it], cut it off” (Luke 13:7, LSV).

Jude’s description is cumulative, and each term deepens the judgment:

1. **“Autumnal”** (φθινοπωρινά). The trees are seen in late autumn, at the end of the harvest season, when fruit is expected. Abbott-Smith explains the phrase as “autumn trees (said to be without fruit therefore at a time when fruit might be expected),” and refers to J. B. Mayor’s “elaborate note” on the word.[102] Some interpreters think instead of trees in late autumn after the fruit is gone and the leaves have fallen, bare and lifeless-looking. The first sense fits the next word better.
2. **“Without fruit”** (ἄκαρπα). At the very season of fruit, they have none. The intruders bear no fruit of the Spirit (cf. v. 19, “not having the Spirit”).
3. **“Having died twice”** (δὶς ἀποθανόντα). A fruitless tree may still be alive. These are dead, and “twice” dead. The phrase may mean dead in two ways, barren and rootless; dead now and destined for the “second death” (Rev 20:14); or, as Clement read it, dead first in sin and then in judgment. The language of a “second death” was current in Jewish as well as Christian circles, and the allusion may be intended.
4. **“Having been uprooted”** (ἐκριζωθέντα). The final image is of trees torn up by the roots, beyond any hope of recovery. “Every plant that My heavenly Father did not plant will be rooted up” (Matt 15:13, LSV); “God

breaks you down forever, / … And He has uprooted you / Out of the land of the living” (Ps 52:5, LSV).

The sequence moves from disappointment to death to destruction. Like the cloud, the tree holds out a promise that it cannot keep. Unlike the cloud, which drifts on, the tree’s end is fixed: uprooted.

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102. Abbott-Smith, s.v. φθινοπωρινός, referring to J. B. Mayor, *The Epistle of St. Jude and the Second Epistle of St. Peter* (London: Macmillan, 1907), 55–59.↩

D. Original-Language Investigation

Greek	Transliteration	Basic meaning	In context	Notes
σπιλάς	*spilas*	reef, rock in the sea; (late) stain	“stains” (LSV) / “hidden reefs”	NT hapax; see deep dive.
ἀγάπη (pl.)	*agapai*	love feasts	“love-feasts”	First attested use for the meal.
συνευωχέομαι	*syneuōcheomai*	feast together	“feasting together with you”	Only here and 2 Pet 2:13.
ἀφόβως	*aphobōs*	without fear	“without fear”	Here: without reverence.
ποιμαίνω	*poimainō*	shepherd, tend, feed	“shepherding”	Cf. LXX Ezek 34:8 (βόσκω).
νεφέλη	*nephelē*	cloud	“clouds”	
ἄνυδρος	*anydros*	waterless	“waterless”	2 Pet 2:17 has “wells without water.”
παραφέρω	*parapherō*	carry away, carry aside	“being carried away”	Heb 13:9: “Do not be carried away.” Byzantine variant περιφερόμεναι, “carried around.”
φθινοπωρινός	*phthinopōrinos*	of late autumn	“autumnal”	NT hapax.
ἄκαρπος	*akarpos*	fruitless	“without fruit”	
δίς	*dis*	twice	“twice”	
ἀποθνῄσκω	*apothnēskō*	die	“having died”	
ἐκριζόω	*ekrizoō*	uproot	“having been uprooted”	Matt 15:13; Luke 17:6.

A caution on "agape." Because the meal was called "agape," some teachers have treated the love feast as proof that the early church understood *agapē* as a technical term for a uniquely Christian kind of love. The word's use for the meal shows how central love was to Christian identity. It does not show that the word *agapē* by itself carried a special meaning. Its significance came from the love of God in Christ that the meal celebrated.

E. The Historical and Cultural World

Banquets and associations. In the Greco-Roman world, voluntary associations (trade guilds, religious societies, burial clubs) met regularly for common meals, often with rules about seating, contributions, and behavior. Roman authorities were sometimes suspicious of such associations as potential centers of political unrest. Pliny's ban on *hetaeriae* in Bithynia, which led Christians there to stop their common meal, shows that Christian meals could be seen as one more association's dinner.[103] Within this culture, Christian love feasts stood out because they brought together people of different classes and backgrounds and because they fed the poor.

Hospitality to traveling teachers. As noted in Chapter 2, early Christian communities welcomed traveling apostles and prophets, who would naturally be invited to the community's meals. The *Didache*'s warning about prophets who order meals "in the Spirit" and eat from them suggests that some visitors exploited this hospitality.[104]

The agricultural year. Jude's readers lived close to the land. Hegesippus's account of Jude's grandsons as farmers suggests that Jude's own family did too. Images of clouds and rain, fruit trees and harvest, were part of daily experience, and the failure of either meant hardship.

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103. Pliny, *Letters* 10.96.7 (see n. 13).↩

104. *Didache* 11.9, ANF 7.↩

F. Connections Across Scripture

Ezekiel 34 (allusion). "Shepherding themselves" closely echoes Ezek 34:2, 8. This is probably a deliberate allusion.

Proverbs 25:14 (probable allusion). "Clouds and wind without rain" is the nearest Old Testament parallel to Jude's waterless clouds, and the shared context of empty boasting strengthens the connection. As noted in the Introduction, the Septuagint version of this proverb differs from the Hebrew, so Jude's image matches the Hebrew more closely.

Matthew 15:13; Luke 13:6–9; Matthew 21:19 (shared imagery). Jesus' sayings about uprooted plants and fruitless trees share Jude's imagery and moral logic.

1 Corinthians 11:17–34 (background). Paul's correction of the Corinthian meal is the best evidence for the setting in which love feasts were abused.

2 Peter 2:13, 17 (literary parallel). Peter has "spots and blemishes, reveling in their deceits, feasting with you" and "wells without water, and clouds driven by a storm" (LSV). His version supports the "stains" interpretation of σπιλάδες and shows that the cloud image was a fixed part of the tradition.

John 10:11–13; 1 Peter 5:2–3; Acts 20:28–29 (shared theme). These texts give the positive model of shepherding against which Jude's intruders are measured.

G. Scholarly and Theological Questions

1. "Reefs" or "stains"? Discussed in the deep dive. Most modern scholars favor "reefs," while noting the support for "stains" in 2 Peter and in later Greek usage.

2. Were the love feast and the Lord's Supper the same event in Jude's day? Probably they were not yet separated, but the evidence is indirect. In 1 Corinthians the Lord's Supper occurs within a meal. In Ignatius and the *Didache*, the relationship is ambiguous. In Pliny, the meal appears to be separate from the dawn worship. Practices likely varied between regions and changed over time. Christian traditions today differ in how they understand the relationship of meal, fellowship, and sacrament, and readers may bring those differences to this verse. Jude's own concern is the conduct of people at the community's table.

3. Were the intruders leaders? "Shepherding themselves" suggests that they held or claimed some leadership role. They may have been traveling teachers, local leaders who had adopted their teaching, or hosts in whose homes the meals took place. Jude does not specify.

4. What does "twice dead" mean? See the deep dive. The options are not mutually exclusive.

H. The Passage Within Jude

Verse 12 begins the longest application in the letter (vv. 12–13), which interprets the woe of v. 11 in five images. The images move through the natural world: the sea (reefs), the sky (clouds), the earth (trees), and in v. 13

the sea again (waves) and the heavens (stars). As Chapter 7 will show, this sweep through creation probably reflects 1 Enoch's contrast between the obedience of nature and the disobedience of sinners.

The love feast is the most concrete detail in Jude's description of the intruders. It shows that they were not distant heretics but people sitting at the same table as the readers, which makes Jude's later call to mercy and rescue (vv. 22–23) all the more pointed. The danger is not "out there," and neither are the people who need rescue.

I. Contemporary Understanding

Suggested applications, distinct from the original meaning.

The table as a test of community. For the early Christians, the shared meal was where love was enacted or betrayed. Communities today might ask what their tables, whether in the Lord's Supper, fellowship meals, or hospitality, reveal about their love. Do they mirror the world's rankings, as at Corinth, or overcome them? Who is fed, and who goes hungry?

Leadership that feeds others. Jude's charge, "shepherding themselves," remains a searching test for anyone with influence. Leaders can ask whether their position mainly serves others or serves themselves, and communities can ask whether their structures reward self-serving leadership.

Promises and fruit. The waterless clouds and fruitless trees invite reflection on the difference between appearance and substance, between impressive promises and actual fruit. Jesus' teaching that a tree is known by its fruit (Matt 7:16–20) gives believers a way to evaluate teachers and movements, and themselves.

Hidden dangers in familiar places. Hidden reefs are dangerous because they are unseen in calm water. Communities may need to recognize that the gravest dangers often arise within, at the very places where trust is greatest. This awareness should lead to wisdom and care, not paranoia.

J. Reflection and Discussion

1. What did you know about "love feasts" before reading this chapter? What surprised you most about the early Christian practice of shared meals?
2. Paul, Jude, and Clement of Alexandria all address abuses of the community meal. Why do you think shared meals are so vulnerable to selfishness and division? Where do you see similar dynamics today?
3. Does the image of "hidden reefs" or of "stains" seem more fitting to you? How does each image shape your understanding of the danger Jude

describes?

4. Jude’s images of clouds without rain and trees without fruit describe a gap between promise and delivery. Where do you see this gap in religious life today, and how can it be recognized?
5. If the love feast was where Christian love became visible, what practices in your community serve a similar purpose? How could they be strengthened?

K. Sources

- LSV texts: eBible.org edition. Greek: SBLGNT and apparatus; 2 Pet 2:13 apparatus; Robinson–Pierpont; TR.
- Abbott-Smith, s.vv. σπιλάς, σπίλος, σπιλόω, ἀγάπη, φθινοπωρινός, ἄκαρπος, ἄνυδρος, παραφέρω, ἐκριζόω, ἀφόβως.
- Ignatius, *To the Smyrnaeans* 8.2 (ANF 1); *Didache* 9–11 (ANF 7); Pliny the Younger, *Letters* 10.96.7 and 2.6 (Latin text, The Latin Library; translations mine); Tertullian, *Apology* 39 (ANF 3); Clement of Alexandria, *Paedagogus* 2.1 (ANF 2); Clement, *Adumbrationes* on Jude 12.
- LXX Ezek 34:8 (Brenton’s Greek Septuagint).
- 1 Enoch 80:2, trans. R. H. Charles (1917).
- Mayor, *The Epistle of St. Jude*, on v. 12 (cited via Abbott-Smith).

Chapter 7. Wild Waves and Wandering Stars (Jude 13)

A. The Text

> **13** wild waves of a sea, foaming up their own shameful [deeds]; stars going astray, for whom the gloom of the darkness throughout the age has been kept.
>
> — Jude 13, LSV

B. Plain-English Orientation

Jude completes his series of images with two more, drawn from the sea and the sky. The intruders are like **wild waves** that throw up foam and scum on the shore, except that what they throw up is their own shameful conduct. They are also like **wandering stars**, heavenly bodies that have left their proper courses and for whom the deepest darkness has been reserved forever.

Together with the clouds and trees of v. 12, these images complete a tour of the created world: the air, the earth, the sea, and the heavens. In each region Jude finds a picture of disorder: clouds that do not rain, trees that do not bear, waves that cannot rest, stars that do not keep their paths. Jewish readers familiar with 1 Enoch would have recognized the pattern. In the natural world, everything obeys God's order. Only sinners do not.

C. Phrase-by-Phrase Exploration

"wild waves of a sea"

The Greek κύματα ἄγρια θαλάσσης (*kymata agria thalassēs*) means "wild waves of the sea." The adjective ἄγριος (*agrios*) is used of wild animals and uncultivated land. Here it describes the untamed, restless violence of a stormy sea.

For the people of the Bible, the sea was not a place of recreation. It was the great image of chaos and danger. In the beginning "darkness [was] on the face of the deep" (Gen 1:2, LSV), and God's power is shown in setting limits to the sea: "Who has made sand the border of the sea, / A perpetual limit, and it does not pass over it, / They shake themselves, and they are not able" (Jer 5:22,

LSV). In Job, God says to the sea, “To here you come, and no more, / And a command is placed / On the pride of your billows” (Job 38:11, LSV). The Psalms praise God as “ruler over the pride of the sea” (Ps 89:9, LSV). The sea is powerful, but in Scripture it is held in check by God’s command.

“foaming up their own shameful [deeds]”

The participle ἐπαφρίζοντα (*epaphrizonta*), “foaming up,” another word found only here in the New Testament, comes from ἀφρός (*aphros*), “foam.”[105] The image is of breakers that heave up foam, weed, and debris and leave them on the shore.

What the waves throw up is τὰς ἑαυτῶν αἰσχύνας (*tas heautōn aischynas*), “their own shames,” a plural meaning “shameful deeds” or “disgraceful things.” The LSV supplies “[deeds]” to make the sense clear.

The image almost certainly draws on Isaiah: “And the wicked [are] as the driven out sea, / For it is not able to rest, / And its waters cast out filth and mire. ‘There is no peace,’ said my God, ‘for the wicked!’” (Isa 57:20–21, LSV). As noted in the Introduction, the Greek Septuagint version of this verse lacks the “filth and mire,” while the Hebrew includes it. Jude’s image matches the Hebrew.[106]

The point is twofold. First, the intruders are restless and agitated, never at peace, always churning, like the sea of Isaiah that “is not able to rest.” Second, their activity produces only filth. As a storm leaves a beach strewn with foam and debris, their teaching and conduct leave behind visible shame. Paul’s description of those “whose glory [is] in their shame” (Phil 3:19, LSV) is a close parallel. The intruders may have boasted of their freedom, but what they produced was disgraceful.

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105. Abbott-Smith, s.v. ἐπαφρίζω: “to foam up: metaph., τ. αἰσχύνας, Ju 13.”↩

106. LXX Isa 57:20: Οἱ δὲ ἄδικοι κλυδωνισθήσονται, καὶ ἀναπαύσασθαι οὐ δυνήσονται (“the unrighteous will be tossed like waves and will not be able to rest”), Brenton’s Greek Septuagint; translation mine.↩

“stars going astray”

The final image is ἀστέρες πλανῆται (*asteres planētai*), “wandering stars.” The LSV’s “stars going astray” brings out the moral sense of πλανάω (*planaō*), “to lead astray, wander.” The noun πλανήτης (*planētēs*), “wanderer,” unique in the New Testament to this verse, is the source of the English word “planet.”[107] Greek astronomers called the planets “wandering stars” because, unlike the fixed stars, they moved across the sky along irregular-seeming paths. The

word also links back to “the deceit (πλάνη, *planē*) of Balaam” in v. 11. The intruders wander, and they lead others to wander.

What did Jude’s readers picture? Several possibilities have been suggested, and they are not mutually exclusive:

1. **Planets.** The ordinary meaning of the phrase. To an observer, the planets seemed to break the regular order of the heavens.
2. **Shooting stars or meteors.** Stars that appear to fall from their places and vanish into darkness. This fits “for whom the gloom of the darkness … has been kept,” but the word πλανῆται does not usually mean meteors.
3. **Stars as angels.** In Jewish and early Christian thought, stars were often associated with angels (Rev 1:20; 9:1; Job 38:7). In 1 Enoch, as the deep dive shows, disobedient stars are punished in a place of darkness and fire. On this reading, the intruders are compared to the rebellious heavenly beings of v. 6.

The third possibility is the strongest, because of Jude’s evident use of 1 Enoch. It combines naturally with the first. To an ancient Jewish observer, a “wandering” star might be precisely a star that had transgressed its appointed course.

There may also be a practical image here. Ancient sailors navigated by the stars. A star that did not keep its place would lead travelers astray, just as the intruders’ teaching misled the community. That fits the nautical imagery of the reefs (v. 12) and the sea (v. 13).

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107. Abbott-Smith, s.v. πλανήτης: “a wanderer: ἀστέρες π. (cl. planets), wandering stars, Ju 13.” ↩

“for whom the gloom of the darkness throughout the age has been kept”

The final clause, οἷς ὁ ζόφος τοῦ σκότους εἰς αἰῶνα τετήρηται (*hois ho zophos tou skotous eis aiōna tetērētai*), “for whom the gloom of darkness has been reserved forever,” announces the destiny of the wandering stars. It repeats two key terms:

- **ζόφος** (*zophos*), “gloom,” used in v. 6 for the darkness in which the rebellious angels are held. The repetition binds the intruders’ fate to the angels’.
- **τετήρηται** (*tetērētai*), “has been kept,” the perfect passive of τηρέω (*tēreō*). This is the fourth occurrence of “keep” in the letter. The readers have been kept for Jesus Christ (v. 1). The angels did not keep their position and are kept in bonds (v. 6). Now darkness is kept for the intruders.

The phrase “the gloom of the darkness” (ὁ ζόφος τοῦ σκότους) doubles the idea of darkness, which is something like “the blackness of darkness” (KJV) or “blackest darkness” (BSB). The LSV’s “throughout the age” renders εἰς αἰῶνα (*eis aiōna*), literally “into the age,” a common biblical idiom for “forever.” Some manuscripts read εἰς τὸν αἰῶνα with the article. The meaning is unchanged.[108]

For a star, whose nature is to shine, the ultimate judgment is darkness. The image recalls Jesus’ sayings about “the outer darkness—there will be the weeping and the gnashing of the teeth” (Matt 8:12, LSV). Second Peter uses Jude’s phrase almost word for word: “to whom the deepest gloom of darkness has been kept throughout the age” (2 Pet 2:17, LSV).

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108. The Text-Critical Greek NT notes (eBible.org) give εἰς τὸν αἰῶνα in about 37% of manuscripts and εἰς αἰῶνα (the reading of SBLGNT and RP) in about 55%.↩

D. Original-Language Investigation

Greek	Transliteration	Basic meaning	In context	Notes
κῦμα	*kyma*	wave	“waves”	
ἄγριος	*agrios*	wild, fierce	“wild”	Used of untamed animals.
θάλασσα	*thalassa*	sea	“a sea”	Biblical symbol of chaos restrained by God.
ἐπαφρίζω	*epaphrizō*	foam up	“foaming up”	NT hapax; from ἀφρός, foam.
αἰσχύνη	*aischynē*	shame, disgrace	“shameful [deeds]”	Plural: shameful acts.
ἀστήρ	*astēr*	star	“stars”	
πλανήτης	*planētēs*	wanderer	“going astray”	NT hapax; source of “planet”; cf. πλάνη (v. 11).
ζόφος	*zophos*	gloom, deep darkness	“the gloom”	Also v. 6.
σκότος	*skotos*	darkness	“the darkness”	
αἰών	*aiōn*	age; (εἰς αἰῶνα) forever	“throughout the age”	
τηρέω	*tēreō*	keep, reserve	“has been kept”	Perfect passive; fourth use in Jude.

A caution on "planet." It is tempting to read modern astronomy into Jude's "wandering stars," as though Jude were making a scientific observation about planetary orbits. Jude uses the ancient observational category, lights in the sky that do not keep the regular pattern of the fixed stars, and gives it a moral and theological meaning. The image works because, to his readers, the heavens normally displayed perfect order.

Deep dive: Wandering stars and ancient cosmological imagery

To understand Jude's last image, it helps to step into the ancient view of the heavens.

Order in the heavens. For ancient peoples, the night sky was the supreme picture of order. The fixed stars wheeled in the same patterns year after year, and the calendar, agriculture, and navigation depended on them. Scripture celebrates this order: "Praise Him, sun and moon, / Praise Him, all stars of light. … He gave a statute, and they do not pass over" (Ps 148:3, 6, LSV). Jeremiah speaks of God as the one "giving the sun for a light by day, / The statutes of moon and stars for a light by night" (Jer 31:35, LSV). The Jewish *Testament of Naphtali* draws the moral lesson: "Sun and moon and stars change not their order; so also you shall not change the law of God in the disorderliness of your doings."[109]

Disorder as rebellion. Against this background, a heavenly body that did not keep its course was a picture of rebellion. 1 Enoch develops this idea vividly. Enoch, on his heavenly journey, sees "seven stars like great burning mountains," and the angel explains: "This place is the end of heaven and earth: this has become a prison for the stars and the host of heaven. And the stars which roll over the fire are they which have transgressed the commandment of the Lord in the beginning of their rising, because they did not come forth at their appointed times. And He was wroth with them, and bound them" (1 Enoch 18:13–16, trans. Charles).[110] Later he sees "seven stars of the heaven bound together," and is told: "These are of the number of the stars [of heaven], which have transgressed the commandment of the Lord, and are bound here" (21:3, 6).

In 1 Enoch these stars are closely linked with the fallen angels. Their "prison" is described in the same terms as the angels' prison (21:10: "This place is the prison of the angels"). Clement of Alexandria read Jude 13 in this way: "Wandering stars,—that is, he means those who err and are apostates are of that kind of stars which fell from the seats of the angels—to whom, for their apostasy, the blackness of darkness is reserved forever."[111]

The four regions of nature. The pattern goes further. 1 Enoch opens, immediately after the prophecy Jude quotes in vv. 14–15, with a call to observe the obedience of nature:

> Observe ye everything that takes place in the heaven, how they do not change their orbits, [and] the luminaries which are in the heaven, how they all rise and set in order each in its season, and transgress not against their appointed order. … Behold the summer and the winter, how the whole earth is filled with water, and clouds and dew and rain lie upon it.
>
> — 1 Enoch 2:1, 3 (trans. Charles)

It goes on to the trees (“how the trees cover themselves with green leaves and bear fruit,” 5:1) and the sea (“how the sea and the rivers in like manner accomplish and change not their tasks,” 5:3). Then it turns to the sinners: “But ye—ye have not been steadfast, nor done the commandments of the Lord, But ye have turned away and spoken proud and hard words With your impure mouths against His greatness” (5:4).[112]

Later, 1 Enoch describes how, “in the days of the sinners,” nature itself will fall into disorder: “the rain shall be kept back,” “the fruits of the trees shall be withheld in their time,” and “many chiefs of the stars shall transgress the order (prescribed)” (1 Enoch 80:2–3, 6).[113]

Compare Jude’s four nature images:

Jude 12–13	Region	1 Enoch 2–5: obedient nature	1 Enoch 80: disorder in the days of sinners
“waterless clouds”	air/sky	“clouds and dew and rain lie upon it” (2:3)	“the rain shall be kept back” (80:2)
“autumnal trees without fruit”	earth	“the trees … bear fruit” (5:1)	“the fruits of the trees shall be withheld” (80:3)
“wild waves of a sea”	sea	“the sea and the rivers … change not their tasks” (5:3)	—
“stars going astray”	heavens	luminaries “transgress not against their appointed order” (2:1)	“many chiefs of the stars shall transgress the order” (80:6)

The correspondence is striking enough that Richard Bauckham and others have concluded Jude had these passages of 1 Enoch in mind.[114] Each part of creation has its God-given task: clouds give rain, trees bear fruit, the sea keeps its bounds, and stars keep their courses. The intruders are like nature gone wrong. They fail their purpose as surely as a rainless cloud, a fruitless tree, a sea that will not rest, or a star that leaves its path.

The parallel also explains why Jude's images move straight into the quotation from Enoch (vv. 14–15). 1 Enoch 1:9, which Jude quotes, stands just before the call to "observe" nature in chapters 2–5. Jude may be moving through a passage he knew well: the nature contrast first, then the prophecy that precedes it in the book.

What Jude adds. Jude does not simply repeat 1 Enoch. He applies its cosmic images to people *within* the Christian community, which turns a description of the wicked in general into a warning about leaders the readers know. He also connects the stars' fate with the language of "keeping" that runs through his letter.

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109. *Testament of Naphtali* 3:2, trans. R. Sinker, ANF 8.↩

110. 1 Enoch 18:13–16; 21:3, 6, 10, trans. R. H. Charles (1917), Wikisource. Charles's editorial brackets (⌈ ⌉) are retained where quoted.↩

111. Clement of Alexandria, *Adumbrationes* on Jude 13, ANF 2.↩

112. 1 Enoch 2:1, 3; 5:1, 3–4, trans. R. H. Charles (1917), Wikisource; Charles's editorial brackets omitted in the block quotation.↩

113. 1 Enoch 80:2–3, 6–7, trans. R. H. Charles (1917), Wikisource.↩

114. Bauckham, *Jude, 2 Peter*, on vv. 12–13 (cited from prior knowledge). The correspondences in the table were checked against Charles's translation for this edition.↩

E. The Historical and Cultural World

The sea in the ancient Near East. In the myths of Israel's neighbors, the sea was a chaotic divine power that the storm god had to defeat. Israel's scriptures echo this imagery but transform it. The sea is a creature, powerful but subject to the LORD (Ps 93:3–4). For people who lived mostly inland and knew the sea from the coastline or from dangerous voyages, its restless waves and debris-strewn beaches were familiar images of turmoil.

Astronomy and astrology. Educated people in the Greco-Roman world knew the five visible planets (Mercury, Venus, Mars, Jupiter, Saturn) as "wanderers." Many also believed that the stars and planets influenced human affairs, and astrology was widespread. Jewish and Christian writers generally rejected astrological fatalism. 1 Enoch even warns that sinners will "err and take them to be gods" (80:7). Jude uses the image of wandering stars to describe people who have left their place, not to say anything about the influence of the heavens.

Darkness and judgment. In both Jewish and Greek thought, the realm of the dead and the place of punishment were associated with darkness, ζόφος in

Homer, “outer darkness” in Jesus’ sayings, and the dark prison of the angels in 1 Enoch. Jude draws on this shared imagery.

F. Connections Across Scripture

Isaiah 57:20–21 (probable allusion). “The wicked [are] as the driven out sea, / For it is not able to rest, / And its waters cast out filth and mire” (LSV). Jude’s image of waves foaming up shame matches the Hebrew of this verse closely.

Job 38:8–11; Psalm 89:9; Jeremiah 5:22 (shared theme). God’s restraint of the sea’s “pride” provides the background against which “wild waves” appear as rebellion.

James 1:6 (verbal and thematic link). James compares “he who is doubting” to “a wave of the sea, driven by wind and tossed” (LSV). The verb translated “doubting” (διακρίνομαι, *diakrinomai*) is the same verb Jude uses of those who are “doubting” in v. 22. The restless sea is an image of instability both in James and in Jude.

Revelation 1:20; 8:10; 9:1; Isaiah 14:12 (shared imagery). Stars as angels, and fallen stars as images of judgment or of rebellious powers, appear across Scripture. Isaiah’s taunt against the king of Babylon, “How you have fallen from the heavens, / O shining one, son of the dawn!” (Isa 14:12, LSV), was later read by many Christian interpreters as a description of Satan’s fall.

Daniel 12:3; Philippians 2:15 (contrast). The faithful are pictured as stars that shine: “those justifying the multitude as stars for all time and forever” (Dan 12:3, LSV); believers “appear as luminaries in the world” (Phil 2:15, LSV). The wandering stars of Jude 13 are their dark opposite.

2 Peter 2:17 (literary parallel). Peter keeps the “gloom of darkness” but applies it to “wells without water, and clouds driven by a storm” (LSV), and drops the waves and stars.

1 Enoch 2–5; 18; 21; 80 (source tradition). See the deep dive.

G. Scholarly and Theological Questions

1. Do the images reflect 1 Enoch? Many scholars think so, given the correspondence of the four regions of nature and Jude’s explicit use of 1 Enoch in the next verses. Others regard the images as drawn more generally from common Jewish and biblical imagery. The parallels with 1 Enoch 2–5 and 80 are strong enough to make the connection probable, though not certain.

2. What are the "wandering stars"? Planets, meteors, or stars identified with fallen angels. The Enochic background favors the last, without excluding the ordinary meaning "planets."

3. Does "forever" imply eternal punishment? The phrase "has been kept … throughout the age" (εἰς αἰῶνα) uses standard biblical language for permanence. As with "continuous fire" in v. 7, questions about the nature and duration of final judgment belong to the wider biblical and theological discussion. Jude's own concern is to stress the seriousness and finality of the intruders' destiny, in contrast with the readers, who await "continuous life" (v. 21).

H. The Passage Within Jude

Verse 13 completes the application begun in v. 12. The five images (reefs, clouds, trees, waves, stars) have moved from the community's table outward through creation, and they end in darkness. The repetition of "gloom" (ζόφος) from v. 6 and of "kept" (τηρέω) from vv. 1 and 6 ties this conclusion to the beginning of Jude's argument. The intruders' fate is the fate of the rebel angels.

The verse also sets up the next section. The nature imagery of 1 Enoch 2–5 leads naturally to the prophecy of 1 Enoch 1:9, quoted in vv. 14–15, which announces the coming of the Lord to judge "all the impious." Jude moves from images to prophecy, from picture to proclamation.

I. Contemporary Understanding

Suggested applications, distinct from the original meaning.

Restlessness and peace. Isaiah's sea "is not able to rest," and "There is no peace … for the wicked." Jude's wild waves may prompt reflection on how a life without God's order can be restless, churning, and productive mainly of debris. In contrast, Jude wishes his readers peace (v. 2).

Order as gift. The ancient view of the heavens saw order as beautiful and good. Modern readers who value freedom from constraint may find it fruitful to consider how faithfulness to God's order can be compared to a star keeping its course: not a cage, but the condition of shining.

Guides who lead astray. Wandering stars were useless, and dangerous, to navigators. Believers might consider whom they look to for guidance, and how to tell a reliable guide from one who has left the path. They might also consider whether their own lives are guides others can safely follow.

The beauty of creation's obedience. 1 Enoch, and probably Jude, invited readers to observe nature's faithfulness: rain in its season, fruit in its time, the sea within its bounds, the stars on their courses. In an age of ecological disruption, that invitation may take on new resonance. Though ancient writers did not imagine modern environmental science, the conviction that human sin and creation's disorder are connected runs through Scripture (Gen 3:17–18; Rom 8:19–22). The application must be made carefully, but it is not foreign to the biblical vision.

J. Reflection and Discussion

1. Why do you think Jude used images from nature (clouds, trees, sea, stars) to describe people? What do these images communicate that plain description could not?
2. Read 1 Enoch 2:1–5:4 and 80:2–8 (or the excerpts in this chapter). Do you find the connection with Jude 12–13 convincing? What difference does it make to your reading?
3. Isaiah says the wicked are like a sea that "is not able to rest." What forms of restlessness do you observe in contemporary life, and what might Jude's image suggest about their source?
4. Daniel pictures the faithful as stars that shine forever, and Jude pictures the intruders as stars headed for darkness. What do you think it means for a believer to "keep course" like a star?
5. How might the ancient conviction that creation displays God's order shape the way Christians relate to the natural world today?

K. Sources

- LSV texts: eBible.org edition. Greek: SBLGNT; Text-Critical Greek NT notes on εἰς (τὸν) αἰῶνα.
- 1 Enoch 2:1–3; 5:1–4; 18:13–16; 21:1–10; 80:2–8, trans. R. H. Charles (1917), Wikisource.
- *Testament of Naphtali* 3:2, ANF 8.
- Clement of Alexandria, *Adumbrationes* on Jude 13, ANF 2.
- LXX Isa 57:20 (Brenton's Greek Septuagint).
- Abbott-Smith, s.vv. ἐπαφρίζω, πλανήτης, ζόφος.
- Bauckham, *Jude, 2 Peter*, on vv. 12–13 (cited from prior knowledge).

Chapter 8. Enoch, the Seventh from Adam (Jude 14–15)

A. The Text

> **14** And Enoch, the seventh from Adam, also prophesied to these, saying, “Behold, the LORD has come with myriads of His holy ones, **15** to do judgment against all, and to convict all their impious ones, concerning all their works of impiety that they did impiously, and concerning all the harsh [words] that impious sinners spoke against Him.”
>
> — Jude 14–15, LSV

B. Plain-English Orientation

Jude now quotes a prophecy attributed to Enoch, the ancient patriarch who “habitually walks with God, and he is not, for God has taken him” (Gen 5:24, LSV). The prophecy announces that the Lord comes with countless holy angels to judge everyone and to convict the ungodly of all their ungodly deeds and of all the harsh words they have spoken against him. Jude says that Enoch prophesied “to,” or about, “these,” the intruders. He sees the ancient prophecy as describing people in his own community.

The quotation comes from the opening chapter of the book known today as **1 Enoch**, a Jewish writing composed in stages over the last centuries before Christ. This is the only explicit quotation in Jude, and the clearest case in the New Testament of a Jewish writing from outside the Hebrew Bible being quoted and introduced as prophecy. It has raised questions from the second century to the present: Did Jude regard 1 Enoch as Scripture? What does his quotation imply about the book’s authority? This chapter looks first at what the quotation says and how Jude uses it, and then turns to the questions of canon.

C. Phrase-by-Phrase Exploration

“And Enoch, the seventh from Adam”

Genesis 5 lists the generations from Adam to Noah: Adam, Seth, Enosh, Kenan, Mahalalel, Jared, Enoch (cf. 1 Chr 1:1–3). Counting Adam as the first,

as ancient counting usually did, Enoch is the seventh: ἕβδομος ἀπὸ Ἀδάμ (*hebdomos apo Adam*), "seventh from Adam." The phrase appears in 1 Enoch itself, where Noah refers to his great-grandfather as "taken up, the seventh from Adam, the first man whom the Lord of Spirits created" (1 Enoch 60:8), and where Enoch says, "I was born the seventh in the first week" (1 Enoch 93:3).[115]

The description does three things:

1. **It identifies him.** There was another Enoch, Cain's son, after whom Cain named a city (Gen 4:17). Jude means the righteous Enoch of Seth's line.
2. **It stresses antiquity.** Enoch lived before the flood, in the seventh generation of humanity. His prophecy is among the oldest words of God imaginable. Calvin saw this as Jude's purpose: "he says expressly that he was the seventh from Adam, in order to commend the antiquity of the prophecy, because it existed in the world before the flood."[116]
3. **It may suggest completeness.** Seven was a number of fullness and perfection in Jewish thought. The "seventh" from Adam was a person of special standing, the one who "walks with God" and was taken by God. Jude does not draw attention to the symbolism, but his readers may have felt it.

Genesis says that Enoch "habitually walks with God" and that "God has taken him" (Gen 5:24, LSV). Hebrews adds: "By faith Enoch was translated—not to see death … for before his translation he had been testified to—that he had pleased God well" (Heb 11:5, LSV). A man so close to God and taken from the earth without dying was an ideal recipient of revelation, and Jewish tradition attributed to him visions of heaven, of the secrets of the cosmos, and of the final judgment.

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115. 1 Enoch 60:8; 93:3, trans. R. H. Charles (1917), Wikisource.↩

116. John Calvin, *Commentaries on the Catholic Epistles*, trans. John Owen (1855), on Jude 14.↩

"also prophesied to these"

The verb προεφήτευσεν (*proephēteusen*), "prophesied," is significant. Jude does not say that Enoch "wrote" or that "it is written." He says that Enoch prophesied. The word "also" (καί, *kai*) links this prophecy to the other evidence Jude has presented: Israel's history, the angels, Sodom, Michael, Cain, Balaam, and Korah all testify against the intruders, and so does Enoch.

The dative τούτοις (*toutois*), "to these," is best understood as "about these" or "with reference to these." Jude does not claim that Enoch foresaw these particular individuals by name. He claims that the people Enoch described, the

“impious” whom the Lord will judge, are people like these. This is the same way of reading prophecy found in the Dead Sea Scrolls and elsewhere in the New Testament: ancient words are understood as speaking to the reader’s own time.

“saying, ‘Behold, the LORD has come’”

The quotation opens with Ἰδού (*Idou*), “Behold!” or “Look!”, a prophetic call to attention.

“The LORD” translates κύριος (*kyrios*). The LSV prints it in capitals because the reference is to the God of Israel. In 1 Enoch, the subject is God: “And behold! He cometh with ten thousands of His holy ones” (1 Enoch 1:9, trans. Charles). In Jude, however, “Lord” most often refers to Jesus (vv. 4, 17, 21; also, on some readings, v. 5). Many interpreters think Jude understands the coming Lord of Enoch’s prophecy to be Jesus Christ at his return. That would be a further instance of the pattern seen in v. 5 and v. 4: language about the God of Israel applied to Jesus. The New Testament repeatedly pictures Jesus coming “with all His holy ones” (1 Thess 3:13, LSV) and “with messengers of His power” (2 Thess 1:7, LSV).

The verb ἦλθεν (*ēlthen*) is in the aorist, “came” (LSV: “has come”). In the context of a prophecy of future judgment, the past tense expresses certainty. Hebrew prophets often spoke of future events in the perfect tense, as though already accomplished, and Jude’s Greek reproduces the effect. Some interpreters suggest that the past tense reflects the Aramaic or Greek form of Enoch that Jude knew.

“with myriads of His holy ones”

The phrase ἐν ἁγίαις μυριάσιν αὐτοῦ (*en hagiais myriasin autou*), “with his holy myriads,” means “with tens of thousands of his holy ones.” A μυριάς (*myrias*) is ten thousand, and the plural means “countless thousands.” The “holy ones” are angels, the heavenly army that accompanies God in his appearing.

The image goes back to the theophany at Sinai, as described in Moses’ blessing: “YHWH has come from Sinai, / And has risen from Seir for them; He has shone from Mount Paran, / And has come [with] myriads of holy ones” (Deut 33:2, LSV). 1 Enoch’s opening deliberately echoes this. It describes God coming to “tread upon the earth, (even) on Mount Sinai” (1 Enoch 1:4).[117] Zechariah also foresees the day when “my God YHWH has come in, / All holy ones [are] with You” (Zech 14:5, LSV). Jesus speaks of the Son of Man coming “in His glory, and all the holy messengers with Him” (Matt 25:31, LSV).

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117. 1 Enoch 1:3–4, trans. R. H. Charles (1917): “The Holy Great One will come forth from His dwelling, And the eternal God will tread upon the earth, (even) on Mount Sinai.”↩

“to do judgment against all”

The purpose of the coming is ποιῆσαι κρίσιν κατὰ πάντων (*poiēsai krisin kata pantōn*), “to execute judgment against all.” The word “all” (πᾶς, *pas*) is repeated four times in the quotation: judgment on all, convicting all, concerning all their works, concerning all the harsh words. The judgment is universal and complete. Nothing escapes.

“and to convict all their impious ones”

The verb ἐλέγξαι (*elenxai*) means “to expose, convict, prove guilty.” It is the language of a courtroom in which guilt is demonstrated. Jesus says that the Spirit “will convict the world concerning sin, and concerning righteousness, and concerning judgment” (John 16:8, LSV).

A textual note. The object of “convict” varies in the manuscripts:

Edition	Reading	Translation
SBLGNT, WH, Tregelles	πάντας τοὺς ἀσεβεῖς	“all the impious”
Robinson–Pierpont (Byzantine), TR	πάντας τοὺς ἀσεβεῖς αὐτῶν	“all their impious ones” (LSV)
NA28	πᾶσαν ψυχήν	“every soul”

The NA28 reading, “every soul,” corresponds more closely to the wording of 1 Enoch 1:9, “to convict all flesh” in Charles’s translation, and the NA28 editors judged it original. The SBLGNT editors preferred “all the impious,” which fits Jude’s emphasis on the word “impious.” The LSV follows the Byzantine reading with “their.” The difference does not affect the sense of the passage: on any reading, the ungodly are convicted.[118] (The TR also reads ἐξελέγξαι, a strengthened form of the verb.)

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118. SBLGNT apparatus and eBible.org SBLGNT notes: “πάντας τοὺς ἀσεβεῖς WH Treg NIV] + αὐτῶν RP; πᾶσαν ψυχὴν NA28.” The Text-Critical Greek NT notes give the Byzantine reading in about 80% of manuscripts and πᾶσαν ψυχήν in under 1%; such counts do not determine originality.↩

“concerning all their works of impiety that they did impiously”

Here the quotation reaches its most emphatic point. The Greek περὶ πάντων τῶν ἔργων ἀσεβείας αὐτῶν ὧν ἠσέβησαν (*peri pantōn tōn ergōn asebeias autōn hōn ēsebēsan*) uses the root ἀσεβ- (*aseb-*), “ungodly,” twice in quick succession: “their ungodly works which they ungodly did.” With “impious” earlier and “impious sinners” at the end, the word family appears four times in

a single sentence. The verb ἠσέβησαν (*ēsebēsan*), “they acted impiously,” occurs nowhere else in the New Testament.

The repetition is deliberate. Jude introduced the intruders as ἀσεβεῖς, “impious,” in v. 4. Now, in the words of the ancient prophecy, the same word rings out four times. Jude’s earlier description of them was not merely his own opinion. It was the language of prophecy.

“and concerning all the harsh [words] that impious sinners spoke against Him”

The last clause shifts from deeds to words: περὶ πάντων τῶν σκληρῶν ὧν ἐλάλησαν κατ’ αὐτοῦ ἁμαρτωλοὶ ἀσεβεῖς (*peri pantōn tōn sklērōn hōn elalēsan kat’ autou hamartōloi asebeis*), “concerning all the hard things that ungodly sinners spoke against him.” The adjective σκληρός (*sklēros*) means “hard, harsh, rough.” In context it means defiant, insolent speech against God.

1 Enoch returns to this theme repeatedly. Immediately after the prophecy, it accuses sinners: “ye have turned away and spoken proud and hard words / With your impure mouths against His greatness” (1 Enoch 5:4). It speaks of a valley of judgment for those “who utter with their lips against the Lord unseemly words and of His glory speak hard things” (27:2), and it charges, “ye spake proud and insolent words against His righteousness” (101:3).[119]

The emphasis on speech connects the quotation with Jude’s charges. The intruders “speak evil of glorious [ones]” (v. 8) and of “whatever [things] they have not known” (v. 10). In the next verse Jude will add that “their mouth speaks swollen words” (v. 16), and the apostles foretold “scoffers” (v. 18). Sins of speech run through the letter.

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119. 1 Enoch 5:4; 27:2; 101:3, trans. R. H. Charles (1917), Wikisource.↩

Comparing Jude 14–15 with 1 Enoch 1:9

Placing Jude’s quotation beside R. H. Charles’s translation of 1 Enoch 1:9 (which Charles made from the Ethiopic, compared with the Greek) shows both close agreement and some differences:

Jude 14–15 (LSV)	1 Enoch 1:9 (trans. Charles)
“Behold, the LORD has come”	“And behold! He cometh”
“with myriads of His holy ones,”	“with ten thousands of [His] holy ones”
“to do judgment against all,”	“To execute judgement upon all,”
—	“And to destroy [all] the ungodly:”
“and to convict all their impious ones,”	“And to convict all flesh”

Jude 14–15 (LSV)	1 Enoch 1:9 (trans. Charles)
“concerning all their works of impiety that they did impiously,”	“Of all the works [of their ungodliness] which they have ungodly committed,”
“and concerning all the harsh [words] that impious sinners spoke against Him.”	“[And of all the hard things which] ungodly sinners [have spoken] against Him.”

The differences are of three kinds:

1. **Jude names “the Lord”** where 1 Enoch has “He.” This may be Jude’s clarification, and it opens the way to applying the prophecy to Christ.
2. **Jude lacks the line “And to destroy all the ungodly,”** found in the Ethiopic and Greek of 1 Enoch.
3. **“All flesh” vs. “the impious.”** The NA28 reading, “every soul,” is close to 1 Enoch’s “all flesh,” which is one reason the NA28 editors adopted it.

The Aramaic original of 1 Enoch 1:9 is partly preserved in a fragment from Qumran Cave 4, known as 4Q204. J. T. Milik, who published the Aramaic Enoch fragments, judged that Jude’s wording stands closer to the Aramaic than either the Greek or the Ethiopic versions do.[120] Richard Bauckham has argued that Jude knew the Greek version but made his own rendering with an eye on the Aramaic.[121] These detailed reconstructions should be treated as scholarly proposals. What is clear is that Jude quotes a form of the text very close to the one we know, adapting it to his purpose.

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120. J. T. Milik, *The Books of Enoch: Aramaic Fragments of Qumrân Cave 4* (Oxford: Clarendon, 1976). Milik’s judgment is reported here from secondary discussions and was not checked against his volume for this edition.↩

121. Bauckham, *Jude, 2 Peter*, on vv. 14–15 (cited from prior knowledge).↩

Deep dive: The Book of Enoch and the biblical canon

Jude’s quotation of Enoch raises one of the most interesting questions in the history of the Bible: what does it mean when a biblical writer quotes a book that is not itself in most Bibles?

1. What is 1 Enoch?

“1 Enoch” (also called “Ethiopic Enoch”) is a collection of five main sections, written by Jewish authors at different times between roughly the third century BC and the turn of the era:

Section	Chapters	Content	Approximate date
Book of the Watchers	1–36	Coming judgment; fall of the Watchers; Enoch’s journeys	3rd century BC or earlier

Section	Chapters	Content	Approximate date
Book of Parables (Similitudes)	37–71	Visions of the “Son of Man” / “Elect One” and judgment	1st century BC–1st century AD (debated)
Astronomical Book	72–82	Movements of sun, moon, and stars; calendar	3rd century BC or earlier
Book of Dreams	83–90	Visions of the flood and of Israel’s history (the “Animal Apocalypse”)	2nd century BC
Epistle of Enoch	91–108	Exhortations, woes, the “Apocalypse of Weeks”	2nd century BC

The quotation in Jude comes from the opening of the Book of the Watchers, one of the oldest parts.[122]

How the text survives. Aramaic fragments of most parts of 1 Enoch were found among the Dead Sea Scrolls in Qumran Cave 4 (manuscripts known as 4Q201–4Q212). The oldest are dated by their handwriting to the early second century BC. The Book of Parables is not represented at Qumran, which is one reason it is often dated later. A Greek manuscript of chapters 1–32, found at Akhmim (ancient Panopolis) in Egypt and published in 1892, preserves the Greek translation, and other Greek fragments survive. The complete book survives only in **Ge’ez**, the classical language of Ethiopia, in which it has been transmitted as part of the Bible.[123]

Canonical status today. 1 Enoch is part of the Old Testament in the **Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church** and the **Eritrean Orthodox Tewahedo Church**. It is used by the Beta Israel (Ethiopian Jewish) community. It is not part of the canon of Rabbinic Judaism or of other Christian churches, whether Catholic, Eastern Orthodox, Oriental Orthodox outside Ethiopia and Eritrea, or Protestant.[124]

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122. The division and approximate dating follow the standard scholarly consensus, as summarized in Nickelsburg, *1 Enoch 1*, and “Book of Enoch,” *Wikipedia*. Dates for individual sections, especially the Book of Parables, remain debated.↩

123. “Book of Enoch,” *Wikipedia* (accessed 7 November 2026): Aramaic fragments 4Q201–4Q212; Akhmim Greek codex of chapters 1–32 published in 1892; complete text only in Ge’ez.↩

124. Ibid.↩

2. How did early Christians respond to Jude’s quotation?

The ancient church took up the question directly, and its answers diverged:

- **Tertullian** (c. 200) argued that the Book of Enoch should be accepted. He acknowledged that "the Scripture of Enoch … is not received by some, because it is not admitted into the Jewish canon either," but he insisted that "Enoch possesses a testimony in the Apostle Jude."[125] For Tertullian, Jude's quotation proved Enoch's authority.
- **Jerome** (late fourth century) reported the opposite effect: "because in it he quotes from the apocryphal Book of Enoch it is rejected by many. Nevertheless by age and use it has gained authority and is reckoned among the Holy Scriptures."[126] For some, Jude's quotation of Enoch counted against Jude.
- **Augustine** (early fifth century) took a middle position: "We cannot deny that Enoch, the seventh from Adam, left some divine writings, for this is asserted by the Apostle Jude in his canonical epistle. But it is not without reason that these writings have no place in that canon of Scripture which was preserved in the temple of the Hebrew people." He explained that such books are excluded because of their "obscure origin" and because "though there is some truth in these apocryphal writings, yet they contain so many false statements."[127]
- **John Calvin** (sixteenth century) suggested that Jude might not have taken the prophecy from a book at all: "I rather think that this prophecy was unwritten, than that it was taken from an apocryphal book; for it may have been delivered down by memory to posterity by the ancients."[128]

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125. Tertullian, *De cultu feminarum* 1.3, ANF 4 (https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/0402.htm).↩

126. Jerome, *De viris illustribus* 4, NPNF² 3 (https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/2708.htm).↩

127. Augustine, *City of God* 15.23, NPNF¹ 2 (https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/120115.htm).↩

128. Calvin, *Commentaries on the Catholic Epistles*, on Jude 14.↩

3. How can Jude's use be understood?

Modern interpreters generally take one of the following views. They are presented here with their strengths and weaknesses.

(a) Jude regarded 1 Enoch as Scripture. On this view, Jude, like some Jews of his time (the Qumran community preserved many copies of Enoch), treated 1 Enoch as authoritative revelation.

- *Strength:* Jude calls the passage prophecy and uses it as decisive evidence.

- *Weakness:* Jude does not use the formulas by which New Testament writers usually introduce Scripture ("it is written," "the Scripture says"). And the book was not, as far as we know, part of the scriptures generally recognized in the synagogues.

(b) Jude regarded this prophecy as a genuine word of Enoch, without endorsing the whole book. On this view, Jude believed that the historical Enoch spoke these words, which had been preserved in tradition and recorded in the Enochic literature, without implying that everything in 1 Enoch was inspired.

- *Strength:* This view takes Jude's "Enoch … prophesied" seriously and matches Augustine's position.
- *Weakness:* Modern historical study regards 1 Enoch as written many centuries after any historical Enoch. Those who hold this view must either dispute that conclusion or argue that the book preserves an ancient tradition. Both are possible but hard to demonstrate.

(c) Jude quoted a respected text that his readers knew, as true in what it says, without making a claim about its authorship or canonical status. On this view, "prophesied" means that the passage speaks truly about the future judgment, as indeed the Old Testament does in many places (Deut 33:2; Zech 14:5; Dan 7:10). Jude quotes it because it was familiar and authoritative *to his readers*, and possibly to the intruders themselves, if they appealed to visionary literature.

- *Strength:* The New Testament elsewhere quotes non-biblical sources for true statements without implying their inspiration. Paul quotes a Greek poet at Athens: "as certain of your poets have also said: For we are also His offspring" (Acts 17:28, LSV). Writing to Titus, he even calls the Cretan poet Epimenides "a prophet of their own" before quoting him and adding, "This testimony is true" (Titus 1:12–13, LSV). He quotes a proverb found in the Greek playwright Menander: "evil communications corrupt good manners" (1 Cor 15:33, LSV). Second Timothy names Moses' opponents "Jannes and Jambres" (2 Tim 3:8, LSV), names known from Jewish tradition and not from the Old Testament.
- *Weakness:* Jude's language is stronger than these parallels. He says Enoch "prophesied," and he treats the prophecy as applying directly to the intruders.

4. Principles worth holding

Whatever view one takes, several principles help readers think clearly:

1. **Quotation is not canonization.** That a biblical author quotes a book does not make that book Scripture. Paul's quotations of pagan poets do

not make those poets canonical. The question of Jude's view of Enoch must be decided on its own evidence.

2. **The quoted statement can be true without endorsing everything in the source.** Jude affirms that the Lord will come with his holy ones in judgment, a truth taught throughout Scripture. Nothing in his quotation requires readers to accept the astronomical calendar of 1 Enoch 72–82 or every detail of its angelology.
3. **Jude's own authority does not depend on the answer.** The church accepted Jude into its canon in full knowledge that Jude quoted Enoch, as Tertullian, Jerome, and Augustine show. Christians who accept Jude as Scripture can hold different views of 1 Enoch.
4. **The study of 1 Enoch illuminates the New Testament.** Whatever its canonical status, 1 Enoch helps modern readers understand ideas that were current in Jude's world: the Watchers, the judgment of fallen angels, the "Son of Man," and the coming of God with holy myriads. Reading it is no threat to faith. It is a way of hearing the New Testament in its own historical accent.
5. **Respect for other traditions.** For Ethiopian and Eritrean Orthodox Christians, 1 Enoch is Scripture. Other Christians can respect that tradition while explaining their own canon, and can recognize that the boundaries of the canon were not settled in the same way or at the same time everywhere.

D. Original-Language Investigation

Greek	Transliteration	Basic meaning	In context	Notes
ἕβδομος	*hebdomos*	seventh	"the seventh from Adam"	Inclusive counting; 1 Enoch 60:8; 93:3.
προφητεύω	*prophēteuō*	prophesy	"prophesied"	Not "wrote" or "it is written."
τούτοις	*toutois*	to/about these	"to these"	Dative of reference.
ἰδού	*idou*	behold, look	"Behold"	Prophetic call to attention.
ἦλθεν	*ēlthen*	came	"has come"	Aorist expressing certainty.
μυριάς	*myrias*	ten thousand	"myriads"	Countless angelic host.
ἅγιος	*hagios*	holy	"holy ones"	Angels (Deut 33:2; Zech 14:5).

Greek	Transliteration	Basic meaning	In context	Notes
κρίσις	*krisis*	judgment	"judgment"	
ἐλέγχω	*elenchō*	expose, convict	"to convict"	TR: ἐξελέγχω.
ἀσεβής / ἀσέβεια / ἀσεβέω	*asebēs* / *asebeia* / *asebeō*	impious / impiety / act impiously	"impious … impiety … did impiously"	Fourfold repetition; ἀσεβέω is an NT hapax.
σκληρός	*sklēros*	hard, harsh	"harsh [words]"	Insolent speech; cf. 1 Enoch 5:4; 27:2.
ἁμαρτωλός	*hamartōlos*	sinner	"sinners"	
πᾶσαν ψυχήν	*pasan psychēn*	every soul	(NA28 reading)	Alternative to "all the impious."

On "prophesied." The verb προφητεύω has a range of uses in the New Testament: foretelling (Matt 15:7), speaking God's message (1 Cor 14:1–5), and even mocking demands to "prophesy" (Mark 14:65). In Jude, it clearly means that Enoch's words convey a true message about the future judgment of the ungodly. Whether it also implies a judgment about the book's authorship and authority is the question discussed in the deep dive.

E. The Historical and Cultural World

Enoch traditions in Judaism. Enoch fascinated Jewish writers of the Second Temple period. Apart from 1 Enoch, he appears in *Jubilees*, in the Dead Sea Scrolls, and in later works such as *2 Enoch* (preserved in Slavonic) and *3 Enoch* (Hebrew). He was celebrated as a scribe, a sage, a recipient of heavenly secrets, and a witness to the coming judgment. Jude's readers, who knew the Watcher story (v. 6) and probably the nature images of 1 Enoch (vv. 12–13), evidently regarded Enoch as a significant voice.

Fluid boundaries. In Jude's day, the boundaries of the Jewish scriptures were not settled in every detail, especially at the margins of the "Writings." The Qumran community preserved many copies of 1 Enoch and Jubilees alongside biblical books. Other Jewish groups, and later the rabbinic tradition, did not treat these books as Scripture. Early Christians inherited this situation, and their own canonical lists took several centuries to stabilize. Jude's quotation should be read against that background, not anachronistically against later definitions.

Prophecy as present-tense interpretation. Jewish interpreters of the period frequently read ancient prophecies as referring to their own time. The Dead Sea Scrolls' commentaries (the *pesharim*) quote a prophetic text and

then explain its “interpretation” in terms of the community’s experience. Jude’s “Enoch … prophesied to these” is the same kind of reading.

F. Connections Across Scripture

Genesis 5:21–24; Hebrews 11:5 (Enoch). The biblical basis for Enoch’s reputation. Hebrews celebrates his faith and translation.

Deuteronomy 33:2 (source of the imagery). The coming of the LORD “[with] myriads of holy ones” at Sinai is the ultimate source of the picture in 1 Enoch 1:9 and Jude 14.

Zechariah 14:5; Daniel 7:10 (shared theme). The coming of God with his holy ones to judge.

Matthew 25:31; Mark 8:38; 1 Thessalonians 3:13; 2 Thessalonians 1:7 (shared theme). The return of Jesus with his angels. If Jude understands “the Lord” in the quotation to be Jesus, these texts are his closest New Testament parallels.

Acts 17:28; Titus 1:12–13; 1 Corinthians 15:33; 2 Timothy 3:8 (method). New Testament quotations of, and allusions to, non-biblical sources. These help frame the question of what Jude’s quotation implies.

John 16:8 (vocabulary). The Spirit “will convict” (ἐλέγξει, *elenxei*) the world, the same verb as Jude’s “to convict.”

G. Scholarly and Theological Questions

1. Did Jude regard 1 Enoch as Scripture? Discussed in the deep dive. Interpreters remain divided. The most cautious conclusion is that Jude regarded this prophecy as a true word of God about judgment, and that his readers recognized it as authoritative. The question of what Jude thought about the book as a whole cannot be answered from his single quotation.

2. Who is “the Lord” in v. 14? God in 1 Enoch. Most likely Jesus in Jude’s application, given Jude’s usage elsewhere and the New Testament’s expectation of Christ’s coming with his angels.

3. Which text did Jude use? Probably a Greek or Aramaic form of 1 Enoch close to the ones we know, perhaps with his own adaptations. The exact relationship is debated.

4. Which reading is original in v. 15? “All the impious” (SBLGNT), “all their impious ones” (Byzantine), or “every soul” (NA28). The meaning is the same in substance.

5. Does Jude's use of Enoch undermine his authority? Some early Christians thought so. The church as a whole concluded otherwise. Modern readers who share the church's acceptance of Jude can read his quotation as an example of how the Spirit used the literature and traditions of the time to speak a true word, without thereby endorsing everything in that literature.

H. The Passage Within Jude

The Enoch quotation is the centerpiece of Jude's case. It supplies the clearest example of the judgment "written beforehand" (v. 4), and its fourfold "impious" confirms that Jude's description of the intruders was the language of prophecy. It is followed by another application ("These are…," v. 16), which applies the prophecy's charge of "harsh words" to the intruders' grumbling and arrogant speech.

The quotation also provides the letter's main picture of the future: the Lord coming with his holy ones. The readers, by contrast, are told to wait for "the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ" (v. 21) and are promised that God will set them "in the presence of His glory unblemished" (v. 24). The same coming that brings judgment on the impious brings mercy and joy to those who have been kept.

I. Contemporary Understanding

Suggested applications, distinct from the original meaning.

Reading Scripture with its world. Jude's quotation of Enoch shows that the New Testament was written in conversation with the literature and traditions of its time. Modern readers may find their understanding enriched, not threatened, by learning about that world: the Dead Sea Scrolls, the Jewish writings of the Second Temple period, and the history of the canon.

Humility about the canon. Christians today hold different views about which books belong in the Old Testament (Protestant, Catholic, Orthodox, and Ethiopian canons differ). Jude's quotation of Enoch, and the varied responses of Tertullian, Jerome, Augustine, and Calvin, may encourage both conviction about one's own tradition and charity toward others.

Words matter to God. Enoch's prophecy convicts sinners not only of their deeds but of "the harsh [words]" they have spoken against God. Jude's letter is full of concern about speech: slander, harsh words, grumbling, boasting, scoffing. In an age of easy and often harsh public speech, the passage may prompt reflection on accountability for words.

The coming of the Lord. The picture of the Lord coming with countless holy ones is both a warning and a comfort. It warns that injustice and ungodliness will not have the last word. It comforts those who wait for "the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ" (v. 21).

J. Reflection and Discussion

1. How did you react to learning that Jude quotes a book not found in most Bibles? Did it raise questions for you, and how would you begin to answer them?
2. Compare Jude's use of Enoch with Paul's quotations of Greek poets (Acts 17:28; Titus 1:12; 1 Cor 15:33). What similarities and differences do you see?
3. Tertullian, Jerome, Augustine, and Calvin each responded differently to Jude's quotation. Which response do you find most persuasive, and why?
4. Enoch's prophecy emphasizes "harsh [words] … spoken against Him." Why might speech be singled out alongside deeds in a description of ungodliness?
5. How does the picture of the Lord coming "with myriads of His holy ones" shape your hope and your sense of responsibility?

K. Sources

- LSV texts: eBible.org edition. Greek: SBLGNT and apparatus (with NA28 data); Robinson–Pierpont; TR.
- 1 Enoch 1:1–9; 5:4; 27:2; 60:8; 93:3; 101:3, trans. R. H. Charles (1917), Wikisource.
- Tertullian, *De cultu feminarum* 1.3 (ANF 4); Jerome, *De viris illustribus* 4 (NPNF² 3); Augustine, *City of God* 15.23 (NPNF¹ 2); Calvin, *Commentaries on the Catholic Epistles*, on Jude 14.
- On the text and canonical status of 1 Enoch: "Book of Enoch," *Wikipedia* (accessed 7 November 2026); George W. E. Nickelsburg, *1 Enoch 1* (Hermeneia, 2001); J. T. Milik, *The Books of Enoch* (1976) (both cited from prior knowledge).
- Bauckham, *Jude, 2 Peter*, on vv. 14–15 (cited from prior knowledge).

Chapter 9. Grumblers, Fault-Finders, and Flatterers (Jude 16)

A. The Text

> **16** These are discontented grumblers, walking according to their own lusts; and their mouth speaks swollen words, giving admiration to persons for the sake of profit;
>
> — Jude 16, LSV

B. Plain-English Orientation

After Enoch's prophecy, Jude applies it once more: "These are…" Enoch's prophecy ended with "the harsh [words] that impious sinners spoke against Him." Jude now shows how the intruders' speech fits that description. They **grumble**, complaining against God and their circumstances. They **blame their lot**, always dissatisfied. They **follow their own desires**. They **speak arrogant words**, boastful and grandiose. And they **flatter people** when there is something to be gained.

The portrait is psychologically sharp. The same people who complain about God and boast about themselves are servile toward anyone who can benefit them. Their speech moves between resentment, arrogance, and flattery, and self-interest drives all three.

C. Phrase-by-Phrase Exploration

"These are discontented grumblers"

The verse opens with the formula Οὗτοί εἰσιν (*Houtoi eisin*), "These are," which marks the third application in the letter (vv. 8, 10, 12, 16, 19). The LSV's "discontented grumblers" combines two Greek words, each found nowhere else in the New Testament.

γογγυσταί (*gongystai*), "grumblers, murmurers." The noun comes from the verb γογγύζω (*gongyzō*), "to grumble, mutter," whose sound imitates low, discontented muttering. The noun itself is rare, and in the Greek Old Testament it appears only in later revisions.[129] The verb and its related noun γογγυσμός (*gongysmos*), however, are the standard Septuagint terms for

Israel's murmuring in the wilderness. "In YHWH's hearing your murmurings, which you are murmuring against Him … Your murmurings [are] not against us, but against YHWH" (Exod 16:8, LSV). After the spies' report, "all the sons of Israel murmur against Moses and against Aaron" (Num 14:2, LSV), and God says, "The murmurings of the sons of Israel, which they are murmuring against Me, I have heard" (Num 14:27, LSV). The murmuring led to the death of that generation in the wilderness, the very event Jude recalled in v. 5. Korah's rebellion, too, was a "murmuring" against Aaron (Num 16:11; 17:5).

Paul draws the same lesson for the church: "neither murmur, as also some of them murmured, and perished by the destroyer" (1 Cor 10:10, LSV). He urges the Philippians, "Do all things without murmurings and deliberations" (Phil 2:14, LSV). For Jude's readers, "grumblers" would have called up the whole wilderness story: people delivered by God who complained against him and perished.

μεμψίμοιροι (*mempsimoiroi*), "fault-finders, complaining of their lot." This word combines μέμφομαι (*memphomai*, "to blame, find fault") and μοῖρα (*moira*, "lot, portion, fate"). Its sense is "blaming one's lot," "querulous," and it describes a person perpetually dissatisfied with what life, or God, has given.[130] It was a recognized character type in Greek moral writing. The philosopher Theophrastus (fourth century BC) included "the Grumbler" (Μεμψιμοιρία, *Mempsimoiria*) among his thirty sketches of human types. His grumbler receives a gift of food from a friend's table and complains, "He grudged me a dish of soup and a cup of wine, I suppose, and so couldn't invite me to dinner."[131] Jude's readers would have recognized the type, a person whose ingratitude turns every blessing into a grievance.

Put together, the two words describe people whose fundamental posture toward God is complaint. They are the opposite of the thankful, contented trust that the faith produces (Phil 4:11–12; 1 Tim 6:6–8).

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129. Abbott-Smith, s.v. γογγυστής: "[in Sm.: Pr 26:22, Is 29:24; Th.: Pr 26:20] a murmurer: Ju 16" (i.e., found in the later Greek versions of Symmachus and Theodotion, not in the main Septuagint).↩

130. Abbott-Smith, s.v. μεμψίμοιρος: "(< μέμφομαι, + μοῖρα, fate, lot), complaining of one's fate, querulous: Ju 16."↩

131. Theophrastus, *Characters* 17, as rendered in Charles E. Bennett and William A. Hammond, *The Characters of Theophrastus* (New York: Longmans, Green, 1902), Project Gutenberg #58242. Bennett and Hammond title the sketch "The Thankless Man." The Greek title is Μεμψιμοιρία.↩

"walking according to their own lusts"

The phrase κατὰ τὰς ἐπιθυμίας αὐτῶν πορευόμενοι (*kata tas epithymias autōn poreuomenoi*), “going according to their desires,” describes a whole way of life governed by craving. The verb πορεύομαι (*poreuomai*), “to go, walk,” repeats the “went” of v. 11 (“they went on in the way of Cain”), and it will return in v. 18 (“following after their own lusts of impieties”). The noun ἐπιθυμία (*epithymia*), “desire, craving,” is neutral in itself but in this context means disordered desire. The intruders’ grumbling and their self-indulgence are two sides of the same thing. Those whose desires rule them will always complain that their desires are not met.

A textual note. The SBLGNT and the Byzantine text read αὐτῶν (*autōn*), “their,” while NA28 reads ἑαυτῶν (*heautōn*), “their own.” The difference is minimal. The LSV’s “their own” matches the sense of either.[132]

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132. eBible.org SBLGNT notes: “αὐτῶν WH Treg RP] ἑαυτῶν NA28.”↩

“and their mouth speaks swollen words”

The Greek τὸ στόμα αὐτῶν λαλεῖ ὑπέρογκα (*to stoma autōn lalei hyperonka*) means literally “their mouth speaks swollen things.” The adjective ὑπέρογκος (*hyperonkos*), from ὑπέρ (*hyper*, “over”) and ὄγκος (*onkos*, “bulk, mass”), means “excessively large, immoderate,” and in later Greek it was used of arrogant, bombastic speech.[133] The LSV’s “swollen words” is vivid and accurate. The ASV’s “great swelling words” and the BSB’s “arrogantly” capture the sense.

The phrase has a striking biblical precedent. In the Greek version of Daniel, the arrogant king of the end time “shall speak swollen things” (λαλήσει ὑπέρογκα, *lalēsei hyperonka*) against the God of gods (Dan 11:36, Theodotion).[134] The Hebrew behind it says he “speaks wonderful things against the God of gods” (Dan 11:36, LSV). Daniel also describes the little horn with “a mouth speaking great things” (Dan 7:8, LSV). 1 Enoch, which Jude has just quoted, accuses sinners of speaking “proud and hard words / With your impure mouths against His greatness” (1 Enoch 5:4) and “proud and insolent words against His righteousness” (101:3).[135] Jude’s phrase places the intruders’ boasting in this line of arrogant speech against God.

What did their “swollen words” sound like? Perhaps grand claims about their visions (v. 8), their freedom (v. 4), or their spiritual superiority (v. 19). Second Peter’s parallel adds content: “speaking swollen words of vanity, they entice in desires of the flesh” (2 Pet 2:18, LSV). Their impressive talk was a means of luring others into their way of life.

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133. Abbott-Smith, s.v. ὑπέρογκος: “of excessive weight or size; metaph., excessive, immoderate, in late writers, of arrogant speech (v. Mayor on Ju, l.c.): n. pl., II Pe 2:18,

Ju 16.”↩

134. Greek Daniel (Theodotion) 11:36: καὶ λαλήσει ὑπέρογκα (Brenton’s Greek Septuagint, eBible.org).↩

135. 1 Enoch 5:4; 101:3, trans. R. H. Charles (1917), Wikisource.↩

“giving admiration to persons”

The phrase θαυμάζοντες πρόσωπα (*thaumazontes prosōpa*) means literally “admiring faces.” It is not natural Greek. It is a Hebrew idiom rendered word for word in the Greek Old Testament. The Hebrew expression “to lift up the face” of someone (*nāśā’ pānîm*) means to show favor or partiality, especially to the powerful. The Septuagint often translated it as θαυμάζειν πρόσωπον, “to admire a face.”[136] For example:

- “you do not lift up the face of the poor, nor honor the face of the great” (Lev 19:15, LSV), where the Septuagint has “you shall not admire the face of the powerful”;
- “your God YHWH … who does not accept by appearances, nor takes a bribe” (Deut 10:17, LSV), where the Septuagint has “who does not admire a face”;
- “[It] is not good to discern faces” (Prov 28:21, LSV);
- and, strikingly, in the Sodom narrative itself, the angel’s words to Lot, “Behold, I have also accepted your face for this thing” (Gen 19:21, LSV), where the Septuagint has ἐθαύμασά σου τὸ πρόσωπον, “I have admired your face,” meaning “I have granted your request.”

The New Testament uses a related compound for the same vice: “do not hold the faith of the glory of our Lord Jesus Christ in favor by appearance” (Jas 2:1, LSV); “if you favor by appearance, you work sin” (Jas 2:9, LSV). Peter at Cornelius’s house declares that “God is not favoring by appearance” (Acts 10:34, LSV).

The intruders, then, show favoritism. They flatter and court people of influence.

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136. Brenton’s Greek Septuagint: Gen 19:21 (ἐθαύμασά σου τὸ πρόσωπον); Lev 19:15 (οὐδὲ μὴ θαυμάσῃς πρόσωπον δυνάστου); Deut 10:17 (οὐ θαυμάζει πρόσωπον); 2 Chr 19:7; Job 13:10; 22:8; 32:22; Prov 18:5; Isa 9:15 (versification varies).↩

“for the sake of profit”

The reason for their flattery is ὠφελείας χάριν (*ōpheleias charin*), “for the sake of advantage” or “for profit.” The noun ὠφέλεια (*ōpheleia*) means “help, benefit, advantage.”[137] The word χάριν (*charin*), used here as a preposition meaning “for the sake of,” is in origin the accusative of χάρις (*charis*), “grace.”

It is tempting to see an irony: the intruders, who turned the *grace* (χάρις) of God into license (v. 4), now flatter people *for the sake of* (χάριν) profit. Whether Jude intended the echo is uncertain, since χάριν was an everyday preposition, but attentive readers may have heard it.

The combination is telling. Those who grumble against God and speak arrogantly against him are servile toward people who can reward them. Paul describes similar figures: “such do not serve our Lord Jesus Christ, but their own belly; and through the good word and fair speech they deceive the hearts of the harmless” (Rom 16:18, LSV). Paul contrasts his own ministry: “at no time did we come with speech of flattery … nor in a pretext for covetousness” (1 Thess 2:5, LSV). Balaam’s “reward” (v. 11) and the self-feeding shepherds (v. 12) find their counterpart here. The intruders’ speech, like their leadership, serves their own advantage.

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137. Abbott-Smith, s.v. ὠφέλεια: “profit, advantage, benefit: Ro 3:1, Ju 16.”↩

D. Original-Language Investigation

Greek	Transliteration	Basic meaning	In context	Notes
γογγυστής	*gongystēs*	grumbler, murmurer	“grumblers”	NT hapax; cf. γογγύζω, LXX wilderness murmuring.
μεμψίμοιρος	*mempsimoiros*	complaining of one’s lot, querulous	“discontented”	NT hapax; Theophrastus’s “Grumbler” type.
ἐπιθυμία	*epithymia*	desire, craving	“lusts”	Also v. 18.
πορεύομαι	*poreuomai*	go, walk	“walking”	Echoes v. 11; anticipates v. 18.
στόμα	*stoma*	mouth	“their mouth”	Semitic expression.
ὑπέρογκος	*hyperonkos*	excessive, swollen; arrogant	“swollen words”	Dan 11:36 Theod.; 2 Pet 2:18.
θαυμάζω πρόσωπον	*thaumazō prosōpon*	“admire a face” = show partiality	“giving admiration to persons”	LXX idiom for Heb. *nāśā’ pānîm*.
ὠφέλεια	*ōpheleia*	advantage, profit	“profit”	
χάριν	*charin*	for the sake of	“for the sake of”	Preposition (from χάρις).

A caution about the "admiring faces" idiom. Because θαυμάζω normally means "to marvel, wonder at," a reader without the Septuagint background might think the intruders were simply impressed by people. The phrase is a fixed idiom for partiality and favoritism. Here, as often, the Greek of the New Testament makes sense only against the Greek of the Old Testament.

E. The Historical and Cultural World

Patronage and flattery. The Greco-Roman world was structured by patronage. Wealthy patrons supported clients, who repaid them with loyalty, public praise, and services. Flattery was the lubricant of the system, and moralists from Theophrastus to Plutarch wrote about how to tell a flatterer from a friend. Early Christian communities, which met in the homes of wealthier members and depended on their hospitality, were not immune to these dynamics. James warns against honoring the rich man in fine clothes and dishonoring the poor man (Jas 2:1–9). Jude's intruders seem to have courted influential members of the community, perhaps the hosts of the love feasts, for their own advantage.

Moral character types. Greek moral writers catalogued human vices in sketches of recognizable types, including the flatterer, the grumbler, the boaster, and the toady. Jude's string of vivid descriptors resembles such sketches, though his categories are shaped by Scripture: the murmurers of the wilderness, the arrogant speakers of Daniel and Enoch, the partial judges condemned by the Law.

F. Connections Across Scripture

Exodus 16; Numbers 14; 1 Corinthians 10:10 (background). The wilderness murmuring is the main background for "grumblers." Jude's readers would connect v. 16 with v. 5: those who murmured perished.

Numbers 16:11; 17:5 (Korah). Korah's rebellion was a "murmuring." The grumblers of v. 16 walk in Korah's "controversy" (v. 11).

Daniel 7:8; 11:36 (verbal parallel). The arrogant king who "speaks wonderful things," Greek "swollen things," against God provides the closest biblical parallel to "swollen words."

Leviticus 19:15; Deuteronomy 10:17; James 2:1–9; Acts 10:34 (idiom and theme). Partiality is condemned in the Law, and God himself is the model of impartiality.

Romans 16:17–18; 1 Thessalonians 2:5 (shared theme). Paul's warnings against those who serve their own appetites with "fair speech," and his own

refusal of flattery, parallel Jude's charge.

2 Peter 2:18 (literary parallel). "Swollen words of vanity" used to entice others.

1 Enoch 5:4; 101:3 (source tradition). Proud and hard words against God.

G. Scholarly and Theological Questions

1. How does v. 16 relate to the Enoch quotation? Most interpreters see v. 16 as the application of the quotation, especially of its final phrase about "harsh [words] … against Him." The intruders' grumbling, boasting, and flattery are the "harsh words" of the prophecy in present form.

2. Whom did the intruders flatter? Jude does not say. Suggestions include wealthy members who hosted the community, people who might become followers and supporters, and church leaders whose approval they sought. The general point, that they cultivated people for gain, does not depend on a specific identification.

3. Is all complaint sinful? Scripture contains many complaints addressed to God, the laments of the Psalms, of Job, and of Jeremiah, which are not condemned. The difference lies in the posture. Lament brings pain *to* God in trust. Grumbling speaks *against* God in resentment and unbelief. The wilderness murmuring that Jude recalls was a refusal to trust the God who had delivered them (Num 14:11). Jude's word μεμψίμοιροι, "blaming one's lot," captures this spirit of grievance against God's providence.

H. The Passage Within Jude

Verse 16 completes the third "text and application" unit (vv. 14–16), applying Enoch's prophecy to the intruders. It also gathers threads from earlier in the letter: the murmuring of the wilderness generation (v. 5), the slander of glorious ones (vv. 8, 10), Korah's rebellion (v. 11), and Balaam's greed (v. 11). And it prepares for v. 18, where the apostles' prediction of "scoffers, following after their own lusts" repeats the phrase about walking according to lusts.

Throughout this middle section, speech is a recurring concern: slander (vv. 8–10), harsh words (v. 15), grumbling and swollen words (v. 16), and scoffing (v. 18). By contrast, the readers' speech is to be prayer "in the Holy Spirit" (v. 20) and the letter ends in praise (vv. 24–25).

I. Contemporary Understanding

Suggested applications, distinct from the original meaning.

Gratitude as resistance. Grumbling can become a habit of mind that colors every blessing with grievance, as in Theophrastus's grumbler who received a gift and complained he had not been invited to dinner. Jude's portrait may invite believers to examine their own speech about God, their circumstances, and their communities, and to cultivate thankfulness as a spiritual discipline.

Lament vs. grumbling. Christians sometimes suppress honest lament out of fear that it is "grumbling." Scripture's laments show that bringing pain to God in faith is not the sin Jude describes. The question is whether complaint is addressed to God in trust or spoken against God in resentment.

Flattery and influence. In churches as in every institution, there are temptations to court those with money, status, or power. James and Jude both condemn partiality. Communities may consider whether they treat wealthy or influential members differently, and whether their leaders' speech is shaped by the desire for advantage.

Inflated speech. "Swollen words" are common in religious marketing, political rhetoric, and online self-presentation. Jude's phrase may prompt reflection on the difference between speech that serves truth and speech that serves the speaker's image.

J. Reflection and Discussion

1. Why do you think grumbling was treated so seriously in the wilderness narratives and in Jude? What does grumbling reveal about a person's relationship with God?
2. How would you distinguish biblical lament from the grumbling Jude condemns? Can you think of examples from Scripture or experience?
3. Jude describes people who are arrogant toward God and flattering toward people. Why do you think these two traits often go together?
4. Where do you see the temptation to "admire faces," to show favoritism for advantage, in your church, workplace, or community?
5. What practices might help cultivate contentment and gratitude in a culture that often encourages complaint?

K. Sources

- LSV texts: eBible.org edition. Greek: SBLGNT and apparatus (NA28 data). LXX: Brenton's Greek Septuagint (Lev 19:15; Deut 10:17; Gen 19:21; Job 13:10; Prov 18:5; Dan 11:36 Theodotion).
- Abbott-Smith, s.vv. γογγυστής, μεμψίμοιρος, ὑπέρογκος, ὠφέλεια.
- Theophrastus, *Characters* 17 ("The Thankless Man"/"Grumbler"), trans. C. E. Bennett and W. A. Hammond (1902), Project Gutenberg #58242.
- 1 Enoch 5:4; 101:3, trans. R. H. Charles (1917).

Chapter 10. Remember What the Apostles Said (Jude 17–19)

A. The Text

> **17** but you, beloved, remember the sayings spoken before by the apostles of our Lord Jesus Christ, **18** that they said to you, that in the last time there will be scoffers, following after their own lusts of impieties, **19** these are those causing divisions, natural men, not having the Spirit.
>
> — Jude 17–19, LSV

B. Plain-English Orientation

With “but you, beloved,” Jude turns from the intruders to his readers. He has been building his case from ancient sources: Israel’s history, angelic traditions, the stories of Cain, Balaam, and Korah, and Enoch’s prophecy. Now he brings it close to home. The readers themselves had heard the apostles warn that in the last days there would be scoffers, driven by ungodly desires. The intruders fulfill that prediction. In Jude’s final description of them, they are people who create divisions, who are merely “natural” in their outlook, and who do not have the Spirit.

This is the last “text and application” unit in the letter. Its text is not an ancient prophecy but the recent teaching of the apostles, and its application is the most theologically pointed charge of all: the people who claim spiritual revelation do not have the Spirit.

C. Phrase-by-Phrase Exploration

“but you, beloved”

The Greek Ὑμεῖς δέ, ἀγαπητοί (*Hymeis de, agapētoi*) places the pronoun “you” first for emphasis: “*But you*, beloved.” It marks a sharp contrast with the repeated “these” (οὗτοι, *houtoi*) of the previous verses. This is the second of Jude’s three addresses to the “beloved” (vv. 3, 17, 20), and it begins the turn toward the readers that will carry through to the end of the letter.

“remember”

The aorist imperative μνήσθητε (*mnēsthēte*), "remember," is Jude's first direct command to his readers. In the Bible, remembering is never merely recalling information. It means calling the past into the present so that it shapes action. Moses tells Israel, "you have remembered all the way which your God YHWH has caused you to go these forty years in the wilderness, in order to humble you" (Deut 8:2, LSV). Paul writes, "Remember Jesus Christ, raised out of the dead" (2 Tim 2:8, LSV). Jude began the main body of his letter with "I intend to remind you" (v. 5). Now he asks his readers to do their own remembering.

"the sayings spoken before by the apostles of our Lord Jesus Christ"

The readers are to remember τῶν ῥημάτων τῶν προειρημένων ὑπὸ τῶν ἀποστόλων (*tōn rhēmatōn tōn proeirēmenōn hypo tōn apostolōn*), "the words spoken beforehand by the apostles." The perfect participle προειρημένων (*proeirēmenōn*), "spoken before" or "foretold," stresses that the warning was given in advance and still stands.

Two observations follow:

1. **Jude distinguishes himself from "the apostles."** He does not say "we apostles." This fits the author's modest self-description in v. 1 and is one of the reasons for thinking that the author did not claim apostolic status. Some scholars have read the phrase as evidence that the apostles belonged to a past generation and that the letter is therefore late. The next verse suggests otherwise: the apostles had spoken "to you," to the readers themselves.
2. **The apostles' words are placed alongside the prophets.** Jude has cited Israel's history and Enoch's prophecy. Now he adds the apostles' teaching as a further authority. Second Peter's parallel makes the pairing explicit: "to be mindful of the sayings said before by the holy prophets, and of the command of us the apostles of the LORD and Savior" (2 Pet 3:2, LSV). For the early church, the prophets and the apostles together were the foundation of the faith (Eph 2:20).

"that they said to you"

The imperfect ἔλεγον (*elegon*), "they were saying" or "they used to say," suggests repeated teaching rather than a single statement. The warning about scoffers was a regular part of apostolic instruction. And it was said ὑμῖν (*hymin*), "to you." Jude's readers had heard it firsthand, probably from the missionaries who founded their community. That detail points to a date within the first generation or so of the church. It also makes Jude's appeal personal. He is not citing a distant authority. He is reminding them of what they themselves heard.

What did the apostles say? The New Testament preserves several such warnings. Paul told the Ephesian elders: “there will enter in, after my departing, grievous wolves to you, not sparing the flock, and there will arise men of your own selves, speaking perverse things, to draw away the disciples after them” (Acts 20:29–30, LSV). He told Timothy that “in latter times some will depart from the faith” (1 Tim 4:1, LSV) and that “in the last days there will come perilous times, for men will be lovers of themselves, lovers of money, boasters, proud, slanderous … unthankful … lovers of pleasure more than lovers of God, having a form of piety, but having denied its power” (2 Tim 3:1–5, LSV). Jesus himself had warned: “many false prophets will arise, and will lead many astray” (Matt 24:11, LSV); “behold, I have foretold you all things” (Mark 13:23, LSV). Jude’s summary does not quote any of these passages directly, but it reflects the same tradition of prophetic warning.

“that in the last time there will be scoffers”

The phrase ἐπ’ ἐσχάτου χρόνου (*ep’ eschatou chronou*), “at the last time,” reflects the conviction, shared by the whole New Testament, that the coming of Christ inaugurated the “last days.” Hebrews says God has spoken “in these last days … in [His] Son” (Heb 1:2, LSV). Peter at Pentecost quoted Joel’s promise of what would happen “in the last days” (Acts 2:17). John says, “Little youths, it is the last hour” (1 John 2:18, LSV). The “last time” is not a distant future. It is the period in which the church lives, between Christ’s first coming and his return.

A textual note. The manuscripts differ in the wording of this phrase. The Byzantine text and TR read ἐν ἐσχάτῳ χρόνῳ (*en eschatō chronō*), “in the last time.” NA27 read ἐπ’ ἐσχάτου τοῦ χρόνου, with the article. SBLGNT and NA28 read ἐπ’ ἐσχάτου χρόνου. Some manuscripts also add a second ὅτι (“that”) before the quotation. The sense is unaffected.[138]

The **scoffers** (ἐμπαῖκται, *empaiktai*) are “mockers,” people who ridicule. The word appears in the New Testament only here and in 2 Pet 3:3.[139] In 2 Peter the scoffers mock the promise of Christ’s return: “Where is the promise of His coming? For since the fathers fell asleep, all things so remain from the beginning of the creation” (2 Pet 3:4, LSV). Jude does not specify the object of their mockery. In the context of his letter it is most naturally the moral demands of the faith and the warning of judgment. The intruders treat God’s judgment as a joke, and their way of life follows from it. The “scorner” of Israel’s wisdom literature is a similar figure: “O the blessedness of that one, … And has not sat in the seat of scorners” (Ps 1:1, LSV). Proverbs adds, “Do not reprove a scorner, lest he hate you” (Prov 9:8, LSV).

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138. SBLGNT apparatus and eBible.org SBLGNT notes: “ὑμῖν WH NA28] + ὅτι Treg NA27 RP • Ἐπ’ ἐσχάτου χρόνου WH Treg NA28] Ἐπ’ ἐσχάτου τοῦ χρόνου NA27; ἐν ἐσχάτῳ

χρόνῳ RP.”↩

139. Computed from MorphGNT/SBLGNT. Abbott-Smith, s.v. ἐμπαίκτης: “a mocker: II Pe 3:3, Ju 18,” noting one LXX occurrence (Isa 3:4).↩

“following after their own lusts of impieties”

The scoffers are κατὰ τὰς ἐαυτῶν ἐπιθυμίας πορευόμενοι τῶν ἀσεβειῶν (*kata tas heautōn epithymias poreuomenoi tōn asebeiōn*), literally “going according to their own desires of ungodlinesses.” The genitive “of impieties” describes the kind of desires: ungodly desires. The phrase echoes v. 16 almost word for word (“walking according to their own lusts”) and adds Jude’s key word one last time: ἀσέβεια, “impiety.” From v. 4, through the fourfold repetition in the Enoch quotation (v. 15), to here, the intruders are consistently the “ungodly.”

“these are those causing divisions”

The final application begins with the familiar formula, Οὗτοί εἰσιν (*Houtoi eisin*), “These are.” The first description is οἱ ἀποδιορίζοντες (*hoi apodiorizontes*). The verb, found only here in the New Testament, means “to mark off, separate, make distinctions.”[140] It is built from ὅρος (*horos*, “boundary”) with prefixes meaning “away” and “through.” The intruders draw lines through the community.

Two senses are possible:

1. **“Those who cause divisions.”** The intruders create factions, separating their followers from the rest of the community. Paul warns against “those who are causing the divisions and the stumbling-blocks, contrary to the teaching that you learned” (Rom 16:17, LSV), and lists “dissensions, sects” among the works of the flesh (Gal 5:20, LSV).
2. **“Those who make distinctions.”** The intruders classify people into spiritual ranks, regarding themselves as the truly “spiritual” and others as inferior. This reading fits the next word, ψυχικοί, especially if that was a term the intruders used for others.

The two senses overlap. Drawing distinctions of spiritual rank is a way of dividing a community. The Textus Receptus adds ἑαυτούς (*heautous*), “themselves,” which gives the KJV’s “These be they who separate themselves,” as though the intruders withdrew from the community. Most manuscripts and the critical editions lack the word.[141] Jude’s picture is not of people who have left but of people who divide from within. They still sit at the love feasts (v. 12).

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140. Abbott-Smith, s.v. ἀποδιορίζω: “to mark off, hence metaph. to make separations: Ju 19.”↩

141. The TR (Scrivener) reads οἱ ἀποδιορίζοντες ἑαυτούς. The Text-Critical Greek NT notes give the reading with ἑαυτούς in about 21% of manuscripts. Clement of Alexandria paraphrased: “Those, he says, separating the faithful from the unfaithful” (*Adumbrationes* on Jude 19, ANF 2).↩

“natural men”

The adjective ψυχικοί (*psychikoi*) is difficult to translate. It derives from ψυχή (*psychē*), “soul, life,” and describes what belongs to ordinary, natural human life as opposed to what belongs to the Spirit of God.[142] The LSV has “natural men,” the KJV “sensual,” the WEB “worldly-minded,” and the BSB “worldly.”

Paul uses the word in a similar contrast: “the natural man does not receive the things of the Spirit of God, for they are foolishness to him … and he who is spiritual, indeed discerns all things” (1 Cor 2:14–15, LSV). He also contrasts the “natural body” with the “spiritual body” of the resurrection (1 Cor 15:44). James describes a false wisdom as “earthly, physical, demon-like” (Jas 3:15, LSV), where “physical” translates the same Greek word.

The term carries a sharp irony. If the intruders claimed spiritual superiority through their dreams and visions, and perhaps used “natural” (*psychikoi*) as a label for less enlightened believers, Jude turns their own category back on them. *They* are the merely natural ones. A century later, some Gnostic groups divided humanity into “spiritual,” “natural” (*psychikoi*), and “material” classes. Jude’s opponents were not second-century Gnostics, and it would be anachronistic to read that system into the letter. The Corinthian correspondence shows, however, that the contrast between “natural” and “spiritual” people was already being used in early Christian disputes about status.

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142. Abbott-Smith, s.v. ψυχικός: “of the ψυχή (as the lower part of the immaterial in man), EV, natural: opp. to πνευματικός, I Co 2:14 15:44, 46; πνεῦμα μὴ ἔχοντες … Ju 19.”↩

“not having the Spirit”

The final phrase, πνεῦμα μὴ ἔχοντες (*pneuma mē echontes*), “not having the Spirit,” is the most serious charge in the letter. In the New Testament, possessing the Holy Spirit is the mark of belonging to Christ. Paul writes: “if anyone does not have the Spirit of Christ—this one is not His” (Rom 8:9, LSV), and “in one Spirit we were all immersed into one body” (1 Cor 12:13, LSV).

The intruders, who appear to have claimed special spiritual experiences, are in Jude’s judgment devoid of the Spirit. Their dreams (v. 8) were not the Spirit’s gift. Their conduct, with its immorality, greed, grumbling, arrogance, and divisiveness, is the opposite of the fruit of the Spirit. The very next verse urges

the readers to pray “in the Holy Spirit” (v. 20). Jude’s contrast is complete: the intruders lack the Spirit, while the readers pray in the Spirit.

(The Greek word πνεῦμα has no article here and could in principle mean “spirit” in a general sense: “not having a spirit,” that is, being merely soulish and lacking a spiritual dimension. Given the New Testament usage and the contrast with v. 20, most interpreters take it as the Holy Spirit.)

D. Original-Language Investigation

Greek	Transliteration	Basic meaning	In context	Notes
ὑμεῖς δέ	*hymeis de*	but you	“but you”	Emphatic contrast with “these.”
μιμνήσκομαι	*mimnēskomai*	remember	“remember”	Aorist imperative.
ῥῆμα	*rhēma*	word, saying	“the sayings”	
προλέγω	*prolegō*	say beforehand, foretell	“spoken before”	Perfect passive participle.
ἀπόστολος	*apostolos*	apostle, sent one	“the apostles”	Jude does not include himself.
ἔλεγον	*elegon*	they were saying	“they said”	Imperfect: repeated teaching.
ἔσχατος χρόνος	*eschatos chronos*	last time	“the last time”	Variants in wording.
ἐμπαίκτης	*empaiktēs*	mocker, scoffer	“scoffers”	Only here and 2 Pet 3:3.
ἐπιθυμία	*epithymia*	desire	“lusts”	Repeats v. 16.
ἀσέβεια	*asebeia*	impiety	“impieties”	Final use of the key word.
ἀποδιορίζω	*apodiorizō*	mark off, make divisions	“causing divisions”	NT hapax. TR adds ἑαυτούς.
ψυχικός	*psychikos*	natural, soulish, unspiritual	“natural men”	1 Cor 2:14; 15:44; Jas 3:15.
πνεῦμα	*pneuma*	spirit, Spirit	“the Spirit”	The Holy Spirit (cf. v. 20).

A caution about ψυχικός. It is tempting to build a doctrine of human nature, body, soul, and spirit, on words like ψυχικός. That is not Jude’s purpose, nor Paul’s in 1 Corinthians. The word describes an *orientation*: life lived on the level of ordinary human impulses, without the transforming

presence of God's Spirit. It does not mean that the soul is bad or that the Spirit replaces human nature.

E. The Historical and Cultural World

Apostolic teaching and its transmission. In the first decades of the church, the apostles and their associates traveled among the churches teaching, and their teaching was passed on orally before and alongside written letters. Jude's readers had heard apostolic warnings "said to you." The phrase gives a glimpse of the early process by which communities received, remembered, and relied on the apostles' words, the same process that eventually led to the collection of the New Testament writings.

Factions and spiritual elitism. The churches of the first century were small communities in which differences of background, status, and spiritual experience could easily harden into factions. The Corinthian church divided around favored teachers ("I, indeed, am of Paul," 1 Cor 3:4, LSV) and around spiritual gifts (1 Cor 12–14). Jude's intruders seem to have created a similar division, with their followers presented as the truly spiritual.

"Last days" expectation. Jewish apocalyptic thought expected a period of intensified evil and apostasy before God's final intervention. Early Christians believed that this period had begun with Christ, and they interpreted false teaching and moral collapse within the church as signs of it (1 John 2:18–19; 2 Tim 3:1–5). Jude shares that outlook.

F. Connections Across Scripture

2 Peter 3:1–4 (literary parallel). Peter's version of this passage pairs the prophets and the apostles and specifies that the scoffers mock the promise of Christ's coming. The relationship between the two letters is especially close here.

Acts 20:29–30; 1 Timothy 4:1; 2 Timothy 3:1–5; 4:3–4 (apostolic predictions). These passages illustrate the kind of warning Jude's readers had heard. Note especially 2 Tim 4:3: people "will heap up teachers according to their own desires" (LSV).

Matthew 24:11, 24; Mark 13:22–23 (dominical predictions). Jesus' warnings about false prophets in the last days are the root of the apostolic tradition.

1 John 2:18–19 (shared situation). John's opponents "went forth out of us, but they were not of us" (1 John 2:19, LSV). Jude's intruders, by contrast, are still within the community, causing division from inside.

1 Corinthians 2:14–15; 15:44–46; James 3:15 (vocabulary). The contrast between the "natural" and the "spiritual."

Romans 8:9; 1 Corinthians 12:13 (theology of the Spirit). Having the Spirit is the mark of belonging to Christ.

Romans 16:17; 1 Corinthians 1:10; 3:3–4; Galatians 5:20 (divisions). Paul's warnings against division illuminate Jude's charge.

G. Scholarly and Theological Questions

1. Does v. 17 show that Jude is late? Some argue that the reference to "the apostles" as a group whose words are remembered implies a post-apostolic date. Others point out that v. 18 says the apostles spoke "to you," the readers, which places the letter within the lifetime of people who had heard the apostles. The verse is compatible with an early or a later date, but it does not require a late one.

2. Which apostles? Jude does not name them. The readers may have been evangelized by Paul, by Peter, or by other apostles and missionaries. Since the warning is generic, the question cannot be settled.

3. Did the intruders use the term ψυχικοί? It is an attractive hypothesis, especially given the parallel in 1 Corinthians, but it cannot be proven from Jude alone. What is certain is that Jude uses the term to deny the intruders' spiritual claims.

4. Can someone in the church "not have the Spirit"? Jude's judgment raises a pastoral and theological question. Christian traditions differ on how to understand people who are outwardly part of the church but show no evidence of the Spirit's work. Some understand them as never having been truly regenerate. Others see them as having fallen away, and others again allow for degrees of unfaithfulness. Jude does not offer a theory. His purpose is to warn his readers not to mistake the intruders' claims for spiritual reality. Notably, he still holds out hope of rescue for those influenced by them (vv. 22–23).

H. The Passage Within Jude

Verses 17–19 complete the long central section that began in v. 5. They form the fifth "text and application" unit, and the pattern of the whole section is now visible:

Text	Application
Three examples of judgment (vv. 5–7)	"those dreaming…" (v. 8)
Michael and the Devil (v. 9)	"these … speak evil" (v. 10)

Text	Application
Cain, Balaam, Korah (v. 11)	“These are stains…” (vv. 12–13)
Enoch’s prophecy (vv. 14–15)	“These are … grumblers” (v. 16)
The apostles’ prediction (vv. 17–18)	“these are those causing divisions” (v. 19)

The texts move from the distant past to the recent past, from the exodus to the readers’ own memory of the apostles. The last application is the climax: the intruders lack the Spirit. That sets up the contrast with which the next section opens: “But you, beloved, … praying in the Holy Spirit” (v. 20).

I. Contemporary Understanding

Suggested applications, distinct from the original meaning.

The discipline of remembering. Jude does not tell his readers to figure out new strategies. He tells them to remember. Christian communities today may find stability in recalling what they have received, in Scripture, creeds, and the teaching of faithful predecessors, rather than in perpetual novelty.

Warnings as gifts. The apostles warned their converts about future false teachers. Warning is an act of love. Leaders and parents who prepare others for difficulty are doing apostolic work.

Spiritual elitism. The intruders seem to have divided the community into the spiritual and the merely natural. Every era has its versions: groups that claim superior experience, knowledge, or holiness and look down on ordinary believers. Jude’s verdict, that such dividers may themselves be “natural” and “not having the Spirit,” is a warning against spiritual pride in every form, including in those who oppose the intruders.

The evidence of the Spirit. Jude’s charge that the intruders lack the Spirit invites a question for every believer: what is the evidence of the Spirit’s presence? The New Testament answers with love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, self-control (Gal 5:22–23), unity (Eph 4:3), and prayer (Jude 20), rather than with dramatic experiences alone.

J. Reflection and Discussion

1. Jude tells his readers to “remember.” What specific teachings or warnings do you think Christians today most need to remember?
2. The apostles warned that “scoffers” would come. What forms does scoffing at faith take today, both outside and inside the church?
3. How can a community distinguish between healthy diversity and divisive factionalism?

4. What does it mean to “have the Spirit”? How would you recognize the Spirit’s presence in a person or community?
5. Spiritual elitism divided Jude’s community. Where might spiritual pride show up in your own context, perhaps even among those who consider themselves defenders of the faith?

K. Sources

- LSV texts: eBible.org edition. Greek: SBLGNT and apparatus (NA27/NA28 data); TR (ἑαυτούς in v. 19).
- Abbott-Smith, s.vv. ἐμπαίκτης, ἀποδιορίζω, ψυχικός.
- Clement of Alexandria, *Adumbrationes* on Jude 19, ANF 2.
- Word counts: MorphGNT/SBLGNT.

Chapter 11. Building, Praying, Keeping, Waiting (Jude 20–21)

A. The Text

> **20** But you, beloved, building yourselves up on your most holy faith, praying in the Holy Spirit, **21** keep yourselves in the love of God, waiting for the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ [resulting] in continuous life;
>
> — Jude 20–21, LSV

B. Plain-English Orientation

After the long exposure of the intruders, Jude finally tells his readers what to do. He began by urging them to "fight for the faith" (v. 3). Here is what that fight consists of. It is not, first of all, an attack on the intruders. It is a way of life:

- **building** one another up on the foundation of the holy faith;
- **praying** in the power of the Holy Spirit;
- **keeping** themselves in God's love;
- **waiting** with hope for the mercy of Jesus Christ that leads to eternal life.

The grammar shows what matters most. There is one main command, "keep yourselves in the love of God," and three supporting activities expressed as participles: building, praying, and waiting. These are the means by which believers remain in the love that God has already shown them (v. 1).

The passage also has a striking shape. It mentions the Holy Spirit, God (the Father), and the Lord Jesus Christ, and it gathers faith, love, and hope, the three great Christian virtues. In two verses Jude sketches the whole Christian life.

C. Phrase-by-Phrase Exploration

"But you, beloved"

For the third and last time, Jude addresses his readers as "beloved" (vv. 3, 17, 20). The emphatic Ὑμεῖς δέ (*Hymeis de*), "But you," repeats the turn of v. 17 and sets the readers against the intruders just described. The intruders are

“not having the Spirit” (v. 19). The readers pray “in the Holy Spirit” (v. 20). The contrast could hardly be sharper.

“building yourselves up on your most holy faith”

The participle ἐποικοδομοῦντες (*epoikodomountes*), “building up on,” comes from the language of construction: οἰκοδομέω (*oikodomeō*), “to build a house,” with the prefix ἐπί (*epi*), “upon.” The New Testament uses this image often for the growth of believers and of the church. Paul writes: “I have laid a foundation, and another builds on [it], for no one is able to lay another foundation except that which is laid, which is Jesus the Christ” (1 Cor 3:10–11, LSV). Believers are “built on the foundation of the apostles and prophets, Jesus Christ Himself being chief corner-[stone]” (Eph 2:20, LSV), and are to be “rooted and built up in Him, and confirmed in the faith” (Col 2:7, LSV).

“Yourselves” (ἑαυτούς, *heautous*) is a reflexive pronoun. In the plural it often has a reciprocal sense, “one another.” Paul uses the same pronoun when he tells the Colossians to be “teaching and admonishing each other” (νουθετοῦντες ἑαυτούς, Col 3:16, LSV), and the Ephesians to be “forgiving one another” (χαριζόμενοι ἑαυτοῖς, Eph 4:32, LSV).[143] Jude is not describing private self-improvement. He is describing a community building each other up: “build up one another, as also you do” (1 Thess 5:11, LSV).

“On your most holy faith” (τῇ ἁγιωτάτῃ ὑμῶν πίστει, *tē hagiōtatē hymōn pistei*). The foundation is “the faith,” the same faith “once delivered to the holy ones” that Jude urged his readers to contend for in v. 3. The phrase “your most holy faith” ties the end of the letter to its beginning. Contending for the faith (v. 3) and building on the faith (v. 20) are the same activity seen from two sides.

The adjective ἁγιωτάτῃ (*hagiōtatē*), “most holy,” is the superlative of ἅγιος (*hagios*), “holy.” It is the only superlative of that adjective in the New Testament.[144] Jude chooses the strongest possible word. The faith is not a human tradition to be adjusted to taste. It is “most holy,” set apart by God and belonging to him. The intruders have turned grace into licentiousness (v. 4). The readers build on a faith that is holy through and through.

The Byzantine text puts the words in a different order, “on your most holy faith building yourselves up,” but the meaning is the same.[145]

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143. SBLGNT Col 3:16: διδάσκοντες καὶ νουθετοῦντες ἑαυτούς; Eph 4:32: χαριζόμενοι ἑαυτοῖς. The LSV renders these “teaching and admonishing each other” and “forgiving one another.”↩

144. Computed from MorphGNT/SBLGNT: the only superlative form of ἅγιος in the New Testament is ἁγιωτάτῃ in Jude 20.↩

145. SBLGNT apparatus: “ἐποικοδομοῦντες ἑαυτοὺς τῇ ἁγιωτάτῃ ὑμῶν πίστει WH Treg NIV] τῇ ἁγιωτάτῃ ὑμῶν πίστει ἐποικοδομοῦντες ἑαυτοὺς RP.”↩

“praying in the Holy Spirit”

The second participle, προσευχόμενοι (*proseuchomenoi*), “praying,” is qualified by ἐν πνεύματι ἁγίῳ (*en pneumati hagiō*), “in the Holy Spirit.” See the deep dive below. In brief, it describes prayer that the Holy Spirit inspires, empowers, and guides. That is the opposite of the intruders, who are “not having the Spirit” (v. 19), and of their “dreaming” (v. 8), which Jude regards as false spirituality.

“keep yourselves in the love of God”

Here is the main verb of the sentence and the central command of the letter: ἑαυτοὺς ἐν ἀγάπῃ θεοῦ τηρήσατε (*heautous en agapē theou tērēsate*), “keep yourselves in the love of God.” The aorist imperative τηρήσατε (*tērēsate*) is the fifth and final use of τηρέω, “keep,” the word that runs through the whole letter:

- the readers “having been kept in Jesus Christ” (v. 1);
- the angels who “did not keep” their place (v. 6);
- the angels whom God “has kept” in bonds (v. 6);
- the darkness that “has been kept” for the wandering stars (v. 13);
- and now, “keep yourselves” (v. 21).

The readers have been kept by God, and now they are to keep themselves. The angels did not keep their position. The readers must keep theirs. See the deep dive below.

“The love of God” (ἀγάπῃ θεοῦ, *agapē theou*) could grammatically mean either God’s love for us or our love for God. In Jude, the first is clearly primary. The readers are “having been loved in God [the] Father” (v. 1). To “keep yourselves in the love of God” is to remain in the place where God’s love has put you. Jesus said: “According as the Father loved Me, I also loved you, remain in My love; if you may keep My commands, you will remain in My love” (John 15:9–10, LSV). Responding love for God is implied, but the foundation is God’s love.

“waiting for the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ”

The third participle is προσδεχόμενοι (*prosdechomenoi*), “waiting for, expecting.” It is the word used of Simeon, who was “looking for the comforting of Israel” (Luke 2:25, LSV), and of believers “waiting for the blessed hope and appearing of the glory of our great God and Savior Jesus Christ” (Titus 2:13, LSV). It describes active, eager expectation, not passive delay.

What the readers wait for is "the mercy (ἔλεος, *eleos*) of our Lord Jesus Christ." Mercy was the first gift Jude wished his readers (v. 2). Here it is the mercy they will receive at Christ's coming, when he comes to judge (vv. 14–15). Paul prays for a friend, "may the LORD give to him to find kindness from the LORD in that day" (2 Tim 1:18, LSV), using the same Greek word, ἔλεος. The coming that means judgment for the ungodly (vv. 14–15) means mercy for those who wait for it.

"[resulting] in continuous life"

The final phrase, εἰς ζωὴν αἰώνιον (*eis zōēn aiōnion*), "into eternal life," names the goal of the waiting. The LSV supplies "[resulting]" to show that the Greek preposition εἰς expresses direction or result. Christ's mercy leads to eternal life. The LSV's "continuous life" reflects its consistent rendering of αἰώνιος (*aiōnios*). In New Testament usage the phrase means both life without end and the life that belongs to the age to come.

The contrast with the intruders' destiny is deliberate. For them, "the gloom of the darkness throughout the age has been kept" (v. 13) and "continuous fire" is the example (v. 7). For the readers, the same word αἰώνιος describes life. Two destinies are set before the readers, and Jude's command is to remain in the love that leads to life.

The shape of vv. 20–21

The sentence has a clear structure:

Element	Greek	Relation
building yourselves up on your most holy faith	ἐποικοδομοῦντες	participle (means)
praying in the Holy Spirit	προσευχόμενοι	participle (means)
keep yourselves in the love of God	**τηρήσατε**	**main imperative**
waiting for the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ	προσδεχόμενοι	participle (accompanying attitude)
into eternal life	εἰς ζωὴν αἰώνιον	goal

Two further patterns appear:

- **A Trinitarian pattern:** the Holy Spirit (v. 20), the love of God the Father (v. 21), and the mercy of the Lord Jesus Christ (v. 21). Jude does not offer a doctrine of the Trinity, but he speaks naturally of Spirit, Father, and Son as together the source of the Christian's life. Paul does the same in 2 Cor 13:14.

- **A pattern of faith, love, and hope:** "your most holy faith" (v. 20), "the love of God" (v. 21), and "waiting" for mercy and eternal life (v. 21), which is hope. Paul's famous triad is "faith, hope, love—these three" (1 Cor 13:13, LSV). He also speaks of "your work of faith, and the labor of the love, and the endurance of the hope" (1 Thess 1:3, LSV). Jude's version may reflect a shared early Christian pattern.

Deep dive: Praying in the Holy Spirit

What does it mean to pray "in the Holy Spirit"? The phrase ἐν πνεύματι ἁγίῳ can be read in several ways, and Christian traditions have emphasized different aspects.

The New Testament background. The closest parallel is Eph 6:18: "praying at all times in the Spirit, and in this, watching in all perseverance and supplication for all the holy ones" (LSV). Paul also describes the Spirit's role in prayer:

- The Spirit enables the most basic Christian prayer, the cry to God as Father: "you received [the] Spirit of adoption in which we cry, 'Abba! Father!'" (Rom 8:15, LSV); "God sent forth the Spirit of His Son into your hearts, crying, 'Abba! Father!'" (Gal 4:6, LSV).
- The Spirit helps believers in their weakness: "the Spirit helps our weaknesses; for what we may pray for, as it is necessary, we have not known, but [this] One—the Spirit—makes intercession for us with unutterable groanings" (Rom 8:26, LSV).
- In 1 Corinthians, Paul speaks of praying "in an [unknown] tongue" and says, "I will pray [in] the spirit, and I will also pray [with] understanding" (1 Cor 14:14–15, LSV).

Jesus speaks of worship "in spirit and truth" (John 4:23–24), and Paul of "serving God by the Spirit" (Phil 3:3, LSV).

Interpretations.

1. **Prayer inspired and guided by the Spirit.** Most interpreters understand Jude to mean prayer that is prompted, empowered, and shaped by the Holy Spirit, prayer that flows from the Spirit's presence in the believer and the community. On this reading, the phrase describes all genuine Christian prayer, including the "Abba, Father" of adoption and the Spirit's help in weakness.
2. **Charismatic or ecstatic prayer.** Some interpreters, especially in Pentecostal and charismatic traditions, see in Jude 20 a reference to Spirit-inspired prayer of the kind described in 1 Corinthians 14, including prayer in tongues. That is a possible reading, since Jude's communities,

like Paul's, were probably familiar with such phenomena. Nothing in Jude's wording, however, requires it.

3. **Prayer within the sphere of the Spirit**, as opposed to the "natural" sphere of v. 19. This reading emphasizes the contrast with the intruders. Whatever the intruders' spiritual claims, true prayer happens in the realm of the Holy Spirit.

These readings are not exclusive. What is clear from the context is Jude's contrast. The intruders appealed to "dreams" and claimed spiritual superiority, but in Jude's judgment they were "not having the Spirit." The readers' answer is not to reject spiritual experience but to pray in the Spirit, inside the community, on the foundation of the faith, and in the love of God. In Jude's view, genuine spirituality is marked by prayer, holiness, love, and humility, not by private revelations that license sin.

Prayer as part of contending. It is significant that prayer is one of the means by which believers "fight for the faith" (v. 3). Jude does not imagine that false teaching can be met only with arguments. A praying community, dependent on the Spirit, is itself a defense of the faith.

Deep dive: Keeping oneself in the love of God

Jude's central command, "keep yourselves in the love of God," raises a question that runs through the whole letter: how does the believer's keeping relate to God's keeping?

God's keeping comes first. The letter opens by describing the readers as "having been kept in Jesus Christ" (v. 1), or, as the Greek dative may also mean, kept *for* him. The perfect participle describes a settled state. It closes with praise to "Him who is able to guard you without stumbling" (v. 24). The readers' security rests on God's action, which frames the whole letter.

The believer's keeping is real. Between those two statements stands the command of v. 21: "keep yourselves." It is not a suggestion. The negative examples in the letter show what failure to keep looks like: the wilderness generation that did not believe (v. 5) and the angels who "did not keep their own principality" (v. 6).

How the two fit together. Jude does not explain the relationship theoretically, but the structure of vv. 20–21 suggests a practical answer. The believer keeps himself or herself in God's love not by heroic effort but by staying where God's love is found: building on the faith, praying in the Spirit, and waiting for Christ's mercy. These are not ways of earning God's love. They are ways of remaining in it. Jesus' words in John 15 offer a parallel: "remain in My love; if you may keep My commands, you will remain in My love" (John 15:9–10, LSV). The love comes first, and obedience is the way of abiding in it.

An image may help. The love of God is like a sheltered harbor. God has brought the readers into it (v. 1), and God is able to keep them there (v. 24). The command "keep yourselves in the love of God" means: do not sail out of the harbor. Build up the community, pray, wait for the Lord, and you will remain where you have been placed.

Different traditions, one command. As noted in Chapter 1, Christian traditions explain the relationship between divine preservation and human perseverance differently. All can agree on Jude's practical point: the command to keep oneself in God's love is meant seriously, and the means of obeying it are building, praying, and waiting.

D. Original-Language Investigation

Greek	Transliteration	Basic meaning	In context	Notes
ἐποικοδομέω	*epoikodomeō*	build upon	"building yourselves up"	Construction image (1 Cor 3:10–14; Eph 2:20; Col 2:7).
ἑαυτούς	*heautous*	yourselves; one another	"yourselves"	Plural reflexive can be reciprocal (Col 3:16; Eph 4:32).
ἁγιώτατος	*hagiōtatos*	most holy	"most holy"	Only superlative of ἅγιος in the NT.
πίστις	*pistis*	faith	"faith"	The faith of v. 3.
προσεύχομαι	*proseuchomai*	pray	"praying"	
ἐν πνεύματι ἁγίῳ	*en pneumati hagiō*	in the Holy Spirit	"in the Holy Spirit"	See deep dive.
τηρέω	*tēreō*	keep	"keep"	Aorist imperative; fifth use.
ἀγάπη θεοῦ	*agapē theou*	love of God	"the love of God"	Primarily God's love for believers.
προσδέχομαι	*prosdechomai*	wait for, expect	"waiting for"	Eager expectation (Luke 2:25; Titus 2:13).
ἔλεος	*eleos*	mercy	"the mercy"	Echoes v. 2.
ζωὴ αἰώνιος	*zōē aiōnios*	eternal life	"continuous life"	Life of the age to come.

A grammatical note on the participles. Greek participles that accompany an imperative often take on some of its force. Many translations therefore render vv. 20–21 as a series of commands: “build yourselves up … pray … keep yourselves … wait” (compare the WEB and BSB). That is legitimate. It is still worth seeing that Jude subordinates building, praying, and waiting to the single command to keep oneself in God’s love. They are not three extra tasks. They are how the one task is done.

E. The Historical and Cultural World

Prayer in early Christian gatherings. From the beginning, prayer was central to Christian community life. The Jerusalem believers were “continuing steadfastly in … the prayers” (Acts 2:42, LSV). Paul’s letters are full of prayer reports and requests. The *Didache* provides texts of thanksgiving prayers and instructs believers to pray the Lord’s Prayer three times a day.[146] Jude’s call to pray in the Spirit belongs to this common practice. Since the love feasts were also occasions of prayer, the instruction may have had a communal setting in mind.

Waiting for the Lord. The early Christians lived in expectation of Christ’s return. The Aramaic prayer *Maranatha*, usually understood as ‘Our Lord, come!’ (1 Cor 16:22; *Didache* 10.6), preserved this hope in the language of the earliest Palestinian believers. (The LSV renders it “The LORD has come!” in 1 Cor 16:22, reflecting a different way of dividing the Aramaic words.)[147] Jude’s “waiting for the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ” expresses the same expectation, colored by the judgment scene he has just quoted.

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146. *Didache* 8.2–3 (the Lord’s Prayer, “Thrice in the day thus pray”) and 9–10 (thanksgiving prayers), ANF 7 (https://www.newadvent.org/fathers/0714.htm). The citation of chapter 8 is from the same New Advent text consulted for chapters 9–12.↩

147. *Didache* 10.6 in the original Greek reads μαρανα θά. The New Advent (ANF) translation renders the passage; the Aramaic term itself is also found at 1 Cor 16:22.↩

F. Connections Across Scripture

1 Corinthians 3:10–11; Ephesians 2:20–22; Colossians 2:7; Acts 20:32 (building imagery). The church as a building on the foundation of Christ and the apostolic faith. Jude’s “building yourselves up on your most holy faith” belongs to this family of images.

Ephesians 6:18; Romans 8:15–16, 26–27; Galatians 4:6 (prayer in the Spirit). The closest parallels to Jude’s “praying in the Holy Spirit.”

John 15:9–10; 1 John 4:16 (remaining in love). “God is love, and he who is remaining in love, remains in God, and God in him” (1 John 4:16, LSV). The Johannine language of “remaining” in God’s love parallels Jude’s “keep yourselves in the love of God.”

Romans 5:5; 8:39 (the love of God). “The love of God has been poured forth in our hearts through the Holy Spirit” (Rom 5:5, LSV). Paul, like Jude, connects God’s love and the Spirit.

Titus 2:13; Luke 2:25 (waiting). The same verb of eager expectation.

1 Corinthians 13:13; 1 Thessalonians 1:3; 5:8 (faith, love, hope). The triad that Jude’s vv. 20–21 seem to echo.

G. Scholarly and Theological Questions

1. Is the reference to the Holy Spirit Trinitarian? Jude’s mention of the Holy Spirit, God, and the Lord Jesus Christ in two verses is often noted as an early example of the threefold pattern that later Christian theology articulated as the doctrine of the Trinity. Jude does not reflect on the relationship among the three. His language reflects the experience of early Christians, who knew God as Father, Jesus as Lord, and the Spirit as present power.

2. What kind of prayer is “in the Holy Spirit”? See the deep dive. Interpretations range from all Spirit-led prayer to specifically charismatic forms.

3. Is “the love of God” God’s love or our love? God’s love is primary (v. 1), though a responding love is implied.

4. Is the “mercy” of v. 21 present or future? It is future, the mercy shown at Christ’s coming and judgment. The waiting has present effects: it shapes how believers live now.

H. The Passage Within Jude

Verses 20–21 are the positive counterpart to the whole central section. Each element answers something in the description of the intruders:

The intruders	The readers
pervert grace into license (v. 4)	build on the most holy faith (v. 20)
“dreaming” (v. 8); “not having the Spirit” (v. 19)	praying in the Holy Spirit (v. 20)
stains (or reefs) at the love feasts (v. 12)	keep themselves in the love of God (v. 21)

The intruders	The readers
darkness kept for them forever (v. 13)	waiting for mercy leading to eternal life (v. 21)

The passage also completes the frame that began in vv. 1–2. Love, keeping, mercy, God, and Jesus Christ all return. Verse 3's call to contend for the faith is now explained: contending means building, praying, keeping, and waiting.

Finally, vv. 20–21 prepare for vv. 22–23. Those who are kept in God's love and wait for Christ's mercy are the ones who can show mercy to others. The movement is from receiving mercy to extending it.

I. Contemporary Understanding

Suggested applications, distinct from the original meaning.

The positive shape of faithfulness. When Christians face false teaching or moral confusion, it is easy to define faithfulness only by what one opposes. Jude's instructions are almost entirely positive: build, pray, keep, wait. Communities under pressure may find that their best defense is a deep, positive spiritual life rather than constant vigilance against enemies.

Community, not isolation. "Building yourselves up" is communal. Jude assumes that believers grow together, through shared teaching, worship, encouragement, and accountability. Modern individualism can make faith a private project. Jude's grammar resists that.

Prayer as spiritual defense. Prayer in the Spirit is part of contending for the faith. Churches facing division or confusion might give prayer, honest and dependent, a central place in their response, not merely a ceremonial one.

Living from love toward hope. The passage moves from the love of God, already given, to the mercy of Christ, still awaited. The Christian life is lived between those two points, secure in love and leaning toward hope. That orientation may help believers handle both complacency and anxiety.

J. Reflection and Discussion

1. Jude's response to false teaching is mostly positive: build, pray, keep, wait. Why might that be more effective than a purely defensive strategy?
2. How do you understand "praying in the Holy Spirit"? How has your tradition shaped your understanding?
3. What practices help you, or your community, "keep" yourselves in the love of God? Which of Jude's three activities (building, praying, waiting) is most neglected in your experience?

4. Jude speaks of the faith as “most holy.” What does it mean to treat the faith as holy rather than as a human tradition to be adjusted?
5. How does waiting for “the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ” shape the way you think about the future and live in the present?

K. Sources

- LSV texts: eBible.org edition. Greek: SBLGNT and apparatus (RP word order). Greek of Col 3:16 and Eph 4:32 from SBLGNT/MorphGNT.
- Superlative count: MorphGNT/SBLGNT.
- *Didache* 8; 10, ANF 7.
- Abbott-Smith, s.vv. τηρέω, ἔλεος.

Chapter 12. Mercy for the Wavering, Rescue from the Fire (Jude 22–23)

A. The Text

> **22** and, indeed, show mercy to those who are doubting, **23** and rescue others by snatching [them] out of fire; but show mercy to others in fear, hating even the coat having been stained from the flesh.
>
> — Jude 22–23, LSV

B. Plain-English Orientation

Jude's last instructions turn from the readers' own spiritual life (vv. 20–21) to their responsibility toward others. Those who have been kept in God's love and who wait for Christ's mercy must now show mercy themselves. Jude names three kinds of people (on the most widely accepted reading of the text):

1. **Those who are wavering**, unsettled by the intruders' influence. Show them mercy.
2. **Those in immediate danger**, already near the fire of judgment. Snatch them out.
3. **Others who are deeply compromised.** Show them mercy too, but with fear, hating even the clothing stained by their sin.

These two verses transform the letter. After so much warning and condemnation, Jude's last practical word is mercy. The readers are not to write off everyone touched by the intruders. They are to distinguish between people in different situations and to act toward each with compassion, urgency, and wisdom. Contending for the faith (v. 3) ends in rescue.

The Greek text of these verses is one of the most complicated in the New Testament. The manuscripts preserve two-clause and three-clause versions with different verbs. This chapter follows the three-clause text printed in the LSV, the SBLGNT, and NA28, and explains the alternatives in a deep dive.

C. Phrase-by-Phrase Exploration

"and, indeed, show mercy"

The command ἐλεᾶτε (*eleate*), “show mercy, have mercy,” is a present imperative of ἐλεάω (*eleaō*), a variant form of the more common ἐλεέω (*eleeō*). The Byzantine manuscripts read ἐλεεῖτε, the more familiar form.[148] The word picks up the theme of mercy that frames the letter. Jude wished his readers mercy (v. 2), and they wait for Christ’s mercy (v. 21). Now they are to show mercy. Mercy received becomes mercy given.

The construction καὶ οὓς μὲν … οὓς δὲ … οὓς δὲ (*kai hous men … hous de … hous de*), “and some … others … others,” divides the people in view into groups. The LSV’s “and, indeed, … others … others” reflects it.

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148. SBLGNT apparatus for Jude 22–23: “ἐλεᾶτε WH NIV] ἐλεεῖτε RP; ἐλέγχετε Treg.”↩

“to those who are doubting”

The participle διακρινομένους (*diakrinomenous*) comes from διακρίνω (*diakrinō*), a verb with a wide range: “to separate, distinguish, judge,” and in the middle voice “to dispute” or “to doubt, waver.” Jude used the same verb in v. 9 for Michael “disputing” with the Devil. Here two meanings are possible:

1. **“Those who doubt” or “waver.”** This is the sense the verb usually has in the New Testament when it describes a person’s inner state. Jesus says, “if you may have faith, and may not doubt” (Matt 21:21, LSV). James writes, “let him ask in faith, doubting nothing, for he who is doubting has been like a wave of the sea, driven by wind and tossed” (Jas 1:6, LSV). On this reading, Jude refers to believers who have been unsettled by the intruders and are uncertain whom to believe. They need mercy, patient and compassionate help, not condemnation.
2. **“Those who dispute.”** This sense matches Jude’s own use in v. 9. It would refer to people who argue, perhaps those who have taken the intruders’ side. Some manuscripts read “convict” or “refute” (ἐλέγχετε, *elenchete*) instead of “show mercy” in this clause, which would give “refute those who dispute.”

Most translations and commentators prefer “doubt” or “waver.” The image in James of the doubter as “a wave of the sea” offers an interesting echo of Jude’s “wild waves” (v. 13). The intruders are wild waves, and those they unsettle are tossed by them. The wavering are not the enemy. They are the ones at risk.

The Byzantine text reads the nominative διακρινόμενοι (*diakrinomenoi*), which makes the participle describe the readers rather than the people they help. The King James Version translates it “And of some have compassion, making a difference,” meaning that the readers should show compassion while discerning between cases. That reading also has a good sense, but the accusative form, referring to those who doubt, has stronger early support and is printed in the critical editions.[149]

149. The Text-Critical Greek NT notes (eBible.org) record ἐλεεῖτε διακρινόμενοι in about 88% of manuscripts, ἐλέγχετε διακρινομένους in about 7% (including the reading of the Tyndale House GNT, marked “TH”), and ἐλεᾶτε διακρινομένους (NA28, SBLGNT, WH) in about 2%. Manuscript counts do not determine originality; the critical editions weigh the age and quality of witnesses.↩

“and rescue others by snatching [them] out of fire”

The second group is in more urgent danger. The command σῴζετε (*sōzete*), “save, rescue,” is accompanied by the participle ἁρπάζοντες (*harpazontes*), “snatching, seizing.” The verb ἁρπάζω (*harpazō*) means “to seize by force, to grab.” Jesus uses it when he says that “no one will snatch them out of My hand” (John 10:28, LSV). Here it describes a rescuer pulling someone out of a burning building, an act of urgent, physical intervention.

The “fire” (πῦρ, *pyr*) recalls the “continuous fire” of Sodom (v. 7), the fire of judgment. These people are already, so to speak, in the flames, close to the fate of the intruders. They cannot be helped by gentle persuasion alone. They need decisive action.

The image comes from the prophets. In Zechariah’s vision, the LORD says of Joshua the high priest: “Is this not a brand delivered from fire?” (Zech 3:2, LSV), a burning stick pulled out of the fire before it is consumed. The Septuagint’s wording, δαλὸς ἐξεσπασμένος ἐκ πυρός (*dalos exespasmenos ek pyros*), “a brand snatched out of fire,” is close to Jude’s ἐκ πυρὸς ἁρπάζοντες (*ek pyros harpazontes*).[150] Amos uses the same image in a passage that also recalls Sodom and Gomorrah: “I have overturned among you, / Like the overturn by God of Sodom and Gomorrah, / And you are as a brand delivered from a burning” (Amos 4:11, LSV). Jude’s readers, who have just heard about Sodom’s fire (v. 7), are called to be the hands that pull people from it.

Notice where this allusion comes from. Zechariah 3 also stood behind Michael’s words in v. 9: “The LORD rebuke you!” In that chapter, the accuser stands against Joshua, the LORD rebukes the accuser, Joshua is called “a brand delivered from fire,” and his filthy garments are removed (Zech 3:1–4). Jude draws on the same scene twice. In v. 9 it shows the restraint of the heavenly defender. In v. 23 it shows the rescue of the one accused.

150. LXX Zech 3:2: οὐκ ἰδοὺ τοῦτο ὡς δαλὸς ἐξεσπασμένος ἐκ πυρός; (Brenton’s Greek Septuagint).↩

“but show mercy to others in fear”

The third group also receives mercy, ἐλεᾶτε again, but now ἐν φόβῳ (*en phobō*), “in fear” or “with fear.” What kind of fear?

1. **Fear of God.** Mercy must be shown with reverent awareness of God's holiness and judgment. The readers must not treat sin lightly while showing mercy to sinners. Paul writes, "having known, therefore, the fear of the LORD, we persuade men" (2 Cor 5:11, LSV), and Hebrews calls believers to serve God "with reverence and fear, for our God [is] also a consuming fire" (Heb 12:28–29, LSV).
2. **Caution about contamination.** Those who help people deeply involved in sin must take care not to be drawn into it themselves. Paul gives the same caution: "you who [are] spiritual restore such a one in a spirit of meekness, considering yourself—lest you also may be tempted" (Gal 6:1, LSV).

The two senses go together, and the next phrase explains the second.

"hating even the coat having been stained from the flesh"

The final phrase is vivid: μισοῦντες καὶ τὸν ἀπὸ τῆς σαρκὸς ἐσπιλωμένον χιτῶνα (*misountes kai ton apo tēs sarkos espilōmenon chitōna*), "hating even the tunic stained by the flesh."

- The **χιτών** (*chitōn*) was the basic garment of the ancient world, a tunic worn next to the skin under the outer cloak.
- **ἐσπιλωμένον** (*espilōmenon*), "stained, spotted," is the perfect passive participle of σπιλόω (*spiloō*), "to stain, defile."[151] It belongs to the same family as σπίλος, "stain," and, on one reading, as the σπιλάδες of v. 12. If Jude intended the link, the intruders who were "stains" at the love feasts (LSV) have stained the garments of those they influenced.
- **"From the flesh"** (ἀπὸ τῆς σαρκός, *apo tēs sarkos*) points to the source of the stain: sinful human nature, and especially the sexual sins Jude has repeatedly mentioned (vv. 4, 7–8).

The image is deliberately strong. The undergarment touched the body directly. To hate "even the coat" is to want nothing to do with the sin, not even with what has been in contact with it, while still reaching out to the person. Again Zechariah 3 is in the background: "Joshua was clothed with filthy garments," and the LORD says, "Turn aside the filthy garments from off him. … See, I have caused your iniquity to pass away from off you, so as to clothe you with costly apparel" (Zech 3:3–4, LSV). The garment is not the person. The garment can be removed, and the person can be clothed afresh.

The phrase holds together two attitudes that are easily separated: mercy toward people and hatred of sin. Christians have often summarized the balance in the slogan "love the sinner, hate the sin." Jude gives a more demanding picture. The mercy is real, but it is shown "in fear," and the hatred of sin is strong enough to recoil from its slightest trace.

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151. Abbott-Smith, s.v. σπιλόω: “to stain, spot, defile: c. acc., Ja 3:6, Ju 23.”↩

Deep dive: Showing mercy to those who doubt

Jude’s instruction to “show mercy to those who are doubting” is one of the most pastorally significant sentences in the letter, and it deserves reflection.

Who are the doubters? In Jude’s situation, they were probably believers who had been exposed to the intruders’ teaching and conduct and had become unsure. Perhaps the intruders’ visions impressed them, or their freedom seemed attractive. Perhaps they could not see why Jude and the other leaders objected. Such people were not yet committed to the intruders’ way of life, but they were wavering.

Why mercy? Jude could have told his readers to rebuke or exclude the doubters. Instead he tells them to show mercy. Several reasons emerge from the letter:

- **They have received mercy themselves** (vv. 2, 21). Those who wait for Christ’s mercy cannot withhold mercy from others.
- **Doubt is not the same as rebellion.** The intruders deliberately turn grace into license and reject authority. The doubters are uncertain. To treat uncertainty as rebellion would push the wavering toward the very people Jude warns against.
- **The goal is restoration.** Jude’s whole letter aims to keep people in God’s love. Mercy toward the wavering serves that goal.

What does mercy look like? Jude does not spell it out, but the New Testament offers many models. Paul urges, “receive him who is weak in the faith—not to determinations of reasonings” (Rom 14:1, LSV). The Lord’s servant “must not quarrel, but to be gentle to all, apt to teach, patient under evil, instructing those opposing in meekness—if perhaps God may give to them conversion” (2 Tim 2:24–25, LSV). James promises that “he who turned back a sinner from the straying of his way will save a soul from death” (Jas 5:20, LSV). Jesus’ parable of the shepherd who leaves the ninety-nine to seek the one gone astray ends, “it is not [the] will in [the] presence of your Father who is in the heavens that one of these little ones may perish” (Matt 18:14, LSV). Mercy to the doubting likely includes patience, gentle instruction, prayer, presence, and the steady testimony of a community that is building itself up in the faith (v. 20).

Discernment. Jude’s threefold distinction shows that mercy is not uniform. The wavering need patient compassion. Those near the fire need urgent rescue. The deeply compromised need mercy mixed with caution. Wise pastoral care pays attention to the person’s situation.

Doubt today. The word “doubt” covers many experiences: intellectual questions, emotional struggles, confusion caused by conflicting teachers, disappointment with the church. Not all of them are what Jude had in mind. His instruction, though, suggests a general principle. Communities that hold firmly to “the faith once delivered” should be the most merciful toward those who struggle to hold it. Firmness and mercy are not opposites in Jude. Both flow from being kept in God’s love.

Deep dive: The text of Jude 22–23

Few New Testament passages survive in as many forms as these two verses. The main forms can be grouped as follows (Greek simplified):[152]

Witness	Text	Structure
SBLGNT, NA28, Tregelles, NIV Greek text; LSV	καὶ οὓς μὲν **ἐλεᾶτε** διακρινομένους, οὓς δὲ σῴζετε ἐκ πυρὸς ἁρπάζοντες, οὓς δὲ ἐλεᾶτε ἐν φόβῳ…	Three groups: show mercy to the doubting / save others, snatching from fire / show mercy to others in fear
Tregelles (first verb), Tyndale House GNT (as reported)	καὶ οὓς μὲν **ἐλέγχετε** διακρινομένους…	Three groups, but the first is “refute (or convict) those who dispute”
Westcott–Hort	καὶ οὓς μὲν ἐλεᾶτε διακρινομένους σῴζετε ἐκ πυρὸς ἁρπάζοντες, οὓς δὲ ἐλεᾶτε ἐν φόβῳ…	Two groups: “have mercy on some who doubt, saving them by snatching them from fire; and on others have mercy in fear”
Robinson–Pierpont, TR (KJV)	καὶ οὓς μὲν ἐλεεῖτε διακρινόμενοι, οὓς δὲ ἐν φόβῳ σῴζετε ἐκ (τοῦ) πυρὸς ἁρπάζοντες…	Two groups: “on some have compassion, making a difference; others save with fear, pulling them out of the fire”
P72 (early papyrus)	οὓς μὲν ἐκ πυρὸς ἁρπάσατε, διακρινομένους δὲ ἐλεεῖτε ἐν φόβῳ…	Two groups: “snatch some from the fire, but on those who doubt have mercy in fear”

Early Christian writers knew different forms. Clement of Alexandria paraphrased a two-part text: “But some, he says, save, plucking them from the fire; but of some have compassion in fear.”[153]

Why so many forms? The repetition of similar words (two forms of “show mercy,” and the series οὓς μὲν … οὓς δέ) made the passage easy to miscopy. Scribes may have dropped a clause by accident when the eye skipped from one οὓς δέ to the next, or they may have smoothed a difficult text. The verb διακρίνω, which can mean “doubt” or “dispute,” also invited different interpretations and therefore different verbs (“show mercy” or “refute”).

Which is original? Scholars are divided. Many accept the three-clause text printed in the SBLGNT and NA28, which has good early support and explains the two-clause forms as accidental omissions. Others, including Richard Bauckham, have argued that a shorter two-clause form closer to P72 is original and that the three-clause text arose when scribes expanded it.[154]

Does it matter? The core of the passage is the same in all forms: mercy toward some, urgent rescue of others from the fire, and caution about the defilement of sin. The differences affect how many groups Jude distinguishes and whether the first group receives mercy or rebuke. This book follows the three-clause text of the LSV and SBLGNT, while recognizing that certainty is not possible.

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152. Readings for the editions are from the SBLGNT apparatus and the eBible.org SBLGNT notes (NA28). The Tyndale House reading is as reported in the Text-Critical Greek NT notes. The P72 reading is given from the standard critical literature and was not checked against a printed apparatus for this edition.↩

153. Clement of Alexandria, *Adumbrationes* on Jude 22–23, ANF 2.↩

154. Bauckham, *Jude, 2 Peter*, on vv. 22–23 (cited from prior knowledge). For a full study of the manuscripts, see Wasserman, *The Epistle of Jude: Its Text and Transmission* (Stockholm: Almqvist & Wiksell, 2006).↩

D. Original-Language Investigation

Greek	Transliteration	Basic meaning	In context	Notes
ἐλεάω / ἐλεέω	*eleaō* / *eleeō*	show mercy	“show mercy”	Present imperative; variant ἐλέγχετε, “convict.”
διακρίνομαι	*diakrinomai*	dispute; doubt, waver	“those who are doubting”	Same verb as v. 9; Jas 1:6.
σῴζω	*sōzō*	save, rescue	“rescue”	
ἁρπάζω	*harpazō*	seize, snatch	“snatching”	Urgent action; John 10:28.
πῦρ	*pyr*	fire	“fire”	Judgment fire (v. 7); Zech 3:2; Amos 4:11.
φόβος	*phobos*	fear, reverence	“in fear”	Fear of God and caution.
μισέω	*miseō*	hate	“hating”	
χιτών	*chitōn*	tunic, undergarment	“the coat”	Garment worn next to the skin.

Greek	Transliteration	Basic meaning	In context	Notes
σπιλόω	*spiloō*	stain, defile	“stained”	Perfect passive participle; cf. σπιλάδες (v. 12).
σάρξ	*sarx*	flesh	“the flesh”	Sinful human nature; cf. vv. 7–8.

E. The Historical and Cultural World

Clothing and purity. In the Jewish world, garments could become ritually impure through contact with bodily discharges or with unclean things (Lev 13–15), and purification involved washing clothes. The image of a defiled garment would have carried both ritual and moral overtones. Zechariah’s vision of the high priest’s filthy garments, which are removed and replaced with clean ones, provided a powerful picture of forgiveness and restoration.

Fire as judgment. In Jewish and early Christian thought, fire was the most common image of divine judgment: the fire of Sodom, the fire of Gehenna, the “continuous fire” of the final judgment. To snatch someone from the fire was to rescue them from judgment, by persuasion, intervention, or prayer, before it was too late.

Church discipline and restoration. Early Christian communities practiced various forms of discipline toward members who fell into serious sin (Matt 18:15–17; 1 Cor 5; 2 Thess 3:14–15). The goal was always restoration: “do not count as an enemy, but admonish as a brother” (2 Thess 3:15, LSV). Jude’s instructions belong to this pastoral tradition, though they do not describe formal procedures.

F. Connections Across Scripture

Zechariah 3:1–5 (allusion). The brand snatched from the fire and the filthy garments removed. This is the most important background for both images in v. 23, and the same chapter stands behind Michael’s words in v. 9.

Amos 4:11 (shared image). “A brand delivered from a burning,” in a passage that also mentions Sodom and Gomorrah.

James 1:6; 5:19–20 (shared themes). The doubter as a wave of the sea, and the saving of a sinner from death. James’s closing verses resemble Jude’s in spirit: both letters end by urging readers to restore those who wander.

Galatians 6:1; 2 Timothy 2:24–26; Romans 14:1 (pastoral care). Gentle restoration with awareness of one's own vulnerability.

Matthew 18:12–14 (the lost sheep). God's will that none of the little ones perish.

Revelation 3:4; 2 Corinthians 7:1 (defiled garments; cleansing). "a few names even in Sardis who did not defile their garments" (Rev 3:4, LSV); "may we cleanse ourselves from every defilement of flesh and spirit, perfecting sanctification in the fear of God" (2 Cor 7:1, LSV). Paul joins cleansing from defilement of the flesh with "the fear of God," as Jude joins mercy "in fear" with hatred of the garment "stained from the flesh."

G. Scholarly and Theological Questions

1. Two groups or three? See the deep dive.

2. "Doubt" or "dispute"? Most interpreters prefer "doubt" or "waver," following New Testament usage and the logic of showing mercy. The alternative ("dispute," with "refute" or "convict") has some manuscript support and matches Jude's use of the verb in v. 9.

3. Who is in the fire? Probably people who have gone further than the doubters, adopting the intruders' practices. Some interpreters think the intruders themselves might be included among those who could still be snatched from the fire. Jude's harsh descriptions in vv. 4–19 do not encourage that reading, but his structure leaves the door open in a way that is worth noting.

4. What does "in fear" mean? Fear of God, caution about contamination, or both.

5. How do vv. 22–23 relate to the rest of the letter? Some readers find the shift from condemnation to mercy abrupt. It is better understood as the goal of the letter. Jude exposes the intruders in order to protect the community and rescue those at risk. The warnings serve the mercy.

H. The Passage Within Jude

Verses 22–23 complete the exhortation that began in v. 20. The readers who keep themselves in God's love (v. 21) now extend that love to others. The letter's three great themes come together here:

- **Mercy:** wished for the readers (v. 2), awaited from Christ (v. 21), shown to others (vv. 22–23).

- **Fire and judgment:** the fire of Sodom (v. 7), the coming judgment (vv. 14–15), and the fire from which people must be snatched (v. 23).
- **Defilement:** the flesh defiled by the intruders (v. 8), the stains at the love feasts (v. 12), and the garment stained by the flesh (v. 23).

The passage also prepares for the doxology. The readers who rescue others from stumbling into the fire will themselves be kept "without stumbling" by the God who is able (v. 24).

I. Contemporary Understanding

Suggested applications, distinct from the original meaning.

Mercy as the end of contending. Jude's letter shows that contending for the faith does not end in triumph over opponents but in mercy toward the wavering and rescue of the endangered. Christians who are passionate about truth might ask whether their passion leads to the same place.

Differentiated care. Jude distinguishes among people in different situations. Pastoral care today might likewise distinguish between honest questioners, people in crisis, and people deeply entangled in harmful patterns, responding to each with appropriate compassion, urgency, and wisdom.

Mercy without naïveté. Showing mercy "in fear" and "hating even the coat" suggests that mercy does not mean ignoring danger. Those who help others out of destructive situations, whether addiction, abuse, or spiritual manipulation, often need to set boundaries and protect themselves. That is not a failure of mercy but part of it.

The garment can be changed. Zechariah's vision, behind Jude's words, ends with new clothes. Those who have been stained can be cleansed. Christians who show mercy do so in the hope that God will "turn aside the filthy garments" and clothe people afresh.

J. Reflection and Discussion

1. Why do you think Jude ends his practical instructions with mercy rather than with further warnings? How does this change your reading of the whole letter?
2. Think of people you know who are "wavering" in faith. What would it look like to show them mercy, in practical terms?
3. Jude speaks of "snatching" some from the fire. Are there situations in which urgent intervention is more loving than patient waiting? How can one tell?

4. What does it mean to show mercy “in fear”? How can believers help others without being drawn into the same patterns?
5. The garment imagery comes from Zechariah 3, where filthy garments are removed and replaced. How does this picture of cleansing shape the way you think about people who have fallen into sin?

K. Sources

- LSV texts: eBible.org edition. Greek: SBLGNT and apparatus (WH, Treg, NIV, RP, NA28 data); Text-Critical Greek NT notes (eBible.org); TR.
- LXX Zech 3:2 (Brenton’s Greek Septuagint).
- Clement of Alexandria, *Adumbrationes* on Jude 22–23, ANF 2.
- Abbott-Smith, s.v. σπιλόω.
- Bauckham, *Jude, 2 Peter*, on vv. 22–23; Tommy Wasserman, *The Epistle of Jude: Its Text and Transmission* (2006); Metzger, *Textual Commentary*, on Jude 22–23 (all cited from prior knowledge).

Chapter 13. To Him Who Is Able: Kept from Stumbling (Jude 24–25)

A. The Text

> **24** And to Him who is able to guard you without stumbling, and to set [you] in the presence of His glory unblemished, in gladness, **25** to the only wise God our Savior, [is] glory and greatness, power and authority, both now and forever! Amen.
>
> — Jude 24–25, LSV

B. Plain-English Orientation

Jude ends his letter not with greetings or travel plans but with praise. Having warned his readers of danger, urged them to keep themselves in God's love, and told them to rescue others, he turns their eyes to God. God is able to keep them from stumbling. God will bring them into his glorious presence, blameless and full of joy. To this God, the only God and Savior, belong glory, majesty, power, and authority, through Jesus Christ, before all time, now, and forever.

This doxology is one of the most beloved in Scripture and is often used to close Christian worship. In the context of Jude it is also the letter's final word on its central theme. The readers have been kept (v. 1) and must keep themselves (v. 21), and now they are assured that God is able to guard them. The danger of stumbling is real, but the one who holds them is stronger.

A note on the text. The LSV's wording of v. 25 follows the Byzantine tradition and the Textus Receptus: "to the only wise God our Savior … both now and forever." The SBLGNT and NA28 have a longer text: "to the only God our Savior, **through Jesus Christ our Lord**, [be] glory, majesty, power, and authority **before all time** and now and forever." This chapter discusses both, since the differences are theologically interesting.

C. Phrase-by-Phrase Exploration

"And to Him who is able"

The doxology begins with a dative, Τῷ δὲ δυναμένῳ (*Tō de dynamenō*), “Now to the one who is able.” Its main clause comes only at the end: “to Him … [is] glory.” Paul’s letters close in a similar way: “And to Him who is able to establish you” (Rom 16:25, LSV); “and to Him who is able to do exceedingly [and] abundantly above all things that we ask or think” (Eph 3:20, LSV).

The emphasis falls on God’s **ability**. Throughout the letter Jude has described powers that threaten the readers: intruders who slip in unnoticed, persuasive dreamers, slanderers, reefs, wild waves. Now he names the power that is greater. Everything depends not on the readers’ strength but on God’s.

“to guard you without stumbling”

The infinitive φυλάξαι (*phylaxai*), “to guard,” comes from φυλάσσω (*phylassō*), a near synonym of τηρέω (*tēreō*), “keep,” the word that has run through the whole letter. φυλάσσω carries the idea of a guard posted to protect, “implying custody and protection.”[155] Jesus used it in his prayer: “I guarded those whom You have given to Me, and none of them were destroyed” (John 17:12, LSV).

A textual note. The SBLGNT, NA28, and TR read ὑμᾶς (*hymas*), “you,” and the LSV follows them. The Robinson–Pierpont text, following most Byzantine manuscripts, reads αὐτούς (*autous*), “them,” which shifts the focus slightly.[156]

“Without stumbling” translates ἀπταίστους (*aptaistous*), an adjective found nowhere else in the New Testament. It is formed from πταίω (*ptaiō*), “to stumble, trip,” with the negative prefix ἀ-, and means “not stumbling, sure-footed.”[157] It is used in the Greek Bible only once elsewhere, in 3 Maccabees, where God rescues the Jews of Egypt “unharmed” from destruction (ἀπταίστους, 3 Macc 6:39).[158] See the deep dive below.

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155. Abbott-Smith, s.v. τηρέω, synonym note: “φυλάσσω, implying custody and protection: τ. expresses the idea of watchful care and ‘may mark the result of which φ. is the means’ (Thayer s.v.).”↩

156. SBLGNT apparatus: “ὑμᾶς WH Treg NIV] αὐτούς RP.” The Text-Critical Greek NT notes give αὐτοὺς ἀπταίστους in about 63% of manuscripts and ὑμᾶς ἀπταίστους in about 22%, with a further variant adding καὶ ἀσπίλους (“and spotless”) in about 7%.↩

157. Abbott-Smith, s.v. ἄπταιστος: “(< πταίω) … without stumbling, sure-footed: metaph. … Ju 24.”↩

158. 3 Macc 6:39: ἀπταίστους αὐτοὺς ἐῤῥύσατο ὁμοθυμαδόν (“he rescued them all together, unharmed”), Brenton’s Greek Septuagint; translation mine. Abbott-Smith lists this as the only LXX occurrence.↩

“and to set [you] in the presence of His glory unblemished, in gladness”

God's ability extends beyond protection along the way to the destination. He is able στῆσαι κατενώπιον τῆς δόξης αὐτοῦ (*stēsai katenōpion tēs doxēs autou*), "to make [you] stand before his glory." The verb ἵστημι (*histēmi*), "to set, make stand," suggests standing upright in the presence of a king or judge. The adverb κατενώπιον (*katenōpion*) means "before, in the presence of."[159] "His glory" is the radiant presence of God, the glory that Moses longed to see and that the prophets described. The scene is the final judgment, the same judgment described in vv. 14–15. For the ungodly it means conviction. For those kept by God it means standing before his glory.

They will stand **"unblemished"** (ἀμώμους, *amōmous*). The word was originally used of sacrificial animals "without blemish," and then morally of people who are "faultless."[160] Paul uses it of the goal of God's work: "to present you holy, and unblemished, and unblameable before Himself" (Col 1:22, LSV); "that He might present the Assembly to Himself in glory, having no spot or wrinkle … but that it may be holy and unblemished" (Eph 5:27, LSV). In Jude the word stands in deliberate contrast to the intruders, who were "stains" (v. 12) and whose garments were "stained" by the flesh (v. 23). The readers will be presented without stain.

And they will stand **"in gladness"** (ἐν ἀγαλλιάσει, *en agalliasei*). The noun means "exultation, exuberant joy."[161] It is the joy of celebration, of a festival or a wedding. Peter uses the related verb: "rejoice, that you may also rejoice in the revelation of His glory—exulting" (1 Pet 4:13, LSV). After so much darkness, Jude's letter ends with the picture of believers standing before God's glory, faultless and overflowing with joy.

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159. Abbott-Smith, s.v. κατενώπιον: "over against, before: c. gen., τ. δόξης, Ju 24."↩

160. Abbott-Smith, s.v. ἄμωμος: "of sacrificial victims, without blemish … ethically, unblemished, faultless: Eph 1:4 5:27, Phl 2:15, Col 1:22, Ju 24, Re 14:5."↩

161. Abbott-Smith, s.v. ἀγαλλίασις: "exultation, exuberant joy."↩

"to the only wise God our Savior"

The God who can do all this is "the only God our Savior." The LSV, following the TR and Byzantine text, reads "only **wise** God" (μόνῳ σοφῷ θεῷ, *monō sophō theō*). The critical texts lack "wise." Most likely a scribe added it under the influence of Paul's doxology, "to the only wise God, through Jesus Christ, to Him [be] glory for all ages" (Rom 16:27, LSV; cf. 1 Tim 1:17).[162] On either reading, the emphasis falls on "only." There is one God. Earlier, Jude called Jesus Christ "our only Master and Lord" (v. 4). The two "only"s stand side by side without contradiction. For Jude, confessing Jesus as the only Master does not compromise the confession of one God.

“Our Savior” (σωτῆρι ἡμῶν, *sōtēri hēmōn*) gives God the title σωτήρ, “Savior, deliverer.” In the Greco-Roman world the title was commonly given to kings and emperors.[163] In the Bible it belongs to God, who saved Israel from Egypt (v. 5) and who saves now. The letter that began with “our common salvation” (v. 3) ends by naming God “our Savior.”

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162. SBLGNT apparatus: “μόνῳ WH Treg NIV] + σοφῷ RP.” The Text-Critical Greek NT notes give σοφῷ θεῷ in about 82% of manuscripts and θεῷ alone (the critical text) in about 7%.↩

163. Abbott-Smith, s.v. σωτήρ: “a freq. epithet of kings in the Ptolemaic and Rom. periods.”↩

‘through Jesus Christ our Lord’ (critical text)

The critical texts include the phrase διὰ Ἰησοῦ Χριστοῦ τοῦ κυρίου ἡμῶν (*dia Iēsou Christou tou kyriou hēmōn*), “through Jesus Christ our Lord.” The phrase is absent from the Byzantine text, the TR, and therefore the LSV. It is well attested in early manuscripts, and most scholars regard it as original.[164]

If original, it says something important. Glory is given to God *through* Jesus Christ. That may mean that God’s glory is revealed and exercised through Christ, or that believers give glory to God through Christ, or both. Paul’s doxology in Romans has the same pattern (“to the only wise God, through Jesus Christ”). So does Peter’s: “so that in all things God may be glorified through Jesus Christ, to whom is the glory and the power through the ages of the ages” (1 Pet 4:11, LSV). The doxology, like the whole letter, holds God and Jesus Christ together.

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164. SBLGNT apparatus: “διὰ Ἰησοῦ Χριστοῦ τοῦ κυρίου ἡμῶν WH Treg NIV] – RP.” The Text-Critical Greek NT notes give the phrase in about 21% of manuscripts. Its presence in the critical editions reflects the judgment that the earliest witnesses include it.↩

“[is] glory and greatness, power and authority”

Four attributes are ascribed to God:

- **Glory** (δόξα, *doxa*): God’s radiant splendor and honor. This is the “glory” before which believers will stand (v. 24).
- **Greatness** or **majesty** (μεγαλωσύνη, *megalōsynē*): a word of the Greek Bible, used in Hebrews of God as “the Greatness in the highest” (Heb 1:3, LSV).[165]
- **Power** or **dominion** (κράτος, *kratos*): might and sovereign rule, common in New Testament doxologies (1 Tim 6:16; 1 Pet 4:11; 5:11; Rev 1:6).[166]
- **Authority** (ἐξουσία, *exousia*): the right to rule.

The list recalls David's prayer: "To You, O YHWH, [is] the greatness, and the might, and the beauty, and the victory, and the splendor … to You, O YHWH, [is] the kingdom" (1 Chr 29:11, LSV). The intruders "disregard lordship" (v. 8) and slander glorious beings (v. 8). The doxology declares where true glory, majesty, and authority lie.

"Is" or "be"? The Greek has no verb. Translators must supply one. The LSV supplies "[is]," making the doxology a declaration: glory *is* God's. Most translations supply "be," making it a wish or prayer: glory *be* to God. Both are grammatically possible. In 1 Pet 4:11 a verb is expressed ("to whom *is* the glory," ᾧ ἐστιν ἡ δόξα), which shows that the declarative sense was natural to early Christians. Perhaps the best understanding holds both: glory belongs to God, and the worshiping community gladly acknowledges it.

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165. Abbott-Smith, s.v. μεγαλωσύνη: "greatness, majesty: He 1:3 8:1, Ju 25 (elsewhere Eccl. only)."↩

166. Abbott-Smith, s.v. κράτος: "in doxologies, I Ti 6:16, I Pe 4:11 5:11, Ju 25, Re 1:6 5:13."↩

'before all time, and now, and forever' (critical text) / "both now and forever" (LSV)

The critical text has a magnificent triple expression of time: πρὸ παντὸς τοῦ αἰῶνος καὶ νῦν καὶ εἰς πάντας τοὺς αἰῶνας (*pro pantos tou aiōnos kai nyn kai eis pantas tous aiōnas*), "before all the age, and now, and into all the ages." God's glory reaches back before creation, fills the present, and extends without end into the future. The phrase "before all time" is absent from the Byzantine text and the LSV, which reads "both now and forever."[167]

The longer form is unusual in New Testament doxologies. It is the only one that explicitly includes the eternity *before* time. It fits the letter's sweep, which ranges from the ancient past (Enoch, the angels, the exodus), through the present (the intruders and the readers), to the future (the coming of the Lord, eternal life). The God who was glorious before all ages is the God who keeps his people now and will present them in glory forever.

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167. SBLGNT apparatus: "δόξα WH Treg NIV] + καὶ RP • πρὸ παντὸς τοῦ αἰῶνος WH Treg NIV] – RP."↩

"Amen."

The final word, ἀμήν (*amēn*), is a Hebrew word meaning "truly, so be it." It was the congregation's response to prayer and praise in the synagogue. Early Christians kept it in its Hebrew form. When Jude's letter was read aloud in the

community, the people would likely have answered “Amen,” making his doxology their own.

Deep dive: Being kept from stumbling

Jude’s last promise, that God is able to guard his readers “without stumbling,” gathers up the letter’s central theme.

Stumbling in the Bible. The image of the foot that slips is common in Scripture, especially in the Psalms. “He does not permit your foot to be moved, / He who is preserving you does not slumber” (Ps 121:3, LSV). “You have delivered my soul from death, / Do You not [keep] my feet from falling?” (Ps 56:13, LSV). “You have delivered my soul from death, / My eyes from tears, my feet from overthrowing” (Ps 116:8, LSV). In Psalm 73 the writer confesses, “As nothing, my steps have slipped, / For I have been envious of the boastful” (Ps 73:2, LSV). His stumbling began with envy of the arrogant, the kind of people Jude has described.

What stumbling means in Jude. In the context of the letter, to stumble is to fall away from “the faith once delivered” (v. 3). It means following the intruders into their perversion of grace, being swept along by wild waves, leaving the place God has given as the angels did (v. 6), or failing to believe as the wilderness generation did (v. 5). The letter has shown how real that danger is.

The guard who does not sleep. Against this danger stands the God who is “able.” The verb φυλάσσω, “guard,” suggests a sentry who keeps watch through the night. The Psalmist’s “He who is preserving you does not slumber” captures the image (Ps 121:3, LSV). God’s guarding does not depend on the believer’s alertness. It is God’s own vigilance.

The relationship with v. 21. How does God’s guarding relate to the command “keep yourselves in the love of God” (v. 21)? Jude places both side by side without tension. God’s ability to guard is the ground of the believer’s confidence. The believer’s keeping is the way that confidence is lived. The doxology does not cancel the command. It makes it possible. A believer who builds up, prays, and waits (vv. 20–21) does so in the assurance that God is able to finish what he began.

Not perfection, but preservation. “Without stumbling” does not mean that believers will never sin or struggle. The New Testament is honest about believers’ failures (“we all make many stumbles,” Jas 3:2, LSV). The promise is that God will keep them from the stumbling that leads to ruin, from falling away from him. The goal is to “set [you] in the presence of His glory unblemished,” and that blamelessness is God’s gift, not the reader’s achievement.

A word for the wavering. Jude has just told his readers to show mercy to "those who are doubting" (v. 22). The doxology is good news for them too. The strength that keeps believers from stumbling is not their own certainty but God's ability. Those who waver may find their footing not by trying harder to be sure but by trusting the one who is able.

D. Original-Language Investigation

Greek	Transliteration	Basic meaning	In context	Notes
δύναμαι	*dynamai*	be able	"Him who is able"	Doxology opening (Rom 16:25; Eph 3:20).
φυλάσσω	*phylassō*	guard, protect	"to guard"	Synonym of τηρέω; "custody and protection."
ἄπταιστος	*aptaistos*	not stumbling, sure-footed	"without stumbling"	NT hapax; LXX only 3 Macc 6:39.
ἵστημι	*histēmi*	set, make stand	"to set"	Standing before a king or judge.
κατενώπιον	*katenōpion*	before, in the presence of	"in the presence of"	Eph 1:4; Col 1:22.
δόξα	*doxa*	glory	"His glory" / "glory"	
ἄμωμος	*amōmos*	without blemish	"unblemished"	Sacrificial and moral.
ἀγαλλίασις	*agalliasis*	exultation	"gladness"	Exuberant joy.
μόνος	*monos*	only	"only"	Cf. v. 4.
σοφός	*sophos*	wise	"wise"	TR/Byzantine only; cf. Rom 16:27.
σωτήρ	*sōtēr*	savior	"our Savior"	Royal title in the Greco-Roman world; in the Bible, of God.
μεγαλωσύνη	*megalōsynē*	greatness, majesty	"greatness"	Heb 1:3; 8:1.
κράτος	*kratos*	power, dominion	"power"	Doxological term.
ἐξουσία	*exousia*	authority	"authority"	

Greek	Transliteration	Basic meaning	In context	Notes
αἰών	*aiōn*	age	“forever”	“Before all the age … into all the ages.”
ἀμήν	*amēn*	truly, so be it	“Amen”	Hebrew liturgical response.

E. The Historical and Cultural World

Doxologies in Jewish and Christian worship. Jewish prayer was rich in blessings and doxologies ascribing glory to God, and the five books of the Psalter each close with one (Pss 41:13; 72:18–19; 89:52; 106:48; 150). Early Christians continued the practice, and doxologies often closed letters that would be read in worship (Rom 16:25–27; Phil 4:20; 1 Tim 1:17; 1 Pet 4:11; 5:11; 2 Pet 3:18). Jude’s letter, read aloud in the community, would end in worship.

“Savior” in the Roman world. Hellenistic kings and Roman emperors were often hailed as “savior” (σωτήρ) and “benefactor” in inscriptions and official language.[168] When Christians called God “our Savior” and gave him “glory,” “power,” and “authority,” they were making a claim that implicitly relativized every human ruler. Jude’s doxology is not a political manifesto, but its language would not have been neutral in the first-century world.

Standing in the presence of a king. In the ancient Near East, to stand in the presence of a king was an honor reserved for those admitted to court. To be “set” before God’s glory “unblemished” and “in gladness” is the image of acceptance at the royal court of heaven.

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168. Abbott-Smith, s.v. σωτήρ (see n. 9).↩

F. Connections Across Scripture

Romans 16:25–27; Ephesians 3:20–21 (form). The closest parallels in form: “to Him who is able … to the only wise God, through Jesus Christ, to Him [be] glory” (Rom 16:25, 27, LSV). The parallel probably explains the addition of “wise” in some manuscripts of Jude.

1 Timothy 1:17; 1 Peter 4:11; 2 Peter 3:18 (doxologies). Other New Testament doxologies use similar vocabulary. Second Peter ends: “to Him [is] the glory both now, and to the day of the age! Amen” (2 Pet 3:18, LSV), a doxology to Christ that resembles Jude’s.

Psalms 121; 56:13; 116:8 (being kept from stumbling). The Old Testament roots of Jude's promise.

Colossians 1:22; Ephesians 1:4; 5:27; 1 Thessalonians 3:13 (presentation unblemished). The goal of God's work is a people presented holy and blameless before him.

1 Chronicles 29:10–13 (attributes). David's blessing of God, ascribing greatness, power, glory, and kingdom to him.

John 17:5; 2 Timothy 1:9 (before time). "The glory that I had with You before the world was" (John 17:5, LSV); grace "given to us in Christ Jesus, before the times of the ages" (2 Tim 1:9, LSV). These texts share the critical text's vision of glory before time.

G. Scholarly and Theological Questions

1. Which text of v. 25 is original? Most scholars accept the longer text of the critical editions, with "through Jesus Christ our Lord" and "before all time," and without "wise." The Byzantine form is shorter in two places and adds "wise," probably from Rom 16:27. Readers of the LSV should know that their translation reflects the Byzantine form here.

2. Is the doxology addressed to God or to Christ? It is addressed to "the only God our Savior," with glory ascribed "through Jesus Christ" (critical text). Some later doxologies are addressed directly to Christ (2 Pet 3:18; Rev 5:13). Jude's is addressed to God through Christ, and that reflects the pattern of early Christian worship.

3. Does "able to guard you without stumbling" guarantee perseverance? As in Chapters 1 and 11, Christian traditions answer differently. All agree that the doxology expresses confidence in God's power and faithfulness. Some read it as a guarantee that true believers will persevere. Others read it as a statement of God's ability that believers must still respond to. Jude's placement of the doxology after v. 21 suggests that he did not see the two as competing.

4. "Is" or "be"? The verbless Greek allows both. The LSV's "[is]" emphasizes that glory already belongs to God. The traditional "be" emphasizes the worshipers' acknowledgment.

H. The Passage Within Jude

The doxology completes the letter's frame. The opening described the readers as "called, … loved … and … kept" (v. 1). The ending praises God who is "able to guard" them (v. 24). Between these two statements of God's keeping lies

everything else: the intruders, the examples of judgment, the woes, the images of disorder, the call to build, pray, keep, wait, and show mercy.

Every major theme of the letter is gathered in these two verses:

- **Keeping and guarding:** "able to guard you" (v. 24), completing the τηρέω thread (vv. 1, 6, 13, 21).
- **Stumbling and falling:** the danger shown by the wilderness generation, the angels, and the intruders, and averted by God's power.
- **Blemish and purity:** "unblemished" (v. 24), in contrast to the stains (v. 12) and the stained garment (v. 23).
- **Glory:** the "glorious [ones]" slandered by the intruders (v. 8), and the true glory of God before which the readers will stand (vv. 24–25).
- **Joy:** "in gladness" (v. 24), the final mood of a letter that began with mercy, peace, and love.
- **Salvation:** "our common salvation" (v. 3) and "God our Savior" (v. 25).
- **Lordship:** "our only Master and Lord—Jesus Christ" (v. 4) and 'through Jesus Christ our Lord' (v. 25, critical text).
- **Time:** ancient examples, present dangers, and future judgment, all embraced by the eternal glory of God, 'before all time, and now, and forever.'

Jude wanted to write about "our common salvation" (v. 3) and was forced to write a warning instead. In the doxology he finally gets to write about salvation, and he does it in praise.

I. Contemporary Understanding

Suggested applications, distinct from the original meaning.

Ending in worship. Jude ends a hard letter with praise. Christians facing conflict, confusion, or danger might learn from his example to return, finally, to the worship of God, not as an escape from difficulty but as the truest response to it.

Confidence that is not self-confidence. The doxology's emphasis on God's ability frees believers from depending on their own steadiness. That is good news for the wavering, the weary, and those who have stumbled before.

Joy as the end. The final picture is of believers standing before God's glory "in gladness." Christian faith, for all its seriousness about sin and judgment, aims at joy. Communities that have forgotten that may need Jude's ending as much as his warnings.

Using the doxology. Jude 24–25 has long been used as a benediction at the close of Christian services. Its use may be enriched by remembering its

context. It is spoken to people who face real dangers, by someone who knows those dangers well, in confidence that God is greater.

J. Reflection and Discussion

1. How does reading the doxology after the rest of Jude change its meaning for you, compared with hearing it as a stand-alone benediction?
2. What does "stumbling" look like in your life or community? How does the promise that God "is able to guard you" speak to that?
3. Jude pictures believers standing before God's glory "unblemished, in gladness." What does that picture suggest about the goal of the Christian life?
4. The critical text includes "before all time, and now, and forever." What difference does it make to think of God's glory as stretching back before creation?
5. Jude both commands believers to keep themselves (v. 21) and praises God for keeping them (v. 24). How do you hold these together in your own life?

K. Sources

- LSV texts: eBible.org edition. Greek: SBLGNT and apparatus (WH, Treg, NIV, RP, NA28 data); Robinson–Pierpont; TR.
- Abbott-Smith, s.vv. φυλάσσω, τηρέω (synonym note), ἄπταιστος, κατενώπιον, ἄμωμος, ἀγαλλίασις, μεγαλωσύνη, κράτος, σωτήρ.
- 3 Maccabees 6:39 (Brenton's Greek Septuagint).
- Greek of 1 Pet 4:11 from SBLGNT.

Afterword: Reading Jude Whole

We have walked through Jude phrase by phrase, stopping at reefs and clouds, angels and archangels, Enoch and the love feast. It is worth stepping back, as Jude's first hearers would have done when the reading ended, and hearing the letter once more as a single word.

Jude wrote to people he loved about something he loved, "our common salvation." What he found was a community in danger. People had slipped in who spoke impressively, claimed visions, sat at the common table, and taught that grace made holiness unnecessary. Jude did not respond with a treatise. He responded with memory. Remember the people saved from Egypt who did not believe. Remember the angels who left their place and Sodom's fire. Remember Michael, who did not presume to judge even the Devil. Remember Cain, Balaam, and Korah. Remember what Enoch said and what the apostles told you. In each memory, Jude saw the present more clearly. The story of God's people had seen this danger before, and God had not been defeated by it.

Yet the letter does not end in memory, and it certainly does not end in denunciation. It ends with a community building itself up on a most holy faith, praying in the Holy Spirit, keeping itself in the love of God, and waiting for the mercy of Jesus Christ. It ends with that community reaching out in mercy to the wavering, snatching the endangered from the fire, and showing compassion even where caution is needed. And it ends with praise to the God who is able to keep his people from stumbling and to bring them, faultless and rejoicing, into the presence of his glory.

Three sentences may summarize what Jude asks of every generation that reads him:

Remember what God has done and said. The faith was delivered once for all. Its shape is known. Novelty is not the measure of truth.

Keep yourselves in the love of God. Faithfulness is not mainly a matter of fighting enemies but of remaining where God's love has placed us, through building up one another, prayer, and hope.

Show mercy. Those who contend most earnestly for the faith should be the quickest to reach out to the doubting and the endangered, because they themselves live by mercy.

Around these three sentences stand the two great statements that frame the letter: you have been called, loved, and kept; and God is able to guard you

without stumbling. Between them lies everything else, the danger, the warnings, and the work. Jude's readers, then and now, are invited to live in the space those two statements define, in confidence that the one who kept them from the beginning will keep them to the end.

To Him be glory. Amen.

Part Two: Reference

Appendix A. Significant Textual Variants in Jude

This appendix collects the variation units in Jude that affect translation or interpretation. For each unit it gives the reading of the SBL Greek New Testament (SBLGNT), the Nestle–Aland 28th edition (NA28), the Robinson–Pierpont Byzantine text (RP), and the Textus Receptus (TR), and it indicates which reading the LSV follows. The data come from the SBLGNT apparatus, the updated apparatus citing NA28 in the eBible.org SBLGNT edition, and the Robinson–Pierpont and TR texts themselves.[169] Approximate manuscript percentages, where given, come from the Text-Critical Greek New Testament notes. They count manuscripts without weighing them and are included only to show how a reading is distributed.

How to read the tables. "+" means "adds," and "–" means "omits." "Byz" refers to the Byzantine majority text.

A.1 Summary table

v.	SBLGNT	NA28	RP (Byzantine)	TR	LSV follows	Significance
1	ἠγαπημένοις "loved"	same	ἡγιασμένοις "sanctified"	ἡγιασμένοις	SBLGNT/NA28 ("loved")	Moderate: affects the letter's love theme
3	κοινῆς ἡμῶν σωτηρίας "our common salvation"	same	– ἡμῶν	– ἡμῶν	SBLGNT/NA28	Minor
4	δεσπότην "Master"	same	+ θεόν "God"	+ θεόν	SBLGNT/NA28	Moderate: KJV reads two persons
5	εἰδότας ὑμᾶς ἅπαξ πάντα ὅτι Ἰησοῦς	same (NA27: … ὅτι ὁ κύριος ἅπαξ …)	ἅπαξ τοῦτο ὅτι ὁ κύριος	same as RP	SBLGNT/NA28 ("Jesus")	**Major**: Christology
7	τρόπον τούτοις	same	τούτοις τρόπον	same as RP	—	Word order only

v.	SBLGNT	NA28	RP (Byzantine)	TR	LSV follows	Significance
12	οἱ ἐν ταῖς ἀγάπαις	same	– οἱ	– οἱ	—	Minor (grammar of σπιλάδες)
12	παραφερόμεναι “carried away”	same	same	περιφερόμεναι “carried about”	—	Minor
13	εἰς αἰῶνα	same	same	εἰς τὸν αἰῶνα	—	None in meaning
15	πάντας τοὺς ἀσεβεῖς “all the impious”	πᾶσαν ψυχήν “every soul”	+ αὐτῶν “their”	+ αὐτῶν; ἐξελέγξαι	RP (“all their impious ones”)	Moderate: relation to 1 Enoch 1:9
16	αὐτῶν	ἑαυτῶν	αὐτῶν	αὐτῶν	—	None in meaning
18	ἐπ’ ἐσχάτου χρόνου	same (NA27 adds τοῦ)	ἐν ἐσχάτῳ χρόνῳ; + ὅτι	same as RP	—	None in meaning
19	οἱ ἀποδιορίζοντες	same	same	+ ἑαυτούς “themselves”	SBLGNT/RP	Moderate: “separate themselves” (KJV) vs. “cause divisions”
20	word order	same	different order	same as RP	—	None in meaning
22–23	three clauses, ἐλεᾶτε … σῴζετε … ἐλεᾶτε	same	two clauses, ἐλεεῖτε διακρινόμενοι … ἐν φόβῳ σῴζετε	same as RP	SBLGNT/NA28 (three clauses)	**Major**: number of groups; mercy vs. rebuke
24	ὑμᾶς “you”	same	αὐτούς “them”	ὑμᾶς	SBLGNT/TR (“you”)	Minor
25	μόνῳ θεῷ “only God”	same	+ σοφῷ “wise”	+ σοφῷ	RP/TR (“only wise God”)	Minor: assimilation to Rom 16:27
25	διὰ Ἰησοῦ Χριστοῦ τοῦ κυρίου ἡμῶν	same	–	–	RP/TR (omits)	Moderate: glory “through Jesus Christ”
25	πρὸ παντὸς τοῦ αἰῶνος “before all time”	same	–	–	RP/TR (omits)	Moderate: glory before time

169. SBLGNT apparatus, https://www.sblgnt.com/download/86-Jud-APP.txt; eBible.org SBLGNT edition (files dated 30 October 2026) with NA28 notes; Robinson–Pierpont 2018 and the Textus Receptus (eBible.org); Text-Critical Greek NT notes (eBible.org `grctcgnt`). Witnesses such as P72, Alexandrinus, and Vaticanus are named from the standard critical literature; see the verification notes in the Bibliography.↩

A.2 Notes on the major units

Jude 1: “loved” or “sanctified.” About 90% of manuscripts read “sanctified.” The critical editions all read “loved,” judging it the earlier and harder reading. “Sanctified in God the Father” looks like a scribal improvement of the unusual “loved in God the Father,” perhaps influenced by 1 Cor 1:2. See Chapter 1.

Jude 4: “only Master [God] and Lord.” The added θεόν appears in the Byzantine tradition and produced the KJV’s “denying the only Lord God, and our Lord Jesus Christ.” Since a single article governs the nouns, even the longer text most naturally refers all the titles to Jesus, as the WEB’s rendering of the Majority Text shows: “our only Master, God, and Lord, Jesus Christ.” See Chapter 2.

Jude 5: “Jesus” or “the Lord.” This is the most discussed variant in the letter. “Jesus” is read by important early manuscripts, including Codex Alexandrinus and Codex Vaticanus. The early papyrus P72 has “God Christ.” Most later manuscripts have “the Lord.” The editors of NA28 adopted “Jesus,” reversing NA27, and the SBLGNT reads it too. The placement of “once” also varies. See the deep dive in Chapter 3.

Jude 15: “all the impious” or “every soul.” NA28’s “every soul” corresponds to 1 Enoch 1:9’s “all flesh” (Charles). SBLGNT’s “all the impious” matches Jude’s emphasis on “impious.” The Byzantine text adds “their.” See Chapter 8.

Jude 19: “who cause divisions” or “who separate themselves.” The TR’s added ἑαυτούς creates the KJV’s “These be they who separate themselves,” suggesting withdrawal. The critical and Byzantine texts lack it, which gives “these are the ones who cause divisions.” See Chapter 10.

Jude 22–23: two groups or three? Five main forms survive. The SBLGNT, NA28, and LSV have three clauses (mercy, rescue, mercy with fear). Westcott–Hort, the Byzantine text, and P72 have two clauses in different arrangements. Tregelles and the Tyndale House Greek New Testament (as reported) read “refute” (ἐλέγχετε) instead of “show mercy” in the first clause. Clement of Alexandria’s paraphrase suggests a two-part text. See the deep dive in Chapter 12.

Jude 25: the shape of the doxology. The critical text's "through Jesus Christ our Lord" and "before all time" are absent from the Byzantine text and the LSV. The Byzantine "wise" is probably borrowed from Rom 16:27. See Chapter 13.

A.3 What the variants show about the LSV

The LSV states in its preface that its New Testament is based on the Textus Receptus and the Majority Text, departing from them "in certain, specific instances … where the evidence seems incontrovertible."[170] Jude illustrates this policy well. In vv. 1, 3, 4, 5, and 22–23 the LSV adopts readings of the critical editions against the Byzantine majority. In vv. 15 and 25 it keeps the Byzantine readings. Readers of this book should therefore keep in mind that the LSV's English does not always correspond to a single printed Greek edition. The commentary notes every place where that matters.

170. LSV preface, https://www.lsvbible.com/p/the-preface-to-literal-standard-version.html (accessed 7 November 2026).↩

A.4 How significant are these variants?

None of Jude's variants affects any central Christian doctrine. Several affect how particular verses are read: whether Jesus is named as Israel's deliverer (v. 5), how many groups the readers are to help (vv. 22–23), and whether glory is ascribed to God "through Jesus Christ" and 'before all time' (v. 25). Honest reading includes knowing where the text is uncertain, and good textual scholarship lets readers see how much of the text is secure. For Jude, by any measure, almost all of it is.

Appendix B. Disputed Interpretations at a Glance

This appendix summarizes the main interpretive questions discussed in the commentary. For each one it lists the principal options and the position this book takes, with the chapter where the evidence is discussed. “Preferred” means the reading this book judges most probable. It does not mean the other options lack merit.

v.	Question	Options	This book	Chapter
1	Who is the author?	(a) Jude, brother of Jesus and James; (b) a later writer using his name; (c) an associate writing for him	(a) a responsible conclusion; not treated as proven	Intro §1
1	“Kept … Jesus Christ”	kept *for* / *by* / *in* Jesus Christ	“for” most natural; all three possible	1
3	What is “the faith”?	the content of the gospel and its moral shape; personal trust	content (with its moral shape)	2
4	“Written beforehand”	(a) in earlier prophecies; (b) in heavenly books; (c) predestined individually	(a)	2
4	“Only Master and Lord”	both titles of Jesus; or (TR) God and Jesus	both of Jesus	2
5	Who saved the people from Egypt?	Jesus; the Lord; God	Jesus (textual and theological discussion)	3
6	Which angels?	(a) Watchers of Gen 6 / 1 Enoch; (b) primordial fall of Satan; (c) Sethite reading of Gen 6	(a)	3
7	Antecedent of “these”	the angels; the intruders	the angels	3
7	“Other flesh”	(a) angelic flesh; (b) same-sex relations; (c) sexual immorality generally	(a) primary; general immorality also condemned	3

v.	Question	Options	This book	Chapter
8	“Dreaming”	claimed revelations; moral fantasy; delusion	claimed revelations (Deut 13)	4
8	“Lordship”	the Lord’s authority; angelic powers; church leaders	the Lord’s authority	4
8	“Glorious [ones]”	angels (good or evil); human leaders	angels	4
9	Source of the Michael story	lost ending of the *Testament/Assumption of Moses*; oral tradition	the Moses literature (with uncertainty)	4
9	“A judgment of slander”	(a) a slanderous judgment; (b) a condemnation for slander	both presented; same lesson	4
11	Which aspect of Cain?	hatred/murder; corrupting others; denial of judgment	open; possibly all	5
11	“They perished”	prophetic aorist; fate already sealed	prophetic certainty	5
12	σπιλάδες	hidden reefs; stains/spots; deliberate double sense	reefs (stains possible)	6
12	Love feast and Lord’s Supper	one event; distinct events	probably not yet separated in Jude’s time	6
12	“Twice dead”	fruitless and uprooted; present and second death; sin and judgment	open; complementary	6
12–13	Source of the nature images	1 Enoch 2–5 and 80; general biblical imagery	probably 1 Enoch	7
13	“Wandering stars”	planets; meteors; stars as fallen angels	stars as rebellious heavenly beings (with “planets”)	7
14–15	Status of 1 Enoch for Jude	(a) Scripture; (b) a genuine prophecy within a non-canonical book; (c) a respected text quoted for a true statement	open; principles for weighing the options given	8

v.	Question	Options	This book	Chapter
14	“The Lord”	God (as in 1 Enoch); Jesus	Jesus, in Jude’s application	8
16	Whom did they flatter?	wealthy hosts; potential followers; leaders	unknown	9
17	Does v. 17 imply a late date?	yes; no (apostles spoke “to you”)	not necessarily	10
19	ἀποδιορίζοντες	cause divisions; make distinctions; separate themselves (TR)	cause divisions / make distinctions	10
19	ψυχικοί	the opponents’ own term turned back; Jude’s own term	possibly ironic; uncertain	10
20	“Praying in the Holy Spirit”	Spirit-led prayer generally; charismatic prayer; prayer in the sphere of the Spirit	Spirit-led prayer (others compatible)	11
21	“The love of God”	God’s love for us; our love for God	God’s love (primary)	11
22	διακρινομένους	doubting/wavering; disputing	wavering	12
22–23	Two groups or three?	three-clause text; two-clause forms	three (with uncertainty)	12
25	Supplied verb	“is” (declaration); “be” (wish)	both senses present	13

Appendix C. Jude and 2 Peter: The Parallel Passages

This appendix sets the parallel passages side by side in the Literal Standard Version. The texts are generated directly from the LSV source files by `tools/make_parallels.py`, so they are exact. For discussion of the relationship between the two letters, see the Historical and Literary Introduction, §8.

Summary of the evidence. The two letters share a sequence of themes, images, and rare words. Three Greek words occur in the New Testament only in these two letters: συνευωχέομαι (“feast together”), ὑπέρογκος (“swollen”), and ἐμπαίκτης (“scoffer”).[171] Jude contains material not found in 2 Peter: the quotation of Enoch (vv. 14–15), the named dispute of Michael and the Devil over Moses’ body (v. 9), Cain and Korah (v. 11), the wild waves and wandering stars (v. 13), and the closing exhortations to mercy (vv. 20–23). 2 Peter adds the flood and Noah (2:5), Lot (2:7–8), Balaam’s donkey (2:16), and the scoffers’ question about Christ’s coming (3:4).

Jude 2 ‖ 2 Pet 1:2

> **2** mercy and peace and love be multiplied to you!
>
> — Jude 2, LSV

> **1:2** Grace and peace be multiplied to you in the acknowledgment of God and of Jesus our Lord!
>
> — 2 Pet 1:2, LSV

Observation: Same wish formula (“be multiplied”); Jude’s triad differs.

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171. Computed from MorphGNT/SBLGNT lemmas; see `research/data-notes.md`.↩

Jude 4 ‖ 2 Pet 2:1–3

> **4** for there came in certain men stealthily, having been written beforehand to this judgment long ago, impious, perverting the grace of our God to licentiousness, and denying our only Master and Lord—Jesus Christ.
>
> — Jude 4, LSV

> **2:1** But there also came false prophets among the people, as there will also be false teachers among you, who will stealthily bring in destructive sects, even denying the Master who bought them, bringing quick destruction to themselves, **2:2** and many will follow out their destructive ways, because of whom the way of the truth will be spoken of [as] evil, **2:3** and in covetousness, with forged words, they will make merchandise of you, whose judgment of old is not idle, and their destruction does not slumber.
>
> — 2 Pet 2:1–3, LSV

Observation: Intruders “came in … stealthily” / “will stealthily bring in”; both deny the Master (δεσπότης). Jude: past tense; 2 Peter: future.

Jude 5 ‖ 2 Pet 1:12

> **5** Now I intend to remind you, you once having known all this, that Jesus, having saved a people out of the land of Egypt, He secondly destroyed those not having believed;
>
> — Jude 5, LSV

> **1:12** Therefore, I will always be ready to remind you about these things, although you have known [them] and have been established in the present truth,
>
> — 2 Pet 1:12, LSV

Observation: Both remind readers of what they already know.

Jude 6 ‖ 2 Pet 2:4

> **6** messengers also, those who did not keep their own principality, but left their proper dwelling, He has kept in eternal bonds under darkness until [the] judgment of [the] great day,
>
> — Jude 6, LSV

> **2:4** For if God did not spare messengers having sinned, but having cast [them] down to Tartarus with chains of deepest gloom, delivered [them], having been reserved to judgment,
>
> — 2 Pet 2:4, LSV

Observation: Sinning angels kept in gloom for judgment. 2 Peter adds “Tartarus.”

Jude 7 ‖ 2 Pet 2:6–8

> **7** as Sodom and Gomorrah, and the cities around them, in like manner to these [messengers], having given themselves to whoredom, and having gone after other flesh, have been set before [as] an example, undergoing the justice of continuous fire.
>
> — Jude 7, LSV

> **2:6** and having turned the cities of Sodom and Gomorrah to ashes, condemned with an overthrow, having set [them as] an example to those about to be impious, **2:7** and He rescued righteous Lot, worn down by the conduct of the lawless in licentiousness, **2:8** for the righteous [man] dwelling among them was tormented in [his] righteous soul, day by day, in seeing and hearing unlawful works—
>
> — 2 Pet 2:6–8, LSV

Observation: Sodom and Gomorrah as example. 2 Peter adds the rescue of Lot and inserts the flood (2:5) to make a biblical sequence.

Jude 8 ‖ 2 Pet 2:10

> **8** In like manner, nevertheless, those dreaming indeed defile the flesh, and they disregard lordship, and they speak evil of glorious [ones],
>
> — Jude 8, LSV

> **2:10** and chiefly those following after the flesh in lust [and] defilement, and despising lordship. Bold, self-pleased, they are not afraid to speak evil of glorious ones,
>
> — 2 Pet 2:10, LSV

Observation: Defiling the flesh, despising lordship, slandering “glorious ones.”

Jude 9 ‖ 2 Pet 2:11

> **9** yet Michael, the chief messenger, when disputing with the Devil, reasoning about the body of Moses, did not dare to bring against [him] a judgment of slander, but said, “The LORD rebuke you!”
>
> — Jude 9, LSV

> **2:11** whereas messengers, being greater in strength and power, do not bear a slanderous judgment against them before the LORD;

> — 2 Pet 2:11, LSV

Observation: Angels do not bring a slanderous judgment. 2 Peter omits Michael, the Devil, and Moses.

Jude 10 ‖ 2 Pet 2:12

> **10** But these, indeed, whatever [things] they have not known, they speak evil of; and whatever [they know], like the irrational beasts, they understand naturally—in these they are corrupted;
>
> — Jude 10, LSV

> **2:12** and these, as irrational natural beasts, made to be caught and destroyed—in what things they are ignorant of, slandering—in their destruction will be destroyed;
>
> — 2 Pet 2:12, LSV

Observation: Slandering what they do not know; irrational beasts; destruction.

Jude 11 ‖ 2 Pet 2:15–16

> **11** woe to them! Because they went on in the way of Cain, and they rushed to the deceit of Balaam for reward, and in the controversy of Korah they perished.
>
> — Jude 11, LSV

> **2:15** having forsaken a right way, they went astray, having followed in the way of Balaam the [son] of Bosor, who loved a reward of unrighteousness, **2:16** and had a rebuke of his own iniquity—a mute donkey, having spoken in man’s voice, forbid the madness of the prophet.
>
> — 2 Pet 2:15–16, LSV

Observation: Balaam and his reward. 2 Peter omits Cain and Korah and adds the donkey.

Jude 12 ‖ 2 Pet 2:13; 2 Pet 2:17

> **12** These are stains at your love-feasts, feasting together with you without fear, shepherding themselves; waterless clouds, being carried away by winds; autumnal trees without fruit, having died twice, having been uprooted;

> — Jude 12, LSV

> **2:13** doing unjustly, [they will receive] a reward of unrighteousness, esteeming pleasure in the day, [and] luxury—[they are] spots and blemishes, reveling in their deceits, feasting with you, … **2:17** These are wells without water, and clouds driven by a storm, to whom the deepest gloom of darkness has been kept throughout the age;
>
> — 2 Pet 2:13; 2 Pet 2:17, LSV

Observation: "Feasting together" (only here in the NT); "stains/reefs" vs. "spots and blemishes"; "love-feasts" vs. "deceits" (a one-letter difference in Greek); waterless clouds vs. "wells without water, and clouds driven by a storm."

Jude 13 ‖ 2 Pet 2:17

> **13** wild waves of a sea, foaming up their own shameful [deeds]; stars going astray, for whom the gloom of the darkness throughout the age has been kept.
>
> — Jude 13, LSV

> **2:17** These are wells without water, and clouds driven by a storm, to whom the deepest gloom of darkness has been kept throughout the age;
>
> — 2 Pet 2:17, LSV

Observation: "The gloom of the darkness … has been kept" applied in 2 Peter to the wells and mists.

Jude 16 ‖ 2 Pet 2:18

> **16** These are discontented grumblers, walking according to their own lusts; and their mouth speaks swollen words, giving admiration to persons for the sake of profit;
>
> — Jude 16, LSV

> **2:18** for speaking swollen words of vanity, they entice in desires of the flesh—licentiousness, those who had truly escaped from those conducting themselves in error,
>
> — 2 Pet 2:18, LSV

Observation: "Swollen words" (ὑπέρογκα; only here in the NT).

Jude 17–18 ‖ 2 Pet 3:1–3

> **17** but you, beloved, remember the sayings spoken before by the apostles of our Lord Jesus Christ, **18** that they said to you, that in the last time there will be scoffers, following after their own lusts of impieties,
>
> — Jude 17–18, LSV

> **3:1** This [is] now, beloved, a second letter I write to you, in both which I stir up your pure mind in reminding [you] **3:2** to be mindful of the sayings said before by the holy prophets, and of the command of us the apostles of the LORD and Savior, **3:3** knowing this first, that there will come scoffers in the last days, going on according to their own desires,
>
> — 2 Pet 3:1–3, LSV

Observation: Remembering the apostles' words; scoffers in the last time/days following their own desires (ἐμπαῖκται; only here in the NT). 2 Peter adds the prophets and specifies mockery of the promise of Christ's coming.

Jude 24–25 ‖ 2 Pet 3:17–18

> **24** And to Him who is able to guard you without stumbling, and to set [you] in the presence of His glory unblemished, in gladness, **25** to the only wise God our Savior, [is] glory and greatness, power and authority, both now and forever! Amen.
>
> — Jude 24–25, LSV

> **3:17** You, then, beloved, knowing before, take heed, lest, together with the error of the impious being led away, you may fall from your own steadfastness, **3:18** and increase in grace, and in the knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ; to Him [is] the glory both now, and to the day of the age! Amen.
>
> — 2 Pet 3:17–18, LSV

Observation: Both close with a warning against falling and a doxology. 2 Peter's doxology is addressed to Christ.

Material in Jude without a parallel in 2 Peter

- The greeting's description of believers as called, loved, and kept (v. 1).
- The exodus example, with the reading "Jesus" (v. 5).

- The story of Michael and the Devil over Moses' body (v. 9).
- Cain and Korah (v. 11).
- "Wild waves of a sea" and "stars going astray" (v. 13).
- The quotation from 1 Enoch (vv. 14–15).
- "Grumblers" and flattery (v. 16).
- "Causing divisions … not having the Spirit" (v. 19).
- Building, praying in the Holy Spirit, keeping in God's love (vv. 20–21).
- Mercy for the doubting and rescue from the fire (vv. 22–23).

Glossary of Greek and Theological Terms

Greek words are listed by transliteration, with the Greek form and the verse in Jude where it appears. Lexical summaries draw on Abbott-Smith's *Manual Greek Lexicon of the New Testament* (1922) unless noted.

Greek words

agapē (ἀγάπη), vv. 2, 12, 21. "Love." In the plural (v. 12), "love feasts," the community's shared meals. See Chapter 6.

agapētoi (ἀγαπητοί), vv. 3, 17, 20. "Beloved," Jude's address to his readers.

agalliasis (ἀγαλλίασις), v. 24. "Exultation, exuberant joy."

akarpos (ἄκαρπος), v. 12. "Fruitless."

alogos (ἄλογος), v. 10. "Without reason"; τὰ ἄλογα ζῷα, "irrational animals."

amōmos (ἄμωμος), v. 24. "Without blemish," used of sacrificial animals, and morally "faultless."

antilogia (ἀντιλογία), v. 11. "Contradiction, dispute, rebellion." In the LXX it is used for the "water of contention" (Meribah).

anydros (ἄνυδρος), v. 12. "Waterless."

aphobōs (ἀφόβως), v. 12. "Without fear," here meaning without reverence.

apodiorizō (ἀποδιορίζω), v. 19. "To mark off; to make divisions." NT hapax.

aptaistos (ἄπταιστος), v. 24. "Without stumbling, sure-footed." NT hapax.

archangelos (ἀρχάγγελος), v. 9. "Archangel, chief messenger" (LSV). Used of Michael.

archē (ἀρχή), v. 6. "Beginning; rule, domain." The angels' assigned position (LSV "principality").

asebēs, asebeia, asebeō (ἀσεβής, ἀσέβεια, ἀσεβέω), vv. 4, 15, 18. "Impious/ungodly," "impiety," "to act impiously." Jude's key description of the intruders.

aselgeia (ἀσέλγεια), v. 4. "Licentiousness, shameless excess."

atheteō (ἀθετέω), v. 8. "To set aside, reject."

aidios (ἀΐδιος), v. 6. “Everlasting.”

aiōn, aiōnios (αἰών, αἰώνιος), vv. 7, 13, 21, 25. “Age” and “age-long, eternal.” The LSV renders αἰώνιος “continuous.”

blasphēmeō, blasphēmia (βλασφημέω, βλασφημία), vv. 8–10. “To slander, revile”; “slander.” Used of abusive speech against anyone, not only against God.

deigma (δεῖγμα), v. 7. “A specimen, example (as a warning).” NT hapax.

despotēs (δεσπότης), v. 4. “Master, owner, sovereign.” Used of Jesus.

diabolos (διάβολος), v. 9. “Slanderer, accuser; the Devil.”

diakrinomai (διακρίνομαι), vv. 9, 22. ‘To dispute’ (v. 9) or ‘to doubt, waver’ (v. 22).

dikē (δίκη), v. 7. “Justice; the penalty carried out.”

doulos (δοῦλος), v. 1. “Slave, servant.” Also an honorific (“servant of the LORD”).

doxa, doxai (δόξα, δόξαι), vv. 8, 24, 25. “Glory”; in the plural (v. 8), “glorious ones,” that is, angels.

ekporneuō (ἐκπορνεύω), v. 7. “To give oneself up to sexual immorality.” NT hapax.

ekrizoō (ἐκριζόω), v. 12. “To uproot.”

eleos, eleaō (ἔλεος, ἐλεάω), vv. 2, 21, 22, 23. “Mercy”; “to show mercy.” In the LXX ἔλεος chiefly translates Hebrew *ḥesed*.

elenchō (ἐλέγχω), v. 15. “To expose, convict.”

empaiktēs (ἐμπαίκτης), v. 18. “Scoffer, mocker.” In the NT only here and 2 Pet 3:3.

enypniazomai (ἐνυπνιάζομαι), v. 8. “To dream.” In the LXX, used of the false prophet as “dreamer” (Deut 13).

epagōnizomai (ἐπαγωνίζομαι), v. 3. “To contend for.” NT hapax.

epaphrizō (ἐπαφρίζω), v. 13. “To foam up.” NT hapax.

epithymia (ἐπιθυμία), vv. 16, 18. “Desire, craving.”

epoikodomeō (ἐποικοδομέω), v. 20. “To build upon.”

gongystēs (γογγυστής), v. 16. “Grumbler, murmurer.” NT hapax.

hagioi (ἅγιοι), vv. 3, 14. “Holy ones”: God’s people (v. 3) or angels (v. 14).

hagiōtatos (ἁγιώτατος), v. 20. “Most holy.” The only superlative of ἅγιος in the NT.

hapax (ἅπαξ), vv. 3, 5. “Once, once for all.”

harpazō (ἁρπάζω), v. 23. “To seize, snatch.”

hyperonkos (ὑπέρογκος), v. 16. “Swollen, excessive; arrogant (of speech).”

hypechō (ὑπέχω), v. 7. “To undergo, suffer (a penalty).” NT hapax.

katenōpion (κατενώπιον), v. 24. “Before, in the presence of.”

klētos (κλητός), v. 1. “Called.”

koinos (κοινός), v. 3. “Common, shared.”

kratos (κράτος), v. 25. “Power, dominion.” Common in doxologies.

kyriotēs (κυριότης), v. 8. “Lordship, dominion.”

megalōsynē (μεγαλωσύνη), v. 25. “Greatness, majesty.”

mempsimoiros (μεμψίμοιρος), v. 16. “Complaining of one’s lot, querulous.” NT hapax.

metatithēmi (μετατίθημι), v. 4. “To change, transfer; to turn one thing into a pretext for another.”

miainō (μιαίνω), v. 8. “To defile.”

oikētērion (οἰκητήριον), v. 6. “Dwelling, habitation.”

ouai (οὐαί), v. 11. “Woe!” The prophetic announcement of judgment.

paradidōmi (παραδίδωμι), v. 3. “To hand over, deliver.” The technical term for passing on tradition.

parapherō (παραφέρω), v. 12. “To carry away.”

pareisdyō (παρεισδύω), v. 4. “To slip in secretly.” NT hapax.

phthinopōrinos (φθινοπωρινός), v. 12. “Of late autumn.” NT hapax.

phylassō (φυλάσσω), v. 24. “To guard, protect.” Near synonym of τηρέω.

physikōs (φυσικῶς), v. 10. “Naturally, by instinct.” NT hapax.

planē (πλάνη), v. 11. “Error, deception, wandering.”

planētēs (πλανήτης), v. 13. “Wanderer”; ἀστέρες πλανῆται, “wandering stars.” The source of English “planet.” NT hapax.

plēthynō (πληθύνω), v. 2. “To multiply.” πληθυνθείη: “may it be multiplied” (optative).

poimainō (ποιμαίνω), v. 12. “To shepherd, tend.”

prographō (προγράφω), v. 4. “To write beforehand.”

psychikos (ψυχικός), v. 19. “Natural, soulish, unspiritual.”

sklēros (σκληρός), v. 15. “Hard, harsh”; “harsh words.”

sōtēr (σωτήρ), v. 25. “Savior.” A title also given to kings and emperors in the Greco-Roman world.

spilas (σπιλάς), v. 12. “Reef, rock in the sea”; in later Greek, “stain.” NT hapax. See Chapter 6.

spiloō (σπιλόω), v. 23. “To stain, defile.”

syneuōcheomai (συνευωχέομαι), v. 12. “To feast together.” In the NT only here and 2 Pet 2:13.

tēreō (τηρέω), vv. 1, 6, 13, 21. “To keep, guard, preserve.” Jude’s key word.

zophos (ζόφος), vv. 6, 13. “Deep gloom,” associated with the underworld.

Grammatical and theological terms

Aorist. A Greek verb form that presents an action as a whole, without reference to its duration.

Canon. The list of books a community recognizes as Scripture.

Critical text. A Greek text reconstructed by editors from the manuscripts in order to approximate the earliest recoverable text (for example, NA28, SBLGNT).

Byzantine text / Majority Text. The form of the Greek text found in the majority of (mostly later) manuscripts, edited by Robinson and Pierpont among others.

Doxology. A formula ascribing glory to God.

Etymological fallacy. The mistake of assuming that a word’s origin or component parts determine its meaning in use.

Hapax legomenon (plural *hapax legomena*). A word that occurs only once in a given body of literature, here the New Testament.

LXX (Septuagint). The Greek translation of the Hebrew scriptures, used widely by Greek-speaking Jews and early Christians.

Optative. A Greek verb mood used for wishes and prayers. It is rare in the New Testament.

Participle. A verbal adjective ("having been loved," "praying").

Perfect tense. A Greek tense presenting a completed action with continuing results.

Pre-existence (of Christ). The belief that the Son existed before his human birth.

Prophetic aorist. The use of a past tense to describe a future event as certain.

Pseudepigrapha. Ancient Jewish (and Christian) writings attributed to biblical figures, such as 1 Enoch and the *Testament of Moses*.

Pseudonymity. Writing under another person's name.

Second Temple Judaism. Judaism from the rebuilding of the temple (late sixth century BC) to its destruction in AD 70.

Targum. An Aramaic translation and paraphrase of the Hebrew scriptures.

Textus Receptus (TR). The printed Greek text that underlies the King James Version.

Theophany. An appearance of God.

Type / typology. A person or event in Scripture understood as a pattern of later persons or events.

Watchers. In 1 Enoch, the angels who descended to earth and took human wives (Gen 6:1–4).

Index of Scripture and Ancient Sources

References are to chapters (“Ch. 6”), the introductory chapters, and appendices. Generated by `tools/make_indexes.py` from the manuscript text.

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